

Engl 311 The Shakespearean Comedies

Numbered Transcript

ENGL 311 • Dr. Andrew Doyle

Contents

Lecture 1. The Comic Shakespeare

Lecture 2. Merry Wives & Comedy of Errors

Lecture 3. Love's Labour's Lost

Lecture 4. Taming of the Shrew & Much Ado

Lecture 5. As You Like It

Lecture 6. Two Gentlemen & Midsummer Night's

Lecture 7. The Merchant of Venice

Lecture 8. Twelfth Night

Lecture 1: The Comic Shakespeare

At a glance — Doyle introduces the comic Shakespeare and what makes his comedies work.

- 1.1 Have you ever seen a really angry vicar? Well, I want to tell you about a really famous angry vicar who once lived in the small town of Stratford-upon-Avon in England. His name was the Reverend Francis Gastrell, who, one day in 1756, in a fit of absolute rage, went out into his back garden with an ax, and he cut down a mulberry tree. Now, there was nothing wrong with the tree. Gastrell was just furious. He wanted rid of this tree.
- 1.2 This proved to be one of the most controversial horticultural events in history because it wasn't an ordinary mulberry tree. This was New Place in Stratford-upon-Avon, and one of the previous owners of New Place was a certain Mr. William Shakespeare. It was believed that this mulberry tree had been planted by William Shakespeare back in the day.
- 1.3 The reason why Gastrell was angry at the tree—well, it wasn't really the tree he was annoyed about. He was annoyed about the tourists. He was annoyed. This was 140-odd years after Shakespeare's death, and he died in New Place. And Gastrell was annoyed because these tourists kept traipsing up and down in his garden, and they would cut little snippets off the mulberry tree, souvenirs, and they were bothering his peace and quiet, and so he just chopped it down.
- 1.4 Now, this, as you can imagine, caused a huge scandal locally, and Gastrell was branded as a philistine. He was widely despised. At the same time, he was in the midst of a quarrel with Stratford's civic authorities over property taxes because he had a property somewhere else, in Lichfield. So he was refusing to pay the local taxes. He claimed, "Well, I don't live in Stratford-upon-Avon full-time. Why should I pay?"
- 1.5 So, by the time we get to 1759, he'd had enough. At that point, he actually demolished the whole house. New Place was razed to the ground in a fit of pique by this disgruntled vicar. And of course, the tree had gone already a few years before that. Now, to be fair to Gastrell, I should point out that the building he demolished wasn't the same one that Shakespeare lived in and died in. That had been demolished and rebuilt in 1702. But even so, I think this was an act of cultural vandalism that puts the Taliban to shame. It's a terrible thing to do.
- 1.6 And it's really frustrating. I don't know if any of you have been to Stratford-upon-Avon, in the middle of England, in Warwickshire. If you go along, you can see, you can visit New Place, but you can only see the remains, the foundations. That's all that's left, and the gardens. That's all there is. It's a real shame. It would have been lovely to be able to see this place. Just opposite, just over the road, there is the grammar school where it's almost certain Shakespeare attended as a boy. So, he's ruined it for the tourists, this angry priest or vicar, rather.

- 1.7 Shakespeare bought New Place in 1597. It was a five-gabled house directly opposite the grammar school, as I said. He was a wealthy man by this point. He didn't start off wealthy, started off quite middle-class, ended up very, very rich, very, very successful. But for me, personally, I think the destruction of the mulberry tree is worse than the destruction of the building, if we're going to be ranking them, because there's something quite poetically satisfying about this idea of a plant that was tended by Shakespeare himself, still flourishing a century and a half after his death.
- 1.8 And you can still see, if you go to New Place, in the garden, there is a mulberry tree that allegedly was cut from the original tree or grown from cuttings from the original tree, so there is still some sort of connection. And the other thing that you can do, which is very interesting, is you can actually see artifacts that were created after Gastrell chopped the tree down. There was a local entrepreneur called Thomas Sharp, and he had a good idea that he would take the wood and create these various artifacts. And there are goblets and snuff boxes and caskets.
- 1.9 There's even a bust of William Shakespeare made from the wood of the mulberry tree that Shakespeare probably planted. You can see all of that. The Shakespeare Birthplace Trust has most of that. And mulberries are mentioned in a number of Shakespeare's works. They're mentioned in Coriolanus and the Two Noble Kinsmen, Venus and Adonis. You remember in A Midsummer Night's Dream, mulberries are one of the fruits that Titania commands the fairies to bring to Bottom, so there's a lovely sort of connection there.
- 1.10 And people will say this probably didn't happen. They'll say this is one of these urban myths. But I think, on balance, it probably did. And the reason I think it did is that Shakespeare was living in New Place, living in Stratford-upon-Avon. He grew up there, moved to London, roughly 1587, and we think he ended up retiring, going back to Stratford-upon-Avon. He always had a house there. It may be that he was traveling back and forth. His wife, Anne Hathaway, lived there for the whole time, as well as his children.
- 1.11 There's recently been some evidence uncovered that perhaps Anne Hathaway also lived in London. That's very interesting. We don't really know. What we do know is that he died in Stratford-upon-Avon and that he was living in New Place when he died. The reason why I think the mulberry tree story is probably true is that King James I, who was on the throne at the time, was a big fan of the mulberries. He'd imported 100,000 saplings. He'd planted a lot of them himself. And not only that, he'd issued a proclamation, ordering landowners to plant mulberry trees.
- 1.12 Now, this wasn't just an aesthetic thing. King James I was keen on the mulberry trees because France had a monopoly on the silk trade, and mulberries were the food of silkworms, the only thing that silkworms would eat. He wanted to break that monopoly. And it makes complete sense. He wrote this proclamation in 1609, saying,

"You must plant these mulberry trees." Shakespeare, in 1609, was probably back in Stratford. It all adds up, so I like to think it's probably true.

1.13 Also, you've got to remember, Stratford-upon-Avon, a very small town, lots of families, word of mouth, oral tradition. This is one of those things that we think might be right. Now, one of the reasons I wanted to tell you about Shakespeare and the mulberry tree and the destruction of the tree is because I think there might be a lot of people watching this lecture who find Shakespeare a bit frustrating. There's a bit of that. I want to send that message. I want you to know you're not the first.

1.14 Gastrell was very angry at Shakespeare for different reasons. But in a way, it's quite similar. I feel that Gastrell saw all these tourists turning up, all these Shakespeare lovers, and he felt he wasn't one of the gang. You can imagine that frustration, that sense of escalating anger, just watching these people. "Why are they coming here? Why are they coming to my garden? Why are they vandalizing my tree? Because of a dead poet. Who cares?"

1.15 I think, in a way, this frustration, this kind of frustration, is shared by a lot of people today. They see all these writers and critics and commentators lauding Shakespeare, saying, "This is the greatest writer who has ever lived," but they don't see what the big deal is. They're forced to study him at school, and they don't enjoy it. They can barely understand a word of it. They're taken along as children to productions which are basically indecipherable to them. They don't know what's going on.

1.16 And particularly, I think this is the case with the comedies. I think a lot of people go and see the comedies and they get quite annoyed, because there are people in the audiences who will be laughing at jokes that they don't get. There's nothing worse than not being in on the joke; you know that feeling. And I've often heard people complain about Shakespeare audiences at comedies saying, "Well, they're pretending to understand the references, to show off how educated they are. That's why they're laughing."

1.17 There's a bit of that going on. There is a bit of that, too. This annoys people. There's an episode, there's a sitcom in Britain called *Blackadder*, and there was an episode called *Blackadder: Back and Forth*. This is where the lead character goes back in time, and he actually meets Shakespeare, and he punches him in the face. He says to him, "That's for every schoolboy and schoolgirl for the next 400 years." That's how angry people get.

1.18 Now, I want to begin with a caveat. I'm going to be talking to you about these plays. I'm going to try and impress upon you that this idea that they are inaccessible simply isn't the case. This idea that you need to be educated in every single detail of what every single reference means in order to find it funny, in order to appreciate the comedic art, I'm going to make the case that that is simply not true.

1.19 The other thing I'm going to caveat this series with is that this is obviously eight lectures on the major comedies, and that's a bit hubristic on my part, in a way. I mean, I

could have done eight lectures on one of the comedies. I could have done eight lectures on one passage of one of the comedies, come to that. He's such a dense, abundant writer that you can spend a lot of time. I mean, there have been people who've written whole books about very short passages in Shakespeare. That can be done.

- 1.20** I'm covering quite a lot of ground in these lectures, and therefore, I'm not going to go into too much depth, that kind of depth. I'm going to try and give you, rather, a broad overview, and I'm particularly aiming this at people for whom, well, the uninitiated, people who have some familiarity with comedies, hopefully read the comedies, but hasn't really gone into a particular depth. That's what I'm going to be trying to do.
- 1.21** The other thing I want to just mention from the outset is, I'm going to be making various arguments based on my personal interpretation of the plays, what I feel about the plays. By that, I don't mean to shut down any other interpretations. Shakespeare, as I say, is an abundant writer. He revelled in the multiplicity of meaning in language. So the idea of someone coming along and saying, "This interpretation is right, this interpretation is correct, and nothing else is," that's just plain wrong. So if I sound as though I'm being dogmatic, I don't mean to be. You might have other ideas about the plays, and that's great. I'm not at all trying to shut them down.
- 1.22** There's all sorts of bizarre interpretations that I can't get on board with. There was an article in 1955 in the International Journal of Psychoanalysis by a guy called A. Bronson Feldman. He was arguing that the Comedy of Errors expresses Shakespeare's unconscious desire to have sex with his mother. This is a full article on this. Now, of course, that is arrant nonsense, but he's entitled to that interpretation. I'm not going to push my point of view on anyone else, even the mad ones.
- 1.23** Now, I'm going to be covering as well, just to let you know, I'm going to be covering the early comedies, what we call the apprentice plays. So that's Two Gentlemen of Verona, Taming of the Shrew, Love's Labour's Lost, Comedy of Errors. I'm also going to be covering the major comedies, Midsummer Night's Dream, Twelfth Night, As You Like It, Much Ado About Nothing, The Merchant of Venice. We're also going to have a look at The Merry Wives of Windsor, which I consider a bit of an outlier, and you'll see why when we get to it.
- 1.24** These plays, by the way, all fall into the category of what John Dover Wilson, the great critic, called the happy comedies. It's quite a nice way of putting it. He wrote a book called Shakespeare's Happy Comedies in 1962. That is a book that's well worth reading. But the other thing I'm going to express in these lectures, and hopefully impress upon you, is that there is more to it than that. There is a darker element to these comedies, which I think is fascinating.
- 1.25** By the way, I won't be covering all of the comedies. I'm not going to cover the comedies that fall into the category of the late romances, so all the problem plays.

Those are things like *The Tempest*, *The Winter's Tale*, *Measure for Measure*, *All's Well That Ends Well*, *Troilus and Cressida*. I think *Troilus and Cressida*, although you could say it's a tragedy, there's an argument, there's a case that that is actually a very, very dark satirical comedy. I'm probably going to refer to these from time to time, but I'm not going to focus on them because I don't want to overreach. I don't want to be an Icarus. I want to be able to deal with a certain number of plays in a reasonably comprehensive way.

- 1.26** So, comedy ages, doesn't it? I think some of us in here are old enough to remember sitcoms of our youth, and we watch them now and think, "Oh, why did I laugh at that? That's weird." You see a lot of that, don't you? You see a lot of articles online about how "isn't *Friends* an awful offensive show?" and that was only, what, 20 years ago, maybe 25? Comedy really ages very, very rapidly. However, some comedy doesn't.
- 1.27** So I want to start by talking about some of the types of comedies in history, the precedents for Shakespeare's approach to comedy, how he borrows from traditions that do seem as fresh today as they ever did. I think this is really important in terms of understanding Shakespeare's comedies. Why are they still successful? I mean, I'll go and see a modern production of *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, and I'll still laugh at a lot of the passages.
- 1.28** I'm not talking about that kind of fake esoteric laughter. "Oh, I get the joke." I mean, they're authentically funny. Why? It's 400 years after he died. He died in 1616. How can this be? It still works. And why do we keep going back to see these plays? Now, you could argue this is just a kind of cultural habit, a kind of meme. He's the bard. We've got into this habit of thinking of him as the greatest writer that ever lived, and therefore we'll pretend that he is. But that's not true. He actually is. And that's why we enjoy it.
- 1.29** I don't think that our enthusiasm for Shakespeare, culturally speaking, is a form of posturing. I think it's grounded in the fact that he is one of the pillars of our civilization. Now, there's a passage in John Dover Wilson's book, the book that I mentioned, *Shakespeare's Happy Comedies*. This is from 1962, and he writes, "I once tried Dogberry upon a typical Elizabethan audience." Dogberry is the comical constable character from *Much Ado About Nothing*.
- 1.30** And John Dover Wilson, he says, "I once tried him on a typical Elizabethan audience. I'd been asked to lecture on Shakespeare to 288 male prisoners in Lincoln jail. But learning from the chaplain that 60% of them were illiterate, instead of a lecture, I read to them the Dogberry scenes, and at once had the whole prison roaring with laughter over the antics of the constable." I have to say, I think if that were to be tried in a prison today, it probably wouldn't get that response. You'd probably get shanked or something.
- 1.31** But I think, it's 1962. 60% of these people are illiterate. They're mostly thugs and criminals. They were roaring with laughter at Dogberry, a character created centuries

before they were born. That, to me, is quite fascinating. How does that work? Now, a lot of you have been reading the comedies before we've started, so you'll be trying to get into them, trying to understand them. There's a certain experience that I think a lot of us will have while we read these comedies, I think more so than the tragedies.

- 1.32** And I mean, when you're reading the play, and the dialogue is running very smoothly, and you're carried along with the characters, and you're enjoying it, and you're understanding it, and then, bam, you hit a brick wall, and that brick wall is something, some kind of reference, something that blocks you. Let me give you an example. This is from *Much Ado About Nothing*. This is Beatrice, the character Beatrice, who has sworn off men. She wants nothing to do with men, but of course, we know that she's in love with Benedick, and vice versa. He's in love with her. He won't admit it.
- 1.33** She's talking to her uncle, Leonato. This is in Act 2, Scene 1. She's saying, that she's pleased that God hasn't sent her a husband. She says, "For the which blessing, I am at him upon my knees every morning and evening. Lord, I could not endure a husband with a beard on his face. I'd rather lie in the woolen." And you might think, there, you might stick there. Woolen? What's it? Well, she's talking about the blanket, the scratchy blankets without the sheets. I'd rather lie there than have this scratchy, hairy, hirsute face all over me.
- 1.34** And so we're going with it. We understand what's happening. Then Leonato says, "Well, you may light on a husband that hath no beard." Beatrice says, "What should I do with him? Dress him in my apparel and make him my waiting-gentlewoman? He that hath a beard is more than a youth, and he that hath no beard is less than a man, and he that is more than a youth is not for me, and he that is less than a man, I am not for him."
- 1.35** All well and good. So we understand what's happening. We know what she's saying. The humor works very well. She's finding excuses why no man is going to work for her. Young, old—it doesn't matter. And the language feels modern in tone. I mean, it's very kind of epigrammatic. There's a false syllogism there. It feels a bit Wildean, doesn't it? That could be in an Oscar Wilde play, and it would make complete sense. It sounds like it's logical, but it's actually a form of cynicism. That's a very Wildean thing to do.
- 1.36** It's ironically self-aware because, of course, she's using her wit as a form of self-defense. This is a recognizable thing. Most readers, most modern readers, won't have a problem with this. But then Beatrice says the following. She says, "Therefore, I will even take sixpence in earnest of the bear-ward and lead his apes into hell." What the hell is that? Most of us are going to be completely, "What's a bear-ward?" Why is she saying she's going to lead apes into hell? Has she gone mad? That's what it sounds like to us.
- 1.37** But it's a joke. It's a joke that doesn't work now. But it did work in 1598 when the play was first performed. The bear-ward was the keeper of the bears. At the time, you'll probably know bear-baiting was very, very popular. Just outside the Globe, there was a

place called The Bear Garden, where they would chain bears and have them attacked by dogs. They would put apes on the back of horses and have them chased. Very cruel, horrible, but very popular.

- 1.38** You would have people leading bears from town to town in chains, so they could be baited by dogs. The bear-ward was a recognizable figure of the time. We just don't know what it is anymore. She's talking about leading apes into hell. She'll pay the bear-ward for her apes. She'll lead the apes into hell. Why? Because there was a proverb of the time that an old maid, a woman who had refused to marry, would end up being punished in hell by leading apes about the place. I don't quite know why, but everyone knew this phrase. Everyone knew it.
- 1.39** So Beatrice is saying, "You know what? I'll take that punishment. I'll do it, so long as I don't have to deal with men." That's how much she doesn't want to deal with men. I get where she's coming from. It's a joke. It's a joke that works really well. It worked really well for an Elizabethan audience, but we get stuck. So, this presents a problem when you're reading a comedy, and you're expecting to be laughing out loud, doesn't it? A bit.
- 1.40** Because real laughter, genuine laughter, is involuntary laughter, isn't it? There are various kinds of laughter. There's social laughter, what we call social lubrication. Next time you have a chat with a taxi driver or a cashier at the bank or just someone you don't know, some stranger, try and clock how often you laugh. You'll find you do it quite a lot. You'll say to a taxi driver, "Oh, is it busy today?" And they'll laugh. "Yeah, it's been quite busy all morning."
- 1.41** What's the laughter for? No one's told a joke. It's social lubrication. It's saying, "We're strangers, but I'm not a threat. You're not a threat. This can be fine." That's the function that that laughter serves. There's another kind of laughter which you see in a lot of comedy clubs, a lot of modern comedy clubs, a lot of modern comedians. They're really politicians rather than comedians. They sermonize rather than tell jokes. People laugh to show that they endorse the point, or they more often than that clap.
- 1.42** That's why, if you ever see a comedian, and they get more clap, more applause, than laughter, it's probably because they're not really funny. They're just saying things that are politically on trend. There's a phrase for that. It's called clapter. But real laughter, genuine laughter, is involuntary. It's from the gut. You must have felt this, where you laugh at something you know you're not meant to, but it just comes out of you. That's the best kind of laughter. And that's the kind of laughter that we sometimes get with the best kind of comedy, I think.
- 1.43** Now, Ben Jonson, who was Shakespeare's great rival, a little bit younger than him, but thought he was above him, he was a real snob, and he didn't like that. He wrote comedies, but he didn't like this about comedy. He actually distrusted it. He wrote that "the moving of laughter is a fault of comedy, a kind of turpitude that depraves some

part of a man's nature." Well, so much for him. Because Shakespeare understands that we often laugh when we don't want to.

- 1.44 Think about—have you ever wanted to laugh at a funeral? I have. It's not because I find it funny that someone's died; it's because I know I shouldn't. The gravity of the event kind of dares you to rebel. This is why—I'm sure you're familiar with Monty Python and John Cleese and Graham Chapman. When Graham Chapman, one of the Monty Python crew, died, John Cleese gave his eulogy. You can watch it online. He says, "Good riddance to him, the free-loading bastard. I hope he fries." That got a laugh at the funeral, not because he means it, but because it's thoroughly inappropriate. And it's the kind of thing that Graham Chapman would have wanted.
- 1.45 People laugh, involuntarily. We laugh against our will sometimes. That presents a problem when we have jokes from the past, a Shakespearean joke that doesn't land with us. Because what are you meant to do in the theater? Are you meant to hear the joke, stop, check your book, check the note? What does that mean? Oh, yeah. Oh, that means that. That's funny. Ha, ha, ha. Then it's not involuntary laughter. Then it's not spontaneous. Then it's not laughter at all. Then it's something else. It's a signal.
- 1.46 So what I'm going to advise you as we go through these comedies is, don't get stuck up on the difficulties of the language. If there's a joke you don't understand, it doesn't matter. Move on. I made this point. I did a series of lectures for the Peterson Academy about tragedies, and I made the point that Shakespeare ultimately is a poet, and poems are not riddles to be solved. When you read a lot of poems, you'll find that there are references and allusions that don't immediately land, that you don't quite understand where they're getting at.
- 1.47 But you can still get to the end of a poem and be moved by it, even if you haven't understood every single reference. That's the way I think you should see Shakespeare's plays. I mean, there are going to be culturally specific allusions that we don't have access to. There are even jokes in Shakespeare that critics don't understand, with all their historical knowledge. And I think, by all means, when you're reading the plays, do check what they mean. Do keep up with that, but don't overly worry about it.
- 1.48 I remember when I was studying the Canterbury Tales as an A-level student, my teacher—we were doing the Miller's Tale, and I was stuck on this because it's Middle English. It's further back than Shakespeare. It's obscure. And he got me to read passages out loud. And what I found straight away is that I started to get the meaning just by that, just by reading out loud. That's why I would say, another good shortcut with Shakespeare is, of course, to watch modern adaptations, film adaptations.
- 1.49 The best thing to do is to choose wisely. Choose those adaptations where you have a cast who understand the meaning. Then it's always conveyed very, very clearly. A good example of this is an adaptation of Twelfth Night from 1996, directed by Trevor Nunn. The cast is incredible. It's got Helena Bonham Carter, Ben Kingsley, Imelda Staunton,

Nigel Hawthorne, Mel Smith, Toby Stephens, Richard E. Grant, star-studded, but well selected, well cast, because they all understand what they're saying. There's never a point when you're watching that film where you'll be stuck.

- 1.50** Another good thing to do is to keep the subtitles on, which you can do nowadays on streaming services, so you have the text in front of you as you watch it. It's a really, really good way of doing it. And particularly, choose adaptations that are faithful to the text. I mean, even something like Baz Luhrmann's *Romeo and Juliet*, it cuts about half the text out, but the text it uses is Shakespeare's text. It's not messing about with it.
- 1.51** The other thing I should say is that after—and I'm aiming this at anyone watching who is relatively new to Shakespeare—there's a kind of barrier you have to get over. If you haven't really read many of his plays, it's going to be off-putting. I think this is what a lot of children find off-putting, but that's where teachers are getting it wrong. You persist. Don't spend a whole term or two terms studying one play. Read through a whole play. Move on to another play. Keep going. What happens is that you find that your mind locks into the language.
- 1.52** I remember as a kid, the first play I studied was *Taming of the Shrew*. I was 10 years old, and I had no clue. I would get stuck on words like "ere", E-R-E. What's that? Then it happened four or five times, and I knew what it meant. It meant before, and it always means before. You just lock into a new way of speaking. Remember, this is not Old English. This is not Middle English; this is modern English. We can understand this. You just have to lock into it.
- 1.53** I mean, a good analogy for this would be the novel *A Clockwork Orange* by Anthony Burgess. It's a novel from the early '60s. It's the one that famously was turned into a film by Stanley Kubrick, which Burgess was annoyed about because he considers it one of his weakest novels. But anyway, what he does very well in that novel is, he creates a new language, a new dialect, called Nadsat. The gang, the young gang of men in that novel, speak their own language.
- 1.54** They say "droogs" instead of friends. And you're reading this—they order a glass of "moloko." What's that? It's milk. They say "horrorshow." They say all sorts of strange phrases. It's a blend of Russian and Cockney rhyming slang and a bit of German. Phrases like "devotchka", meaning a young woman. But I promise you, after the first 10 pages, you're confused. By page 50, 100, you know exactly what they're saying. You've locked into the language. The same thing happens with Shakespeare. So don't be put off by jokes you don't understand.
- 1.55** And the other thing, of course, which I must emphasize, is that the comedies of Shakespeare are not all about the laughter. They're far more layered, far more complex, far more interesting than that. They're not just entertainment pieces; they're works of art. So some will age better than others. If you take the *Merchant of Venice*, a lot of people don't know that the *Merchant of Venice* is a comedy. A lot of people

assume it's a tragedy because it delves into some very, very serious areas. But it is a comedy. But that's aged very, very quickly.

- 1.56** There's a film of *The Merchant of Venice* from 2004, starring Al Pacino as Shylock and Jeremy Irons as Antonio, as directed by Michael Radford. And that feels like a straight-up drama. There are elements of humor in it, but it's played as a drama. In fact, in an early scene, you see Antonio spit on Shylock on the streets of Venice. It's a very serious anti-Semitic moment. And he's trying to let you know, this is what it's going to be about.
- 1.57** But of course, that play, the way we approach that play, changed after the Holocaust. It had to. We have a completely different idea. I'm going to get into that, of course, when we go into *Merchant of Venice*. But my point is that the film is still excellent. Pacino is brilliant as Shylock. It is a really, really impressive film, but you wouldn't watch it for comedic entertainment, is what I'm saying, but it still works as a play. So don't worry about the lack of laughs as you perceive it in Shakespeare. It doesn't matter. At the same time, if you watch a good production of these plays, you will laugh.
- 1.58** I remember reading an interview with Woody Allen once—I can't remember where it was. I think it was about when he was doing *Mighty Aphrodite*. If anyone finds it, let me know. But he was talking about how he regretted not being a tragic writer. He regretted choosing comedy. He was making the point that comedy is going to age, and "I won't be known anymore; my legacy will be gone. Whereas with tragedy, it doesn't matter." He has a point, in a way, because Woody Allen's comedies are all about, well, they're comedies of manners, aren't they? They're very much about a specific time.
- 1.59** They're very much about, a lot of them, particularly the ones set in New York, and he's depicting these urban middle-class, educated, neurotic types of characters. Sometimes he even has a lead role. When he's not in the film, he normally has a proxy for himself, doesn't he? Like when Kenneth Branagh is in *Celebrity* or John Cusack in *Bullets Over Broadway*, he's just playing Woody Allen, isn't he? There's always that character, these stock Woody Allen-ish characters, which do locate it very much in that Manhattan café, therapist-office kind of milieu.
- 1.60** Like Molière, like Sheridan, like Oscar Wilde, Allen satirizes social behavior, affectation, neuroses, within a recognizable social class, the intellectual type, self-absorbed artists, that kind of thing. Pseudo-intellectuals, yeah, cultural snobs. But there is another side to that, because although Woody Allen's films do work on the level of sociological comedies of manners, they also work as philosophical comedies of human folly.
- 1.61** So Woody Allen also addresses universal themes such as the absurdity of desire, guilt, self-delusion, and that stuff doesn't age. All the trappings around it do; the heart of it doesn't. If you think about Oscar—there's a play by Oscar Wilde, *The Importance of Being Earnest*. It's on at the moment in London. National Theater Production, transferred to the West End. If you go and see that, you'll see they've really lent into

the Victorian look of the thing. So the whole thing will look, the cultural furnishings of it will look of its time.

- 1.62** But the play is still really bloody funny. The play really works because, whilst you could see it as a time capsule of an era, the themes, Wilde's cynicism, his arch aphorisms, they always work because there's always going to be a percentage of the population that are cynical and arch, people we know. It doesn't really matter when it's set. Think of it this way. The more a comic form depends on context, the quicker it ages. The more it depends on human folly, the longer it lives, because human beings essentially do not change.
- 1.63** Shakespeare is a master, a specialist in the development of characters. These are timeless qualities. He's dealing with human beings. The emotional states of Shakespeare's characters resonate today because we feel the same way. The past is like a different world with different cultural norms, but ultimately, it's populated by the same people. We haven't really changed. That's what's so wonderful about reading even an ancient Greek text, and you suddenly see an emotion that you feel expressed in a better way than you ever could. It's a really lovely, lovely moment.
- 1.64** This is why Shakespeare's men and women feel real to us. One thing that he does that most writers, virtually all writers, cannot really do is that he creates individuals who leap off the page. They live themselves. They almost escape their author. The way that he has this capacity for creating such a plurality of people who react differently to the same scenarios, think differently, he isn't just writing himself over and over again. Somehow—this is the essence of his genius, I think—somehow he is able to inhabit the mindset of everyone.
- 1.65** It makes him almost godlike within the realm of literature. He could write you. I mean, I see moments of some of his characters where I think, "That's what I would have done. That's what I would think. How does he know that? How can he do that?" He can't have thought like everyone. He was just one man, but he was able to do this. So let's consider some types of comedy, how they've aged, why they've aged, and how they form a precedent for Shakespeare.
- 1.66** If we go back to the father of comedy, Aristophanes, he's considered the father of comedy, fifth century BC, ancient Greece, he writes in what we call the Old Comedy, the form of Old Comedy. He's very interesting, Aristophanes. But a lot of his remaining plays, the plays that survive, are rooted in Athenian politics, very much of the time, the laws and scandals of the time. You have political satire, you've got direct attacks on public figures, you've got these fantastical plots, bawdy humor, absurdist fantastical elements. If you think of the *Clouds* or the *Frogs*.
- 1.67** Now, the elements about Athenian culture have very much dated. Of course they have, and we need a guide. We need academics to tell us what happened, or historians to tell us what he's alluding to there. But sometimes the political satire has parallels today in

really interesting ways. There's a play by Aristophanes called *The Assemblywomen*. Does anyone know this play, *The Assemblywomen*? It's really interesting. It's a play in which the women of Athens disguise themselves as men, infiltrate the Assembly, and then vote to take over the government. So effectively, the joke is, it's a society now run by women.

- 1.68 And what do the women do when they take control? They abolish private property. They abolish marriage. They establish a communal egalitarian society where everything is shared equally, even sexual partners. That sounds a bit like communism, doesn't it? And it's interesting to me. It tallies that, at the moment, I'm seeing all these articles about the way that women, young women, are moving rapidly to the left, all the way to the left. Young men are moving rapidly to the right. You could say that this play by Aristophanes, the father of comedy, is satirizing our political moment.
- 1.69 If you want to see the parallel, was this all being anticipated by Aristophanes? Very interesting. What about the play *Lysistrata*? You might have heard of this one. This is where the women end a war by withholding sex. They say, "We're not going to have sex until you stop fighting." Now, that actually happened in 2012. I know because I was commissioned to write a rapid response play at the Soho Theater in London to a current news event. I was given the news story three days before the show. I had to write it. We had to get actors, direct it, put it on.
- 1.70 What was happening is, high-class escorts in Spain were withholding sex from bankers until they agreed to open up credit to poor families. This was women using sex, withholding sex, from powerful men, to achieve a political goal. That is Aristophanes all over again, but it actually happened just 15 years ago or whatever. So Old Comedy, as I say, has aged because it's specific to the time, but the political parallels are interesting.
- 1.71 But then we go into a new phase, New Comedy, very interesting. New Comedy, late fourth and third century BC in ancient Greece. Most notable figure is Menander from the New Comedy. The Old Comedy of the century of Pericles, that's epitomized by Aristophanes. The New Comedy, the century of Alexander, that is epitomized by Menander. Aristophanes wrote about, well, we think at least 40 plays; 11 of those survived. That's not a bad ratio, actually, given all the stuff we've lost from the ancient world. There's lots of fragments and things like that.
- 1.72 Menander, he wrote even more. He wrote over 100 plays. There's references to over 100 plays by Menander. Hugely popular, even five centuries after his death. I remember the first time I learned about Menander, I was reading many years ago, I was reading a book, and it mentioned Menander. There was a whole passage on Menander. This book, by the way, was written in 1880, and it was talking about how none of his plays survive.
- 1.73 I was reading about it, thinking, "This is really interesting, the New Comedy, the stuff about domestic life and mistaken identity and young lovers." A lot of it seemed very

similar to the stuff we do today, and I wanted to read them. Then it said, "They've all gone." They all went, by the way, because, apparently, the Byzantine priests, many centuries after Menander, got permission from the emperors to burn them all, because they were angry about it. They were offended.

- 1.74** So I was gutted when I read this, and then I went out and I realized this wasn't up to date. I'd been reading a book published in the 1880s. They found one of his plays. They found one in the 1950s, one of Menander's play, just one. By all accounts, not his best play, but at least there's one full play. There's fragments elsewhere, but there's one full play, and it's called *The Bad-Tempered Man*, discovered in the sands of Egypt, on a papyrus, in 1952. It's just fascinating.
- 1.75** You read this play, it's about a misanthrope, obviously, as the title suggests, a guy called Knemon, and he hates everyone. I'll tell you about this because it gives you a sense of what New Comedy is all about. He hates everyone. He rails against the world, hates human beings, doesn't want to be around any human. He just wants privacy. This is a very good example of the kind of stock comic trope that doesn't go away, does it? It never ages. So this is what happens. I'll just read it to you.
- 1.76** This is when Knemon enters in the play, the first time you see him. He begins by talking about Perseus, and if you don't know, Perseus was the warrior who killed Medusa. He borrowed the winged sandals of Hermes so he could fly off and kill Medusa. And this is what Knemon says. He walks in, grumbling. He's annoyed already; straightaway, he's annoyed. He walks in, he says, "Well, wasn't Perseus the lucky one—twice over, too. First, he could fly, so he never had to meet any of these who walk the Earth; and then he had this marvelous device which he used to turn anyone who annoyed him into stone. I wish I had that now. There'd be no shortage of stone statues around here."
- 1.77** You see, straightaway, he doesn't want to see anyone. He wants to get rid of everyone. Then he says, "Life is becoming intolerable, by God it is. People are actually walking onto my land now, and talking to me. Heaven, here's another one, standing right beside my door," and he sees Sostratos, this young man, who says, "Oh, I wonder if he'll hit me?" And Knemon says, "Privacy—you can't find it anywhere, not even if you want to hang yourself."
- 1.78** Then Sostratos says, "Am I offending you, sir? I'm waiting here for someone. I arranged to meet him." And Knemon says, "What did I tell you? Do you and your friends think this is a public walkway? Sure, make a date to meet at my door, if you want to see someone. Feel free. Pull up a bench if you want. Build yourselves a clubhouse." Doesn't that sound just like Basil Fawlty? Doesn't that sound exactly like Basil Fawlty from *Fawlty Towers*? It's this kind of thing he would say. I can hear John Cleese saying it, when I read those words.
- 1.79** But the difference is, of course, there is a difference. Basil Fawlty is really angered by the plebs. He doesn't want to be around people. Everyone's always bothering him,

even his wife. But when he thinks he's with a lord or someone slightly important, he is obsequious and fawning and overly polite. Do you remember when he, in the first episode of *Fawlty Towers*, when he meets Lord Melbury, or the man he thinks is Lord Melbury, he's really deferential, unlike when he's talking to Manuel, who he just slaps around the place.

- 1.80 So that's a very interesting comic precedent, a kind of variation of the Knemon thing, except Knemon hates everyone all the time. Basil Fawlty is a bit more complex, because Basil Fawlty, he's a snob trapped in a life of service. He's always thinking, "I should be better than this. Everyone is my inferior."
- 1.81 Isn't that Malvolio to a tee? Isn't that what Malvolio is? Isn't he a Basil Fawlty? I mean, look at the way that Malvolio treats Sir Toby Belch and Andrew Aguecheek and Feste and Maria, when he goes in and finds them drinking at night. Look at the snobbish. He's oozing with snobbishness and disdain. Then as soon as he's talking to Lady Olivia, the countess, totally different story, deferential.
- 1.82 What I'm saying, I suppose, is that the human dynamics that you get in the New Comedy of Menander recur throughout history. You can see a direct line from Menander to Shakespeare, right through to a 1970s sitcom, such as *Fawlty Towers*. It never ends. We're talking about how jokes age. These stock characters, these scenarios, they don't. They keep recurring. We acknowledge that comedy ages, but in some respects, it never does.
- 1.83 I don't think it's an accident, by the way, that some of those sitcoms from the early 2000s have already aged, and *Fawlty Towers* hasn't. If you watch an old *Fawlty Towers* episode, there's a production of *Fawlty Towers* on the London stage at the moment. A lot of young people are going to see it, and a lot of young people are seeing it anew, and they're laughing. They haven't seen it before, and it still survives in a way that a lot of the sitcoms that came much later just died. It's very interesting.
- 1.84 We've seen how the Old Comedy and New Comedy of ancient Greece can still resonate. We then move forward a bit. We go to the Roman comedy of the third to second century BC. Most notably, we're talking about Terence, we're talking about Plautus. These are Roman writers that Shakespeare would have encountered at grammar school, as well as the tragedians, Seneca being the most obvious. And Plautus and Terence were very influential on the likes of Molière, the *commedia dell'arte* tradition, the Italian tradition, which, of course, is entirely grounded in stock characters.
- 1.85 Shakespeare knew these writers. Plautus and Terence were adapting the New Comedy of Menander. And so you get these stock characters. Stock characters of Roman comedy are things like the braggart soldier, or the clever slave, or the miser, those kind of characters, all of which recur later in Shakespeare. We can see, of course, the most obvious influence of Plautus, or Plautus, sorry, in Shakespeare, is the Comedy of Errors,

which is based explicitly on a play by Plautus called the *Menaechmi*. We'll get onto that in the next lecture.

- 1.86** I could carry on, on this line. We could talk about the various styles of comedy, branches of comedy, that have influenced Shakespeare. Conscious of time, so I just want to finally mention the medieval comedy tradition, which is of the 12th to 15th centuries. Broad farce, moral and social satire, the carnivalesque inversion of authority, all of these things that Shakespeare drew upon.
- 1.87** That's often the function of the clowns in Shakespeare, is that they're the ones with the authority, the working-class figures who can speak truth to power, could say whatever they want and not get their heads cut off. Very important characters, most notably, of course, in *Lear*. But there's clowns and fools in lots and lots of Shakespeare's plays. We're going to be talking a bit about that. There's two in *As You Like It*. We'll get onto that.
- 1.88** And of course, farce—farce, slapstick, physical humor, these are common aspects to all phases of comedy, all of them, all of the ones that I've been describing. They don't ever age, do they? The pompous schoolmaster who falls over on the stage at school, you all remember that? Straightaway, it's funny. The priest who slips on a banana skin? Funny. Powerful people falling over is always funny. Anyone falling over is a bit funny. We've all had that experience. Someone falls over, your instinct is, you laugh, and then you say, "Oh, are you OK?" We've all done that. Because there's an instinct, isn't it? Again, it's that thing of laughing at things we know we're not meant to.
- 1.89** Just this week, I heard Donald Trump. He was talking about how Biden kept falling over. He said, "I really make sure," because Donald Trump's getting on. He's about 80. He was saying, "I really make sure I don't fall over. I'm going to be very careful. I just think to myself, don't fall over." Why? Because he knows, it's the best way to deflate power. Hannah Arendt wrote about that. She said, "Laughter is the surest way to undermine authority." She was right, and he knows it.
- 1.90** Comedy came easy to Shakespeare. It was very natural, I think, to Shakespeare. I think, with tragedy, he had to learn his way a bit more. If you go to his first tragedy, it was *Titus Andronicus*, not his best work. The great tragedies are much later in the Jacobean period, really—*Othello*, *King Lear*, *Macbeth*, and *Hamlet*, of course, which is roughly 1600, so end of Elizabeth's reign. Those are masterpieces. *Hamlet* is unsurpassed, but he had to learn his way, edge his way.
- 1.91** When you read *Titus Andronicus*, I still like it, actually. I think it's better than people say. But it is very indebted to Christopher Marlowe, the tradition of Christopher Marlowe's plays, and it's very Seneca. It's a Senecan tragedy. There are elements of Seneca in *Hamlet* as well, but this is very direct. It's unsubtle. It doesn't have the psychological depth. You don't get those great soliloquies of the tragic hero on stage,

revealing to the audience what he's feeling, sometimes revealing to the audience something he doesn't even understand himself.

- 1.92** That's the complexity of those soliloquies. That's the innovation. No one had done that before Shakespeare, and no one's done it as well since. But as a comedian, I think we get the sense that Shakespeare was a natural comedian. He just knew it. He just got it. You know those people with funny bones? I think he just had it. If you go to the early comedies, and they're not the best comedies that he wrote, but if you think of the *Taming of the Shrew*, *Comedy of Errors*, *Love's Labour's Lost*, they land; straightaway, they land.
- 1.93** They don't have those clumsy moments that *Titus Andronicus* has. He has an instinct for it. Yes, they get more refined. The early comedies, the apprentice plays, they seem a bit formulaic, they seem a bit rigid with end-stopped lines and rhyming couplets. The language became more flexible, more interesting. He was using language in far more interesting ways; and most importantly, of course, there's far greater psychological depth when you get to *Twelfth Night*, when you get to *As You Like It*. We're dealing with real human beings there, not so much in the early comedies.
- 1.94** Actually, Samuel Johnson pointed this out a long time before me. He said that, in comedy, Shakespeare "seems to repose, or to luxuriate, as in a mode of thinking congenial to his nature." I hope to show in these lectures that he is exactly right. So let's just talk a bit about genre in Shakespeare's time, the traditional division of Shakespeare's plays. Now, I've talked about the late romances, I've mentioned the problem plays, but broadly speaking, we think of Shakespeare's plays as being divided into the histories, the comedies, and the tragedies.
- 1.95** Now, that didn't really happen as a tripartite division until 1623. What happened in 1623? Shakespeare had been dead for seven years, eight years, something like that. Two actors in his company, the King's Men, John Heminge and Henry Condell, they published a folio, a big book of Shakespeare's plays. This is key. Without that big book of Shakespeare's plays, we would have lost about half of his work. So let me explain how, a bit about the publication history, because I'm going to use these words, and I want you not to be confused about what I'm talking about.
- 1.96** During Shakespeare's lifetime, now he was writing for around 20 years, right, so gets to London around 1587. His early plays 1592, 1593, finishes around 1611, with the final play, *Henry VIII*, which ended up destroying the Globe, burnt down the Globe, because there was a cannon went off, hit the thatched roof, the whole thing went down. What an ending. Shakespeare's writing for about 20 years, *Hamlet* right in the middle, that's the way to think of it, and spanning two monarchs, Elizabeth and James. James VI of Scotland became James I of England when he came down.
- 1.97** Throughout that time, you've got to remember that the theater wasn't really seen as high art. There wasn't really any reason why would you publish this? It was

entertainment. It was bawdy. It was low-brow. But of course, it wasn't, because of the likes of the University Wits, people like Marlowe and Thomas Kyd and George Peele and John Lyly, and people like Ben Jonson, those people who were dignified, making it more literary.

- 1.98** What's really interesting about Shakespeare, he comes into this moment and he has this perfect moment where he is blending the low-brow and the high-brow. That's why his plays are so great. That's why it's good he didn't go to university, because he wasn't an intellectual like Ben Jonson or Thomas Kyd. Thank goodness for that. It isn't over-intellectualized. This is at a time when, at the theater, half of the people in that theater would have been the groundlings, poor, dirt-poor.
- 1.99** Also, the very richest in society would have been there as well, in the galleries. What an interesting combination of social class, high and low art. But the theater wasn't really dignified for a long, long time. What happened was, sometimes the popular plays were published, and they found their way into what we call quarto editions. Now, a quarto edition is, basically, created by folding a page twice over. You end up with four leaves, hence quarto, eight pages. Each leaf is about 9 by 12 inches.
- 1.100** These are small little booklets, quite perishable. A lot of them went. They were overused, they fell apart. A lot of them survive, but a lot of them don't; most of them don't. But then you get a folio. A folio is a big, luxury, prestige volume, hard-bound, leather-bound book. Folio means leaf, and that's a sheet that is folded once. So you end up with two leaves and four pages. And then you put them all together and you make a book. These are bigger as well. They're 12 by 18 inches in size, and luxury items, as I say.
- 1.101** So Heminge and Condell decide, after Shakespeare's death, "We're going to create this book and we're going to preserve for posterity Shakespeare's plays." There are 38 confirmed plays by Shakespeare. There's a few we don't have. We don't have Cardenio, we don't have Love's Labour's Won, but we have most of them. But only 20 were published in quarto edition during his lifetime, and a lot of them were bad. A lot of those were quartos that were created by actors who were in the company, who, from memory, wrote down what they thought the script was. So you get these bad quartos.
- 1.102** There's one of Henry IV, there's one of Hamlet, where they're not right; they're from memory. But the folio, largely, Heminge and Condell, and Ben Jonson, who was involved as well, used Shakespeare's foul papers. The foul papers are his own handwritten plays. None of those survived, by the way, but they had them. And so, these are more definitive texts, preserved, 1,000 copies printed. There's about 230 left. You can see one if you go to the Folger Shakespeare Library; they have quite a number of them—big valuable books.
- 1.103** If they hadn't have done that, we would have lost half of his plays. Macbeth would have gone. Antony and Cleopatra would have been gone. If you think about—it doesn't

really bear thinking about, what they did, the efforts they went to. This is why there's a monument to Heminge and Condell in London, quite near to where Shakespeare lived in Silver Street. Silver Street doesn't exist anymore, but you can find the monument.

- 1.104** And yet, it's right, because without them, we probably wouldn't be here, talking about Shakespeare today. But they divided in the—the reason I mentioned all of this, first of all, because I want you to understand, when I talk about a quarto, when I talk about folio, you now understand what I'm saying. But also, they divided on the title page, or rather the contents page, they listed the plays by comedy, tragedy, and history. But it's not always very clear-cut.
- 1.105** Where'd you put *Troilus and Cressida*? Where does that go? Well, they got around that by leaving it out of the contents page. It's not there. It's in the folio, but it's just not on the contents page. But Shakespeare doesn't really adhere to typical ideas of genre. Now, Aristotle wrote a famous text called *The Poetics*, in which he set down his rules or laws of tragedy. He also wrote a second part of *The Poetics* about comedy. If you've seen *The Name of the Rose*, or read *The Name of the Rose*, that's what the whole plot is about, discovering that old text, or part of the plot, anyway.
- 1.106** We don't really know what Aristotle wholly thought about comedy, but he certainly thought that tragedy was far more dignified. So did Plato, because, of course, tragedy was for them a form of religious devotion. Those tragic plays, they were a religious ceremony. Of course, they thought it was more important. Comedy was low-brow; it was entertainment. That's all it was.
- 1.107** Aristotle has very strict ideas about what you should do in what genre. Shakespeare blends it. He doesn't really care about that. So he often has clowns. I mean, *Hamlet*, look at the gravedigger scene. Why is a clown turning up in the middle of *Hamlet*? *Othello*, there's a clown there. Why? Because he doesn't really observe any rules, even the rules that were set by his contemporaries.
- 1.108** Philip Sidney, who's a bit earlier than him, but Philip Sidney is a great courtier poet and genre theorist. He wrote, he hated the idea of mixing these genres. He mentioned tragicomedy; he called it a mongrel. He didn't like this idea of blending the two. He said, as soon as you got a clown in a tragedy, it ceases to be a tragedy. Well, not according to Shakespeare. Likewise, he'll have a full-on comedy, and then suddenly you have a moment of tragedy or despair. He'll always blend it.
- 1.109** It's not very easy to pigeonhole Shakespeare's—I know that's what I'm doing, by doing a series of lectures on Shakespeare's comedies and doing another one on the tragedies. But really, I'm cheating. Really, I'm fudging it because, as you'll see, and as we go through, you'll definitely, hopefully see, there's a continual blend. We might want to look to Chaucer's famous definition of tragedy. In *The Monk's Tale*, he says that tragedy is a narrative story of one who falls from prosperity into misery, teaching us not to trust our temporary good fortune. The reverse, I suppose, is true of comedy.

- 1.110** This is a rule of thumb when you think about the genres: tragedy really depicts order descending into chaos; comedy does the reverse—everything is chaotic, and then it's all resolved. Why is it? Of course, why do all comedies end in marriage? All of Shakespeare's comedies end in marriage, except for the Comedy of Errors, but of course, that ends with family reconciliation, and the husband and wife who have been parted for many years meeting again. So he restores harmony that way.
- 1.111** All the other comedies end in marriage, except for Love's Labour's Lost, but that's postponed marriage. They say, "We will marry in a year." So, marriage is a tool to restore harmony and order after that period of chaos, whereas the reverse is true of tragedy. If you think about Macbeth, Macbeth starts, Macbeth is a great hero. He's just defeated the rebel, Macdonwald, in battle. He's at the height of his reputation. And then it all goes to pot because he kills the king, his cousin.
- 1.112** And that's why Dante's Divine Comedy is a comedy, not because it makes us laugh, but because it starts out in the inferno and it ends up in paradise. It starts out in despair and ends up in salvation. That's the hallmark. That's the trajectory of comedy. I want you all to keep that in mind as we go through, this broad point that Shakespeare does not adhere to strict definitions of genre. He's not interested in it.
- 1.113** To prove this point, I'm going to end now on this one key point. Who is Shakespeare's greatest comic creation? Well, it's Falstaff, Sir John Falstaff, the fat knight. He's the most famous, the most successful, even within his own lifetime, it was the most successful comedic character that Shakespeare ever created. I'm not talking about the Falstaff of the Merry Wives of Windsor, who, as we'll see in the next lecture, is a bit of an imposter. I'm talking about the Falstaff of Henry IV, Part One, and Henry IV, Part Two, the history plays.
- 1.114** Falstaff is a figure from the history plays, but he's the epitome of Shakespeare's comic genius. So doesn't that tell you everything? If Shakespeare was adhering to genre very strictly, in the way as we understand it, Falstaff would have been in Twelfth Night, not Sir Toby Belch, who's a far less sophisticated character. Now, Falstaff, as I say, I think he represents the high point of what is possible in a literary comedic characterization. He's a glutton, he's a mischief-maker, he's a coward.
- 1.115** All these traits we would normally assume are rebarbative traits, but we don't find them rebarbative. We love him for it. We even love him when he claims to have killed Hotspur at the Battle of Shrewsbury, having spent the battle pretending to be dead, because he doesn't want to get into a fight. But we don't admire it, but we delight in it, and Falstaff is all about reveling in existence. He's the most alive character, I think, in Shakespeare. He loves the company of his friends, the teasing, the gaming, sex and food and alcohol.
- 1.116** He's all about excess. He understands that life is finite. It's to be enjoyed. Now, this is how the great critic, A. C. Bradley, put it. He said that Falstaff is "the humorist of genius."

Instead of being comic to you and serious to himself, he is more ludicrous to himself than to you. And he makes himself out more ludicrous than he is, in order that he and others may laugh. Prince Hal never made such sport of Falstaff's person as he himself did."

- 1.117** Because Falstaff is an intellect as well. He's smart, he's witty. He wants to make you laugh, even if it makes himself look worse. He's an entertainer. He's all about bringing life into any given scenario. Bradley points out that Falstaff is not a slave to his own vices. He's too self-aware. The self-awareness of Falstaff is fascinating. He's always one step ahead of you. In most of the plays, there's always a moment of dramatic irony, where the audience knows something that the characters don't. That doesn't happen with Falstaff.
- 1.118** It doesn't happen with Rosalind in *As You Like It*, either. Supremely self-aware. But Falstaff does indulge. He eats too much, drinks too much, whores too much. It's a comedy of excess. This is how A. C. Bradley accounts for it. He says, "The direct enjoyment they," as in, the direct enjoyment his appetites bring him, "is scarcely so great as the enjoyment of laughing at this enjoyment; and for all his addiction to sack, you never see him for an instant with a brain dulled by it, or a temper turned solemn, silly, quarrelsome, or pious. The bliss of freedom gained in humor is the essence of Falstaff."
- 1.119** And to think, to live with that liberty, to live as Quentin Crisp once said, "as though there was no such thing as praise or blame." The character of Falstaff has become so iconic, he's even birthed his own adjective, Falstaffian. That's how culturally significant he is. He is larger than life in every sense. He is, as Prince Hal, Henry V, or then Prince Hal who becomes Henry V, he says of Falstaff, he is "that trunk of humors, that bolting-hutch of beastliness, that swollen parcel of dropsies, that huge bombard of sack, that stuffed cloak-bag of guts, that roasted Manningtree ox with the pudding in his belly, that reverend Vice, that gray iniquity, that father ruffian, that vanity in years."
- 1.120** And elsewhere, Hal says to his face, "This sanguine coward, this bed-presser, this horse-back-breaker, this huge hill of flesh." Falstaff has to be fat because he is larger than life. He is life to the full. And this friendship between him and the future king, it's all about rough-and-tumble badinage, but it's about as touching a friendship as exists in Shakespeare's work. And this makes it doubly painful when Prince Hal becomes Henry V and rejects him publicly. Do you remember that incredible scene? "I know thee not, old man." It's actually chilling.
- 1.121** But it's what he has to do, because he can't be the young mischief-making, thieving, drinking lout that Prince Hal is in the company of Falstaff. He has to grow up. He has to become the king. He's got responsibility. Those plays are amazing. I don't want to dwell on it, because I might get around to do a series on the history plays, so I don't want to dwell on it too much.

1.122 But for now, suffice it to say that, if any case were to be made for Shakespeare's innate comic mastery, one need look no further than Falstaff. He is the eternal reminder that Shakespeare was one of the truly great comedians. Falstaff is indispensable. As Falstaff says himself, "Banish plump Jack, and banish all the world."

Lecture 2: Merry Wives & Comedy of Errors

At a glance — The Merry Wives of Windsor and The Comedy of Errors.

- 2.1** A number of years ago, I was commissioned to write a farce for a theater, and the only condition was that I had to have three entrances and exits on stage. And that makes sense because so much of farce, the genre of farce, is about confusion, misdirection. You often have characters dashing in and out of doors, coming in at the wrong time, seeing the wrong thing, misunderstanding what they've seen, mistaken identities, that kind of thing. The best of farce is escalate, and they keep escalating to the point where the audience becomes as confused as the characters. You can't even keep a handle on the plot anymore. It's too anarchic.
- 2.2** A good example of this is a farce called *What the Butler Saw* by Joe Orton, which is from 1967. It was written just before he was murdered. There's a fantastic BBC version available, starring Prunella Scales of *Fawlty Towers* fame, and Timothy West, her husband. By the second half, when you watch this, you'll see, by the second half, you don't know who's where and what they're doing. They're running in and out, they're in disguise, they've got different props. You're not meant to keep a handle on the plot in farce. It's supposed to spiral out of control.
- 2.3** Now, in this lecture, I want to talk about two farces of Shakespeare. Shakespeare generally didn't write farces. He wasn't above bringing in farcical elements. I would say he only wrote three plays that could be classified as farce, and that would be *The Merry Wives of Windsor*, *The Comedy of Errors*, and *The Taming of the Shrew*, and I'm going to focus on the first two of those in this lecture.
- 2.4** *The Merry Wives of Windsor* has the distinction of being the only Shakespearean comedy that is set in England, unless you count *The Taming of the Shrew*, because although that's set in Padua, in Italy, the induction of that—it's a play within a play—and the induction is set in Warwickshire, so that does count, if you like. But apart from that, apart from that framing device, *Merry Wives of Windsor* is the only English play.
- 2.5** Although that said, in a lot of Shakespeare comedies, he may be writing about Athens or Verona, but it feels like England a lot of the time. As *You Like It* doesn't really feel like France, does it? It feels more like England. Anyway, the *Merry Wives of Windsor* centers around one key figure, and that figure is an imposter in more ways than one. He's an imposter because, in the play, he ends up having to be disguised as an old witch. He's trying to pretend to be something that he isn't.
- 2.6** But he's also an imposter in a much more significant way, which is that this is ostensibly Sir John Falstaff, who we spoke about in the previous lecture. In fact, the original quarto edition of *The Merry Wives of Windsor* from 1602 was entitled not *The Merry Wives of Windsor*; it was called *A Most Pleasant and Excellent Conceited Comedy of Sir*

John Falstaff and the Merry Wives of Windsor. That gives you a sense of Falstaff's centrality in that play.

- 2.7 Falstaff, as we know, is the star character of the Henry IV plays. The legend has it that Queen Elizabeth I was so taken with the fat knight that she said to Shakespeare, "I want you to write a play about Falstaff in love." Legend has it, he wrote this in a couple of weeks. It was a direct request, and they think that he wrote it between the first and the second part of Henry IV. Now, this story was first recorded by a critic and dramatist called John Dennis in 1702. It was a good long while after Merry Wives of Windsor, which we can date to around 1597.
- 2.8 Now, Dennis didn't specify where he got this story from. It's probably just another example of oral tradition, the folklore, the kind of thing—you know, we hear, there are hints about Shakespeare passed down by word of mouth through the ages, things like his first job in London at the theater was tying up the horses for the richer audience members, or that he was once a schoolmaster in the country. We have no solid evidence for these things, but they got passed down.
- 2.9 But it is possible that The Merry Wives of Windsor was written very quickly to fulfill the request of Elizabeth I. It would explain a few things. It would explain why the play feels relatively slight in comparison with the other comedies, particularly since this was written later. It wasn't one of the early apprentice plays. It was written in 1597, so he was at the height of his powers. He's about to write Hamlet, for goodness' sake. And some critics have even argued that it's not Shakespeare's work at all, but that he had simply revised an existing text very, very quickly.
- 2.10 But I don't buy that. I think there are too many passages in this play that do clearly bear Shakespeare's fingerprints. It's more possible, I think, that he revised one of his own plays, possibly one of his early plays. That's possible. Or that he just wrote it very, very quickly. Why not? It was a request from the Queen. I think that's most likely. But what we do know, really—and I think we can all agree on this—is that the Falstaff of this play is not the same Falstaff as the Henry IV plays. It's an imposter. He doesn't have the wit, he doesn't have the wisdom, he doesn't have the subtle intelligence.
- 2.11 He has a couple of lines that could have been the original Falstaff. But apart from that, it's a kind of fraudulent version. He's more like Toby Belch from Twelfth Night. This is why lots of critics hate this play. They really loathe this play, because they love Falstaff, and they hate to see Falstaff desecrated in this way. He was the most popular character in Shakespeare's lifetime. This is why Harold Bloom, excuse me, Harold Bloom, who wrote a book called Shakespeare: The Invention of the Human, in 1998, a really great critic, he refers to Falstaff in Merry Wives of Windsor as the "pseudo-Falstaff."
- 2.12 The play does feel like a commission, not a labor of love. This is what Bloom writes. He says, "There are hints throughout that Shakespeare is uncomfortable with what he is doing and wishes to get it over with as rapidly as possible." Well, maybe. But if that's

the case, I don't think we can begrudge Queen Elizabeth I. She loved the plays. She loved Henry IV. She loved Falstaff. If you were the monarch with ultimate power, and you had the greatest writer who ever lived, wouldn't you put in a few requests? He has to do it.

- 2.13** We shouldn't give her a hard time, by the way, because Queen Elizabeth I enabled Shakespeare. He could not have flourished. The theater as a genre could not have flourished if it weren't for the fact that there was a monarch on the throne who loved the theater. I told you before, this wasn't high art, but she supported it financially. She was well behind it, great lover of the arts, apparently a very good dancer.
- 2.14** Let's make this clear then—the Falstaff of *Merry Wives of Windsor* isn't really Falstaff, isn't really the Falstaff of the Henry IV plays. We know it's not the same character, because for one thing, the play seems to be set in the England of Shakespeare's time, the Windsor of Shakespeare's time. You might have been to Windsor. Everything about it—the domestic arrangements, the town of Windsor, the local references—it all seems to point to the 1590s.
- 2.15** Now, if this was Falstaff, it couldn't be in the 1590s. He was a friend of Henry V. We'd have to be in the early 15th century. We know it's not really Falstaff. And Mistress Quickly, who is also in *Merry Wives of Windsor*, doesn't seem to know Falstaff all of a sudden. So these aren't the same characters; he's using kind of stock figures. And the other thing, of course, if Elizabeth had requested for there to be a play about Falstaff in love, it's incoherent.
- 2.16** Such a play wouldn't really—Shakespeare, I can't imagine, would have wanted to write a play about Falstaff in love. Falstaff doesn't fall in love. He would be very, very cynical about that. And he doesn't actually, in *Merry Wives of Windsor*. What he's doing is trying to extract money from people through sex. It's not the same thing. It's a form of love, I suppose. This is a Falstaff that the author himself seems to want to punish, want to disregard. He's a Falstaff; he's always the butt of the joke. He never gets the upper hand.
- 2.17** He sets about seducing these two merry wives, Mistress Page and Mistress Ford, but they're always smarter than him, and so they're able to turn the tables on him. He writes identical love letters to both; never crosses his mind, apparently, that they might share them and compare them. When he comes to woo Mistress Ford, her husband arrives, and so the wives hide him in a laundry basket and dump him in the Thames.
- 2.18** On another occasion, they disguise him as a local witch, the old woman of Brentford, one of the few occasions where a man dresses as a woman on the Shakespearean stage. Then, of course, Falstaff, dragged up, is then beaten up by Master Ford. Finally, of course, the wives' ultimate humiliation: they have him dress up as Herne the Hunter, complete with big horns. You can imagine the big fat man, big horns, in the wood. It's a

mocking image. It brings to mind the idea of the cuckold, which is, of course, what he was trying to do to the husbands. He was trying to make them cuckolds.

- 2.19** They meet him in the woods, and the children dressed up as fairies, they pinch him, they burn him. He's just continually punished throughout the play. The play starts with him—we hear that he's been poaching deer, and people are annoyed with him. Then he's trying to seduce the wives, and then he wants money. He just gets punished and punished and punished and humiliated all the way through. All of this does suggest that this is a character that Shakespeare is perfectly happy to torment.
- 2.20** Now, the Falstaff of Henry IV, he is gulled, not least by Prince Hal and Poins, when they get in disguise and they rob him; and then later on, Falstaff reports back to them—because they were in disguise, he didn't know it was them—and so he says, "Oh, yes, dozens of bandits attacked me." He completely lies to their faces. But in terms of humiliation, that prank comes nowhere near what he experiences in *The Merry Wives of Windsor*.
- 2.21** Now, it doesn't feel cruel or vicious in the way that the gulling of Malvolio, for instance, in *Twelfth Night*, feels cruel and vicious. But it is immensely undignified, isn't it? Now, *The Merry Wives of Windsor* has had an odd theatrical history, insofar as it used to be hugely popular. In the 18th century, it was very, very popular, and then it kind of fell out of fashion. Nowadays, you rarely see it performed at all.
- 2.22** I do find that a bit strange, actually, because although it's not Shakespeare's finest hour, by any means, it still does work brilliantly in performance. If it's done well, it can be very, very good. If you can get over that concern about it not being the real Falstaff, if you can get over that, it's a really fun play. I think maybe it doesn't speak to our times. We're going to get on to the *Taming of the Shrew* in the next lecture and how that's been criticized by some feminist critics for making a powerful woman the subject of farce.
- 2.23** A lot of people say that that is a misogynist, and a lot of people have taken that as evidence that Shakespeare was a misogynist, which is an absurd claim, because the author has been dead for 400 years. Everyone who knew him has been dead for 400 years. We don't know his opinions about anything, least of all women. There are no diaries, there are no interviews. There's just the plays. What you end up doing is, it's all guesswork. You don't know what he thought.
- 2.24** Trying to work out an author's personality from what they write makes no sense, because you may as well say that Stephen King is really happy to murder people, just because he keeps writing about murdering people. Of course he doesn't. He's not a violent man. He just writes about violence. It's not the same thing. This seems pretty basic stuff, but it does have to be reemphasized, because there seems to be a whole generation of critics who are more like moral detectives, trying to work out where they feel Shakespeare was evil or wrong.

- 2.25 We don't know anything about him. If you want to base it in historical fact, that's a different thing. He was, for instance, hoarding grain at a time when grain was much needed. You might make a moral judgment about that, but that's a historical fact. Even then, we don't know the circumstances behind it. We have to be very wary about this.
- 2.26 I actually heard recently on the radio or a podcast, there was a feminist theater director who was saying that she was staging a version of *The Merry Wives of Windsor*, but she cut out the scene where Ford beats up Falstaff dressed as a woman, because she said, "The beating of women is never funny." Well, actual violence is never funny. I agree. But staged violence can be very funny. It's not the same thing.
- 2.27 Look at the moment in *Pulp Fiction*. Remember the moment when John Travolta accidentally shoots a man in the head in the back of the car, because Samuel L. Jackson has driven over a bump in the road? It's horrific. The head explodes. It's horrible. But we laugh because we know it's not real, because we know it's fictional. If that was a real person getting shot in the head by John Travolta, I'd be upset about it. It'd be a tragedy, but it doesn't happen. Makeup. It's effects.
- 2.28 By the way, it's not a woman getting beaten up in that scene. It's Falstaff. It's Falstaff dressed as a woman, or the pseudo-Falstaff, whatever you want to call it. Violence, you see, is an aspect of slapstick. And as we covered in the last lecture, slapstick is an element of comedy that recurs throughout history. Look at *Tom and Jerry*. *Tom and Jerry*, that's for kids. It's not endorsing violence, but it's really violent. I mean, that poor animal gets its head slammed between doors and under irons and all sorts of horrific things.
- 2.29 But we know the difference between real life and fiction, hopefully. If anything, by the way, I think *The Merry Wives of Windsor* seems to empower the female characters, quite obviously. I think it could even be said to be a proto-feminist play. I mean, the men are all ridiculous, aren't they? Ford is a gibbering wreck because he's so terrified of being cuckolded. The suitors of Anne Page are ridiculous, Slender and Dr. Caius.
- 2.30 Falstaff is outplayed by Mistress Ford and Mistress Page at every single step of the way. Anne Page gets to choose the suitor she wants. Even her parents don't want her. You've got Dr. Caius, you've got Slender, she gets Fenton. She gets the man she wants. She chooses. Her other suitors are tricked into going off with boys. Dr. Caius actually marries a boy, thinking it's a girl, thinking it's Anne.
- 2.31 Incidentally, pronunciation. There's a college in Cambridge called Gonville and Caius. Dr. Caius, or Caius, is spelled the same way, but it's pronounced differently—just clarifying that. But I would say that if Shakespeare is a misogynist, because he makes a woman the target of a farce in *The Taming of the Shrew*, then on the evidence of *The Merry Wives of Windsor*, Shakespeare is also a misandrist. You see how we can't really do this? We can't really make judgments about a long-dead author on the basis of his works.

- 2.32** Now, one of the repeated jokes in *The Merry Wives of Windsor* is on the theme of cuckoldry. Very important. It's not just *Merry Wives of Windsor*; it's throughout Shakespeare. Cuckoldry was hilarious to the Elizabethans. They found it really, really funny, the idea of a man, a man's wife, cheating on him. So, to the Elizabethans, the cuckold was a hilarious figure, a man whose wife had cheated on him, and it was one of those jokes that just recurred at the time.
- 2.33** When I was growing up, the conventional joke was about mother-in-laws, or mothers-in-law. That was the joke. Of course, both of those forms of joke, the joke about the mother-in-law and the joke about the cheating wife, both are related to the idea feeling emasculated, men losing their power. That's what that was all about. It was important at the time for reasons which are obvious if you think about it for a moment.
- 2.34** Society in Elizabethan England was patrilineal. It meant that property and titles and names were passed through the male lines. So a man's legitimate heirs were essential to the continuation of the bloodline and the estate. And because there was no way to confirm paternity, other than "he looks a bit like me," a man's only guarantee that his children were his own children were his wife's fidelity, his wife's commitment. So that's why cuckoldry was so feared.
- 2.35** Sexual jealousy wasn't just personal; it was existential. And that's why comedy makes use of it. That's why it's so powerful in comedy, because comedy always addresses our anxieties. It always has. This is why comedians have a tendency to offend, because they address those sensitive issues that we're all worried about. The Elizabethans were obsessed with cuckoldry. They were afraid of cuckoldry. And so, what choice did they have but to laugh at it?
- 2.36** So you'll find, as we go through, this image of the cuckold comes up again and again in the plays of Shakespeare. And the image of Falstaff in the horns, in Act 5 of *Merry Wives of Windsor*, that's a visual reification of the cuckold, because the cuckold had always been associated with the myth of Actaeon, which is the myth—if you read Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, you'll see that Actaeon is a hunter, and he accidentally sees the goddess Diana bathing naked, and as a result, she is enraged. She transforms him into a stag, and he is hunted by his own hounds and torn apart.
- 2.37** For whatever reason, that was connected to the idea of cuckoldry in the Elizabethan mindset. It symbolically became tied to this idea that if a man cannot control his wife, he'll be torn apart by the jealousy or by the mockery of others. So horns, whenever you hear horns mentioned in Shakespeare, it usually means the cuckold. "Horn-mad" is a phrase that's often used. Planting horns in someone's head. It always alludes to the idea of the cuckold.
- 2.38** It's a shorthand for male humiliation through female sexuality, which is a very subversive thing, of course, and it gives power to women. That's another thing that it does. We'll get into that later, when we get to *As You Like It*. Now, before we move on

to the Comedy of Errors, I just want to discuss one particular scene in the Merry Wives of Windsor, which seems to me to be pure Shakespearean. So, for all these debates about how much of it is his, how much of it he revised, this just strikes me as very Shakespeare.

- 2.39** I should give you some context to this—Shakespeare did not attend university. It might have been because his father was in too much debt. He was married at this point, and married men couldn't go to university. There was only Oxford and Cambridge at this point. As I said before, I'm glad he didn't go to university. I think they would have knocked the creativity out of him. He had a grammar-school education, and that was sufficient.
- 2.40** All of his plays, the references to the key grammar-school texts, I mean, they teem with these references. It's very, very clear that this was a grammar-school boy and a very clever grammar-school boy. At grammar school, he would have had a rigorous schooling in rhetoric. Rhetoric was very, very important at this time, and he would have been drilled in it, logic and rhetoric.
- 2.41** At grammar school, there was a key text that every boy studied, and this was William Lily's A Short Introduction of Grammar, which is an educational standard from 1515, right until 1758. The influence is unmissable throughout Shakespeare's work, from his delight in rhetorical devices to figures of speech. There's even direct citations from Lily. We see it in The Merry Wives of Windsor quite clearly in Act 4, Scene 1. Sir Hugh Evans, who is the pedant, the Welsh parson, he's quizzing a schoolboy called William, by the way, on his "accidents" or his Latin grammar.
- 2.42** I don't think it's too fanciful to imagine that William the writer is recreating his own experience at the King's New School in Stratford-upon-Avon, the grammar school, through this character William, the boy William. And I don't think it's a coincidence that, at the school, at the time when Shakespeare was a boy, it was run by a Welshman called Thomas Jenkins. But whatever, that's speculative, but what we can say for sure is that this exchange between Evans and William, in the Merry Wives of Windsor, we can be fairly sure that's something that he was familiar with.
- 2.43** It's the kind of experience that resonates with anyone who did go to grammar school. So you have Evans saying, this is the Welshman, "What is he, William, that does lend articles?" And William says, "Articles are borrowed of the pronoun, and be thus declined. Singulariter, nominativo, hic, haec, hoc." That's a direct quotation from Lily's book on grammar.
- 2.44** And we then go into a series of jokes based on Evans' thick Welsh accent. So he ends up mispronouncing Latin words when he's trying to correct William. So instead of "hic, haec, hoc," which is Latin for "this", the masculine, feminine, and neuter, he says, "Hig, haeg, hog." And Mistress Quickly, who has no Latin at all, she just hears "hang-hog."

She says, "Hang-hog is Latin for bacon, I warrant you," which is true. If you hang a hog, you get bacon.

2.45 Now, you might say that's an example of a joke that no longer works because we're not educated in Latin anymore. But bear in mind that roughly half of the audience in an Elizabethan theater wouldn't have understood Latin either. They'd have just had a few phrases from church. But the joke still works because we know that Mistress Quickly has misunderstood. You can hear the joke, whether you have a knowledge of Latin or not.

2.46 I mean, another example. So, Evans says the phrase, a "focative" case. He means vocative case. Because he's Welsh, it comes out as focative case, which sounds sexually suggestive. And so we get a series of sexual puns. This culminates in Evans asking William for the genitive case, "horum, harum, horum," which Mistress Quickly mishears, and she says, "Well, if Jenny is a whore, we shouldn't mention her case," effectively. So you get the idea.

2.47 Now, the jokes are clearly reminiscent of the typical grammar school education of the time. And in performance, it does still work because we get the sense of the confusions building up because of Evans' accent and the way that the exchange undercuts his pomposity. Now, I've said that three of Shakespeare's plays fall into this category of farce. That's the Merry Wives of Windsor, Taming of the Shrew, and the Comedy of Errors. So let's move on to the Comedy of Errors, and I want to discuss this in some detail.

2.48 Coleridge thought that the distinction between farce and comedy was absolutely crucial. Indeed, in The Comedy of Errors, you don't get the conventional ending of marriage that we've discussed. You get a family reunion. But as I've said, that is just another way for Shakespeare to restore order at the end of the chaos. And boy, there is a lot of chaos in this play. It's called The Comedy of Errors, so you know what you're getting.

2.49 It's one of Shakespeare's earliest plays. As with all of Shakespeare's plays, it's difficult to date exactly, but there's a record, an eyewitness record, of a Christmas performance of this play at the Grey's Inn, one of the Inns of Court, on the 28th of December, 1594. Shakespeare would have been living in London for around seven years at this point. He'd worked in a theater in some capacity.

2.50 Then, crucially, Shakespeare was an actor. Don't forget that. It's very clear, actually, I think, from reading his plays, an actor wrote these plays. An actor is thinking on how the lines are delivered. And by the way, if you look at Hamlet's advice to the players in Hamlet, that's an actor, 100%, right? Giving advice on how to act well. It's obviously something that bothered him.

2.51 He's been working as an actor. Now he's establishing himself as a writer. And I've mentioned that he's a natural comic, so he goes for comedy. He goes for Titus

Andronicus because Senecan tragedy is all the rage. Marlowe is huge. Marlowe is just the big cheese until he's dead in 1593. But he's great at comedy. Shakespeare just nails it with *The Comedy of Errors* straightaway. But he's also an innovative comic. So, of course, all of Shakespeare, the vast majority of Shakespeare's plays, rely on other sources.

- 2.52** I've said that the *Comedy of Errors* relies on Plautus, and specifically the *Menaechmi*, which just means the Menaechmuses, the twins. So effectively, this is a play. Did I mention Plautus? From 254 to 184 BC, the great Latin comic. I said he was largely influenced by Menander, by the New Comedy, but there's a lot more added slapstick. We've got 20 of Plautus' comedies that still survive. Really was the precursor to our modern-day conception of farce. Lots of doors on stage, people going in and out. Pure farce.
- 2.53** The critic Lawrence Danson has described farce rather well. He says it's "that out-loud, laughable, banging-together of bodies in too tight a space." I think that really sums it up. Plautus was a pioneer of this kind of farce. So you'd have slaves rushing between houses, concocting schemes, and then you get the misunderstandings, the near misses, and they all build and build and build. And the play, the *Menaechmus*, or the two, the *Menaechmi*, or the two Menaechmuses, this is about identical twins. This is identical twin brothers, separated as children, who end up in the same city.
- 2.54** So you'll recognize this already from the *Comedy of Errors*. Same plot. It's the same plot. Except, of course, what does Shakespeare do? He doubles it. Shakespeare has two sets of identical twins. This is something that Shakespeare does all the time. He makes things more and more complicated. So, in Shakespeare's play, you have Antipholus of Ephesus and Antipholus of Syracuse, twin brothers, separated at birth. And you have their servants as well, also twin brothers, separated at birth, Dromio of Ephesus and Dromio of Syracuse.
- 2.55** And of course, this is something we've seen before in Shakespeare, this idea of reimagining stories, but complicating the stories. If you look at *King Lear*, for instance, *King Lear* has a subplot about Gloucester, which pretty much mirrors the main plot. *King Lear* has three daughters; two of them turn against him, and one of them is the good daughter. Gloucester, same thing. One son turns against him. Edmund, the good son, defends him and is cast away in the way that Cordelia is. It's odd, in a way. It's the same plot.
- 2.56** It's almost as though, in *King Lear*, the subplot comments on the main plot. That's new, by the way. That wasn't in the existing *King Lear* story. That's something that Shakespeare added himself. He intensifies the plot of the *Comedy of Errors* in a similar way. He intensifies it. That intensification works well because the more complications you have in farce, the more farcical it is, because the audience has to keep up, and the pace is everything.

- 2.57** This is, I think, why it's appropriate that the Comedy of Errors is Shakespeare's shortest play. It feels claustrophobic. It feels intense. It stays within those classical unities of time, place, and action from Aristotle's Poetics, although that's, of course, a view of tragedy; but here it's applied to comedy, and it serves to intensify the experience. And he doesn't do that often. He does it in The Tempest, for instance. He doesn't do it often.
- 2.58** Now, I should point out that Shakespeare also nicks a scene from another Plautus play called Amphitryon. And this is a scene where a woman is dining with the man she assumes is her husband, but in Plautus' play, it's actually Jupiter, the god Jupiter, disguised as her husband, because he wants to have sex with her. And you'll find that the ancient gods did a lot of that kind of thing. If you read Ovid, you'll see Jupiter, in particular, disguising himself as a swan or a bull or even a golden shower at one point, to have sex with the mortals that he desires. You'd think there'd be an easier way.
- 2.59** Now, I've said that Shakespeare's approach in the Comedy of Errors is innovative, and we do see this from the outset. We're going to see this in a lot of the comedies. I'm thinking specifically of the ending of Love's Labour's Lost, which we're going to get to in the next lecture, or the fate of Malvolio in Twelfth Night. What Shakespeare does is, he takes even farce, even high comedy, he'll introduce this darker undercurrent which throws us. In the Comedy of Errors, he does it in the first scene. So this is kind of shocking.
- 2.60** The play is called The Comedy of Errors. You're expecting a farce. You may—the audiences may have known it was based on the Menaechmi, but they turn up, and what happens in the first scene? It doesn't read like a farce at all. It strikes an altogether more harrowing note. We begin with the Duke of Ephesus and Aegeon, the merchant of Syracuse. He's in chains, standing there in chains. That's the first image we see.
- 2.61** And the first line says it all. Aegeon says, "Proceed, Solinus, to procure"—Solinus is the Duke—"Proceed, Solinus, to procure my fall, and by the doom of death end woes and all." It doesn't sound like a farce, does it? He already knows he's condemned to die. And it gets worse because the Duke isn't too happy about it. He has an obligation to enforce the law. Aegeon is from Syracuse. Syracuse is at war with Ephesus, and so the law says he's in enemy territory. He must die.
- 2.62** That conceit, by the way, you might recall from the Taming of the Shrew. If you remember the old stranger from Mantua, who is tricked by Tranio into posing as Lucentio's father, he does this by telling him that Padua and Mantua are at war, and anyone from Mantua who enters Padua is liable to be executed. "So you've got to dress up as my friend's dad." Do you remember? It's a neat conceit.
- 2.63** So the Duke in Comedy of Errors says to Aegeon, "Merchant of Syracuse, plead no more. I am not partial to infringe our laws. The enmity and discord which of late sprang

from the rancorous outrage of your duke to merchants, our well-dealing countrymen, who, wanting guilders to redeem their lives, have sealed his rigorous statutes with their bloods, excludes all pity from our threatening looks." So this is reciprocal. The Duke of Syracuse has demanded the blood of merchants from Ephesus, and so the Duke of Ephesus must do the same.

- 2.64** But there is a get-out clause. This is what he says. "Unless a thousand marks be levied, to quit the penalty and ransom him, thy substance, valued at the highest rate, cannot amount unto a hundred marks. Therefore, by law, thou art condemned to die." So he knows there's no chance of Aegeon raising the thousand marks that he will need to buy his life. And there you have it. The plot is outlined right away from the start. First scene of Comedy of Errors, we know what's going to happen.
- 2.65** The Duke asks him why he's in Ephesus. Aegeon then explains. Years ago, his wife gave birth to identical twin boys, and at the same time, the couple purchased twin slaves to serve them, who had also just been born. And during a voyage, their ship was wrecked, and Aegeon was rescued with one son and one slave, while his wife was saved elsewhere with the other pair. She, of course, she's going to show up later on in the play in a surprise twist, which I've just ruined.
- 2.66** When he became an adult, the surviving son, who was given the same name as the missing brother, went out in search of his brother, accompanied by the servant, who also has the same name as his brother. Aegeon heard nothing for years. He spent the last five years searching, but all in vain. Now he's turned up in Ephesus on his way home. Now, that is an improbable story. That is not very likely. But the Duke finds it very, very moving. He gives him until sunset. He has until sunset to raise the cash to save his life.
- 2.67** So, what's happened? One scene, first scene. All the elements of farce are put into place, like building blocks. You've got the improbable story of the twins separated, which is something which has been replicated in farce for centuries. That's a really common conceit, identical twins. You get lookalikes, don't you? You get disguises. If you're thinking bad soap operas, evil twins, that's like a really common conceit.
- 2.68** I mentioned Joe Orton's farce, What the Butler Saw. Well, at the end of that, Mrs. Prentice, who's the doctor's wife, she discovers that the two younger characters are actually her son and daughter, who she gave away after a sexual encounter in a linen closet during a power cut. She says what she did, she broke a brooch in two and pinned one to one baby and one to the other baby, and she left each baby at opposite sides of the town for no good reason, and they were raised separately.
- 2.69** This all comes out at the end of What the Butler Saw. It's so stupid, but it's deliberately stupid. So Orton is mocking the whole convention of identical twins separated at birth and then reunited in farce. He's mocking the convention, but so is Shakespeare. That's

the thing. So, I remember seeing a production of *Comedy of Errors* in Aberystwyth in Wales on a pier, which had been turned into a nightclub.

- 2.70** And we saw the production, and afterwards, I remember a friend of mine saying, "That ending was stupid. That would never happen." And you just think that Shakespeare knew it would never happen. He's mocking the convention of farce. He's mocking the conventions of—well, even Plautus knew it would never happen. The point about farce is not realism. In fact, the point about a lot of Shakespeare's comedies, don't get hung up on realism. We'll get to that later because that's important.
- 2.71** You're not going to find realism in the *Comedy of Errors*. If you're looking for realism, you would say, "Why is this Abbess, the mother of one of the twins?" She's been in Ephesus for decades, and she's not mentioned it to her son, Antipholus. None of it is probable; that's the point. But as I say, the building blocks are set up in the first scene. We have a ticking time bomb, don't we? Shakespeare has established that there is a time limit on this play. If the money is not recovered by sunset, he's going to die. Aegeon is going to die.
- 2.72** Now, of course, we know he's not going to die, because this is comedy. So something's going to happen in the interim. But the parameters of the plot are all laid out here. The two sets of twins, the time limit, the high stakes, and all that is left is for Shakespeare to have it unfold. He's going to add more and more complications because this is fast. We get this subplot about the golden chain. You remember this?
- 2.73** Antipholus of Ephesus orders the chain from the goldsmith, Angelo. Angelo mistakenly gives it to the other Antipholus. Of course he does. He thinks it's the same man. When the real Antipholus denies receiving it, Angelo has him arrested for non-payment. It's only in that final scene, when both sets of twins appear, and the confusion over the chain and everything else is finally resolved.
- 2.74** But for all its improbability, Aegeon's speech in the opening scene of *Comedy of Errors* is strangely moving, and the threat of death feels darker than a farce would typically be. So even here, in this very early comedy, Shakespeare is playing with the genre. He's not just replicating Plautus. He's not just doing an English version of the *Menaechmi*. He's playing with genre in really interesting ways. In other words, what I'm saying is, Shakespeare was innovative from the start, even in his comedies.
- 2.75** I mean, consider the character of Luciana in the *Comedy of Errors*, Adriana's sister, who is— she's a kind of oasis of calm in this very chaotic play. Her name means light. That's what she's there for. She's principled, she's caring, she's measured. She seems out of place, doesn't she? You wouldn't get that character in normal farces. And I'd like to give another example here. I'd like you to consider Adriana's speech in Act 2, Scene 1. This is when she believes that her husband, Antipholus, is neglecting her for other women.
- 2.76** The tone seems to shift. We've had all the chaos. We've had all the misdirection. People misunderstanding who is who. They don't know. Then we get this speech about

Adriana lamenting her husband's wayward ways. He's always off with other women, or minions, as she calls. She says this.

- 2.77** She says, "His company must do his minions grace, whilst I at home starve for a merry look. Hath homely age the alluring beauty took from my poor cheek? Then hast he wasted it. Are my discourses dull? Barren my wit? If voluble and sharp discourse be marred, unkindness blunts it more than marble hard. Do their gay vestments his affections bait?" As in, the fancy clothes of these women, draw her husband away? "That's not my fault. He's master of my state. What ruins are in me that can be found by him not ruined? Then is he the ground of my defeatures. My decayed fair, a sunny look of his would soon repair."
- 2.78** So you can hear it. It's actually rather real, isn't it? It's actually rather poignant. While her husband seeks out other women, or minions, she gets the blame. But it's precisely his neglect of her that has dulled her wit, made her look tired. The very thing that she thinks has driven him away, he's caused it. And poignantly, she says that she could be revived if only he cared. "My decayed fair, a sunny look of his would soon repair."
- 2.79** Now, the rhyming couplets incline us to think of this as whimsical, but it's not. That's a feature of his apprentice plays, the early plays, the rhyming couplets, the end-stopped lines, which he outgrew, became a much more interesting writer. But the language here conjures a genuine emotion. You're never going to find that in a Joe Orton farce. Shakespeare is doing something far more complex.
- 2.80** Now, at the beginning of this scene, Adriana strikes us as the shrewish wife, the nagging termagant, a stock figure of comedy. By the end of the scene, no, she is humanized in a way that the other characters aren't. She's humanized. We feel for her. Shakespeare, in other words, breaks through the stereotype. He's not satisfied with the stereotype. That's what makes his comedies so rich. And Adriana has a point. I mean, men in Shakespeare and comedies never come off well.
- 2.81** You think about *Much Ado About Nothing*. You think about Claudio's reaction to when he thinks Hero has cheated on him—how easily he's tricked into believing that, how he overreacts at the wedding. You've got Malvolio, dressing in yellow stockings and cross garters for Olivia, making himself foolish. You've got King Leontes in *The Winter's Tale*, who believes his wife is pregnant with his best friend's child on no evidence at all. Pure irrational jealousy.
- 2.82** And consider Antipholus of Ephesus' reaction when he is barred out of his home by his wife, who's with the other Antipholus. And what's his first reaction? He thinks his wife is locking him out of his own house. What's his first instinct? "I know a wench of excellent discourse, pretty and witty, wild and yet, too, gentle. There we will dine." So as soon as he feels snubbed by his wife, he's off to the courtesan. This is in Act 3, Scene 1. He says, "Since mine own doors refuse to entertain me, I'll knock elsewhere to see if they'll disdain me."

- 2.83** Do you see how fragile the male ego is in Shakespeare? This guy feels aggrieved, straightaway, all right, he'll go and commit adultery, and he'll blame it on his wife. It's very reminiscent of, you remember those old episodes of Jerry Springer, where a cheating partner would say, "Oh, well, if you'd been doing your job in the bedroom, I wouldn't have to cheat." Pathetic, isn't it?
- 2.84** Shakespeare is a master of confounding your expectations, of pulling the audience's emotions this way and that. Even in the comedies, he never lets you settle. I think that's the best way to put it. Shakespeare never lets you settle. He never lets you predict. He does something more. I mean, even in all this improbability and this plot, which is a predictable plot, he still finds ways to be authentic and unpredictable, because if he must be formulaic, he will break the formula while he does so.
- 2.85** This is something we see again and again in the comedies as we go through. And so throughout these lectures, I want you to keep that in mind. Think about that. I'll just give you another quick example from the *Winter's Tale*. Do you remember the scene in the *Winter's Tale*, most famous stage direction in the world, probably? "Exit, pursued by a bear." Do you remember this?
- 2.86** This is the scene. Antigonus, do you remember, is leaving the infant Perdita on the coast of Bohemia, and he bids her farewell. And the speech is actually rather moving, and then it's undercut by this ridiculous stage direction, "Exit, pursued by a bear." It might have been an actual bear. There were bears in Elizabethan London. We laugh at this because it's so absurd. We've had this moving speech, and a bloody bear runs off. We laugh. But then what happens?
- 2.87** Shakespeare has the shepherd and the clown come in, and they describe how they just saw Antigonus being murdered, killed by the bear, being torn apart in very gruesome ways. The clown says, "To see how the bear tore out his shoulder bone, how he cried to me for help." Well, that's not funny anymore. That's horrific. So Shakespeare doesn't just shift the tone once. He does it twice, really abruptly in the space of three minutes. He never lets you settle.
- 2.88** Anyway, let's get back to the *Comedy of Errors*. I want to talk, and I want to focus briefly on one particular scene. We talked about Shakespeare's adept use of the conventions of farce. But even in this early comedy, we have his blistering wordplay, his imagination on display. The poetry of the *Comedy of Errors* may be lacking in comparison to his other works, or certainly disappointing for those of us who are expecting one of the late masterpieces. But his description of Nell, the serving wench, seems to me to be a very successful comedic moment.
- 2.89** So just to remind you, we're in Act 3, Scene 2. Antipholus of Syracuse and his servant Dromio of Syracuse are bewildered because everyone in Ephesus seems to know them. What's going on? Dromio has just escaped from a woman who insists that she is his wife, but of course, she's confusing him with Dromio of Ephesus. Now, the wife in

question is Nell, the kitchen wench, the serving wench. She's the maid in the household of the other Antipholus.

- 2.90** I think this discussion is a testament to the power of Shakespeare's language and imagination, because, firstly, we never see Nell on stage. We don't see her, we hear about her, and we are invited to picture her, by virtue of the language that Dromio uses. She's only described, and yet her presence is very, very vivid. First and foremost, let's not beat about the bush, she's fat. She's very, very fat. This is how Dromio describes her.
- 2.91** "Marry, sir, she's the kitchen wench, and all grease; and I know not what use to put her to, but to make a lamp of her, and run from her by her own light." It's pretty harsh. He says, "I warrant her rags and the tallow in them will burn a Poland winter. If she lives till doomsday, she'll burn a week longer than the whole world." Antipholus of Syracuse says, "What complexion is she of?" Dromio says, "Swart," swarthy, "like my shoe. But her face, nothing like so clean kept. For why? She sweats; a man may go overshoes in the grime of it."
- 2.92** Overshoes, meaning shoe deep. She sweats so liberally because she's so fat. It's like wading. And then Antipholus thinks a bath might be in order. He says, "That's a fault that water will mend." And Dromio is not having it. He says, "No, sir, 'tis in grain. Noah's flood could not do it." Antipholus says, "What's her name?" Dromio says, "Nell, sir, but her name and three quarters—that's an ell and three quarters"—an ell is one and a quarter yards—"will not measure her from hip to hip." So he turns the name into a joke about her size.
- 2.93** Antipholus says, "Then she bears some breadth." Dromio: "No. Longer from head to foot than from hip to hip. She is spherical, like a globe. I could find countries in her." And then we get this extraordinary continuation of the metaphor. So he's comparing this obese woman to a globe. And then we have this catalog of her body parts paired with countries and landmarks. So Antipholus says, "In what part of her body stands Ireland?" Dromio: "Marry, sir, in her buttocks. I found it by the bogs."
- 2.94** Because, of course, the joke has expanded. It's not just a joke about a fat woman, although it is that. But now Shakespeare uses the analogy to poke fun at stereotypes of various nations and where they're located on Nell's body. So of course, Ireland is in the buttocks because it's a boggy place. Antipholus says, "Where's Scotland?" "I found it by the barrenness, hard in the palm of her hand." Well, of course, she's a kitchen wench. Her hands will be hard from menial work. Where is more barren and hard than Scotland?
- 2.95** Antipholus now starts to enjoy the game and he starts suggesting countries. He says, "Where's France?" Dromio says, "In her forehead, and reverted, armed and reverted, making war against her heir." Now, of course, this is topical, the enmity between

France and England. That's the joke here, analogized with a receding hairline. The poor woman, it's horrible.

2.96 This actually probably dates the play very specifically because, of course, between 1589 and 1593, we have the civil war in France, don't we? Between Henry of Navarre and the Duke of Guise, which was later dramatized by Christopher Marlowe in *The Massacre of Paris*.

2.97 Then, of course, Antipholus can't resist it. He says, "Where's England?" Dromio says, "I looked for the chalky cliffs, but I could find no whiteness in them." Well, she's too swarthy and unclean, right? He says, "But I guess it stood in her chin, by the salt rheum that ran between France and it." So she dribbles as well. This is a pretty grotesque caricature, isn't it? She's dribbling, and that would be the English Channel. It stands to reason, if her forehead is France, the chin must be England. You get what he's doing.

2.98 Antipholus says, "Where's Spain?" Dromio says, "Faith, I saw it not, but I felt it hot in her breath." Well, that makes sense, doesn't it? Because Spain is the world of passion and heat. Of course, the Armada just happened. That was 1588, and you just have very much in recent memory. Antipholus says, "Where's America, the Indies?" That's interesting. That's the only reference, direct reference, to the Americas in all of Shakespeare.

2.99 Of course, the Americas are known for their abundant wealth and riches. So Dromio imagines the spots on her nose are precious gems. He says, "O, sir, upon her nose, all o'er embellished with rubies, carbuncles, sapphires, declining their rich aspect to the hot breath of Spain, who sent whole armadas of carracks to be ballast at her nose." And so the intimation of the Armada becomes explicit.

2.100 And then, of course, we have the inevitable joke about the Low Countries. Antipholus says, "Where stood Belgia, the Netherlands?" Dromio says, "O, sir, I did not look so low." I don't need to explain that one. But here's my point. We can hear the inventiveness of the humor, the intelligence combined with the bawdy, the fusion of high and low art that characterizes Shakespeare's work, and particularly his comedies.

2.101 Now, what Shakespeare tends to do in every single play is, he creates a unique little world. The laws of logic, the very similitude of each play, vary from play to play. But once you're in it, once you're drawn in, it makes sense. Each play has its own quality, its own logic. I think that applies to the *Comedy of Errors*, too. Now, all farces, of course, force you to suspend your disbelief, but Shakespeare adds a flavor of disorder. Even something portentous, I would say, to this place, his version of Ephesus.

2.102 So it's part of the ancient Greek world. It's where, it would be in modern-day Turkey. That's where we are. It's somewhere exotic to the Elizabethans. He could do what he likes with this place. Shakespeare, to create this little world—and he often does this; he creates light motifs that are very specific to particular plays. So this is why, in *Macbeth*, the word blood recurs a lot. Blood, you hear it a lot.

- 2.103** King Lear—what's the word you hear all the time? Nothing. "Nothing shall come of nothing." Nothing is recurring because it's a nihilistic, bleak, barren world, a soulless world, a godless world. It's a pagan world. It's pre-Christian. That's what King Lear does. And he often does this; he threads through these recurrent themes, or leitmotifs, so that he creates this little world.
- 2.104** Othello is dense with animal imagery. Sometimes this quality isn't something you notice straightaway. You register it. I don't think you would notice the recurrent use of blood in Macbeth unless you were reading it and studying it. But when you're watching it, it works as a subliminal effect, and you clock it without really knowing it. He has an incredible ability to seed this stuff there, this attention to detail, this building-up of an atmosphere in a world through strands of language, through recurring motifs.
- 2.105** I think, in the Comedy of Errors, it's very clear that witchcraft is the motif. Now, we think of this as a farce, chaotic, silly, but the images of witchcraft are abundant. They keep coming back. It creates a backbone to the play, a sense, this ominous sense, that something's wrong, something's disordered, something's rotten. It's latent through the frivolity of the plot. Listen to what Antipholus of Syracuse says at the end of Act One. It's very ominous.
- 2.106** He says, "They say this town is full of cozenage, as nimble jugglers that deceive the eye, dark-working sorcerers that change the mind, soul-killing witches that deform the body, disguised cheaters, prating mountebanks, and many such, like liberties of sin. If it prove so, I will be gone the sooner." And here again, Act 2, Scene 2, Dromio of Syracuse says, "O, for my beads! I cross me for a sinner. This is the fairy land. O, spite of spites, we talk with goblins, owls, and sprites! If we obey them not, this will ensue. They'll suck our breath or pinch us black and blue."
- 2.107** And again, Act 3, Scene 2, Antipholus of Syracuse says, "There's none but witches do inhabit here." It's a bit like that line in the Tempest, "Hell is empty, and all the devils are here." Do you remember the opening storm? It's a very powerful line. The devil is lurking in Ephesus. Shakespeare has taken an exotic place that his audience wouldn't have known. He can apply onto that template anything he likes. He can turn it into whatever he likes, and he turns it into this world where chaos reigns.
- 2.108** Order is eventually established, but there are witches, devils, goblins, sprites. I don't mean Midsummer Night's Dream sprites. I mean evil sprites. All of this sorcery and diabolism is going to be dispelled at the end, in the traditional fashion of comedy, when harmony is restored through the reconciliation, through the unmasking of the identities.
- 2.109** Now, this is not to make any great claim for the Comedy of Errors as a masterpiece or as a pinnacle of the Shakespearean canon; it's far from that. But it does have the seeds of his later mastery, and this is why I think it's important. All of these apprentice plays

are not his best work, but I think, in order to understand his best work better, it's good to be acquainted with them. It's one of the reasons I wanted to cover them in this way.

- 2.110** And of course, you can see elements of these plays perfected later on. The twins separated by a shipwreck, well, where else does that happen? That's *Twelfth Night*, isn't it? In *Twelfth Night* as well, everything gets resolved in that moment. You remember when Viola and Sebastian walk in, they're next to each other. People are like, "Hold a minute, there's two of them," and everything is revealed. Same thing happens in *Comedy of Errors*.
- 2.111** They're not comparable plays. *Twelfth Night* is a masterpiece; *Comedy of Errors* is not. *Comedy of Errors* is not sophisticated in the way *Twelfth Night* is sophisticated. *Twelfth Night* has deeply human characterizations. Each character in that play is a real human being. You don't get that in the *Comedy of Errors*. Luciana, as I say, gestures towards it; isn't fully realized, but there's a gesture there.
- 2.112** The twins are likewise perfunctory. They're often mistaken for each other, not just because they're dressed in the same manner and they look the same, but because their characteristics are interchangeable as well. The critic, Mark Van Doren, put it this way. He said, "They exist for no other purpose than to be mutually mistaken." I mean, of course, it's bonkers anyway. Why would these two sets of twins happen to be dressed in the same way on the same day? It doesn't matter, because it's farce.
- 2.113** But the key point, I think, is in evidence here, which we're going to see when we get onto the *Merchant of Venice* and *Much Ado About Nothing* and *Twelfth Night*, is how Shakespeare effortlessly blends this sense of disquiet with the joviality of the comedy. There's always a darkness lurking where we might expect light, even in the *Comedy of Errors*, the most frivolous of Shakespeare's plays. There are witches lurking in the shadows. As a clown, Shakespeare's tongue is sharp, but it is also forked.

Lecture 3: Love's Labour's Lost

At a glance — Love's Labour's Lost and the strangeness of desire.

- 3.1 Let's talk about sex. Now, objectively speaking, sex is a bit strange. It certainly looks strange. So the novelist Compton Mackenzie once pointed out to D. H. Lawrence that—and this is a direct quote—"Except to the two people who are indulging in it, the sexual act is a comic operation." Now, in his novels, Mackenzie always shied away from depictions of sexual activity, but Lawrence went the other way.
- 3.2 Of course, he wrote *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, which was published privately in 1928 in Italy, so as to avoid the English censors. When an unexpurgated version of that novel came out in 1960, the publisher, Penguin, was famously put on trial for obscenity. The prosecutor, Mervyn Griffith-Jones, famously asked the jury, he said, "Would this be the kind of novel that you would wish your servants or wife to read?" The irony of that, of course, is that, at this time, servants knew everything that went on in the house, and trying to keep them pure was only possible if you were leading by example, which, when it comes to aristocrats, is fairly unlikely.
- 3.3 But I think Mackenzie was onto something. So sexual passion only really means something if the participants are taking it seriously. But it does look funny to other people, unless they're watching it to be titillated, which is the case of pornography. But in that case, the observer is vicariously involved. But sex has always made people laugh. It just has. Why? I think because we know how foolish it is, and yet we have an animal instinct that draws us to it. So it has a leveling effect.
- 3.4 It reminds us that we're part of the animal kingdom, albeit of a more elevated domain. It involves the loss of reason. People make terrible decisions when they're infatuated with someone. Desire makes us fools, not just in terms of the sexual act itself, but in the way it drives us to behave. It makes us objects of ridicule, and we can't escape it, because even to choose a life of celibacy makes us targets for comedy. In English farce, it's often the priest who has his trousers pulled down.
- 3.5 Then, of course, there is love. Sex and love are intimately connected. Each one can exist without the other, of course, but for many lovers, sex is the ultimate consummation. When it is devoid of love, sex invariably degrades. But the sexual impulse and the form of desire, or rather obsession, that we call love, is integral to the human condition. Even those who are celibate, voluntarily or not, need to be loved, and they need to love others. A life without that experience is hollow and purposeless. So the stakes really couldn't be higher.
- 3.6 And all of this explains why Shakespeare returns to love and sex endlessly, and the way in which the two intertwine. Now, of course, that's true of the tragedies, *Romeo and Juliet*, *Antony and Cleopatra*. But in the comedies, it's even more integral to the genre. Without love and sex, Shakespearean comedy would not exist. All the major comedies,

as I've said, end in marriage—*Much Ado About Nothing*, *As You Like It*, *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, *Twelfth Night*, *Taming of the Shrew*, *Merchant of Venice*, *Two Gentlemen of Verona*.

- 3.7** Love's Labour's Lost ends with marriage deferred for a year. As I've pointed out, the Comedy of Errors does not end in marriage at all, but it does have that reunification of the estranged husband and wife. That is the key point about marriage in Shakespeare. We've talked about how marriage is the apparatus by which Shakespeare restores the order from the chaos, and that is what makes a comedy a comedy.
- 3.8** I suppose the function of marriage in society more broadly is a ritual; it's a convention that contains and controls the anarchic quality of sex. It involves monogamy. It is a pledge that one will not just sleep around with multiple people. It's an acknowledgement that commitment and stability is more important than the satisfaction of lust, or it is valued that way in our society. It is a civilizational point. Married people, of course, don't stop fancying others, but they have agreed not to act on those desires.
- 3.9** That's why marriage, as I say, is part of civilization. Civilization itself is a means to overcome the brutally tempestuous and unpredictable quality of the natural world. This is the Nietzschean conflict of the Apollonian and the Dionysian, the tug of war between the transcendent and the decadent, the ethereal and the corporeal, the ordered and the chaotic, as Nietzsche outlines in *The Birth of Tragedy*.
- 3.10** Camille Paglia builds upon Nietzsche's foundation in her book, *Sexual Personae*, which draws upon a broad sweep of the historical and cultural and artistic achievements of the Western world, to support the proposition that paganism was not defeated, but it still flourishes in art, eroticism, astrology, and pop culture. Paglia argues that, while instinct is amoral, civilization offers us the framework within which to cooperate and thrive.
- 3.11** This is why I think we find courtship to be one of the most ritualistic aspects of human interaction. In every society, at any time, there are rituals. There are words that must be said, conventions that must be observed. Of course, we no longer have chaperones. That convention has died. A gentleman no longer needs to seek permission from a woman's father before courting her. We no longer generally value the idea of withholding sex until after marriage. But there are still rituals.
- 3.12** I remember hearing the late brilliant academic, Peter Saccio, a great Shakespearean scholar. I remember seeing a lecture of his, and he talked about this, and he said that he was talking in the mid-90s, and he was saying, he made this point that his students, they would go on dates, and they would go for tacos and Diet Coke, and they would discourse endlessly about what they call their relationship, and talk about their psychological problems and struggles inherited from their family background and so on.

- 3.13** In other words, the point that Saccio was making was, this psycho-babble had become part of the courtship ritual. It was seemingly compulsory. Of course, today, fast forward another 30 years, it's different again. Most of courtship rituals now, they've moved online, haven't they? People meet through Grindr or Bumble or Tinder, these dating apps, and they like other people's comments, or they throw down an emoji, and that signals interest. It's part of a ritual.
- 3.14** They pore endlessly over messages, looking for secret signals that someone might be interested. There's the talking stage, where young people will communicate via messaging to determine whether they are in with a chance. There's also that changing of your relationship status. What is that, if not a ritual, on your social media profile? That's a ritual. No doubt, this is not a world I'm in. I'm speaking as an outsider here, but there are probably all sorts of ritualistic aspects to courtship today of which I am completely ignorant.
- 3.15** But I guarantee you, they will be there, because this is the way we contain, societally, sexual desire. We devise these courtship rituals, certain modes of speech, certain phrases. They're always there. Now, *Love's Labour's Lost* is all about these courtship rituals. That is the play in a nutshell. Of all Shakespeare's comedies, *Love's Labour's Lost*, I think, can feel the most alien to us. We feel the most distant from it, because it's less concerned with plot than with these rituals of language, and of course, those are very time-specific.
- 3.16** Now, it was probably first performed in a private, courtly setting, where audiences would have loved this. In the Elizabethan era, there was a real love for verbal games, particularly among the gentry. We know it was performed before Queen Elizabeth because it says so on one of the quarto editions. Some have speculated that it was written for Henry Wriothesley, who was Earl of Southampton, Shakespeare's patron. In any case, it doesn't matter. It was hugely popular at the time.
- 3.17** We should not mistake our difficulties as a modern reader with this text as evidence that it is a weaker play. It feels very Elizabethan. It was sufficiently popular to be performed after Shakespeare's death at the Blackfriars. But then there was a long gap; there's a long gap of a couple of centuries where it wasn't really performed at all. It gets performed more and more nowadays. I saw a recent film version, I think from 2020, played by young people, and they've adapted it to a boarding school setting.
- 3.18** Actually, that works very well because, really, this should be about young people. That's what this should be about. At its heart, the play explores the linguistic conventions of courtship, as I've said, what we might call flirting. In the 16th century, a lover signaled devotion, not through casual conversation, but through writing poetry, deploying recognized poetic tropes, such as the blazon. The blazon is a poetic trope which itemizes the beloved's beauty, feature by feature.

- 3.19** There are references to this in *Twelfth Night* and also in *Much Ado About Nothing*. Shakespeare does it himself in the sonnets, of course. So it's things like "her golden hair, lips like rubies, cheeks like alabaster," that sort of thing. These tropes are very Petrarchan; they draw on the tradition of Petrarch, the Italian poet, whose sonnets to Laura really shape European love poetry for a long, long time. Shakespeare has a lot of fun playing with those Petrarchan tropes.
- 3.20** At the same time, English writers were striving to elevate their national tongue to make it a serious medium for literature, rather than relying on Greek and Latin, which were considered the proper way to write poetry. The project had already begun. We had the great epic, *The Faerie Queene*, by Edmund Spenser, *Astrophel and Stella* by Philip Sidney, that sequence of love poems towards an unattainable woman.
- 3.21** But I think it reaches its fullest expression with Shakespeare, because his timing was perfect. He expanded the expressive power of English more than any of his contemporaries. And even in this early play, *Love's Labour's Lost*, we see his instinctive mastery of rhetoric. He delights in puns, in the slipperiness of words, in the way language can seduce or mislead in multiple meanings. Loves all that. And Shakespeare doesn't just use language, he interrogates it, exposing both its power and its absurdities.
- 3.22** So, a quick word about Shakespeare and language, and it's often said that Shakespeare coined 1,700 new words, and that's contested because that does include instances of where his is the first recorded usage. But he did coin many, many, many words through sheer linguistic dexterity. He is, as Berowne calls Armado in *Love's Labour's Lost*, "a man of fire-new words." He could turn nouns into verbs, verbs into adjectives. He'd create compound words. He'd modify traditional meanings.
- 3.23** If you think about it, the number of words that we use today that Shakespeare invented—words like bedroom, undress, eyeball, zany, worthless, obscene, manager, lonely, fashionable, inaudible—all these words, we take them for granted. We use them every day. They're Shakespeare's. There's a very famous passage by the critic Bernard Levin. Very famous passage. It used to be on a poster, I remember, at my school. I remember seeing it when I was about seven or eight and being very impressed by it.
- 3.24** Because it's so famous and gets to the point, I'm going to read it. I'm just going to read it to you. This is what Levin said. "If you cannot understand my argument and declare 'it's Greek to me', you are quoting Shakespeare. If you claim to be more sinned against than sinning, you are quoting Shakespeare. If you recall your salad days, you are quoting Shakespeare. If you act more in sorrow than in anger, if your wish is farther to the thought, if your lost property has vanished into thin air, you are quoting Shakespeare."

- 3.25** If you have ever refused to budge an inch or suffered from green-eyed jealousy, if you have played fast and loose, if you have been tongue-tied, a tower of strength, hoodwinked or in a pickle, if you have knitted your brows, made a virtue of necessity, insisted on fair play, slept not one wink, stood on ceremony, danced attendance (on your lord and master), laughed yourself into stitches, had short shrift, cold comfort, or too much of a good thing, if you have seen better days or lived in a fool's paradise—why, be that as it may, the more fool you, for it is a foregone conclusion that you are, as good luck would have it, quoting Shakespeare.
- 3.26** If you think it is early days and clear out bag and baggage, if you think it is high time and that that is the long and short of it, if you believe that the game is up and the truth will out, even if it involves your own flesh and blood, if you lie low to the crack of doom because you suspect foul play, if you have your teeth set on edge at one fell swoop without rhyme or reason, then, to give the devil his due, if truth were known, for surely you have a tongue in your head, you are quoting Shakespeare.
- 3.27** Even if you bid me good riddance and send me packing, if you wish I was dead as a doornail, if you think I am an eyesore, a laughing stock, the devil incarnate, a stony-hearted villain, bloody-minded or a blinking idiot, then, by Jove, O Lord! Tut-tut! For goodness' sake! What the dickens! But me no buts— it's all one to me, for you are quoting Shakespeare."
- 3.28** Now, if you think about that, the sheer range of idioms that we use naturally, all from him, no other writer has done this. No other writer has changed the language to this extent. Shakespeare was, of course, continually experimenting with language and its possibilities. If he wanted a word and it didn't exist, he would make it up, and it would catch on. Incredible. This is particularly the case in comedy, where the multiplicity of meaning is often so essential to the joke. The puns of Shakespeare are so innumerable.
- 3.29** He was never satisfied with just one meaning. He wanted it to be taken in multiple ways and to take the joke as far as he could. *Love's Labour's Lost*, in particular, is a vast linguistic experiment. It satirizes and plays upon the courtly conventions of the time, as I've said, and it's an early play, so it's heavy on rhyme. It's got all those end-stop lines. But that's actually—it works here, because it adds to that sense of courtly artificiality, which is necessary for the theme of love and courtship.
- 3.30** If I could just quote the Shakespearean scholar G. D. Willcock, he wrote that the reign of Queen Elizabeth I was, and this is a quote, "a period of unparalleled linguistic awareness...Verbal fashions chased each other through the court, and the smallness of the Elizabethan world gave them currency in all classes of society...Words mattered; they were savored, bandied to and fro, followed up from jest to jest." That is the context of *Love's Labour's Lost*.
- 3.31** And this is one of the reasons I wanted to devote a whole lecture to this play, because many of its allusions and references are so tied to this specific period of time, because

those puns, they don't immediately resonate. It strikes us as more difficult than his other comedies, but I would offer a word of advice here. There are going to be quips that you miss, but I think we can revel in the linguistic exuberance of the play, even when we miss some of those allusions.

- 3.32** It's one of those plays where, as I said before, if you have a good edition, which will help you through some of the more obscure references, that is helpful. But as I say, this is poetry. The best effect is to read it aloud without interruptions. Read it through. And as with all Shakespeare, I keep saying this: do not feel confounded by the lines you don't understand. Let them wash over you, and the overall effect will be magnetic.
- 3.33** Really, once you get down to it, like I say, it's about rituals, the absurdity of sex, the way desire can both degrade and elevate us, sometimes at the same time. These notions are transhistorical, universal, cross-cultural. Like all of Shakespeare's plays, *Love's Labour's Lost* is about human beings. It is about humanity. We don't need to ask why any of his plays are relevant to us today, because they are the most incisive expressions of what it means to be human. That will always be relevant until we become cyborgs, which will probably happen at some point. Well, I hope not, but it may be.
- 3.34** Now, as usual, one gets a sense in *Love's Labour's Lost* that the plot is not really Shakespeare's chief concern. The plot is perfunctory, isn't it? It sets up, like we had in *Comedy of Errors*, he sets up that plot in the first scene so that he allows the comedy to unfold. So the conditions are set up in that first scene. The King of Navarre and his three lords: Berowne, Longaville, and Dumaine make their pact, and their pact is no more women— chastity, very little sleep, fasting. They're going to devote three years to study, to refining their gentlemanly status.
- 3.35** And Berowne is skeptical. Berowne says—well, first he reads aloud the proclamation. It says that "no woman shall come within a mile of my court on pain of losing her tongue." It's a bit harsh, isn't it? That's reminiscent of *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, of course, in which the penalty in Athens for Hermia not agreeing to marry Demetrius is, according to her father's demands, lifelong celibacy or death. That's the choice she's got, which is why she runs away. Wouldn't you?
- 3.36** Now, by the way, I should just say quickly, some critics have argued that Berowne should be pronounced Berune, but let's not get too hung up on that. The convention of Berowne has become the standard in performance and in criticism. It may not be correct, but we can never be entirely sure about the pronunciation of Shakespeare's English, so we shouldn't get too worried about that.
- 3.37** There's actually a really interesting audio recording, which you can find online, of Anthony Burgess reading aloud a passage from *Hamlet*, in what he believes to be the way it would have been initially pronounced. He was a linguistic scholar as well as a novelist, and it's very alien. I think it's on the Anthony Burgess Foundation website, but

have a look for that. It's very interesting. It doesn't sound the way that we make it sound.

- 3.38** Sometimes you can figure out the way a name is pronounced by the way it scans in the text. That's why, in *As You Like It*, for instance, we know that the name is "Jay-queese", not Jakes. You can work it out because of where it falls in the verse. We know it's two syllables, not monosyllabic. Anyway, Berowne, which is what we're calling him, Berowne agrees to the pact because he knows that women are a distraction, or as the king puts it, "the stops that hinder study quite and train our intellects to vain delight."
- 3.39** But look at Berowne's response. He says, "Why, all delights are vain, but that most vain, which with pain purchased doth inherit pain; as painfully to pore upon a book to seek the light of truth, while truth the while doth falsely blind the eyesight of his look. Light seeking light doth light of light beguile. So, ere you find where light in darkness lies, your light grows dark by losing of your eyes."
- 3.40** You can hear it, can't you? The flourishes, the punning, the paradoxes, the repetition, the double meanings. Much of the play consists of this kind of highly wrought rhetoric, which is why it seems so dense to modern ears. But it's also beautiful; you can hear the beauty, even if you don't quite grasp it. But rhetoric as a concept, I've said this before, really mattered in the Elizabethan Age. And ever since antiquity, the greatest civilizations have known that rhetoric in public life is important.
- 3.41** Great thinkers such as Aristotle and Cicero knew that good ideas are worthless unless they can be argued well, just as bad ideas can circulate if they have a fine rhetorician or orator to convey them. In fact, at this time, at Oxford and Cambridge, the examinations, a third of it, was based on rhetoric. When the tripos, which—the tripos was named after the three-legged stool that the undergraduate would sit on for disputations—if you think about it this way, there are three branches of higher education at the time.
- 3.42** There's grammar, there's logic, or dialectic, and then rhetoric is the third leg of the stool. Rhetoric is the art of persuasion, and it was considered so crucial that it was a third of the degree. Now, Shakespeare didn't go to university, as I said, but he was drilled in rhetoric at his grammar school. He understood, I think, more than any other writer, that an inability to persuade is a harbinger of failure. That is why *Coriolanus* fails. He has this arrogant belief that he doesn't have to win the approval of the plebeians. That guarantees his eventual downfall.
- 3.43** By contrast, Mark Antony in *Julius Caesar*, you all know the speech. "Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears." He is able to turn the crowd against the assassins of Julius Caesar in fewer than 100 lines. And it works because, when we listen to it, we find ourselves being persuaded. It's not just that Shakespeare is aware of the power of rhetoric; it's that he's a master of rhetoric.

- 3.44 Think of Lady Macbeth. What does she do when Macbeth has second thoughts about killing Duncan? She persuades, she uses language, she challenges his masculinity; she knows how to do it, these elegantly phrased slurs against his character. It's the rhetorical flourishes that make that work. It's language. It's the power of language. Now, in the previous lecture about Merry Wives of Windsor, I pointed out that Shakespeare did know his rhetoric, and that we often see these characters in the plays who can change other people's minds. That happens a lot.
- 3.45 I suppose he was aware of the power of this. I think he was also aware of the manipulative potential of this. In Love's Labour's Lost, we have another pedantic schoolmaster in the style of Evans, who we met in Merry Wives of Windsor, Holofernes. He's continually correcting other people's words. He throws around Latin phrases needlessly, pretentiously. When Moth makes a joke about cuckolds, Holofernes demands, "What is the figure? What is the figure?" What is the rhetorical figure of speech? He doesn't think a joke can work unless it's classified in the rhetorical handbook.
- 3.46 And this is why the clown, Costard, mocks Holofernes for his Latinisms. He uses the longest word in Shakespeare, which I know I'm going to get wrong, "honorificabilitudinitatibus," which means the state of being able to achieve honors. It's a deliberate tongue-twister. As Moth says to Costard, "They have been at a great feast of languages and stolen the scraps." So these men are like the beggars who've raided a banquet of learning, but they've only picked up the leftovers. They mouth scraps of Latin to impress, but they don't have any depth of understanding.
- 3.47 Now, in Shakespeare's time, there were actual manuals of rhetoric, how to persuade. They have different names for different rhetorical figures. It was like science, in a way. There's books like Thomas Wilson's Art of Rhetoric, and Abraham Fraunce's The Arcadian Rhetoric, and John Hoskins's Directions for Speech and Style. You could, if you go through Love's Labour's Lost, if you were so inclined, you could identify the various rhetorical devices and find the actual technical name for those devices. It might be a bit boring, but you could do that. You would be able to do that.
- 3.48 Let's have a look at it. Let's go back to Berowne's speech. "Light seeking light doth light of light beguile. So, ere you find where light in darkness lies, your light grows dark by losing of your eyes." It's so dense, isn't it? You have these continual puns on light, which is an example of antanaclasis, which is where a word or a phrase is repeated within a sentence, but with different and contrary meanings.
- 3.49 Let's take the line again. "Light seeking light doth light of light beguile." Now, Harry Levin paraphrased that as "intellect seeking wisdom cheats eyesight out of daylight." You can hear that the word light, every time it's used, has a different definition. All of these meanings are encapsulated here. You also have chiasmus. Chiasmus is the inversion of a structure of a sentence. "Light seeking light doth light of light beguile."

- 3.50** So, we have the multiple meanings, but the line is also chiasmic, because it begins and ends with the same element, the seeker after truth or wisdom, and it has a mirrored middle. "Light seeking light doth light of light beguile." So the light that seeks becomes the light that is beguiled, and the light that is sought deceives the light that seeks. So the structure of the line itself enacts the paradox it describes. OK, so the pursuit turns back on itself.
- 3.51** This is, of course, pure linguistic ornament, and these kinds of rhetorical figures do seem alienating to us. They seem pedantic to us, but they were very appealing in the word games of court. And of course, going back to ancient civilizations, I mean, Cicero was a master of this. He knew that the way that a politician could convey his ideas depended on how those ideas were conveyed.
- 3.52** I think if our modern politicians were to study the art of rhetoric, we would be a lot happier with them. They may not be any nicer, but they would know how to deceive us. At the moment, the problem is that we can see through the deception. It's too easy, because they don't speak well. So they need to read Abraham Fraunce and John Hoskins and that kind of thing, if they want to, or even Shakespeare. That would help.
- 3.53** Now, as I say, these word games, the Elizabethans loved it, particularly in the court. They loved expanding the potential of language. As I said, this is a time where the English language is being dignified in literature. So they're going to play with it. They're going to expand it. They're going to say, "This language is as good as any other." And it is. I mean, English is a mongrel language that just takes and takes, which means that the possibilities of English are so endless.
- 3.54** There's a reason why it's become a global language. Colonialism as well, of course. And we have this same effect in the 135th sonnet, where he uses the word "will" in multiple ways, multiple definitions. So this is Shakespeare's 135th sonnet, not the whole thing. He says, "Whoever hath her wish, thou hast thy 'Will,' and 'Will' to boot, and 'Will' in overplus. More than enough am I that vex thee still to thy sweet will, making addition thus. Wilt thou, whose will is large and spacious, not once vouchsafe to hide my will in thine?"
- 3.55** It's actually a sexual double entendre as well. William's using "Will" to mean himself. His name is William. Also, "will" as a slang term for the genitals. And it's very crude, "to hide my will in thine." But also "will" means desire or wish. So in that one sonnet, multiple meanings are the same word.
- 3.56** Now, the basic plot of *Love's Labour's Lost* follows a broad template that we can apply to most of Shakespeare's comedies. We know that the characters are going to fall in love. We know that they're going to get married by the end of the play. So that means you've got five acts to get through, to get from that one point to the other. OK? You can't just have two people fall in love and then get married, because then it's over at the end of Act 1. We've got five acts.

- 3.57** Now, I recently saw an interview with Aaron Sorkin, who's this famous screenwriter, wrote *The West Wing* and that kind of thing. And he was talking about this notion of intention and obstacle. That's the phrase he used. He said when he's writing any screenplay, it's not good enough just to have a theme or a subject; you need intention and obstacle. So, in *The Social Network*, it's no good that his Mark Zuckerberg character simply sets up Facebook and it's a great success. It's not enough. He needs obstacles in the way of the success, and he does that in that film. You'll notice all sorts of obstacles.
- 3.58** And that's true of Shakespeare. It's true of all storytelling, really. The intention is for the lovers to get together. We have these four men who've made a pact to swear off women. Then four women turn up, who they happen to fall in love with. Oh, well, that's the— but the pact is one of the obstacles, of course. They have to get over that because by the end, we know that there's going to be marriage, or in this case, marriage postponed.
- 3.59** By the way, that vow, that vow of chastity, that collapses in Act 4, Scene 3. And that's the point where all the four men overhear each other reading aloud the love poetry that they have inevitably composed for the women. They realize they've been hypocrites, and that's it; the vow has been scuppered.
- 3.60** Now, as often in Shakespeare, you also get a secondary plot that mirrors the first, or ironically comments on the first. Here you've got the braggart Spaniard, the knight Don Armado, who also falls in love, not with a princess, but with a country wench called Jaquenetta. While the excess of rhetorical style is played out by those main characters, Berowne, Longaville, Dumaine, and the king of Navarre, Armado's attempt at high passionate rhetoric is so stupid, so absurd, that what it does is, it mocks the conventions.
- 3.61** So while you're seeing it attempted for real, Armado, or the function of Armado, is to mock that. And his pomposity is often punctuated by Moth, who sometimes is called Mote, as the little pageboy. Now, I can't focus on Armado because we'll run out of time, but I did want to point out one particular moment with him, which I think says a lot about Shakespeare's attention to detail and Shakespearean technique more generally.
- 3.62** This is Armado's first interaction with Jaquenetta, the object of his desire. This is in Act 1, Scene 2. Armado says, "Maid?" Jaquenetta says, "Man?" Armado says, "I will visit thee at the lodge." Jaquenetta says, "That's hereby." Armado says, "I know where it is situate." Jaquenetta says, "Lord, how wise you are!" Armado: "I will tell thee wonders." Jaquenetta: "With that face?" Armado says, "I love thee." Jaquenetta: "So I heard you say." Armado: "And so, farewell." Jaquenetta: "Fair weather after you!"
- 3.63** OK, it's a short scene. She's barely spoken. But we know exactly who she is. We know how she thinks. She makes such an impression as a full-rounded character. She is dismissive, she is teasing, she's enjoying her power, because she's the object of desire. She's witty, she's rude, she's straightforward. She's plain-speaking. Even that opening,

he's trying to be gracious to her: "Maid?" Her response: "Man?" So what? I'm a maid, you're a man. So what? He's trying to be polite, she undercuts it.

- 3.64** Now, it's interesting there because this is a very, very minor character. And where Shakespeare can be so elaborate, he can also be economical. He's not going to be satisfied with a minor character who just advances the plot. He wants someone who is alive, in and of themselves. I think most writers would have just written a perfunctory character, not worried about the detail, but not Shakespeare.
- 3.65** Now, Armado is a victim of love as much as the king and his men. And as so often in Shakespeare, love is depicted as a kind of sickness, a kind of plague, a disease, because it rids us of our reason. Armado complains that—this is what he says. Armado says, "Love is a familiar. Love is a devil. There is no evil angel but love. Yet was Samson so tempted, and he had an excellent strength. Yet was Solomon so seduced, and he had a very good wit. Cupid's butt-shaft is too hard for Hercules' club." Even the little arrow that Cupid fires is going to defeat the big club of Hercules.
- 3.66** "And therefore too much odds for a Spaniard's rapier. The first and second cause will not serve my turn. The passado he respects not, the duello he regards not. His disgrace is to be called boy, but his glory is to subdue men. Adieu, valour! Rust, rapier! Be still, drum, for your manager is in love." So he is completely defeated by this small boy, Cupid, the little flying blind boy.
- 3.67** Love, in other words, emasculates. Love prevents even the strongest men, like Hercules, from fighting, or the wisest men, like Solomon, from thinking. Antony was thus subdued when he fell for Cleopatra. Cupid, this mere boy, is able to rule over men. Now we hear this again from Berowne much later. This is in Act 4, Scene 3, when Berowne says, "To see a king transformed into a gnat! To see great Hercules whipping a gig, and profound Solomon to tune a jig," and so on.
- 3.68** So all of these ideas we've heard before in Shakespeare; we're going to hear them again. Armado seems to be wallowing in them, enjoying his performance as a lovestruck hero. But we hear the same pangs more elegantly expressed by other characters in Shakespeare. Now, in a previous lecture on the tragedies, in a different series of lectures, I spoke about this conflict between reason and passion. This is essential for Renaissance discourses of desire.
- 3.69** This conflict between reason and passion, sometimes reified imaginatively in the drama, such as in Sidney's *Arcadia*, where he has shepherds representing reason, dancing in a conflict against shepherds representing passion. It's a really common motif. Love, in other words, makes us irrational. We can no longer think. It detaches us from reality, which is why they call it a disease. Now, look at what Theseus says in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. This is in Act 5, Scene 1 of *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. I think this really summarizes it.

- 3.70** Theseus says, "Lovers and madmen have such seething brains, such shaping fantasies, that apprehend more than cool reason ever comprehends. The lunatic, the lover, and the poet are of imagination all compact. One sees more devils than vast hell can hold. That is, the madman. The lover, all as frantic, sees Helen's beauty in a brow of Egypt. The poet's eye, in a fine frenzy rolling, doth glance from heaven to Earth, from Earth to heaven. And as imagination bodies forth the forms of things unknown, the poet's pen turns them into shapes and gives to airy nothing a local habitation and a name."
- 3.71** It's interesting. The lover, the poet, the madman—they all share that quality. The lover can see beauty even where it doesn't exist. In that passage, it's phrased as Helen's beauty, Helen of Troy, in a brow of Egypt, dark-skinned. We get this kind of imagery in Antony and Cleopatra, the idea of the conventional beauty of the light-skinned woman with the darkness, the swarthiness, of Cleopatra. Lovers are madmen, fantasists. And poets, of course, provide the language to weave these dreams together, to make them intelligible.
- 3.72** And so, in Love's Labour's Lost, all of the men, all of the men, write poetry. That's the first thing they do. It's like an instinctive thing. Even Armado calls on some extemporal god of rhyme: "For I am sure I shall turn sonnet." He knows it. He's fallen in love. He's going to write a sonnet. It's what lovers do. And let's consider Berowne's acknowledgement that he's in love. He, too, has been conquered by this boy, Cupid. It is for him deeply humiliating, as it is for most of us. It's like being drunk. The loss of control can be fun, but it is rarely dignified.
- 3.73** This is what Berowne says. He says, "And I, forsooth, in love! I, that have been love's whip, a very beadle to a humorous sigh; a critic, nay, a night-watch constable; a domineering pedant over the boy," Cupid, that is, "than whom no mortal so magnificent!" Previously, Berowne has been able to resist love, to be the master of love, to control it, but not anymore.
- 3.74** And he says, "This wimpled, whining, purblind, wayward boy." Remember that Cupid is always blind. Why? Because we don't choose who we fall in love with. "This Signor Junior, giant dwarf, Dan Cupid, regent of love rhymes, lord of folded arms, the anointed sovereign of sighs and groans, liege of all loiterers and malcontents"—these are the typical aspects of the melancholic love. And Berowne is happy to mock them, even as he becomes one of them.
- 3.75** He says, "Dread prince of plackets, king of codpieces." Well, he's degrading it now, isn't he? That's sexual. The plackets are the slits in the skirt. The codpieces, well, you all know what they are. You can see what he's getting at. "Sole imperator and great general of trotting paritors, O my little heart!" The term paritors is the officers who were specifically interested to summon sex criminals to be tried. And Berowne says, "And I to be a corporal of his field and wear his colors like a tumbler's hoop! What? I love! I sue! I seek a wife!"

- 3.76** You can listen to the language. He's now a mere foot soldier of Cupid, this little boy; he's so demeaned by this. And not just a foot soldier, he's an acrobat, a foolish tumbler with his hoop. Now, you might look at this and say that this is all very misogynistic, this idea that women have the power to reduce men to idiots, to fools. But I think that word is often misused. Misogynistic, I think, means hatred of women. It means hatred of women. I would suggest that it's often misused.
- 3.77** Actually, the way in which the men in these plays are reduced to idiots, simpering fools, when they become infatuated, I think that reflects badly on them. Because women in Shakespeare's comedies are always, well, they're always cleverer. They're often more grounded. They're certainly more witty. Now, that isn't to say that Shakespeare doesn't write misogynistic characters. He does. He knows how to do that.
- 3.78** If you think about Posthumus in *Cymbeline*, do you remember when Posthumus is tricked into thinking his wife has been unfaithful? He launches into a tirade, a misogynistic tirade, where he fantasizes even that the race could be continued without women. He says, "Is there no way for men to be, but women must be half workers?" Think about that. He's saying, "Wouldn't it be great if we could reproduce without them? If we didn't need them."
- 3.79** In *Troilus and Cressida*, Thersites sneers about Cressida as a whore. But Thersites, of course, is the ultimate cynic. He thinks everyone's a whore—man, woman, doesn't matter. He thinks everyone's whorish. So it isn't that Shakespeare doesn't represent misogyny through his characters, or that he doesn't know what it means. I think it's just a leap to say that that makes him misogynistic. What you're doing there is, you're confusing the characters for the author, which is surprisingly common.
- 3.80** I do think, more broadly than that, any kind of condemnation of his plays, for the purported morality of those plays, completely misses the point. Now, some of you might disagree with that. That's fine. But we will certainly be testing this. We're going to go on to *The Taming of the Shrew* and *The Merchant of Venice*. I think those two plays are the ones that really test this principle. But we'll come back to that. In the meantime, let's get back to *Love's Labour's Lost*.
- 3.81** I started this lecture talking about the way that sex levels us, brings us down to Earth. It erodes that distinction between man and beast. This constant sexual punning in *Love's Labour's Lost*, which is a continuum, I think that's a way to acknowledge what I'm talking about. Sex is inevitable, but it never stops being funny. Here's an example. This is Act 4, Scene 1. This is just after Costard has given the wrong letter to the princess when she's out hunting with the ladies.
- 3.82** They then start engaging in this very overtly sexual banter, and they pun—again, the women are cleverer. The princess is smarter, and they're punning on the various hunting and archery metaphors. So Costard says, "By my troth, most pleasant. How both did fit it!" Maria says, "A mark marvelous well shot, for they both did hit it." And

Boyet and the princess have been so on target with their barbs about Armado in his letter; the language is clearly sexualized: "hit it" and "fit it" are both slang terms for having sex.

3.83 And then we have Boyet say, "A mark!" If you imagine the archery, the mark, the target, "A mark! O, mark but that mark! A mark, says my lady! Let the mark have a prick in't, to mete at, if it may be." So you can hear what's going on. The mark is the target, women's genitals; the prick in it requires no explanation. To mete at. Maria says, "Wide o' the bow hand! i' faith, your hand is out." Costard says, "Indeed, a' must shoot nearer, or he'll ne'er hit the clout." The clout is the cloth that was put on the target that you aimed at.

3.84 Boyet says, "And if my hand be out, then belike your hand is in." Costard says, "Then will she get the upshoot by cleaving the pin." So, to get the upshoot by cleaving the pin means she's going to win the archery competition by striking the pin, which is holding the cloth, or the clout, in place at the center of the target. But her hand being in, cleaving the pin, holding the penis, will get the upshoot, result in ejaculation.

3.85 And at this point, we sense the metaphor is going way too far. Maria then interjects and says, "Come, come, you talk greasily." Note what's happening there. We in the audience think, "OK, this is getting really crude now." One of the characters steps and says, "It's getting really crude now." So it comments on what's going on. "You talk greasily. Your lips grow foul." And then Costard says, "She's too hard for you at pricks, sir; challenge her to bowl." And Boyet says, "I fear too much rubbing. Good night, my good owl." That's damn right explicit. "She's too hard for you at pricks."

3.86 OK, we're all adults. Let's be clear what she's saying. In the Arden Shakespeare, that is glossed as, "Her vagina is not soft enough for you to get your penis into it." There's no point beating around the bush with this stuff. That's why Boyet's "I fear too much rubbing," which is a metaphor for bowlings, when the two balls in a bowl rubbed together, he's talking about masturbation, quite obviously.

3.87 I do think we're quite apt to overlook the sexualized, sometimes frenzied sexualized, quality of Shakespeare's language. We don't immediately get it, so we don't think it's there. But Shakespeare is aware of the obscenity. It's deliberate. Obscenity, for him, is another artistic tool that he can use. There's a really famous book from the 1940s called Shakespeare's Bawdy by Eric Partridge, and he literally catalogues all of the various sexualized elements in Shakespeare, and it goes on and on, every filthy joke. There's loads.

3.88 Often, his comedy just is highly sexual. We have to put this into the context. This is a pre-Victorian world. You couldn't have a playwright doing that in the Victorian era. Well, right up until the state censor was abandoned in the 1960s or wherever it was, the Lord Chamberlain, you couldn't do this. But this is a pre-Victorian world. This is the

Elizabethan world. Men wore codpieces in public. The acknowledgement of sex was everywhere.

- 3.89** It's like the Roman world. If you walk around Pompeii—I'm sure you have—there are phalluses just on the door stops, in front of the doors where everyone could see them. Not even just in brothels, by the way. These things are open. So you have to contextualize. The Elizabethans weren't squeamish about sexual matters. But also, also, it really helps the humor, because remember what I said: this is about court gentility. This is about decorum. So it's funnier when it becomes cruder.
- 3.90** Love can be transcendent, but the language of love can also function as an ornament to conceal pure, unadulterated lust. Consider when this was performed, as well; it adds to the humor. I've said the quarto edition of 1598, it boasts on the front that this was performed before the Queen. It says, "at last Christmas," it says. Well, doesn't that make it funnier? A lot of the wordplay is more sophisticated than the parts I've just been quoting, but I'm flagging it up because I'm saying that Shakespeare is not above a dirty joke, even when the Queen is sitting there.
- 3.91** And this also explains maybe why it fell out of fashion. I mean, Samuel Johnson, a great critic, Samuel Johnson, he said the following. He said, "In this play, which all the editors have concurred to censure, and some have rejected as unworthy of our poet, it must be confessed that there are many passages mean, childish, and vulgar; and some which ought not to have been exhibited, as we are told they were, to a maiden queen." So he's not very happy about this.
- 3.92** But then Johnson had odd, very moralistic ideas in his interpretation. He was a brilliant critic, a genius. But for instance, he was very upset by poetic injustice. He didn't like the ending of *King Lear* because poetic justice was abandoned in that play. I understand where he's coming from. It's a horrible ending, but it's a better ending, isn't it? Because he has abandoned that idea of moral justice. It's a world without moral justice. Like I say, *King Lear* is a godless world. Why should the good guys win?
- 3.93** Now, no one is more aware of the degradation of love into sex than Berowne, because Berowne is in love, but he doesn't wish to be in love. He finds himself writing poetry, but he doesn't like it, and he's not good at it. This anticipates Benedick in *Much Ado About Nothing*. He writes some poetry, if you remember. He can't find the rhymes. He can only find the rhyme for lady; the only word he can think of is baby. These are terrible rhymes. You hear him complaining about this in that soliloquy. He writes some terrible poetry.
- 3.94** Orlando, in *As You Like It*, writes some really bad poetry, runs around pinning it on the trees. It's a terrible verse. But of course, bad poetry can convey genuine feeling, because love is a feeling that is often so difficult to put into words. We don't know how to do it. It's just as well that we have poets like Shakespeare who can convey it better than the rest of us. This is why, if you read Valentine's cards, they're all so corny,

cheesy— because very few of us can capture that very important transcendental experience of valuing someone else's life more than your own.

- 3.95** That's what love is. It's the most important thing about life, I think. But to summarize it, to put it into words—no. Shakespeare can do it. Some of his characters really, really can't. That's why you get this awful poetry from Orlando and Berowne, and Benedick as well. But here, Berowne is berating himself again about being—and he keeps having a go at himself for being in love. But you can hear the tension between his reason and his passion, that dichotomy I mentioned, and it's echoed within the language.
- 3.96** That's the source of the comedy. Love, in other words, is making him act against his own will. So this is Act 4, Scene 3. "The king, he is hunting the deer. I am coursing myself." So he's also become a hunter, but of a different kind. He says, "They have pitched a toil. I am toiling in a pitch—pitch that defiles." To pitch a toil is to set up the nets for hunting. But he's punning on the darkness of Rosaline, the woman he's fallen in love with. She's got dark eyes, dark hair, black as pitch, and he is stuck in love, like a fly in pitch.
- 3.97** He says, "I will not love. If I do, hang me. In faith, I will not. O, but her eye! By this light, but for her eye, I would not love her. Yes, for her two eyes," cannot help himself, "by heaven, I do love, and it hath taught me to rhyme and to be melancholy." Such is the fate of lovers, even reluctant lovers. And yet, there's something added here. There's something else to Berowne, isn't there? We get the sense of him falling in love with himself as a lover.
- 3.98** Let me explain that. He's delighted with his own rhetoric. He's wading in it. As much as he is erotically charged by the dark beauty of Rosaline, in her pitch-black eyes, he sees his own desire reflected back to him, kind of falling in love with herself. Critics do often compare him with Benedick in *Much Ado About Nothing*, almost like he's a prototype, Benedick. But I think this is a very clear character distinction. Benedick is not falling in love with himself, even though he shares many qualities with Beatrice. It's a higher love. They're not the same character.
- 3.99** Now, I want to turn quickly to the final scene of *Love's Labour's Lost*, which I think reminds us that, even in this early play, Shakespeare is not your standard comedic writer. We mentioned this before, with the opening of *Comedy of Errors*, the surprise opening, where we start on death at the very opening of a frivolous farce.
- 3.100** In *Love's Labour's Lost*, it's where we end that counts. So what happens? If you remember, we have the men renege on their vow in Act 4. They write poetry, they play word games throughout, they've got all the banter, flirtations. Then you've got the final act, Act 5, where we have all this fun and games. The men dress up as Muscovites, and they attempt to woo the ladies in disguise.
- 3.101** The women, of course, because they are more intelligent than the men, see through the disguise, and so they rebuff them, and then the men leave. Then, when they return,

the women start complaining about, "Oh, these Russians, the intrusion of these Russians." So this is a comedic conceit that Shakespeare then returns to in *Much Ado About Nothing*, where Beatrice, knowing that she's talking to Benedick in a mask, pretends she doesn't know who he is, so she can mock him directly to his face. It's the same idea.

- 3.102** And then, of course, when the king and Berowne and Longaville and Dumaine realize they've been mocked, the princess still wants Costard and his troupe to go ahead with the Pageant of the Nine Worthies. This is all part of the fun and games at the end of the play, in Act 5. The Nine Worthies, by the way, that was a very popular medieval and Renaissance concept, nine legendary heroes who embodied perfect chivalry. There's a lot of fun to be had there, with the continual heckling, the continual interruptions, from the spectators.
- 3.103** Again, we are anticipating something that Shakespeare will do much better in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, with the performance of the Mechanicals in Act 5. But *Love's Labour's Lost* does something starkly different to the end of *Midsummer Night's Dream* here. This play has been very light, very upbeat, very frivolous. A lot of word games, a lot of fun. All the nonsense with the Muscovites, the Nine Worthies, that kind of thing. But then someone else appears. A new character enters the play, an unexpected character.
- 3.104** Do you remember this one? Monsieur Marcade. Monsieur Marcade has not been in the play so far. He's a messenger. And that name, Marcade, signifies—many critics think it signifies death, the danse macabre, the dance of death. And certainly, it does feel like the Grim Reaper has just turned up at a comedy. He's dressed in mourning; he's all in black. He turns up, and the princess says, "Welcome, Marcade, but that thou interruptest our merriment."
- 3.105** Marcade says, "I am sorry, madam, for the news I bring is heavy in my tongue. The king your father—" and the princess doesn't need to hear, "Dead, for my life!" Marcade says, "Even so, my tale is told." And Berowne says, "Worthies, away!" Costard and the others, away. "The scene begins to cloud." It is, theatrically, an incredible moment. The men playing the Worthies are dispatched immediately—Nathaniel, Holofernes, Costard, Moth, Armado. So all the foolish characters are cleared away.
- 3.106** There's no longer time for mirth. The mirth has been sucked out of the play in an instant by the intrusion of this one singular character. It's a theatrical coup. As Berowne says, "The scene begins to cloud." It feels like a black cloud has descended on the whole play. Indulging in these games of love has been a charming diversion, but then reality has intruded, and the darkness at the moment is all the more intense, given the frivolity of the scene that preceded it.
- 3.107** This, I suppose, is all of our experience when we go and see a play. We indulge in it, we escape into the play, we forget who we are; and then we have to leave the theater, and

all our troubles are back again. Reality is back, the harshness of the real world. In other words, this theatricalizes the experience of the theater.

3.108 Now, upon the announcement that the princess's father has died, the women now take the four men seriously. And she, the princess, explains that their attention seemed sportive, trivial, so the women had responded in kind. And that has been the whole tone of the play. She says, "We have received your letters full of love, your favors, the ambassadors of love; and in our maiden council, rated them at courtship, pleasant jest and courtesy, as bombast and as lining to the time."

3.109 That's a great phrase, that "lining to the time," just a frippery, some way to kill time in some light and airy way. "But more devout than this in our respects have we not been; and therefore met your loves in their own fashion, like a merriment." You were playing with us, so we were playing with you. But now they're going to take it seriously. Now, it seems that the intrusion of reality, the death of her father, it's turned the matter from something playful to something of greater import.

3.110 As I've said, *Love's Labour's Lost* is an unusual Shakespearean comedy, insofar as it doesn't end in marriage. It's at this point the marriages are postponed, deferred, for a year, in which time, Rosaline says to Berowne that he's going to have to make a promise that he's going to go to a hospital and entertain the sick for that year. It's a bit of a strange request.

3.111 Then Armado and his gang return to perform the song, the song they were going to end their performance of the Nine Worthies with. But the song now has a different feel about it. Because of all that's happened, because of this intrusion of reality, Armado and the crew, their final song, it's going to take on a whole new atmosphere and life. This is the song of the owl and the cuckoo, of spring and of winter.

3.112 Now, songs in Shakespeare often have a form of commentary about them; they're choric. They often say something about the theme of the play more broadly. But this one has a tonal aspect as well, an impact on the play as a whole. So we hear the duet between spring and winter. Spring's song seems to reflect much of what we've seen in the play—sexual vitality, the joy of love, and the joy of youth. This is the start.

3.113 "When daisies pied and violets blue and lady-smocks all silver-white and cuckoo buds of yellow hue do paint the meadows with delight, the cuckoo then, on every tree, mocks married men. For thus sings he, Cuckoo! Cuckoo! Cuckoo! O word of fear, unpleasing to a married ear!" See, the married man, as we've said, is forever concerned about being cuckolded. The cuckoo, the bird who lays the egg in someone else's nest, that's where you get the word cuckoldry. It's where it's from. And as I've said, it was an endless source of humor for the Elizabethans, so the theme occurs throughout Shakespeare's plays.

3.114 So, in spring's song, even in the supposed security of marriage, there's fear. "When shepherds pipe on oaten straws and merry larks are ploughmen's clocks, when turtles

tread, and rooks, and daws"—turtles are turtle doves, not the other things—"when turtles tread, and rooks, and daws, and maidens bleach their summer smocks, the cuckoo then, on every tree, mocks married men; for thus sings he, Cuckoo! Cuckoo! Cuckoo! O word of fear, unpleasing to a married ear!"

- 3.115** Then we shift to the winter song, and this reflects this shift that we've seen in the play, this broad atmospheric shift, from the festivity before the appearance of Marcade and the darkness that follows after his appearance. The shadow of death hangs over this, the cry of the owl, like a death knell, if your mind runs to that. This is how it goes.
- 3.116** "When icicles hang by the wall, and Dick the shepherd blows his nail, and Tom bears logs into the hall, and milk comes frozen home in pail, when blood is nipped, and ways be foul, then nightly sings the staring owl: Tu-whit, tu-whoo, a merry note, while greasy Joan doth keel the pot." Greasy Joan is a stock rustic figure. So, too, is Dick the shepherd, Tom the log-bearer.
- 3.117** "When all aloud the wind doth blow, and coughing drowns the parson's saw, and birds sit brooding in the snow, and Marian's nose looks red and raw, when roasted crabs hiss in the bowl, then nightly sings the staring owl: Tu-whit, tu-whoo, a merry note, while greasy Joan doth keel the pot." The tone is plaintive, cold, bittersweet. Marriage is postponed and, as spring has sung, marriage is not necessarily the old happy-ever-after, anyway.
- 3.118** But this image of greasy Joan, keeling the pot, stirring the pot, of the roasted crabs hissing away in the bowl, there's something very homely about this, appealing and melancholic and gloomy all at the same time. It isn't like a sudden descent into darkness. It's touching. And theatrically, it's superb. It always works well. It seems to encapsulate this notion that we began with, that love is invariably followed by a cloud.
- 3.119** In our performances of love, our rituals of desire, we may indulge in the joy of the sensations, but there is responsibility, there is fear, there is anxiety. It's the collision of our idealized fantasies and the stark realities. Shakespeare favors neither one nor the other, but he invites us to experience both. Death, of course, is always lingering. Death is always there, watching the lovers, waiting for its moment. And the final line is Armado's: "You that way, we this way." And doesn't that just say it all?

Lecture 4: Taming of the Shrew & Much Ado

At a glance — The Taming of the Shrew and Much Ado About Nothing.

- 4.1 I want to start by telling you about my least favorite word in the English language, which is "problematic". I really can't stand it. Now, I am a free speech absolutist, although I would be quite happy to see that banned forever. The Taming of the Shrew is Shakespeare's play that is most often described as problematic, and I've read endless tracts about this, a lot of feminist writers, who—some write really well, some write very badly, but none of them are particularly adept at concealing the fact that they're offended by the play.
- 4.2 Now, offense is a perfectly legitimate human reaction. I don't have a problem with that. But my point about it is that, if you are offended by something, you are often not engaging critically with the text. As Jaques says in As You Like It, "When you're feeling as though you're being mocked, the best way to retain your dignity is to appear as though you are not hurt." This is what Jaques says. He says, "He that a fool doth very wisely hit doth very foolishly, although he smart, not to seem senseless of the bob."
- 4.3 But it is difficult, isn't it? If you are a woman with any self-respect, watching Taming of the Shrew, how could you sit through that play and see this strong, independent woman being maligned, being the subject of farce, and not feel a bit offended? I'm pretty sure that I would feel offended if I watched that and I were female. But I don't know.
- 4.4 There are many, many books, many films, many plays that I personally, have offended me in the past, or I do find offensive. But maybe that was because I felt that I was, in some way, the target of the satire. But then I am reminded, whenever that happens to me, that taking offense is a choice, as the emperor Marcus Aurelius put it. "Choose not to be harmed, and you won't feel harmed. Don't feel harmed, and you haven't been."
- 4.5 Now, I take the view that art has absolutely nothing whatsoever to do with morality. Now, I know that art can often engage with moral questions in terms of representation or interpretation or interrogation. It can be didactic. It can attempt to teach us to do better. One of my favorite books growing up was Tom Brown's School Days, which is a very didactic book. A lot of Dickens' work is very, very didactic.
- 4.6 But I personally feel that the best art is that which does not attempt to preach, and sometimes, art is seemingly saying something that we find appalling, in order to interrogate those issues. I think of Lars von Trier's film Antichrist, which is a film with Charlotte Gainsbourg and Willem Dafoe, and that was from 2009. This caused a storm, this film. People were so upset about this. They said it was deeply misogynistic, deeply misogynistic. The film was actually about misogyny. It wasn't endorsing misogyny.

- 4.7 Lars von Trier often does this very interesting thing in his films, where he takes an indefensible position and decides, "Right, now I'm going to defend it," in the film. In *Antichrist*, the premise is, well, what if the misogynists are right, and what if women are actually demonic? And so he presents that. He's not actually saying it's real. He's exploring the unthinkable in art. Now, that is at least, I think, interesting, whatever you think about the film.
- 4.8 So if we take a play like *The Taming of the Shrew*, and we say, well, Katherina in this play is degraded, humiliated, the subject of farce, and therefore, this is an anti-female play, this is a misogynistic play, I think we're doing a number of things there. I think one of the things we're doing is, we're assuming that we know what is going on in the mind of the writer, of the mind of the creator.
- 4.9 Just as we can't assume that Lars von Trier is a misogynist because he creates a film about misogyny, we can't do the same for Shakespeare. We don't have that telepathy that can burrow into the mind, least of all because he's been dead for 400 years. So even if we were telepathic, it'd be tricky. We can't do it.
- 4.10 And I would add this. Even if it were confirmed that Shakespeare was a misogynist, even if we found a diary in which he said, "I hate women," my response to that would be, "So what?" Honestly, because I don't expect my artists to be good people. If you look throughout the history of art, some of them are really horrible. Some of my favorite artists were just nasty pieces of work, but they created beautiful things.
- 4.11 I often think about the criticism of Roald Dahl for his anti-Semitism. There's no doubt Roald Dahl was an anti-Semite. He said anti-Semitic things, and I'm not a fan of that kind of thing, obviously. However, maybe, as Christopher Hitchens once pointed out, maybe you needed a mind as twisted as that to come up with works as twisted as he did. And the brilliance of those children's books is that they are twisted. They are strange.
- 4.12 I don't think we should expect artists to be necessarily good people. I think if we got rid of art by all the bad artists, we would lose half the Western canon, and we would all suffer as a result. And that is not to say we endorse their behavior. Caravaggio killed a man while trying to castrate him. That's horrible. What a nasty piece of work. I don't want to know someone like that. I don't want someone like that in my life, but I do want his paintings.
- 4.13 I suppose I'm trying to say that, ultimately, we need to find some way to acknowledge that the art and the artist are not the same. And for the sake of the Western canon, for the sake of civilization, we have to be able to distinguish between the two. We can't expect moral purity from any human being, least of all artists. But I'm going to go back to this point. We don't know what Shakespeare thought. Shakespeare could have been the most wonderful, morally pure individual who ever lived. Or he could have been a right rotter. We just don't know, and it's pointless to speculate.

- 4.14 We've also got to add to this when we're thinking about *The Taming of the Shrew*. There is such a thing as shifting moral trends. Ethics is culturally specific. Things that we believe and take to be true now were once considered to be awful, and vice versa. There are some things that we now consider to be absolutely terrible, beyond the pale, that were once considered virtuous. It very much depends when we live, in what culture we live in, in what time we live in.
- 4.15 Now, Shakespeare is writing in the Elizabethan and Jacobean periods. At this time, it was a given that, in marriage, the husband had supremacy. That was an absolute given. This is 300 years before the suffragettes were even formed. How could someone, raised at that time, in that culture, think otherwise? Women felt the same way about this, as well. It seems to me that complaining about outdated attitudes written four centuries ago is a bit odd. It's a bit like not liking *Hamlet* because there's not many smartphones in it. It doesn't really make any sense. You have to contextualize.
- 4.16 But a word in defense of Shakespeare—I don't think any of these criticisms of Shakespeare actually apply. Now, I'm trying to make the point that, even if they did, I wouldn't care. But I don't think they do. I think, if you look at his female characters, they are often the most brilliantly complex of all of his creations. If you think about Cleopatra, Rosaline, Juliet, Helena, Portia, Lady Macbeth, Queen Margaret, Viola, the list goes on and on. Volumnia is a wonderful character in *Coriolanus* that's so complex, so interesting, so morally ambiguous, so alive.
- 4.17 It's not as though this is a man who can't write women. He can write people, whether they are similar to him or not similar to him. When it comes to the comedies, for all the folly of falling in love, it really is, generally, I have to say, the women who come out on top. The women are generally more self-aware in his comedies. He seems to find men a bit more prone to making fools of themselves.
- 4.18 Like I say, we can't assume anything about his attitude towards men as a result, but you could make a case that Shakespeare was anti-male, misandrist, if you want to go down that line. But I think it's always going to be speculative. In a sense, there is probably nothing that Shakespeare can do to please our modern activist critics. One of the problems we have at the moment in the universities is that a lot of academics are activists first and academics second, which means that they allow their own obsessions to get in the way of their critical analysis.
- 4.19 So if you are an intersectional critic, then you would say that even to be white and male is a form of moral corruption. I actually read a piece a few years ago by a writer of very obviously limited talent, wrote an article called, "We need to kill the Western canon," which claimed that we shouldn't be studying writers like Ernest Hemingway because his sex and his skin color make him complicit in patriarchal and racist power structures.
- 4.20 And this is basically a new religion. This is the new religion of intersectionality. And what it does is, it enables bad writers to claim moral superiority over good writers as a

means to dismiss them. So anyone who claims that we shouldn't be studying the likes of Shakespeare because he was male or because he was white is effectively attempting a form of cultural vandalism. They are trying to impose their identity-obsessed world onto everyone else.

- 4.21 And Shakespeare transcends that. I mean, absolutely, he does. His plays explore all kinds of people. You can read Shakespeare through the lens of group identity. Of course, you can read Shakespeare in many ways, and I'm not trying to say to people they shouldn't do that if they want to. But what I'm saying is, it's very limited. It's very narrow. It's like visiting the Sistine Chapel and just looking at the floor. You wouldn't do it, would you? You want the whole breadth.
- 4.22 Now, when it comes to Shakespeare, as I said, we don't know what type of person he was. We don't know what type of values he stood for. And as I say, even if we did, we should be able to separate the art from the artist. And the other thing to remember is that I don't think it's the role of artists to provide moral instruction.
- 4.23 That's not to say that we don't develop or cultivate our morality by the books we read. I think we do. I think that, that necessarily happens because literature gives us an insight into mindsets that are not our own. And that all contributes to the formation of an ethical system. So I think that is true. But I don't think we read a Shakespeare play to teach us the right message about how to behave. I think that is misconceiving its purpose.
- 4.24 And what of comedy? What of comedy? I think this has particularly affected comedy in the modern world. We've reached a point where the art of comedy has been demeaned by this myopic fixation on language, on power relations. You always hear activists complaining about "problematic" jokes—there's that word again—which they believe are almost like incantations, that if a comedian says something that causes offense to a particular group, it's almost like a toxin that escapes into society and creates evil racists and homophobes and all the rest of it.
- 4.25 Of course, comedy doesn't work like that, and art certainly doesn't work like that. Comedy cannot really exist without the potential to cause offense to someone. I've done stand-up for many, many years. There's always going to be someone who is offended by something you say, because it tallies with something in their own life. Like I say, nothing wrong with feeling offended. We all feel offended from time to time.
- 4.26 My problem would be when someone is offended by comedy and therefore wants to stop it from happening, wants to censor the comedian, wants to pull a comedian's show, as has happened in the UK quite a lot. There was a comedian called Jerry Sadowitz, who had a show in Edinburgh, a very popular comedian, and members of staff saw the first night, were upset, complained, and the next night was completely pulled. He's considered a veteran, a really significant figure, but very offensive. Very offensive, indeed. I'm not denying that.

- 4.27 But the point is that, in every generation, there are different red lines about what is offensive and what is not offensive, and comedians will always be found capering along those red lines. Comedians test the limits of our tolerance. That's one of the things they do. If you think about the fools and the clowns in Shakespeare, that's what he has them do.
- 4.28 Lear's fool is the most obvious example, giving voice to the taboos of our age. Lear. Saying to the king directly, "You've made a mistake. Look at you. You got rid of your one good daughter, you idiot." And he says it to his face. And yes, Lear at one point threatens him with the whip, but he doesn't do it. It's the tyrant that whips the fool. It's the tyrant that kills the clown.
- 4.29 So you can read *Taming the Shrew* and be offended, and that's a perfectly legitimate human response, absolutely. And you can read it and say, "Yeah, this is just a play that attacks women. This says that, if you dare to seek independence, then you need to be stifled." And maybe that's true. Who knows? Maybe that's what Shakespeare was trying to say. But comedy isn't always satirical. And the satirist is someone who mocks the follies and the vices of the powerful. The satirist very much punches up.
- 4.30 The comedian is more scattershot than that. A comedian can punch in all sorts of ways. He or she will get the laugh, no matter what the target. We shouldn't assume that a comedian's joke is necessarily reflective of what they believe. I have comedian friends who will go out there and say that they support a particular political group, even when they don't, because they want to provoke or they want to test something.
- 4.31 The thing with a stand-up performance is that you see the person performing under their own name and you think, "Well, that's that person." Actually, in virtually all cases, a stand-up comedian is playing a persona. It is a theatrical performance. We often forget that. I understand why we forget that because a good comedian makes you forget it. They inhabit this role to such an extent that you think, "Oh, did they really mean that? What are they doing there?" That, to me, is very, very interesting.
- 4.32 Now, that's the difference, I think, there between the satirist and the comedian. The satirist, as I say, goes after the powerful. I would say that the fool in *Lear* is a satirist. He's identifying the problems of the powerful and poking at it. But the comedian sees folly everywhere, and the comedian, instead of railing against it, wanting to change it, the comedian accepts that the world is flawed. And so what the comedian does is he points and laughs at it.
- 4.33 There's a very good quotation by W. H. Auden, the poet, about this distinction between comedy and satire, and I often quote it because I think it really encapsulates it. Auden said, "Satire is angry and optimistic. It believes that the evil it attacks can be abolished. Comedy is good-natured and pessimistic. It believes that, however much we may wish we could, we cannot change human nature and must make the best of a bad job." I

think that's just such a brilliantly succinct summary of that distinction between those two art forms.

- 4.34 Aristophanes. We mentioned Aristophanes before, the father of comedy. There's a good reason he's the father of comedy. He would fire off salvos in all directions. It didn't matter who you were. It didn't matter what your relative power in society was—men, women, old and young, aristocrats and slaves, fashionable and unfashionable, mortal and immortal. He would have a go at the gods. Nobody was spared. He could laugh at the dignity of Socrates. He could laugh at the dramatic power of Euripides. He could laugh at the might of Cleon or the propriety of Aspasia. Anyone was fair game, anyone.
- 4.35 And what that means is that his audiences could never relax. They could never sit there in a play by Aristophanes in the amphitheater and think, "I am not going to get mocked." And that's an interesting experience as an audience member at a comedy. You should never be able to settle down and think, "I'm going to mock people who are not like me. I'm going to laugh at others," because a good comedian will twist it, and suddenly you find yourself in the spotlight. That's so much more interesting.
- 4.36 Critics argue, as I say, that *The Taming of the Shrew* is saying that women should have their wings clipped, women who are free-spirited. And certainly, that is the attitude of Petruchio. Petruchio, or at least this is what he says, so he comes in, Act 3, Scene 2. This is what he says. I think I'm safe in assuming that all of us here would agree that this is not a good attitude to have.
- 4.37 He says, "I will be master of what is mine own. She"—as in my wife—"she is my goods, my chattels. She is my house, my household stuff, my field, my barn, my horse, my ox, my ass, my anything. Here she stands. Touch her, whoever dare. I'll bring mine action on the proudest he that stops my way in Padua." But the thing is, it's slightly too excessive, isn't it? I mean, you hear men who are quite possessive of women, and probably misogynist, and probably overly dominant, but they don't say it like that. It's too much, isn't it? It's too on the nose, I think.
- 4.38 It's almost mocking the idea of the husband's possessiveness of his wife. That does sound very sexist. You just read that passage, you think that's incredibly sexist. But again, we're not Elizabethans. We don't know, really, how they would have felt about that. Those critics who say that this was problematic, this particular passage—they'd use that word, problematic, which I can't stand. Every time I say it, I shudder. The critics who say that it is a problematic passage, I'm going to ask a question of them: "In what way? What do you mean by that?"
- 4.39 These aren't actually Shakespeare's views. They're Petruchio's views. And are they even his views? Or is he expressing them as a ruse to manipulate Katherina? Why would you assume that a writer, who represents a certain viewpoint in a text, automatically endorses it? That, to me, is very literal-minded. What do critics mean when they say

problematic? What they mean is, "I'm offended by it." That's what they mean. Well, that's fine, but I'm not interested in whether you're offended by it. I'm just not. That's your issue.

4.40 Now, as we know, Petruchio engages in a series of very cruel activities that effectively amount to a form of psychological torture, because he is "taming the shrew." He's making Katherina pliable, obsequious, and ostensibly, it works. This is the reason people have a problem with the play, because it actually works. So he does tame the wild Katherina. She repents, and by the end of the play, she's seen the folly of her ways, apparently.

4.41 This is what she says. These are famous lines. She says, "I am ashamed that women are so simple to offer war where they should kneel for peace; or seek for rule, supremacy, and sway, when they are bound to serve, love, and obey." Well, that seems pretty clear-cut, doesn't it? Shakespeare's saying that men should dominate in marriage, and here's a woman who's agreeing. But again, this is not Shakespeare talking. It's one of his characters talking.

4.42 And might it not be possible that his apparent endorsement of convention has enabled him to present the free-spirited Katherina in all her glory throughout the play? If you think about it, the ending of a play does not undermine what came before. At this time, you have to be very careful about what you write. You could have your ears chopped off if you mocked the monarch. You're going to be a bit careful about what you say. Being controversial at this time had real consequences.

4.43 If you wanted, for instance, if Shakespeare wants to present same-sex love, what does he do? Well, he has Antonio, quite clearly is in love with Sebastian in *Twelfth Night*. How does he get away with that? He has everyone happily married off. Sebastian marries off at the end. That subversive relationship is precluded. It's what we would call a containment device. But the fact that he precludes it at the end means that he is able to explore it for the play.

4.44 What if it's the same with Katherina? What if throughout the play, she is wild and funny and witty and anarchic. Maybe that's what he wanted to present, but he knew he had to wrap it all up nicely, so he could get away with that form of presentation. I hope that makes sense. Now, I'm not saying that's definite. Like I said, I don't know his mind. I'm saying that's a possibility.

4.45 But there is also another problem, isn't there? We've established that this is not Shakespeare talking here. These are his characters. We know that Shakespeare creates human characters, human beings that are not him, that are separate from him, and he brings them to life. That's his skill. That's his power. We've established that we don't know Shakespeare's private thoughts.

4.46 So this is a character, and the character's private thoughts we don't necessarily know. This is a play. This is not an autobiography. But even on those terms, even on those

terms, there's an added dimension to *The Taming of the Shrew*, because it's not just a play. It's a play within a play. People often forget about this.

- 4.47 Of course, the opening act—the entire story of Katherina and Petruchio is being performed by players at the house of a lord who wants to trick the drunken tinker, Christopher Sly, who's passed out drunk. They pull him back to his house. They dress him up in fine clothes. They tell him he's a nobleman. This happens in the induction. They call it the induction, which is the opening of *The Taming of the Shrew*. They dress him up in finery.
- 4.48 And then he regains his senses. He comes back, and they say, "Oh, well, we're going to show you this play about a shrew being tamed." What's happening here? Shakespeare is building layers upon layers of fantasy. There's the fantasy of the story of Katherina. There's the fantasy of Sly, who now believes himself to be a lord, who has a pageboy called Bartholomew, who they've dressed up as his wife. There's the fantasy of Sly's story itself, which is a concoction of Shakespeare.
- 4.49 The whole thing is a concoction. It's a concoction within a concoction within a concoction. And yet here we are, modern critics, taking offense about some words uttered by a made-up character within a made-up story within another made-up story. Now, if you're offended by that, that is your right. But for all the talk of modern critics about power structures and problematic representations, maybe, just maybe, Shakespeare was just trying to make us laugh. And the play is very funny.
- 4.50 Now, I would recommend, in particular, the 1967 film by Franco Zeffirelli, which stars Elizabeth Taylor and Richard Burton. I think it's the best adaptation I've seen of it. Zeffirelli cut the induction, so we're straight into Padua. It looks like it was incredibly good fun to film. There is loads of smashing things up and falling over. Elizabeth Taylor is having a great time, trashing everything. Apparently, at this time, Burton and Taylor were drinking a lot and fighting a lot. I think they were married during this time.
- 4.51 But that dynamic—apparently, they were also very much in love. So that dynamic of this destructive and yet deeply passionate relationship, I think, was channeled into these performances. Just that they did in a film they made a year before, called *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*, which you might have seen. It's a film by Mike Nichols, one of the early Mike Nichols films, based on a play by Edward Albee. Very dysfunctional marriage there. They drink all night.
- 4.52 I mean, I won't ruin it for you. It absolutely must be seen. There's a drinking game you can play with *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* If you have a drink every time they do, you won't last. You'll last about half an hour. I mean, they drink improbable amounts of liquor in that film, and it becomes so destructive, and they play horrible games to humiliate each other in front of their house guests. It is quite the film.
- 4.53 But what I'm saying is, apparently, they were in the same—Burton and Taylor were bickering a lot, drinking a lot, fighting a lot, and also they were passionately in love with

each other. Isn't that interesting? Sometimes this happy-ever-after view of romantic relationships isn't necessarily correct. Sometimes the most passionate loves are also the most destructive. I think that's something that Shakespeare is really interested in.

4.54 Now, I should say, by the way, that there was a version of *The Taming of the Shrew* that emerged roughly around the same time as Shakespeare's version, not *The Taming of the Shrew*, but *The Taming of a Shrew*. It's a bit confusing. There are historical records about this. It was entered into the Stationers' Register in 1594—the Stationers' Register was where all new plays were registered. It was the official record book kept by the Stationers' Company of London, which was the guild that controlled printing and publishing in England from the middle of the 16th century onwards.

4.55 A lot of the way we date Shakespeare's plays is when they were entered into the Stationers' Register. It's a very useful historical record that we still have. But *The Taming of a Shrew* and *The Taming of the Shrew*, we don't know which came first. *The Taming of the Shrew* is attributed to Shakespeare very, very explicitly. *The Taming of a Shrew* is anonymous. We don't know who wrote it. So there's been all sorts of debates about this.

4.56 Some people think that this was a source for Shakespeare, that Shakespeare was effectively rewriting this and making it better. Some people think it was by Shakespeare, and that *The Taming of the Shrew* is his revision of an earlier play. Some people think it's the other way around. We actually don't know. We have no idea. It could have been another draft of *The Taming of the Shrew*.

4.57 Remember, we talked about the quarto editions, the small editions that came out, and how sometimes actors in the company would transcribe them from memory, so you would get a bad version, something that wasn't quite right. It could be that. We don't know. But one of the most interesting things about *The Taming of a Shrew*— and if you get a good edition of Shakespeare's play, they normally include this in the appendices—there is a closing scene, which ties up the Sly framing device.

4.58 So, whereas in Shakespeare's play, we open with this Sly being tricked into thinking he's a lord and watching the play, then we watch the play, and then the play ends, and that's it. We sort of forget about Sly by the time we get to Act 5. In *The Taming of a Shrew*, we go back to Sly, which I think is very interesting. I saw a production of *The Taming of the Shrew* where the director incorporated that extra scene, and it changes things a little bit. Bear in mind, this could be by Shakespeare; we don't know.

4.59 Now, at the end, Sly has been watching the play. He falls asleep again. He's carried back to where he was passed out drunk, and he's dressed back up in his old pauper's clothes. He wakes up and he says, "Oh, I've had an incredible dream." He thinks he's dreamed the whole thing. He's woken up by the tapster—which is the word for the bartender of the time. The tapster says, "Aye, marry, but you had best get you home, for your wife will curse you for dreaming here tonight."

- 4.60 And Sly says, "Will she? I now know how to tame a shrew. I dreamt upon it all this night till now, and thou hast waked me out of the best dream that ever I had in my life. But I'll to my wife presently and tame her too, and if she anger me." And then the tapster says, "Nay, tarry, Sly, for I'll go home with thee, and hear the rest that thou hast dreamt tonight."
- 4.61 And if this is Shakespeare, doesn't that rather change the significance of the play? I don't think anyone hearing the final words of Sly will think he genuinely has a chance of taming his wife. He's a stupid drunk, and he's there boasting about, "Oh, I know. I know how to tame a shrew now." And of course, he doesn't.
- 4.62 So the joke then, the joke of the whole play, then becomes about a male fantasy of dominance, which is hopelessly disconnected from the real world. It's the opposite of what people say the play is. If you say the play is sexist and demeaning to women, I would say, this closing of the play completely undercuts that reading.
- 4.63 So, let's start by looking at the first direct interaction between Petruchio and Katherine. Now, I think this is going to demonstrate that Shakespeare's priority, beyond all the politics of gender, is to make us laugh, to have his characters indulge in verbal combat. And remember, this is quite an early play. He's already, like I said, a natural comedian. He's already nailed this.
- 4.64 So Petruchio starts and says, "Good morrow, Kate, for that's your name, I hear." Now, there's a phrase that's used a lot in modern, in our discourse, which is gaslighting, which is when you deny observable reality to someone in order to drive them mad. It's from the movie *Gaslight*, where the husband turns the lights down, and the wife is saying, "Are the lights going down?" He says, "No, that's just your mind." It's a common trick. It's an abusive trick to gain dominance.
- 4.65 You see this later in *Taming of the Shrew*, when he's saying, "Oh, the sun is the moon. I say it's the—" He makes her repeat the fantasies. It's a form of his control, although by that point, she's in on the game. Calling her Kate is a similarly abusive tactic. I don't know if you've ever gotten roused on Twitter or social media. I do all the time, which is really stupid. But one of the key abusive techniques—look out for it—is when someone calls you by a nickname. So someone will say to me, "Well, Andy," rather than Andrew. It's an abuser's trick.
- 4.66 What it does is, it's trying to say, "I'm above you and I can rename you." It's very, very subtle, but look out for it. That's not to say you can't give friends nicknames, but friends aren't abusing each other. When strangers do it, it's an abusive technique. So Petruchio, referring to her as Kate, is automatically—that's the first thing he says to her, remember? It's his first line. He's asserting his dominance. He's saying, "I can rename you."
- 4.67 She says, "Well have you heard, but something hard of hearing; they call me Katherine that do talk of me." Straightaway, she's pushing back. She's not having it. And Petruchio

says, he's gaslighting here, "You lie, in faith, for you are just plain Kate. And bonnie Kate, and sometimes Kate the cursed. But Kate, the prettiest Kate in Christendom, Kate of Kate Hall, my super-dainty Kate, for dainties are all Kates," which is an Elizabethan term for delicacies.

- 4.68** "And therefore, Kate, take this of me, Kate of my consolation—hearing thy mildness praised in every town"—which he hasn't—"the virtues spoke of, and thy beauty sounded, yet not so deeply as to thee belongs, myself am moved to woo thee for my wife." Straightaway, he is establishing his intentions. He is establishing his dominance. He says, "I've heard all about your virtue." Obviously, he hasn't. He's heard about what a tempestuous creature she is, how impossible she is to talk to and deal with.
- 4.69** He talks of her beauty, which is probably actually true. There's a reason why Elizabeth Taylor works in this role. She was considered the most beautiful woman in the world. Now, Katherina, she says, "Moved! In good time! Let him that moved you hither remove you hence." Remember, I said about Shakespeare's characters, they often take a word and they change the meaning and throw it back. It's like a parry.
- 4.70** So she's saying, "Good time, let him that moved you hither remove you hence. I knew you at the first you were a movable." And he says, "Why? What's a movable?" She means a movable; a movable is a movable piece of furniture, as opposed to a fixture. And she says, "You're a joint stool." And Petruchio says, "Thou has hit it. Come, sit on me."
- 4.71** So you see what's happening. She's insulting him by saying he's a movable piece of furniture. She can just throw him out if she wants. A joint stool, just a stool that you can sit on. And he literalizes it and says, "OK, then, if I'm a stool, come and sit on me." She says, "Asses are made to bear, and so are you." Straightaway, he says, "Women are made to bear, and so are you." Of course, we're changing the meaning of bear, to hold up, to bear, as in bear children.
- 4.72** Every time they parry in this way, they tend to take the word, redefine, throw them back. This is a technique that Shakespeare really gets right because he's brilliant at wordplay, and he's fascinated by the way that words have multiple meanings in the English language. The English language really lends itself to this thing. There's a real electricity to this back and forth.
- 4.73** Remember, this is the first time that they've been together, and the play really does a good job of building up that anticipation. We know that she is going to be very, very strong and fierce and ferocious, and we know what the intention of Petruchio is, and we're waiting to see how he's going to do it. This is how he does it. But part of the joy is also the way that she fights back and sometimes bests him. Like I say, it's electric.
- 4.74** When you see a good performance for this—Burton and Taylor do this really well—there is a real electricity between these characters, an immediate connection. And where many people see this as antagonism, I wonder if it's not better seen as synergy.

In that sense, I think it anticipates Beatrice and Benedick in *Much Ado About Nothing*, which we're going to get onto in a bit.

- 4.75 Now, as always, there's many ways to read Shakespeare, and these are plays, after all. So depending on which production you see, you're going to encounter different interpretations, different visions. A director will impose his or her own vision onto this, and the actors, of course, are free to interpret, to a degree, as much as the audience does. So there's layers of interpretation with any production.
- 4.76 So you could put on a version of this where you play the scene as a cruel, boisterous man imposing himself on a woman who is resisting his attention. But might it not be more interesting to present this—I'm not imposing this, I'm suggesting it. If both Katherina and Petruchio are sexually charged by this sparring, isn't that maybe slightly more interesting? I mean, later in the same scene, we have this.
- 4.77 Petruchio says, "Come, come, you wasp. In faith, you are too angry." Katherina says, "If I be waspish, best beware my sting." Petruchio says, "My remedy then is to pluck it out." Katherina: "Ay, if the fool could find where it lies." She's challenging him. Petruchio says, "Who knows not where a wasp does wear his sting? In his tail." Katherina: "In his tongue." Petruchio: "Whose tongue?" Katherina says, "Yours, if you talk of tails, and so farewell."
- 4.78 Then Petruchio says, "What, with my tongue in your tail? Nay, come again, good Kate, I'm a gentleman." She says, "That I'll try," and hits him. She actually hits him. Now, I'm not going to patronize you by explaining the erotic undertones of this exchange. But are they not enjoying themselves? I mean, isn't Katherina, isn't she relieved to have someone who can actually fight back?
- 4.79 I mean, we saw the way that she bullies her sister, Bianca. She's horrible to her. But Bianca's a simp. Bianca takes it. She's one of those people who will be bullied, a walkover. And finally, she's got someone who is witty and will match her wit and will spar. Doesn't she love it? I'm just saying, I think there's a sense in which she's been searching for this rival, and it's a sense in which so has he.
- 4.80 That's the sense I get from Burton and Taylor in the Zeffirelli film. I mentioned earlier how that dynamic, that destructive but also passionate interdependence, is there in that film they did before: *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*, the Edward Albee play. I want to mention that specifically because there's an exchange in that between George and Martha, which is Burton and Taylor, and they're married, and the whole play, the whole film, is set one night after a party.
- 4.81 He's an academic on campus. She's the daughter of the head of the university. She's continually disappointed that he hasn't been promoted. She's invited back this young new couple, an academic and his wife, and they're going to spend the night humiliating each other in front of the newbies. As you can imagine, that's excruciating for the young people there.

- 4.82 But when they've done this a few times, the young couple are out of the room—this is the exchange that happens. This, I think, is very interesting, if you don't mind me digressing into a modern play. George says, "You can sit here in that chair of yours. You can sit there with the gin running out of your mouth, and you can humiliate me. You can tear me apart all night, and that's perfectly all right. That's OK." And Martha says, "You can stand it." He says, "I cannot stand it." She says, "You can stand it. You married me for it."
- 4.83 There's a silence, and George says, "That is a desperately sick lie." But it isn't, and he knows it. Because there are those relationships, aren't there? Where the sparks, the rouse, even the violence, forms part of the attraction. That might be a controversial thing to say. But think about the—I'm sure you know *A Streetcar Named Desire*, the Tennessee Williams play. Well, the relationship between Stanley and Stella is quite clearly erotic and violent. It is also quite clearly the case that part of Stella's attraction to Stanley is his violence.
- 4.84 Again, this is not to endorse domestic violence or to suggest that Tennessee Williams was endorsing it. But he is presenting this desire and destruction, this vortex of the two. That play is hugely problematic. I'm surprised critics don't get more angry about it. But that attraction that she has for her violent husband, because he is violent, is there in the play, unequivocally in there. That's what Williams is interested in doing; he wants to explore that tension, that destructive desire and destruction.
- 4.85 I think Edward Albee is doing the same in *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* I think Shakespeare is doing the same in *The Taming of the Shrew*. And what better place to do it? Because we all agree that violence within a relationship, within a marriage, is vile. I think we all are morally able to say that, unequivocally. So where better to explore this than in drama, in fiction? That's interesting.
- 4.86 Now, all of this stuff, I mean, it seems very dark. It doesn't feel like the stuff of comedy. But as many critics have pointed out, what happens in *The Taming of the Shrew* is something quite interesting. It is a farce. I mentioned—I focused, previously, on the *Comedy of Errors* and the *Merry Wives of Windsor*. *The Taming of the Shrew* has a very strong farcical element to it. But I think what happens in this, as many critics have pointed out, the farce of the piece collapses because of the psychological realism of the piece.
- 4.87 For instance, when Petruchio deliberately turns up late to the wedding, that scene, and he turns up in these ridiculous clothes, and he's making a mockery of the whole thing, that, of course, is another coercive attempt to achieve domination through humiliation. That's the whole point. By this point, but don't we all feel a bit sorry for Katherine?
- 4.88 Don't we all think—I mean, when she believes he's not coming, and she's there in front of everyone, she's humiliated, she says, "Now must the world point at poor Katherine and say, lo, there is mad Petruchio's wife, if it would please him come and marry her!"

And she weeps. Now, this is not the heartless, tempestuous shrew that we've seen so far. This is a human being who has grown accustomed to this kind of performance, and the shell is cracking.

- 4.89** By the end, Petruchio wins his bet. You remember, he has this bet at the end. Who has the most submissive wife? When Hortensio and Lucentio call for their wives, the wives don't come. Petruchio says, "My wife will come," and she does. Then she lectures the wives of Hortensio and Lucentio for not obeying their husbands. So he has done it. He's tamed a shrew, and he has all the social recognition that that astonishing feat entails.
- 4.90** But what if she is as much the victor? What if she gets to perform as the dutiful wife and she gets to lord it over other women? That's quite high status. She definitely craves that status. Look at the way she's treated by Bianca. So, the question I think we're left with at the end of the play is: Is Katherina genuinely subservient to Petruchio, or does she simply know when she's onto a good thing and knows how to perform? And maybe this pair actually do love each other.
- 4.91** Now, the critic Harold Bloom certainly thought so. He makes the case that her final speech, which contains that famously problematic line, "I am ashamed that women are so simple," this is what he says: "Advising women how to rule absolutely, while feigning obedience." Now, Shakespeare is certainly aware and returns often to the notion of the weakness of the male ego, the need for men to feel that they're in charge, even when they're not. I think we all know a lot of men like this. It seems to be fairly common.
- 4.92** And as for Petruchio, might it not be that he, too, is surprised when he falls in love with Katherina? He didn't expect to. At the beginning of the play, he's very clear. His objective is money. It's avaricious, isn't it? He says, at the start, "I come to wive it wealthily in Padua. If wealthily, then happily, in Padua." He's in it for the money, for the dowry, which is huge by Elizabethan standards.
- 4.93** Petruchio says to Baptista, her father, "Then tell me, if I get your daughter's love, what dowry shall I have with her to wife?" And he says, Baptista says, "After my death, the one-half of my lands, and in possession, 20,000 crowns." He's desperate to get rid of her, because the whole point is, the whole plot line is that Baptista can't marry off Bianca to her multiple suitors, or any of her multiple suitors, until he's found a wife for Katherina. So he's happy to pay a lot of money. Petruchio is happy to oblige because he wants the money.
- 4.94** Katherina just wants to reject the advances of all men and tear the world to pieces. These are the mechanisms of traditional farce. But what actually happens? They fall in love. They're perfect for each other. This is where the farce, to me, to my mind, collapses, and the psychological reality begins. You don't have to go down this road. You could take the view that Petruchio is a woman-hater, a misogynist.
- 4.95** He torments and tortures Katherina for money, and that Katherina is relentlessly gaslit and abused to such an extent that she ends up as a victim of Stockholm syndrome,

dependent on her abuser, and that the play rewards this misogynistic assertion of male supremacy, and that we should ignore all the dozens of other female characters in Shakespeare who could not, under any circumstances, utter Katherina's final speech, and take her somehow to be representative of all women in Shakespeare's mind. That interpretation is up to you. I don't find that very interesting.

- 4.96 Now, with *Much Ado About Nothing*, we have a development away from farce in the presentation of this dynamic. You've got a man and a woman deeply in love with each other. Remember, there's intimations at the start of the play that Beatrice and Benedick have been in a relationship before. "I know you of old," she says. But they are in love, and we, as an audience, see that they are in love. We are in that state of dramatic irony. But they're in love with each other, and they misinterpret each other's affections as enmity.
- 4.97 So I want to draw this comparison between these two plays, specifically. *Much Ado About Nothing* is a much more advanced play than *The Taming of the Shrew*. In both plays, though, you have a romantic plot as the main driving force. In *The Taming of the Shrew*, though, the romantic plot is the subplot, which is Lucentio's pursuit of Bianca. He disguises himself as a tutor. He gets a stranger to dress up as his father, gets his servant trying to dress up as him. That's the sort of main romantic love plot. He's fending off Hortensio and Signior Gremio, the other rivals for Bianca.
- 4.98 But in *Much Ado About Nothing*, it's actually the main plot. The romantic plot is the main plot, which is the love of Claudio for Hero, and how Claudio is tricked into believing that Hero has committed adultery because of Don John, who is one of those villainous characters who does evil for the sake of it, a less sophisticated version of Iago, who is the ultimate incarnation of that principle.
- 4.99 Now, in both plays, our chief interest is the bickering couples, Katherina and Petruchio in *Taming of the Shrew*, Beatrice and Benedick in *Much Ado*. So even though Beatrice and Benedick are technically the subplot, they're the ones we remember, aren't they? They're the most important aspects of that play. Claudio and Hero, they're a bit boring, relatively speaking. This is their play. *Much Ado* is the play of Beatrice and Benedick.
- 4.100 Like I say, it's a later play. It's later than *Taming of the Shrew*, so naturally, it's going to be better. It's around 1598, 1599, thereabouts. *Taming of the Shrew*, early 1593, so one of his first plays. Remember, in between, it only sat six years apart. But Shakespeare had come on leaps and bounds in those six years, if you think about it. In that gap, he'd written *The Merchant of Venice*, *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, *Merry Wives of Windsor*. He's refining his comic art.
- 4.101 He's also written *Romeo and Juliet*, a play that is virtually a comedy, but then veers into tragedy at the last second. *Romeo and Juliet* is fascinating for that because the display of the language of love, of the transcendental experience of love, is unsurpassed. And

at the same time, it satirizes the idea of youthful infatuation. It's almost as though the lovers, teenagers who just become obsessed with each other, take a further step.

- 4.102** There's a reason why he contrasts Romeo's infatuation with Rosaline at the start to what he says about Juliet later on. What starts as infatuation steers into something more authentic and powerful and transcendental. Now, Shakespeare has written all these great plays, so by the time he gets to *Much Ado*, he has refined his art. He knows what he's doing. He's about to write *As You Like It*. He's almost about to write *Hamlet*. That's where he is in his career. That's the level of genius we're dealing with.
- 4.103** So the writer of *Much Ado About Nothing* is simply a better writer than *The Taming of the Shrew*. But *Much Ado About Nothing* is a very good forum for Shakespeare to demonstrate his natural comedic instincts, I think, and most certainly through Beatrice and Benedick. But not just Beatrice and Benedick. You'll remember the character of Dogberry. You remember in a previous lecture, I talked about the constable Dogberry, and John Dover Wilson reading out the lines in a prison. I mentioned that.
- 4.104** Dogberry is one of those comic characters that never goes away. He's not a clown in the the court jester sense, but he is a clown in the Shakespearean sense. He's a fully realized clown, pompous constable. Shakespeare gives him some of his funniest malapropisms. This was over a century before Sheridan invented Mrs. Malaprop. We originally called them Dogberryisms, when someone misuses a word in earnest, which is one of the most obviously funny things, that is still funny today.
- 4.105** I mean, for instance, if we take Act 3, Scene 5, when Dogberry informs Leonato that he is a prisoner, this is what Dogberry says. Dogberry says, "One word, sir. Our watch, sir, have indeed comprehended two auspicious persons." He means "apprehended two suspicious persons." He says, "And we would have them this morning examined before your worship." Leonato says, "Take their examination yourself and bring it to me. I am now in great haste, as it may appear unto you."
- 4.106** And Dogberry is completely misjudging the moment. Leonato can't be doing with this bumbling fool because he's preparing for his daughter's wedding. But Dogberry is insistent. He says, "It shall be suffigence," and he means sufficient. So that's not a malapropism. He just doesn't know how to pronounce the word, so he's just saying anything, which is a bit like, I suppose, today, when people say "supposably", and they mean supposedly.
- 4.107** Leonato then says this to him. It's a really great send-off. He says, "Drink some wine ere you go," which is just perfectly pitched. There's a really good version by Kenneth Branagh, a film version with Richard Briers playing Leonato, and he does that line beautifully. So Dogberry mangles words. He mangles language and meaning. Of course, Shakespeare, someone who's so obsessed with language, is also obsessed with the potential mangling of language, the getting it wrong. He finds that very funny.

- 4.108** But what's funnier is that Dogberry mangles the language but retains his sense of self-importance. That's kind of key. He's not just someone who's stupid and ill-educated. He's someone who's stupid and ill-educated and thinks he's clever. That's what's funnier. He only makes these mistakes with such confidence because he's unaware that they are mistakes in the first place. There's always something funny, isn't there, about the overly confident idiot.
- 4.109** Look at what happens when Dogberry brings to Don Pedro the prisoners, Conrade and Borachio, the ones he overheard talking about the Hero trickery. These are Don John's accomplices. Don Pedro says, "Officers, what offense have these men done?" Dogberry says, this is his line, "Marry, sir, they have committed false report. Moreover, they have spoken untruths. Secondly, they are slanders. Sixthly, and lastly, they have belied a lady. Thirdly, they have verified unjust things, and to conclude, they are lying knaves."
- 4.110** Note how he piles up synonym on synonym for the same crime, reorders his numbering. Firstly, sixthly, thirdly. It's all over the place. He loses all the sense in the act of speech. So that's why I think, in performance, Dogberry still works, because that concept of malapropisms and inelegance of language is something that, of course, is still funny. We hear it all the time. We hear it from people we know. It's a great means to puncture the pretensions of those who think that they are important.
- 4.111** For instance, you remember when Mike Tyson, the boxer, he said, someone said, "What will you do now?" in an interview, and he said, "I might just fade into Bolivian." Of course, he didn't mean that. He meant oblivion. There's something just naturally funny about that. Dan Quayle, who was vice president, he had lots of these malapropisms. People often cited them. One of his most famous ones was, "Republicans understand the importance of bondage between a mother and child." Now, I think a lot of Republicans would take issue with that.
- 4.112** Or then, there's Dogberry's logical inconsistencies, linguistic contradictions. And in that, we hear echoes of celebrities today, political figures today. When Arnold Schwarzenegger was running for governor, he said, "I think that gay marriage is something that should be between a man and a woman." Of course, we know what he meant, but the fact that he got it so spectacularly wrong is going to be funny. Why? Because he's in a position of power. He should know.
- 4.113** Bobby Robson, who you may not know that he was the manager of the England football team, there was one moment where he was reflecting on a lost match, talking about the match that his team had lost. He said, "We didn't underestimate them. They were just a lot better than we thought." It's sort of perfect. This is pure Dogberry, and that is sort of interesting how that kind of humor doesn't really age, because human beings are always going to be like that.
- 4.114** Anyway, let's return to an aspect of the play that really remains with us until long after the play is over. This is the relationship between Beatrice and Benedick. This is the

thing that *Much Ado* is known for. This is why we go and see it. These are the roles that great actors want to play. I once saw Simon Russell Beale playing Benedick at the National Theater. He did it brilliantly.

- 4.115** Now, in the last lecture, I spoke about *Love's Labour's Lost*. One way to think about Berowne and Rosaline is that they are a prototype for Beatrice and Benedick. We're going to come back to this a lot in these lectures, where, in these early plays, the reason why I wanted to cover these early plays first is because you will see how they have become more fully realized later on. He's experimenting with ideas that he then perfects later on, and that's what happens here.
- 4.116** Berowne and Rosaline, their back-and-forth, very much anticipates Beatrice and Benedick. Let's have a look at this, just to go back to *Love's Labour's Lost*, Act 2, Scene 1. This is Berowne and Rosaline. This is where they meet for the first time in the play, although they have met before, because Berowne says, "Did I not dance with you in Brabant once?" Rosaline says, "Did not I dance with you in Brabant once?" Berowne says, "I know you did." And she says, "How needless was it then to ask the question?"
- 4.117** And how much does this little exchange tell us about their characterizations? Berowne doesn't just introduce himself in the conventional way. He doesn't say, "Have we met before?" No, he brushes her away, saying, "Did not I dance with you in Brabant once?" That's very different from saying, "Haven't we met before?" Why? Because he's almost implying she's just another one of his conquests, that he's had so many he can't remember. It's a power grab, right?
- 4.118** And Rosaline, though, is no pushover. So she says back to him the same question, "Did not I dance with in Brabant once?" So she doesn't answer yes or no. She's going to say that "maybe, well, maybe you're one of my conquests." She's going to get him back straightaway. And you can sense that Berowne is taken aback because his response is, "I know you did." He's not expecting this. And he's walked into her trap, which she then closes with, "How heedless was it then to ask the question?"
- 4.119** So in other words, his opening line, which was an attempt to assert dominance, has been flipped within three lines. Rosaline has flipped it. She's now the dominant one. She's won that verbal battle. And Berowne says, "You must not be so quick." Rosaline says, "'Tis long of you that spur me with such questions." Berowne says, "Your wit's too hot. It speeds too fast, 'twill tire." And Rosaline says, "Not till it leave the rider in the mire."
- 4.120** And here she's achieved the same effect. She's come out on top with this horse metaphor, this metaphor of being spurred. Four lines, and she's won it again. He starts something, she finishes it. This seems to happen every time. Rosaline is much smarter than Berowne. That's why he's not used to it. And as often in Shakespeare, as well as in life, this kind of repartee is a form of flirtation, this back-and-forth, this completion of each other's thoughts, this barbed wit as a means to conceal affection.

- 4.121** It is really mastered in these exchanges between Beatrice and Benedick. It's more advanced than this. We've seen the effect in *Love's Labour's Lost*, but it becomes more advanced in *Much Ado*. You'll notice, for one thing, that their exchanges are in prose, not in verse. They feel, therefore, more natural, less hemmed in by the conventions of the court that *Love's Labour's Lost* is satirizing.
- 4.122** So this is Act 1, Scene 1 of *Much Ado About Nothing*. Beatrice, this is Beatrice and Benedick first seeing each other within the play. As I say, they've known each other for years. This is where they first see each other in the play. Beatrice says, "I wonder that you will still be talking, Signior Benedick. Nobody marks you." Benedick says, "What, my dear Lady Disdain? Are you yet living?" Beatrice responds, "Is it possible disdain should die while she hath such meet food to feed it as Signior Benedick? Courtesy itself must convert to disdain, if you come in her presence."
- 4.123** His very presence compels her to be caustic and contemptuous. She can't help it. And of course, they're in front of other people, so it becomes a performance. It becomes a combat. And Benedick says, "Then is courtesy a turncoat. But it is certain I am loved of all ladies, only you excepted; and I would I could find it in my heart that I had not a hard heart; for truly, I love none." But we already know he's lying. We already know that he does. Well, to borrow another Shakespearean phrase, "The lady doth protest too much."
- 4.124** So, Benedick declares he loves no one. Beatrice responds, "A dear happiness to women; they would else have been troubled with a pernicious suitor. I thank God and my cold blood, I am of your humor for that. I had rather hear my dog bark at a crow than a man swear he loves me." Any noise, the most horrible, rebarbative noise you would rather hear than someone say that he loves her. Benedick says, "God keep your ladyship still in that mind, so some gentleman or other shall 'scape a predestinate scratched face," suggesting she's a shrew, a difficult woman.
- 4.125** Beatrice says, "Scratching could not make it worse, an 'twere such a face as yours were." You can't get any uglier than you are. Scratching is not going to make a difference. He's saying, "Well, you are a rare parrot-teacher." She says straightaway, "A bird of my tongue is better than a beast of yours." Benedick comes in. "I would my horse had the speed of your tongue, and so good a continuer. But keep your way, i' God's name; I have done."
- 4.126** Do you see what he has to do? To win it, he has to end it. "I have done." He has to walk away because she will always beat him. She always has a response that is one up on what he's come up with. She says, as he separates, "You always end with a jade's trick. I know you of old." Now, Benedick imagines her to be a shrew, one that men better best avoid.
- 4.127** In this battle of wits, remember, Leonato calls it "a merry war," Benedick cuts us short because it's the only way he can win. Leonato says in that first scene, "They never

meet, but there's a skirmish of wit between them." But all of this badinage is, of course, laden with subtext. Like I say, they're at war, but we know they're in love, and we know as well, because this is a comedy, they're going to end up together by the end.

- 4.128** So as I say, it took a while for Shakespeare to perfect this dynamic. Petruchio and Katherina, Berowne and Rosaline, and then he masters it with Beatrice and Benedick. That's the through line here. We might say that this is the high point of his comedic writing, like I say, 1598, about to write *Hamlet*, *Twelfth Night*'s around this time, *Henry V*. So he's not putting a foot wrong at this point in his career.
- 4.129** Like I say, in this scene, one of the most effective elements of this scene is, he's written it as a performance. In other words, they are seeing each other in front of Don Pedro and Claudio and Leonato and everyone else. It's a bit like—you know when, on social media, people argue for days sometimes, and I think the reason is that they know they're being watched. It's a public forum. For them to lose the argument isn't just that they've lost; they've lost publicly, and therefore there's some shame, there's some humiliation attached to that.
- 4.130** I honestly believe that's why these online arguments go on for so long, because people can't bear to lose face. Shakespeare knows this. What he does is, he has Beatrice and Benedick see each other in public, and that's why they're fighting. They're half-fighting, they're half-performing. Benedick has to win, not just because he wants to put Beatrice in her place, but also because he wants to reassert his status among his friends. He's not going to be the man who succumbs to a wife. He's not going to suffer the humiliation of ever finding himself cuckolded.
- 4.131** This is what he says in Act 1, Scene 1. He says this to Don Pedro and Claudio. He says, "That a woman conceived me, I thank her. That she brought me up, I likewise give her most humble thanks. But that I will have a recheat winded in my forehead, or hang my bugle in an invisible baldrick, all women shall pardon me." Now, the recheat is the hunting call, the bugle being the horn. So the image here is of a horn being planted in the forehead. Remember what I said about that? That is the cuckold's horn. That's why we hear jealous husbands called "horn-mad."
- 4.132** Don Pedro says, "I shall see thee, ere I die, look pale with love." And that's the challenge of the play, isn't it? And we know that Don Pedro is the one who orchestrates the trick, the eavesdropping trick, so that he basically puts them together. He's the matchmaker. Don Pedro said, "I will see you look pale with love." Benedick says, "With anger, with sickness, not with love." He actually says, "With sickness or with hunger, not with love."
- 4.133** Don Pedro says, "Well, as time shall try. In time, the savage bull doth bear the yoke." That's a proverb. And Benedick then turns the proverb on its head. He says, "The savage bull may, but if ever the sensible Benedick bear it, pluck off the bull's horns and set them in my forehead and let me be vily painted. And in such great letters as they

write, 'Here is good horse to hire,' let them signify under my sign, 'Here you may see Benedick, the married man.'"

- 4.134** He doesn't mind being publicly displayed and humiliated with a sign if he succumbs to what Don Pedro says he will succumb to. And there's that word again—the cuckold—which, as I say, is always funny in Shakespeare to Elizabethans. Now, I've said that Benedick likes to show off to the other men. This merry war of words with Beatrice is mostly public.
- 4.135** Now, this is in Act 2, Scene 1. This is when Beatrice approaches. Benedick turns to Don Pedro and he says—now, just imagine it. You have Benedick talking to Don Pedro. Don Pedro is, of course, the prince, and Beatrice approaches. Now, what does Benedick do? He wants to perform for Don Pedro. He wants to put his status higher than Beatrice. He says this.
- 4.136** He says, "Will your grace command me any service to the world's end? I will go on the slightest errand now to the Antipodes that you can devise to send me on. I will fetch you a tooth-picker now from the furthest inch of Asia, bring you the length of Prester John's foot, fetch you a hair off the great Cham's beard, do you any embassy to the Pygmies, rather than hold three words' conference with this harpy." I think this works a lot better if Beatrice is within earshot. He's doing it for Don Pedro's benefit, but also for hers.
- 4.137** And Don Pedro, of course, he's loving this. So he says, Benedick says, "You have no employment for me?" He's saying, "Send me anywhere. Get me away from this woman." Don Pedro says, "None, but to desire your good company." So he's loving it; he's having a great time. Now, of course, the play is going to punish Benedick for his hubris, for his belief that he doesn't need a wife, doesn't want a wife, cannot succumb to love. He's above that. He's spent all his time boasting that he's never going to get married.
- 4.138** Like I said, we know what the outcome is going to be. By the end, he's going to be the one advising Don Pedro to "get thee a wife, get thee a wife." We know that Beatrice and Benedick are in love before they do, and so too does Don Pedro, which is why he embarks on the scheme in the first place. But this is also why I want to isolate this passage from the play, which I've always found disappointing. This is why I think we do feel disappointed when—you remember the eavesdropping trick in Act 3, Scene 1?
- 4.139** So Hero and Ursula are discussing Benedick's love for Beatrice, knowing that she's hiding and she can hear it. That's the trick. And of course, Don Pedro has just done the same with Leonato, Claudio, knowing that Benedick can hear them. So it's a trick that always works in performance. This is one of those great farcical moments.
- 4.140** But after Beatrice hears that Benedick is in love with her, this is what she says. "What fire is in mine ears? Can this be true? Stand I condemned for pride and scorn so much? Contempt, farewell! and maiden pride, adieu! No glory lives behind the back of such.

And Benedick, love on. I will requite thee, taming my wild heart to thy loving hand. If thou dost love, my kindness shall incite thee to bind our loves up in a holy band; for others say thou dost deserve, and I believe it better than reportingly."

4.141 Here's my problem with that. That isn't Beatrice. It doesn't sound like Beatrice. It's not the sort of thing that she would say, even with that realization of Benedick's love. It just isn't her voice. For one thing, she is a consistent prose speaker. Now she shifts into verse? That happens to characters at moments of high emotional intensity in Shakespeare. But compare this to what Benedick says, when he overhears that Beatrice is in love with him, in that eavesdropping trick.

4.142 OK, you've got Don Pedro, Leonato, and Claudio saying, "Oh, Beatrice is actually in love with him." He overhears. After they go, Benedick says this. "This can be no trick. The conference was sadly borne. They have the truth of this from Hero. They seem to pity the lady. It seems her affections have their full bent. Love me! Why, it must be requited. I hear how I am censured; they say I will bear myself proudly, if I perceive the love come from her.

4.143 They say, too, that she will rather die than give any sign of affection. I did never think to marry. I must not seem proud. Happy are they that hear their detractions and can put them to mending. They say the lady is fair, 'tis a truth, I can bear them witness; and virtuous, 'tis so, I cannot reprove it; and wise, but for loving me; by my troth, it is no addition to her wit, nor no great argument of her folly, for I will be horribly in love with her."

4.144 Now, that passage is replete with comic wranglings. We can see his ego is at stake. We can see he does love Beatrice; he's starting to admit it. It's humorous to hear him persuading himself that he can be open about his love while saving face. In other words, this is definitely Benedick. It sounds like Benedick. But Beatrice would never say a line like, "Contempt, farewell! and maiden pride, adieu!" She just wouldn't say it.

4.145 Now, John Dover Wilson, the critic I mentioned before, he's actually talked about why there's this sudden incongruity, why this is so out of character. He argues that *Much Ado About Nothing* was an older play that Shakespeare revised, a play from the 1590s, and that's why you get this hangover of a passage that doesn't feel very Shakespearean. Now, that could be so. I don't know about that. I don't think that's right.

4.146 I think what it might point to is the collaborative nature of theater at this time. Theaters had house playwrights who would rewrite passages on the hoof, at the last minute. "Oh, this bit isn't working. Can you quickly rewrite something?" It was very collaborative. And so you sometimes get these passages in Shakespeare that don't feel Shakespearean. Or it could be that Shakespeare just messed up. He's a human being, right? Or he's doing something that I'm not grasping.

- 4.147 I always believe, as Harold Bloom said, "Approach Shakespeare with humility." This is a genius far above my capabilities, so who am I to say he messed up? Maybe he's doing something I just don't get. That's very likely. But I think the voice is so out of character that I think it's probably evidence of some sort of collaborative input from another hand. I think, if I were producing this play, I would be tempted to cut that speech, or I would just have her say the first two lines. That would do the job. And you wouldn't have this moment where we think that's not really her.
- 4.148 But it is an interesting reminder, isn't it, that Shakespeare's plays, the texts that we have, they're not definitive. We don't have his original manuscripts, his foul papers. We have none of those, apart from potentially one page of Thomas More. We have to make do with what we've got. Now, one scene, though, we can say for certain is definitely Shakespeare, is the moment after Claudio erupts at Hero. Do you remember at the wedding, about the infidelity? And this is an incredible theatrical moment. It's quite painful to watch if it's done well.
- 4.149 Hero, wrongly slandered, at the worst possible time, at the wedding. It harks back to the wedding of Petruchio and Katherine—the worst time, him to turn up late. You have to feel for her. It's even worse now. You've got Claudio attacking her, screaming at her in public. It's a grotesque public spectacle, and more so because we know this is Don John's doing. We know this is not real. Claudio is just a mere puppet.
- 4.150 Once everyone has dispersed, we get this moment where Benedick speaks to Beatrice, and the tension of that previous row at the wedding is lingering. So the tone of their conversation is slightly different. They're not doing their merry war of words anymore. This is serious now. And this is what happens. Benedick says, "Lady Beatrice, have you wept all this while?" Beatrice says, "Yea, and I will weep a while longer." Benedick: "I will not desire that." "You have no reason. I do it freely."
- 4.151 Now, Benedick wants to defend Hero. He says, "Surely I believe your fair cousin is wronged." Beatrice says, "Ah, how much might the man deserve of me that would right her!" Benedick says, "Is there any way to show such friendship?" "A very even way, but no such friend." "May a man do it?" "It is a man's office, but not yours." And Benedick is moved to say, "I do love nothing in the world so well as you; is not that strange?"
- 4.152 That's so perfectly done. Shakespeare brings this confession of love at the most surprising moment, and yet it feels so natural. It's so right. Beatrice, of course, is more reticent. She says, "As strange as the thing I know not. It were possible for me to say I love nothing so well as you, and believe me not; and yet I lie not. I confess nothing, nor I deny nothing. I'm sorry for my cousin." She takes it back to the matter at hand because she cannot bear to address what Benedick is saying.
- 4.153 Benedick says, "By my sword, Beatrice, thou lovest me." He's going to be insistent. She says, "Do not swear and eat it." He says, "I will swear by it that you love me, and I will make him eat it that says I love not you." "Will you not eat your word?" Benedick says,

"With no source that can be devised to it. I protest, I love thee." Beatrice says, "Why, then, God forgive me!" "What offense, sweet Beatrice?" "You have stayed me in a happy hour. I was about to protest I loved you."

- 4.154** Benedick says, "And do it with all thy heart!" Come on, just admit what we both know to be true. And Beatrice finally breaks. She says, "I love you with so much of my heart that none is left to protest." It's a very powerful moment. And then, then it shifts, because Benedick says, "Come." In this moment of joy, he says, "Come, bid me do anything for thee." She looks at and she says, "Kill Claudio."
- 4.155** And it is like a rock falling into that scene. It's her moment of greatest vulnerability. Beatrice has confessed her love, but there's a condition to her love. "Kill Claudio." It's such a shock, and it's so devastating. It takes us aback. In the audience, we are taken aback as much as Benedick is taken aback. If you don't know the play, you won't predict that. It has an incredible theatrical—it's like an earthquake.
- 4.156** Out of the public debris of the shaming of Hero, that chaotic, that heartbreaking scene, we have these two antagonists finally opening up to each other. It feels natural, doesn't it, because at moments of heightened intensity, reality seems thinner, and the preservation of ego seems to matter less. And perspective is reestablished. It's in those moments where revelations come. We all know this from our experience.
- 4.157** So, the scene is building and building. It's teasing us with possibilities until the fulfilment comes. Now, this could be the ending of the play, that moment where she declares her love. That's what we've been waiting for. That's what we've been looking forward to. We've been expecting the moment from the first time we saw them bickering.
- 4.158** But Shakespeare doesn't allow us to enjoy it. Those two words, two words, the most abrupt punctuation imaginable to the realization of Benedick's hopes, "Kill Claudio." Now, there aren't many moments in drama that are perfect. This is perfect.

Lecture 5: As You Like It

At a glance — As You Like It and escape into the forest.

- 5.1 Have you ever felt that your troubles are so insurmountable that you fantasize about simply running away from it all, finding some secluded spot in the countryside, living like a hermit, perhaps a cave or something like that? This is a common trope in literature because, I suppose, it's a common experience, this Arcadian dream of a paradise often connected to a nostalgic looking-back to a golden age that probably never existed.
- 5.2 But of course, it's never really that easy, is it? Try living in a cave, subsisting on grubs and rainwater. It's not a nice life. There's no air conditioning. In Iris Murdoch's novel, very famous novel called *The Sea, The Sea*, the lead character in that, a writer, decides to go off to the coast to try and run away from all of his troubles and leave the city life behind. And in that novel, the old world follows him. His ex-wife turns up, characters that he used to know turn up.
- 5.3 In other words, it's not possible to run away from your troubles and live this kind of bucolic dream. That word bucolic is an interesting word. The etymology of that comes from the Greek for herdsman. And that word pastoral, which I'm going to be using quite a lot today when I'm talking about *As You Like It*, that's the Latin for shepherd, which is why we talk of a pastor and his flock. So these terms are very much tied to the rural lifestyle, the rural ideal, the dream.
- 5.4 In Renaissance England, the pastoral genre, there's a whole genre of pastoral literature, hugely popular. These stories of men and women who flee the court, flee the city, go off to the countryside, and they find peace. In a sense, this dynamic was the reverse of Shakespeare's own experience. If you think about it, Shakespeare started out in Stratford-upon-Avon, which was a small town at this time, only 2,500 people living there. He goes off to the metropolis. He goes off to London, 200,000 people. Just a huge culture shock.
- 5.5 That number had doubled in the 25 years before he got there. London was a hugely expanding city at the time. You can only imagine what he must have felt. He hadn't seen it before. There's no TV, there's no internet. He goes from this small rural town to this, as I say, a metropolis. But then you have people in the metropolis, dreaming of going to the country. And of course, it's very easy, isn't it, for city dwellers, who've only ever known their cities, to dream of an ideal trouble-free existence in the forest, living the life of a shepherd.
- 5.6 Sheep are very low-maintenance. You imagine it's very, very easy. You imagine you can just lie there and read poetry all day and play on your lute, the gentle bleating of your flock, if that's your kind of thing. And for those fortunate enough to be born into the

literate classes at this time, there was always poetry and prose and drama that could transport you to this make-believe world.

- 5.7** Now, the literary antecedent of this is Theocritus, The Idylls of Theokritos, and the Eclogues of Virgil. These are very, very popular. It's worth noting at this point that the romanticization of the pastoral tradition comes later, because these early pastoral works, Theocritus, Virgil, tend to combine the idyllic with the tragic. They're a lot more realistic.
- 5.8** The very first idyll of Theocritus sees two herdsmen, and one of them persuades the other to sing the song of Daphnis—Daphnis was an archetypical shepherd, and he persuades this man, this shepherd, to sing the song in return for an elaborately decorated cup. So, while you have this leisurely scene of shepherds singing, and it is pretty idyllic, the song itself, the song of Daphnis, is about a man who has rejected love, and is then punished by Aphrodite and dies.
- 5.9** In other words, the idyll that Theocritus presents is undercut by the song within the idyll. The dark undercurrent, where the sun is strongest, the shadows are much deeper. And this, of course, will become relevant when we look at *As You Like It*, which I'll now explain why. Now, to give you some sense of the popularity of the pastoral tradition in English literature and in the English Renaissance in particular, we should look to a book by Francis Meres.
- 5.10** Now, Francis Meres is an important figure only because he is one of the early writers who mentions Shakespeare, and we can date some of the plays as a result of this. He wrote a book called *Palladis Tamia*, which means "wits treasury," and he talks about Shakespeare being one of the best. He lists some of his comedies and some of his tragedies, and this was published in 1598, so we can date them to that point. He also mentions, by the way, *Love's Labour's Won*, which is one of the missing plays, so that's why we know that such a play did exist.
- 5.11** This is how he describes the pastoral genre. He says, "As Theocritus in Greek, Virgil and Mantuan in Latin, Sannazar in Italian, and the author of *Amyntae Gaudia* and *Walsingham's Meliboeus* are the best for pastoral, so amongst us the best in this kind are Sir Philip Sidney, Master Chaloner, Spenser, Stephen Gosson, Abraham Fraunce, and Barnfield." He means Richard Barnfield.
- 5.12** Now, there are some curious omissions there. If he's saying these are the best pastoral writers that we've got, he's missing out Michael Drayton, who wrote *Idea: The Shepherds Garland*. He's missing out Alexander Barclay, whose *Eclogues* are really the first substantial examples of English pastoral. But let me give you an example of this pastoral literature, so you get a sense of what we're dealing with here.
- 5.13** This is from Book 6 of *The Faerie Queene* by Edmund Spenser. This is a big epic poem; this part was published in 1596. In it, each of the six books of *The Faerie Queene*, has a different knight, and it follows a different knight's adventures through fairyland. Book

VI is about Sir Calidore, and his adventure is to pursue the Blatant Beast, which is a monster with multiple tongues and teeth. This signifies the vicious power of slander and rumor.

- 5.14** You might remember that, in Shakespeare, in Henry IV, Part 2, opens with the figure of Rumor dressed in a robe, painted with tongues. So Shakespeare knew about this idea. So the Blatant Beast, its bite can kill even the most virtuous. Now, this part of The Faerie Queene, there's a pastoral part of The Faerie Queene, Book VI, which is Cantos 9 to 11. That's the pastoral episode. Calidore comes across this community of shepherds, and this is how it's described.
- 5.15** "From thence into the open fields he fled, Whereas the Heardes were keeping of their neat, And shepherds singing to their flockes, that fed, Layes of sweete love and youthes delightfull heat." So countryside, nature, song, love, desire. This is the shepherd's life. And then in the next stanza, we have, "There on a day, as he pursew'd the chace, He chaunst to spy a sort of shepherd groomes, Playing on pypes, and caroling apace. The whyles their beasts there in the budded broomes Beside them fed, and nipt the tender bloomes: For other worldly wealth they cared nought."
- 5.16** Now, don't be put off by that language. Spenser was writing in a deliberately obsolete form of English. This was part of this project to dignify English as the language of literature, so it's deliberately archaic. It's a stylistic choice. But again, with The Faerie Queene, like with A Clockwork Orange, when you read a few stanzas, you lock into the language. The barrier disappears. But anyway, you get the idea. "For otherworldly wealth, they cared not." In other words, the shepherd's life is one that is free from avarice, concerns about professional reputation, all of that stuff that we associate with the city and city life.
- 5.17** Now, Sir Calidore strays into this unfamiliar world. He's instantly bewitched by it, and he falls in love with Pastorella, the aptly named Pastorella, this shepherdess. This, of course, is distracting him from the quest. Calidore is so enamored of the pastoral lifestyle that he resolves to stay and become a shepherd. Of course, the idyllic lifestyle ends up being a myth. The community is ransacked by bandits. Calidore is misdirected to another quest. He thinks that Pastorella has been killed. He seeks revenge on the bandits, et cetera.
- 5.18** It's really worth reading, by the way. I think we've all experienced this, haven't we? Haven't you ever gone off on holiday somewhere, to somewhere remote, and thought, "Oh, I want to live here. I want to be here forevermore. All of my troubles are gone." But then the reality takes hold, and you think, "Actually, if I lived on this island with no cinema or theater or friends or anything or constant power cuts," actually, the reality intrudes. And that's what's quite interesting about this pastoral tradition, is I think it still resonates.

- 5.19** I'm telling you this for a number of reasons. I'm talking today about *As You Like It*, and I think that is probably the most perfect encapsulation of the pastoral tradition in English literature. Shakespeare was later to return to this pastoral idea in *The Winter's Tale*, to a very different effect. But the example of Spenser shows both the romantic image of the bucolic life and also its darker undercurrent. Shakespeare does something, I think, rather more interesting— we'll get onto that.
- 5.20** Spenser, by the way, was a major pastoral poet, major poet, full stop. He wrote *The Shepherd's Calendar*, which is 12 pastoral eclogues. That was published in 1579. And he had a fictive alter ego, Colin Clout. Colin Clout. He wrote a poem called *Colin Clout's Come Home Again* in 1591. And he is Colin Clout. So he's describing himself as a shepherd. Then in Book VI of *The Faerie Queene*, Colin Clout turns up as well. And this is commonplace at the time, the identification of poets with shepherds. So poets themselves were intertwined with the pastoral tradition.
- 5.21** Christopher Marlowe, Shakespeare's great rival, the man who died in 1593, stabbed in the face, but he was dominating the theater scene until Shakespeare came along. Shakespeare were quite lucky, in a way. All of his major rivals just died off. In those plague years, actually, 1592, 1593, we lost Christopher Marlowe, Robert Greene, Thomas Kyd, who was tortured after Marlowe's arrest. We lost all these. Thomas Watson, the great Latin poet. All these people died, leaving this gap for Shakespeare.
- 5.22** I think, unless Marlowe had died, Shakespeare wouldn't have blossomed as he did. But the reason I mention this is, Shakespeare is really indebted to Marlowe. He borrows from him, he improves upon him, he's very much influenced by him. In *As You Like It*, you get a direct reference. In fact, you get a direct quotation from Marlowe. He calls him the dead shepherd. Marlowe had written *The Passionate Shepherd to His Love* in the early 1590s. That's a poem you might know, because it's commonly read at weddings.
- 5.23** But here's the couplet from Act 3, Scene 5, of *As You Like It*. This is Phoebe, the shepherd there. She says, "Dead shepherd, now I find thy saw of might; who ever loved that loved not at first sight?" You probably know that line. It's from *Hero and Leander*, which is Marlowe's poem. What Phoebe is saying is, she's declaring her love for Rosalind, who's disguised as the boy Ganymede. It's actually same-sex desire, but Phoebe doesn't know it.
- 5.24** The reference to Marlowe is direct. She's saying, "Now I understand what the great dead shepherd said, that love at first sight is indeed possible." I would just add that, I think, without Marlowe, there would be no Shakespeare, so important figure. Consider the title of *As You Like It*. Do what you please. It's idyllic, untethered from the conventions of polite society. And that includes singing, drowsily singing songs in the woods, like so many lotus-eaters, or dressing up as the opposite sex, as Rosalind does, or Orlando, as he has it. He runs around penning poems of love, pinning them to the trees.

- 5.25 In other words, in this world of the forest of Arden in the play, the restrictions are not lessened. The expectations and the troubles of the city don't follow them into the woods. But there are, of course, two sides to that. While there's an enjoyable freedom in the bucolic life, there's something to be said for the trappings of civilization, the conventions that we construct to defy our baser instincts. Shakespeare doesn't deal with the purely idyllic. He's not going to do that. He's not going to say that this is an idyllic world that can exist.
- 5.26 I've argued before, and I use that phrase—he never lets you settle on any particular perspective for long. So in *As You Like It*, the Arcadia that he represents is the forest of Arden. So let's explore it together. Now, the forest of Arden—really Ardennes, because this is a play that is ostensibly set in France; you get a smattering of French names. But I think, if you read the play sensitively, you'll come away feeling like it's England, really. It feels more like England.
- 5.27 In a way, it doesn't matter, because the world that Shakespeare creates is so far removed from reality that you don't need to pin it down to a specific geographic location. I mean, this forest has a lioness, for goodness' sake. You're not going to find one of those in France, are you? Unless it escapes from the zoo or something. I think it's difficult—actually, we don't know, with *As You Like It*, how popular it was at the time. It's not one of those that was written about all that much.
- 5.28 The only text we have of *As You Like It* is from the Folio, from the 1623 Folio. It's one of those. It was never published in quarto edition, which is one of those indications that it might have been popular if it had been. I'm not saying it wasn't popular, we just don't know; or the quartos might have all been destroyed. But Shakespeare was, in effect, piggybacking on the popularity of another writer—not only the genre, the pastoral genre being really popular, but also there was a prose romance by Thomas Lodge called *Rosalynde*, which was published in 1590.
- 5.29 The first performance of *As You Like It* is in 1599. In less than a decade, a lot of Shakespeare's sources tend to be old, very old stories, very old sources, historical documents. This one was adapted pretty much straightaway. Now, I wonder whether he was attracted to this story, partly because of the forest of Ardennes, the anglicized forest of Arden. His mother was Mary Arden, who grew up on the outskirts of the actual forest of Arden, near Stratford. And Mary Arden had come from a land-owning family, which had given the forest its name.
- 5.30 There's a real sense of a social disparity between Shakespeare's parents. She was really from the gentry, whereas his father was a glover, but a perfectly respectable middle-class trade, and became the bailiff, which is to say the same as the mayor, really. But he was marrying up, I would say. I'm not going to make too much of his biography. It's just worth noting the forest of Arden, the real place in Shakespeare's imagination, through his mother. Here we have the forest of Arden in the play.

- 5.31 Now, Thomas Lodge's story was very popular. Rosalynde went through nine editions in the 50 years after it was published. And part of the reason for that is that the pastoral genre was just very appealing. Shakespeare does this. He capitalizes on popular trends. He looks at what people are liking, and he does it better. Like, for instance, I've mentioned before, there was a vogue for Senecan tragedy, so he writes Titus Andronicus; and that doesn't quite work. He writes Hamlet. It did work. It was hugely popular. But then he writes Hamlet, which artistically is, of course, perfect.
- 5.32 And that's not to say that Shakespeare was being cynical or exploitative, because he always does something different. He confounds expectations. He takes these existing sources, these works, and he moves them in directions that no one really anticipated. And this is worth emphasizing. Shakespeare's use of sources is really worth emphasizing. Shakespeare was a magpie, and he would borrow quite shamelessly.
- 5.33 He was also—and this is often overlooked—he was a voracious reader. The plays are evidence that he read widely and thoroughly, and he was able to take the elements of history and drama or fable or folklore that interested him, and he was able to build upon them. And so often the most interesting aspects of discussion surrounding Shakespeare's sources is actually the bits he left out, what he chose to keep, what he chose to ignore.
- 5.34 And that's why I always recommend, when students are studying a particular play: Why not have a look at the source text? Why not compare it, see what Shakespeare has done? I mean, you'll find it very enlightening when you do that. Rosalynde is not very long. Rosalynde, the Lodge text, is about the length of a novella. You can read it in an afternoon. It bears similarities to Sidney's Arcadia, which is a very popular pastoral prose piece, which is, it's prose, but it's interspersed with poetry and song. Although Sidney's Arcadia is much longer. It's like a substantial novel length. He actually wrote two versions of it, so there's a lot to get through.
- 5.35 Now, you get this same blend of prose and poetry in another source of Shakespeare's *As You Like It*. Well, a sort of indirect source. This is *Diana* by Jorge Montemayor, a Spanish writer. That was a text from 1559, very popular in England. Shakespeare definitely knew it. He took the plot of *Two Gentlemen of Verona* from Montemayor, and also the central love triangle of Viola, Orsino, and Olivia in *Twelfth Night*.
- 5.36 There's a direct reference to Montemayor in Act 4, Scene 1 of *As You Like It*. It's not a direct source, but it's an influence, is what I'm saying. This is where Rosalind mentions Diana weeping in the fountain. That's a direct reference to Montemayor. Now, Shakespeare doesn't, as I say, he didn't scour Montemayor for the plot. But tonally, stylistically, we can infer the influence. I doubt that it's a coincidence that the first English translation of *Diana* appeared in 1598, *As You Like It*, 1599. So I don't think that's coincidental.

- 5.37** So, you might accuse Shakespeare of milking a few cash cows, seeing something and saying, "OK, I'm going to exploit that." He's taking popular stories, working with them. But with the exception of *Love's Labour's Lost*, basically, you've got *Midsummer Night's Dream*, *Merry Wives of Windsor*, *Tempest*—those are the plays that don't have those direct sources. Shakespeare really borrowed all of his major plot lines, except for those plays. But he is able to surpass his sources. He goes further.
- 5.38** And it's important to understand that the poets of the Elizabethan era were informed by the imitation theory of Quintilian, the Roman rhetorician. That is to say, great art could be produced through a combination of both imitation and invention. Today, if you take someone else's story and you rewrote it and you had a major bestseller, you would get done for plagiarism, and people would sue you and probably win. But copyright laws were different in the Elizabethan era, very different.
- 5.39** Actually, the authors didn't have the copyright. The publishers had the copyright. It was a very different state of affairs. This is why we get these bad quartos coming up. There's no legal system where you can just sue them. And you know, editions that were published without the authorization of the theater company—it was normally the Lord Chamberlain's Men, that was Shakespeare's Company, and later the King's Men—these editions would come out, and there'd be all sorts of trouble about that.
- 5.40** So this combination of invention and imitation is what I want you to remember. He's taking stories, but he doesn't just retell the stories. He improves upon the stories. Now, I would rank *As You Like It* as probably Shakespeare's best comedy, certainly one of the top three. It is a masterpiece, because by this point in his career, he was a master. If you think about the chronology of this play, it's appearing almost exactly halfway through his writing career, 1599. It's written about the same time as *Hamlet*.
- 5.41** He still had plenty of masterpieces to write. You go to the Jacobean period, then you've got your *Othello* and your *Macbeth*, *Coriolanus*, *Antony and Cleopatra*. There's still a lot to come. But I think, really, there's something about this year, *Hamlet* and *As You Like It*, written in quick succession, I mean, who does that? Who can pull that off? It's quite interesting that both of those plays, in a way, are connected; they're both concerned with the hatred of one brother for another.
- 5.42** In *Hamlet*, the entire plot is predicated on the murder of King Hamlet, the older Hamlet, by his brother Claudius. In *As You Like It*, we begin, we open with this rivalry between Orlando and his brother Oliver. It's not an accident that, in *Hamlet*, there's these multiple references to Cain and Abel. The Bible, at the time, was popular culture. If you mention Cain and Abel, the audience know what you're getting at. They know you're talking about fraternal rivalry.
- 5.43** Maybe this is something that was on Shakespeare's mind at this point. I don't want to read too much into that; we don't know. It's fun to do that. If you look at it, two of Shakespeare's brothers were called Richard and Edmund, and they happened to be the

names of two of his most memorable villains. So was brotherly envy; was there something going on there? I don't know. It's not, probably a stupid thing to say, but it's just worth noting.

5.44 One further thought about the rivalry in *As You Like It*—so Oliver's resentment for his younger brother, Orlando, doesn't just stop at the fact that he has not provided for him well, following their father's death, because Oliver got everything, and Oliver is not fulfilling his promise to the father to look after his younger brother. He sent the middle brother, Jack or Jaques, away to school.

5.45 There's some discussion about the pronunciation here because the clown in the play is Jaques. We know it's pronounced Jaques. It might be that the middle brother is pronounced Jacks or potentially Jaques. Probably Jacks or Jakes, to distinguish. It's one of those things we just don't know. Anyway, I'm getting off track.

5.46 So there are the three brothers, and the middle brother has been sent away to school. He's been looked after. Orlando doesn't get that treatment. He's resentful. In the opening scene, he tells Adam, his elderly retainer, that his father had bequeathed him a mere 1,000 crowns, and Oliver was entrusted with everything else, and Oliver was meant to look after him. By the way, he doesn't need to tell Adam any of this. This is one of those moments where Adam already knows all this. This is the first thing we hear in the play.

5.47 We mentioned earlier with the *Comedy of Errors*, how he establishes the plot in that first scene so he can get on with it, and I think it's the same here. Because plot in Shakespeare is always a means to an end. He's interested in people, their motivations, what makes human beings tick, what poetry he can weave around a subject. The plot is always secondary in Shakespeare. That's why he doesn't mind just nicking them.

5.48 Anyway, so Orlando explains this. He says, and here he is explaining the plot, "My brother Jaques he keeps at school and report speaks goldenly of his profit. For my part, he keeps me rustically at home, or to speak more properly, stays me here at home unkempt; for call you that keeping for a gentleman of my birth that differs not from the stalling of an ox?" He's being treated like livestock.

5.49 And again, he says to Adam, "This is it, Adam, that grieves me; and the spirit of my father, which I think is within me, begins to mutiny against this servitude. I will no longer endure it, though yet I know no wise remedy how to avoid it." But he does, mutiny he must, and he does. The spirit of his father is indeed within him, and he rails against his brother. When his brother turns up, we have that fight. He says, "I have as much of my father in me as you." And to prove his worth, he resolves to grapple with the Duke's wrestler, Charles.

5.50 But this rivalry, of course, is not enough. Because as I've said, Shakespeare is an abundant writer. He's not happy with just that rivalry. He wants complexity. He wants to make it more complicated. He relishes in threading in his plays multiple conflicts that

mirror each other. I mentioned before, the secondary plot of *King Lear*, mirroring the first plot. We see this in the *Comedy of Errors*, the *Menaechmi*. He takes the *Menaechmi* of Plautus, and he doubles the sets of twins to make it more complicated.

- 5.51 Here, in *As You Like It*, he adds a second brotherly conflict. So you've got the conflict between Oliver and Orlando. You also have the conflict between Duke Frederick, who usurps his older brother's dukedom and casts him out into the forest in exile. And that's a detail, by the way, that wasn't in the source text. That is not in Thomas Lodge, so it's a Shakespearean embellishment. What I said about looking at the sources, seeing what he changes, that's the most interesting thing. He's made it more complex. He's established a way to mirror one set of rivalry with the other, so that one almost comments on the other.
- 5.52 Now, for all this, the darkness, the forest of Arden is presented throughout in shamelessly idyllic terms. *As You Like It*, by the time they get to the forest, we are in the world of the pastoral. It's the lightest of the comedies, really. We've talked about how Shakespeare likes to blur the boundaries of genre. And yet, in *As You Like It*, we do find ourselves surrendering to the dream world. We can't help it. When we watch this play, you get sucked in.
- 5.53 And even the most cynical person, I think, if you're watching a good production of *As You Like It*, you'll want to stay there. We know it's not real. I mean, Shakespeare continually wants to remind us that it's not real, that this is an impossible world. This is a golden age that never was. And yet, his various conceits just draw us in.
- 5.54 What does Charles the wrestler say about the exiled Duke? We know the Duke has gone off to the forest of Arden. We know that the other characters are about to go there, too. Charles says—he's the wrestler, remember, big burly, butch guy—he says, "They say he is already in the forest of Arden, and a many merry men with him; and there they live like the old Robin Hood of England. They say many young gentlemen flock to him every day and fleet the time carelessly, as they did in the golden world."
- 5.55 There you have it, the golden world. That's the ideal, a carefree life, like the romantic tale of Robin Hood in Nottingham Forest. As I said, the overtones are far more English, aren't they, than French? Let's have a look at the opening of Act 2 when Duke Senior reflects on his exile. Remember, he's been betrayed by his brother, usurped by his brother, but he's in the forest, and he doesn't necessarily dislike it. This is what he says.
- 5.56 "Now, my co-mates and brothers in exile, hath not old custom made this life more sweet than that of painted pomp?" So we have, in that, painted pomp, the artificiality of the court, the thing that we saw satirized in *Love's Labour's Lost*, as opposed to the naturalness of the forest. This is earthy, real, gritty, but also idyllic. He says, "Are not these woods more free from peril than the envious court?" Direct comparison between these two worlds.

- 5.57 "Here feel we not the penalty of Adam." The penalty of Adam, of course, is that Adam was cast out of paradise, and all humankind since then is in a fallen state, a postlapsarian state. But here in the forest, they're none the worse for that. He says, "Here feel we not the penalty of Adam, the seasons' difference; as the icy fang and churlish chiding of the winter's wind, which when it bites and blows upon my body, even till I shrink with cold, I smile and say, 'This is no flattery; these are counsellors that feelingly persuade me what I am.'"
- 5.58 So you see the difference. This is a play—remember, this is a play that, so far, has been dominated by prose. It's a very prose-laden play. Here we have a rhythmic cadence. We're now in the verse, and the rhythmic cadence is deliberate. It's conjuring the toing and froing of the wind, the natural ebb and flow of nature, and it's so much better than the courts. Shakespeare is one of those who—
- 5.59 Now, he doesn't like to, by the way, overuse alliteration. There was a fashion for this. John Lyly established, and the euphuists, these writers who wrote very ornate rhetorical language, packed with alliteration, for its own sake, for the sake of ornament. But here the touch is defter, it's softer, it's more reflective of nature's call. So what I mean is, it feels earned. It's not posturing. So we have, in this passage, you heard it. "Churlish chiding, winter's wind, bites and blows, smile and say."
- 5.60 And furthermore, this alliterative technique is confined to that one sentence that lulls us. We are being lulled into this sense of nature's course. But then he breaks it, abruptly stops it with the rhythm of the speech. So if you listen again, try and hear it. "As the icy fang and churlish chiding of the winter's wind, which when it bites and blows upon my body, even till I shrink with cold, I smile and say, 'This is no flattery,'" and it breaks. We sense an interruption in the verse, the caesura. So while winter is a continuation of the natural cycle, it also stops us in our tracks.
- 5.61 So this is an example of the musicality of Shakespeare's verse. He often reflects within the rhythm of the language the point that he is trying to make. Now, the Duke seems to be saying that the onset of winter, the cruelty of nature, is actually a kind of benevolence. He's saying— let's go back to that caesura in the line, the break in the rhythm. "As the icy fang and churlish chiding of the winter's wind, which when it bites and blows upon my body, even till I shrink with cold, I smile and say, 'This is no flattery.'" Stop.
- 5.62 "These are counsellors that feelingly persuade me what I am. Sweet are the uses of adversity, which, like the toad, ugly and venomous, wears yet a precious jewel in his head." Now, that was folklore. That's not original to Shakespeare. The notion of the toadstone, the jewel in the head of the toad, that goes back to Pliny the Elder. But here it's used with a sense of something glorious within something which is ostensibly ugly, good within evil.

- 5.63 So winter's natural impediments are reframed as something positive, as the equivalent of the councillors at the court, reminding the Duke who he is. Of course, a Duke at a court would have been surrounded by sycophants. Not so in here. My counsellors in my court are the wind and the chill and the ice that reminds me that I'm a human being. This is better than the court. He's a man, and he must live as a man.
- 5.64 "Sweet are the uses of adversity," he says, "even in the travails of winter," which is not, by the way, to say that the play is necessarily set in winter. He's refreshed, he's ennobled, by the condition of living naturally, and he's reflecting on this. And he says this. "And this our life, exempt from public haunt, finds tongues in trees, books in the running brooks, sermons in stones, and good in everything." That is a kind of animism, isn't it? The natural world is alive with spirits. There are tongues in trees.
- 5.65 And of course, that is literalized later on when we have Orlando pinning poems to the barks. There are "sermons in stones." In other words, all you need to learn about life is here in nature. There's good in everything. I suppose this is kind of the view that was advanced by Rousseau, the idea of, if we are left in a state of nature, mankind is naturally better.
- 5.66 Now, the shift from verse to prose, which I mentioned, is a very, as I said, very prosy play. You should always keep an eye on when Shakespeare changes from verse to prose. It always has a function. Now, let's fast-forward in the play. Let's talk about Silvius and Phoebe to give you an example of this. Silvius and Phoebe, both shepherds, speak in verse. It's a failed wooing. Silvius is in love with Phoebe, but she has no interest in him whatsoever.
- 5.67 And Rosalind, who does intervene, when she—now Rosalind always speaks in prose, but when she approaches these idyllic shepherds, these countryfolk, these rustic folk, who speak in verse of love, she intervenes, she starts speaking in verse to match their patterns of speech. It's almost like she's adopting to their dialect, or at least that's the effect of this shift that Shakespeare does.
- 5.68 But let's have a closer look at this scene, because I think it tells us a great deal about the notion of desire and how foolish desire can be—these themes that I've been talking about all the way through these lectures. I think this is a really good example of it. So Silvius is there and he says, "Sweet Phoebe, do not scorn me; do not, Phoebe. Say that you love me not, but say not so in bitterness. The common executioner, whose heart the accustomed sight of death makes hard, falls not the axe upon the humbled neck, but first begs pardon. Will you sterner be than he that dies and lives by bloody drops?"
- 5.69 Are you going to be worse than an executioner? Just tell me you're not interested. I mean, this is a metaphorical commonplace, by the way, of the love object killing the lover because she will not requite his affection. This is all over the place in the literature of the time. And she mocks—I mean, we have it today. "You've broken my heart. You've killed me." She mocks that convention here. So she takes the metaphor literally.

- 5.70** And Phoebe says, "I would not be thy executioner. I fly thee, for I would not injure thee. Thou tell'st me there is murder in mine eye. 'Tis pretty, sure, and very probable that eyes that are the frailest and softest things, who shut their coward gates on atomies, should be called tyrants, butchers, murderers!" That is to say, so frail are eyes that even the smallest mote of dust causes them to shut.
- 5.71** And there's something interesting in Phoebe's response. We get the sense that she's enjoying being desired, and she's enjoying rejecting that desire. I'm told that many women enjoy this. She tests his hyperbolic thesis by taking it literally. She's frowning on this Petrarchan lover to see if he will drop down dead. He says, "If you frown on me, I will die." And so she frowns on him. Well, have you died? She's having a great time. She's enjoying it.
- 5.72** She says, "Now I do frown on thee with all my heart. And if mine eyes can wound, now let them kill thee. Now counterfeit to swoon; why, now fall down. Or, if thou canst not, O, for shame, for shame, lie not, to say mine eyes are murderers." So where does the power lie here? We hear a lot about the patriarchal nature of Shakespeare and Shakespeare's world, albeit a world ruled by a woman, we should add, Elizabeth I. But do men really have the upper hand in courtship? Or is it women who decide?
- 5.73** In love, in other words, the power dynamics of society can be inverted, and Shakespeare is aware of this. Of course, I don't want to generalize. I don't want to essentialize, but we do know that, in evolutionary terms, female choice is the driver of sexual selection. Now, Phoebe doesn't just reject him. She goes further than that, doesn't she? Phoebe is actually mocking him for even making the attempt. So it's not just her rejecting him; it's cruelly done. It's vicious, but it's also funny.
- 5.74** Now, this is a recurring theme in Shakespeare that desire, as I've said, reduces men, even the strongest, the most powerful and proud men, to begging fools, to weak men. Antony and Cleopatra, the obvious example of this. Now, Phoebe takes this even further. She becomes actually pedantic. She starts to get a bit annoying because she's enjoying her power so much. This is what she says.
- 5.75** "Now show the wound mine eye hath made in thee. Scratch thee but with a pin, and there remains some scar of it. Lean thou upon a rush, the cicatrice and capable impressure thy palm some moment keeps. But now mine eyes, which I have darted at thee, hurt thee not; nor, I am sure, there is not force in eyes that can do hurt." So even leaning on a reed by the riverbank, a rush, would leave a scar, would leave a "cicatrice or capable impressure," a visible impression.
- 5.76** And Silvius pleads with her, says that lovers' wounds cannot be seen because they're locked within the heart. He says, "O dear Phoebe, if ever, as that ever may be near, you meet in some fresh cheek the power of fancy, then shall you know the wounds invisible that love's keen arrows make." Pathetic, isn't it? But he's right, because the universe is

about to punish her. He's saying, "If you felt like this, you wouldn't mock me like this. You wouldn't be so cruel." She is about to get punished in a funny way.

- 5.77** He says, "If ever you meet in some fresh cheek the power of fancy," if ever you fall in love, you're going to understand. She's about to fall in love in about 10 seconds' time. That's what the play is doing. Rosalind, who is dressed as Ganymede, the boy; she's disguised herself as Ganymede. When she was exiled to the forest with Celia, her cousin, she disguised herself as Ganymede for protection. This is a common thing in Shakespeare. So she turns up, Phoebe, love at first sight. Phoebe loves Ganymede, not knowing she's in love with a woman.
- 5.78** But not only that, Rosalind, as Ganymede, chastises Phoebe. She's heard this, this cruel behavior to Silvius, and she says, "And why, I pray you?" This is Rosalind. "Who might be your mother, that you insult, exult, and all at once, over the wretched? What though you have no beauty, as, by my faith, I see no more in you than without candle may go dark to bed. Must you be therefore proud and pitiless? Why, what means this? Why do you look on me?" And here's one of those examples of where, in Shakespeare, there are often stage directions within the text, within the dialogue.
- 5.79** Because what's happened? We know what's happening. Rosalind's rebuke is cut short because, suddenly, Phoebe's staring at her. What's going on? And we hear it in what she says. And then Phoebe says that line that I quoted earlier from Marlowe. "O dead shepherd, now I find thy saw of might." A saw is like an axiom, a phrase or a proverb. "Dead shepherd, now I find thy saw of might; whoever loved that loved not at first sight?" So now I get it, she says. Now, a few things to consider here.
- 5.80** So Rosalind returns cruelty with cruelty. So she notes the way that Phoebe is toying with Silvius, and she tells her, "You can't be so choosy because you're not all that." She's saying, "You're not very attractive." And she also rebukes Silvius for being so infatuated. And this is a theme that we're going to return to in *The Merchant of Venice*, the difference between love and infatuation. It's very different.
- 5.81** Rosalind says, "I think she means to tangle my eyes too! No faith, proud mistress. Hope not after it." And this is so cruel. "'Tis not your inky brows, your black silk hair, your bugle eyeballs, nor your cheek of cream, that can entame my spirits to your worship. You foolish shepherd, wherefore do you follow her, like foggy south, puffing with wind and rain? You are a thousand times a properer man than she a woman. 'Tis such fools as you that makes the world full of ill-favoured children."
- 5.82** That couldn't be more damning. First, you have that sarcastic catalogue of the features. Do you remember I mentioned the blazon? The eyes like stars and the hair like golden thread. But it's not; it's sardonic—inky brows, black silk hair, bugle eyeballs, cheek of cream, for goodness' sake. These aren't the conventional Petrarchan metaphors of golden hair, red lips, et cetera, et cetera. If you want to read that kind of thing, you should read Philip Sidney's poem, *Astrophil and Stella*, from the 1580s.

- 5.83 Actually, Shakespeare inverts these Petrarchan blazons in his very famous Sonnet 130. Do you remember? "My mistress' eyes are nothing like the sun. Coral is far more red than her lips' red. If snow be white, why then her breasts are dun. If hairs be wires, black wires grow on her head." So you see what he's doing, he's inverting the Petrarchan conceit. We may get to the sonnets in a future lecture series, not this one.
- 5.84 But here, Rosalind does something even more direct. She says, "'Tis such fools as you that make the world full of ill-favoured children." In other words, the foolishness of desire, the sheer irrationality of desire, means that people fall in love with ugly women and have ugly children. How harsh is this? And then we have this. "'Tis not her glass, but you, that flatters her." She's talking to Silvius. It's not her glass, but you that flatters her. "And out of you, she sees herself more proper than any of her lineaments can show her."
- 5.85 In other words, the glass is the mirror, by the way. So what Rosalind is saying here is that Phoebe's confidence, her sense of her own beauty, is based on a lie. What it's based on is the fact that this guy keeps going on about how beautiful she is. Not that she's actually beautiful. She's ugly. That's what Rosalind's saying, not me. What she would see in the mirror would tell her that you're not desirable, but she sees herself reflected in his desire for her.
- 5.86 Now, I focused on this scene because I want to emphasize that, while the pastoral is concerned with desire and yearning, the natural state that we associate with bucolic life, it's also humiliating. I said that this was Shakespeare's lightest comedy, the play that draws us into the dream world. But he still wants to remind us that love can make us idiots.
- 5.87 It's like that song of the death of Daphnis, in the first idyll of Theocritus, with the young man dying because he's rejected love. And that's an interesting one, because in that first idyll, the song also has Daphnis—it depicts him watching the goats rutting, and he's suddenly mocked by Priapus, the god of fertility, because he isn't doing what the goats are doing. So it's a very strange poem, actually. It's a very disturbing poem.
- 5.88 But what I'm saying is that that tradition in pastoral poetry, of feeding in the darkness within the dream world, we're going to return to this a lot. Shakespeare captures this, I think, more than anyone. He seems to know that love is transcendental, yes, but it's also potentially humiliating and cringe-making. It's also, at once, very, very deadly serious and very, very funny. It can be all these things at once.
- 5.89 If you think about the various trajectories of desire in *As You Like It*, it's the stuff of comedy. You've got Rosalind and Orlando, who fall in love with each other immediately. You've got Silvius' unrequited desire for Phoebe. You've got Phoebe falling in love with Ganymede, not knowing that Ganymede is a woman; and ultimately, she gets tricked into marrying Silvius. You've got Touchstone, who lusts after Audrey,

the country wench, and sees off the rival, William, who also desires Audrey. Then you've got Oliver, who becomes reformed, and then marries Celia, who also loves him.

- 5.90** You can see what's going on in *As You Like It*, all these various trajectories of desire. That's the network. That's like the cat's cradle of how the comedy of the play works. But really, in amidst all of that complication, this play is Rosalind's play. It's all her, really. She's one of the most fully realized characters in Shakespeare. She's shrewd, she's witty, she's incisive. In an earlier lecture, I compared her to Falstaff. Obviously, they're completely different, but they're always one step ahead of the audience.
- 5.91** Rosalind has everything. She's got poise, she's got grace, she's capable of mischief. I love that complexity of character. You get it with Cleopatra. She's a woman who's dismissive and disdainful, but also petulant and beautiful and powerful and wonderful and all of these things—and real, above all, real. I think Rosalind is up there with Cleopatra in that respect. She steals every scene that she's in. That's what I basically mean, just as Falstaff steals every scene he's in. So too does Rosalind.
- 5.92** So often that condition I've described of dramatic irony, that usually happens in Shakespeare, but not here. We almost always know something the characters don't know. In *Macbeth*, we know more about Macbeth than Macbeth knows about Macbeth, because of his soliloquies, because of how inadvertently revealing they are. And there's lots of humor to be found that way, not in *Macbeth*, of course, but generally speaking.
- 5.93** But it just isn't possible here. Why? Because Rosalind is too self-aware. She's gloriously self-aware. She's always ahead of you. Let's just take an example of that. Just to remind you of the background for the plot, in case you haven't read it in a while—Rosalind and Orlando both end up in the forest of Arden because, of course, Rosalind is exiled by her uncle who doesn't really trust her. He's very suspicious of her.
- 5.94** He's allowed her to stick—when he got rid of her father, the Duke, he allowed Rosalind to stick around because his daughter Celia is so close. They have a very close connection. But then he starts to get suspicious. So he says, "Off you go." And of course, Celia said, "Well, if Rosalind's going, I'm going." So Celia goes off with her in exile in the forest of Arden.
- 5.95** And Orlando has, of course, as well, has run off to the forest because his brother, Oliver, is plotting to kill him. He's almost had him killed in that wrestling match. And he fears the wrath of the Duke. Once there, once he's in the forest, he surrenders to the forest, the idyllic atmosphere; he starts writing love sonnets to Rosalind, who he's seen and immediately falls in love with. And he pins these sonnets to the trees.
- 5.96** And she, of course, has disguised herself as Ganymede, and she retains that disguise in his presence. Of course, the convention of Shakespeare is, people never see through disguises. So he sees her, and he thinks he's talking to a boy. So she comes up with a scheme. Rosalind says she's going to test his devotion. Now, the poetry that Orlando

has written is terrible. It's full of cliché. It seems like the empty recitation of the tropes of love, not authentic love. And she wants to test this under the ruse of curing him of his desire.

- 5.97** Now, I should add here that Shakespeare was such a good writer that he could write badly. He could write badly well, if that makes sense. For instance, here's Celia reading aloud one of Orlando's poems. It's one of the ones that Orlando has pinned to the tree. "Why should this a desert be? For it is unpeopled? No, tongues I'll hang on every tree that shall civil sayings show." Even reading it aloud, your mouth naturally stumbles because it's not very elegant.
- 5.98** That harks back to, you remember the Duke's references to tongues in trees; it's a deliberate echo. "Some, how brief the life of man runs his erring pilgrimage, that the stretching of a span buckles in his sum of age. Some, of violated vows 'twixt the souls of friend and friend, but upon the fairest boughs, or at every sentence end, will I Rosalinda write, teaching all that read to know the quintessence of every sprite Heaven would in little show."
- 5.99** You can hear the stilted nature of the verse, the weighty Petrarchan themes, such as the shortness of life, with the implication to seize the day, that "carpe diem" tradition of love poetry. And then he's writing her name everywhere. It's a bad poem, and Rosalind's heard enough. When Celia's reading it out, Rosalind's heard enough. She says, "O most gentle pulpiter, what tedious homily of love have you wearied your parishioners withal, and never cried, 'Have patience, good people.'" Stop it. It's bad.
- 5.100** Now, a less talented playwright, one who was good but not great, wouldn't have been able to resist writing some good verse here, showing off his skills. In other words, a worse writer would have given Orlando better poetry. But Shakespeare pitches it just right. It's bad, but it's not so bad as to be lamentable doggerel. It's just bad enough. It's a bit like the last act of *A Midsummer Night's Dream* when the Mechanicals perform their version of *Pyramus and Thisbe*. It's just bad enough, and they do it terribly.
- 5.101** So Rosalind tells Orlando that he should woo her as though he were Rosalind. So this is the test. Think about that for a moment. So, to cure you of your love for Rosalind, just woo me, the boy Ganymede, and I'll be really cruel back, but I'm actually Rosalind. I mean, it's a funny setup. It's also complex. And she's going to respond in that way that we saw before, from Phoebe to Silvius. She's going to be difficult, she's going to be cruel, she's going to be slippery.
- 5.102** Remember, there's an added complication, isn't there? Which, in the Elizabethan theater, there are no women on the stage. So all of these female roles are played by boy actors. And that adds another level for the audience, because what is the spectacle here? You're watching a boy dressed as a girl, disguised as a boy, being wooed by a man who thinks she's a boy pretending to be a girl. That is to say, we have a premise

here that is not simply the comedy of language, the comedy of wit. This is the comedy of situation.

- 5.103** I think we lose some of that by having female actors in Shakespeare plays. I'm not against it, obviously, I'm just saying. Although I did see a brilliant all-female *Twelfth Night* once with Mark Rylance at the Globe, and it worked—all-male cast, and it worked really well. Anyway, I'm not trying to get women out of work. I'm just saying it's quite a good thing, when it's done well. Now, this is Act 4, Scene 1, and this is the conceit. Rosalind's testing him in this brilliant way.
- 5.104** She says, "Come, woo me, woo me; for now I am in a holiday humor, and like enough to consent. What would you say to me now, an I were your very, very Rosalind?" Orlando says, "I would kiss before I spoke." That's how much he's in love with Rosalind. Rosalind says, "Nay, you were better speak first; and when you were graveled for lack of matter, you might take occasion to kiss. Very good orators, when they are out, they will spit; and for lovers lacking— God warn us!—matter, the cleanliest shift is to kiss."
- 5.105** Do you understand what she's saying there? She has a forensic understanding of the tactics of courtship. Orlando would kiss first. He would want to kiss her first. That would be his instinct. But Rosalind, as Ganymede, says no, you should speak first. Then when you are graveled—which means when you come to a stop, when you're graveled—then you can fall back on a kiss.
- 5.106** She compares it to an orator who stops to spit to clear his throat, when he's run out of things to say. In other words, silence will give you the excuse to kiss. You should try the speech first. So she's not just mocking the conventions of courting, but she's playing on Orlando's insecurity, his embarrassment, the way his desire is making him gauche.
- 5.107** In fact, the whole concept of seduction is here exposed as strategic and transactional. You might even call it cynical. But Rosalind herself, of course—and this is key— she's in love, too. She's in love with him. So this isn't just her being cynical about the concept of love. She's commenting on herself. She's having fun at his expense, but also at her own expense. Orlando says, "Who could be out," who could be out of matter, out of words, "being before his beloved mistress?" How could I be at a loss for words, given that my love is so sincere?
- 5.108** Rosalind says, "Marry, that should you, if I were your mistress." If I were your mistress, if you think about what she's doing here. "Or I should think my honesty ranker than my wit." The joke here is that he could talk freely with her, never at a loss for words, and then she would be too sexually available. Then she makes this sexualized pun.
- 5.109** Orlando says, "What, of my suit?" Out of my suit? Out of my petition? Rosalind says, "Not out of your apparel, and yet out of your suit." He means, of course, "out of words," because his suit is courtship, his petition, the substance of his wooing. But she, again, plays on the word suit to mean his clothing. So by implication, the suit or petition

hasn't been successful because he's still dressed. So we know your seduction hasn't worked, because you've got your clothes on.

- 5.110** Remember, I mentioned this thing about Shakespeare taking words, and the characters taking the words and they redefine the words, or they use another meaning of the word. It's exactly what's happening here. Now, we've already covered, in Love's Labour's Lost, the punning nature of Shakespeare's comedy, how he often relies on double meaning, and how sometimes those puns don't work anymore because the meaning has changed.
- 5.111** This always works in performance, this punning of Rosalind, if it's delivered by someone who understands the text. Rosalind, we can see at all times, is dominant. She takes his words, she twists them, and not to be cruel now, not to be cruel in the way she was with Phoebe, but to poke fun at the artificiality of courtship. That's what she's doing, as well as affectionately acknowledging the necessity of courtship. So we continue.
- 5.112** Rosalind says, "Am I not your Rosalind?" Orlando says, "I take some joy to say you are, because I would be talking of her." Rosalind says, "Well, in her person, I say I will not have you." Orlando says, "Then, in my own person, I die." And that, we mentioned it before, is the Petrarchan motif of the lover who must kill himself because of unrequited desire. I must have you or I will die.
- 5.113** Now, if you've read Marlowe's poem, Hero and Leander, you'll know this metaphor because there's a brilliant part in that poem where he describes Hero and her attire. He says, "Her kirtle blue, whereon was many a stain made with the blood of wretched lovers slain," which is literalizing this metaphor. It's a vivid image of the dress of Hero, smeared with the blood of all the men who have tried and failed to get her. They've gone and killed themselves.
- 5.114** Of course, it's not real. It's a metaphor. It's a visual image of the destructive capacity of love—and the woman's power in withholding love, to return to what I said about Phoebe's rejection of Silvius. But Orlando now says to Rosalind that he will die without Rosalind's love—not a literal statement; it's a Petrarchan convention, and Rosalind knows that, and she wants to expose it, and she does it brilliantly.
- 5.115** So after Orlando says he's going to die if he can't have her, this is what she says. "No, faith, die by attorney. The poor world is almost 6,000 years old, and in all this time there was not any man died in his own person, videlicet, in a love-cause. Troilus had his brains dashed out with a Grecian club; yet he did what he could to die before, and he is one of the patterns of love.
- 5.116** Leander, he would have lived many a fair year, though Hero had turned nun, if it had not been for a hot midsummer night; for, good youth, he went but forth to wash him in the Hellespont and, being taken with the cramp, was drowned; and the foolish chroniclers of the age found it was Hero of Sestos. But these are all lies; men have died from time to time, and worms have eaten them, but not for love."

- 5.117** It couldn't be better put than that. It's so deft. It's so striking. She adopts this faux scholarly language, videlicet, that is to say, namely videlicet. We still say vis. To die by attorney is to die by proxy; in other words, love is blamed for the death of lovers, but it's not really the cause of death. It's not that, is it? Leander swam across the Hellespont and drowned. He didn't die for love. He died of stomach cramp, while he was swimming, or a club to the head, or whatever it might be.
- 5.118** She says, "These are all lies. Men have died from time to time, and worms have eaten them, but not for love." She's telling him to get real. She's saying that love is romanticized to the most extreme point, but she's grounding all of these poets who have written of these tragic paramours. She's so real, isn't she? She's so realistic. And yet, and yet, and yet, she is in love with Orlando. That's important.
- 5.119** So, what she's doing is dissecting her own condition. She's dissecting his condition and hers, at the same time. She's mocking his complaints, his inability to articulate his desire. And by doing so, she is finding a way to articulate her own inarticulable desires. So the mockery of love becomes a means of the expression of love. And because poets try and fail to express it, she's going to find another way.
- 5.120** What did Harold Bloom say of Rosalind? He said, "To be in love, and yet to see and feel the absurdity of it, one needs to go to school with Rosalind." She just gets it. It's exactly right. She just gets it. Who else can retain that kind of objectivity about one's own passion and, at the same time, laugh with it? She feels it intensely. She feels love. She also knows it's funny. The greatest lovers of history have been very quick to lose their sense of humor. Have you noticed? Have you not had friends who fall head over heels in love with someone, and then they'd just become humorless, and everything is serious?
- 5.121** Oscar Wilde was so infatuated with Lord Alfred Douglas, with Bosie, that he didn't realize he was being abused. He even lost his literary judgment, for heaven's sake. Wilde wrote about how Bosie was far the finest of all the young poets in England. Have you read Bosie's verse? He wasn't. You would think Wilde would know better than that, but he was too in love. Because he was in love, his critical faculties just exploded.
- 5.122** This is the point. Love is debilitating. That's the point. It makes us make fools of ourselves. Rosalind knows this, but she finds a way to express it without denigrating love. So it would have been just as easy for her to say, "Yeah, love is stupid. It makes us all stupid. Therefore, love is ridiculous." But she doesn't say that. She knows, while she's mocking it, she knows that love is the most transcendental experience that a person can have.
- 5.123** But it's also funny because we lose our capacity for reason. That's why love is such a strong subject for satire. But Shakespeare takes it to another level because, in *As You Like It*, he offers a satirical view of love whilst satirizing the satirists. There are two clowns in this play. There is Touchstone, who is Duke Frederick's court jester, who

leaves for the forest of Arden with Rosalind and Celia. But there's also Jaques, and he's technically not a jester, but he wants to be. He says he's ambitious for a motley coat.

5.124 Like all the fools in Shakespeare, both of these characters comment satirically on the action. Why is this necessary? Well, there's a wonderful moment where Jaques defends the right of comedians to mock any target. I've mentioned it before, and I want to mention it again. I think you could use this passage just to defend the right of comedians to say what the hell they want.

5.125 He says, "I must have liberty withal, as large a charter as the wind, to blow on whom I please, for so fools have; and they that are most galled with my folly, they most must laugh. And why, sir, must they so? The why is plain as way to parish church: He that a fool doth very wisely hit, doth very foolishly, although he smart, not to seem senseless of the bob; if not, the wise man's folly is anatomized, even by the squandering glances of the fool. Invest me in my motley; give me leave to speak my mind, and I will through and through cleanse the foul body of the infected world, if they will patiently receive my medicine."

5.126 So today, we hear a lot said about punching up and punching down, and who comedians should be able to target. And Jaques says, "No, I must have as large a charter as the wind to blow on whom I please, to mock whoever I like. And furthermore, that those who are most galled, most offended, most barbed should laugh along with me, because if they don't, their folly will be exposed even more. They will have been anatomized." That's the power of the fool. He may mock where others remain silent.

5.127 And the effect is purgative. He says that he's going to provide medicine to cleanse the body of the infected world. Now, this is certainly what the fool in King Lear does. Eventually, he's probably hanged for his trouble. Remember, Lear says at the end, "They hanged my fool," and that's probably him. There are some people who think he's talking about Cordelia, as fool as a term of endearment.

5.128 But anyway, as I've said, the role of satire is to punctuate the pretensions of the powerful. This passage is saying, the satirist has to have this liberty. I think this is just after the Bishops' Ban of 1599, where satirical books were burned publicly. As You Like It was probably written very soon after this. Given that some of Shakespeare's fellow playwrights and poets were caught up in this Bishops' Ban, people like John Marston and Thomas Middleton, you can see why he would have wanted to mount a defense.

5.129 But because it's Shakespeare, it's never that simple, is it? You can take this passage out of context and say, "This is a defense of the comedian." But then what happens in the play? It's not that simple. Jaques says this, then Duke Senior replies. "Most mischievous foul sin, in chiding sin; for thou thyself hast been a libertine, as sensual as the brutish sting itself; and all the embossed sores and headed evils that thou with license of free foot hast caught wouldst thou disgorge into the general world."

- 5.130** In other words, how dare this man dress in motley and judge the world when he himself is prone to vice and folly? In other words, what satirist is free from sin? Who will satirize the satirists? Now, a lesser writer wouldn't go that far. They'd just do the defense of satire. They wouldn't mock the satirist for making the attempts. That's the complexity. That's the abundance of Shakespeare. It's quite extraordinary.
- 5.131** And Jaques is the ultimate melancholic. He, of course, is a ripe target for satire himself because his condition is like a form of narcissism. The melancholy is performative. It's not real. He revels in it, doesn't he? He loves it. He loves being dejected. He loves mooching about the place. "They say you are a melancholy fellow," says Rosalind. Jaques says, "I am so. I do love it better than laughing."
- 5.132** Now, I suppose the equivalent today would be a goth or an emo, if they still exist. I don't know. It's not really my scene. But it's this performative nihilism that you get of the underdeveloped mind. That's what's being mocked here. Jaques is that, a performative melancholic. If you consider Jaques' famous speech about the seven ages of man, this is the most famous speech in the play. Might be one of the most famous speeches in Shakespeare. If you haven't read Shakespeare, you know this speech, this "all the world's a stage" speech.
- 5.133** It's very interesting, by the way. This is probably one of the first plays that was performed in the Globe Theater, which was built, literally constructed by Shakespeare and the Burbage brothers. There's a really good account in James Shapiro's book, 1599. He opens the book with them. There was a legend that they took the timber from the theater in Shoreditch, which the Burbage brothers owned, and they had to build a new theater. And so they are dragging the timber over the frozen ice of the Thames overnight. They had to do it secretly.
- 5.134** That probably didn't happen. It's a bit of a myth, but it's quite compelling. You should read the book. But I'm mentioning this anyway, because on the new Globe theater that Shakespeare was a shareholder in, there was a motto, "Totus mundus agit histrionem," on the beam, they say, of the—somewhere prominent, anyway, of the Globe, which approximates to "all the world's a stage." And of course, so Jaques saying, "All the world's a stage" in the Globe, it's called the Globe, for god's sake. So the line is self-referential, meta-theatrical.
- 5.135** So you certainly know the speech already. Jaques takes us through the seven roles of a human life. "All the world's a stage, and all the men and women merely players. They have their exits and their entrances. And one man in his time plays many parts. His acts being seven ages. At first the infant, mewling and puking in the nurse's arms. Then the whining schoolboy, with his satchel and shining morning face, creeping like snail unwillingly to school.
- 5.136** And then the lover, sighing like a furnace, with a woeful ballad made to his mistress' eyebrow. Then a soldier, full of strange oaths and bearded like the pard, jealous in

honor, sudden and quick in quarrel, seeking the bubble reputation even in the cannon's mouth. And then the justice, in fair round belly with good capon lined, with eyes severe and beard of formal cut, full of wise saws and modern instances. And so he plays his part.

5.137 The sixth age shifts into the lean and slippered pantaloone, with spectacles on nose and pouch on side, his youthful hose, well-saved, a world too wide for his shrunk shank; and his big manly voice, turning again toward childish treble, pipes and whistles in his sound. Last scene of all, that ends this strange eventful history, is second childishness and mere oblivion. Sans teeth, sans eyes, sans taste, sans everything."

5.138 That touching and almost baleful last line is one of those Shakespearean fingerprints, isn't it? The tone of the speech is comedically cynical. And then he veers at the final moment into this image of oblivion, of the loss of all that made us men, of disintegration, of destiny. And it does cut deep. It resonates in a way that we had not expected, because Jaques is the melancholic. But here, he has uttered an undeniable and uncomfortable truth.

5.139 But what then? Shakespeare doesn't let us settle. I think, at this point, a director might want to hold the silence. What can the Duke say to this? What can anyone say to this? The line is so powerful, it strikes us dumb. This is a master stroke from Shakespeare. But who enters? Do you remember? Orlando enters, carrying his faithful elderly servant, Adam, weak and tired, but hardly sans teeth, sans eyes, sans taste, sans everything.

5.140 No, he's not that. He's in the final stage of life, but he has faith, endurance, and dignity. So the cynicism of Jaques is answered by a reality that is far more uplifting, and this is done visually; this is theatricalized. It's right before you. But of course, Jaques is a cynic, and the name is a pun, actually. Jaques or Jakes, Jakes or privy, privy or toilet.

5.141 And while Jaques would love to wear motley and would love to sit in judgment of others as a satirist, Touchstone actually does. I mean, Touchstone wears the motley. Touchstone is the clown. He's the jester. And he's aptly named as well, the touchstone, because a touchstone is a small stone used to test the purity of precious metals. And in a way, Touchstone is a touchstone for the superior wit of Rosalind. She's much wittier than the fool. And of course, in this play, love is the satirist's target.

5.142 When Touchstone hears Silvius pining for his love, Phoebe, his first instinct is to ridicule. He says, "I remember when I was in love, I broke my sword upon a stone, and bid him take that for coming a-night to Jane Smile. And I remember the kissing of her batlet, and the cow's dugs that her pretty chapped hands had milked; and I remember the wooing of a peascod instead of her, from whom I took two cods, and giving her them again, said with weeping tears, 'Wear these for my sake.' We that are true lovers run into strange capers; but as all is mortal in nature, so is all nature in love mortal in folly."

- 5.143** Well, if he did woo a woman called Jane Smile, he certainly didn't enter into a chivalric duel, let alone with a piece of rock. His satirical target is the lover who will fight for his beloved. And since this is Touchstone, he doesn't kiss girl, does he? He kisses her batlet, which is the wooden paddle that you would beat the cloth in laundry, in the process of washing. It feels a bit like he's knocking Phoebe. What knight would duel over a mere shepherdess?
- 5.144** That's why Touchstone says he also kisses the dugs, the cow's dugs, instead of the hands. So if you imagine his loved one milking, and he kisses the dugs instead, it's very silly. And there's no keepsakes for her. There's peas in their pods. So he's completely undercutting the whole convention of courtship. But in a way, I've said that we've got Jaques and Touchstone both commenting archly and satirically on love. But all of that's redundant, really.
- 5.145** That's what the play does. It gives you not just one satirist, but two, and actually not just two, but three, because Rosalind is able to satirize love and desire far more effectively than the two clowns combined. She does it, and she retains her, a sense of love significance as well. She's not duplicitous or performative, even when she's dressed as a boy. She sees through herself, as much as she sees through others. So she is, Rosalind, is, to an extent, the ultimate satirist.
- 5.146** Touchstone, true to his name, tests the world around him, mocks everything and everyone. Jaques indulges in self-satisfied poses of faux despair. Only Rosalind sees it all. She's the only one that sees through everything. This is how the scholar Mark Van Doren put it. He said, "There is only one thing sillier than being in love, and that is thinking it is silly to be in love." Rosalind skips through both errors to wisdom. She is the most effective critic of the pastoral world, and also its champion.
- 5.147** And this is what Shakespeare somehow achieves in this play. He piles on improbability after improbability. He insists on your complicity as an audience. Arden, the world of Arden, the forest makes us better, and we barely know why. Everyone who enters Arden improves. Duke Frederick marches into the forest. What happens? He's converted by a holy man. That's not going to happen. It's so improbable. And so he then returns the kingdom to the rightful lord, to the usurped Duke.
- 5.148** Now, that's not, again, if Shakespeare had been more faithful to his source, that wouldn't have happened, because in Thomas Lodge's novella, *Rosalynde*, the Duke is killed in the process of entering the forest. He's going into war with his rival, also not his brother. Remember, that's an addition by Shakespeare to echo the fraternal rivalry. In other words, what Shakespeare does with his source is, he makes it even more improbable.
- 5.149** We're told of the conversion of Duke Frederick by the middle brother of Orlando and Oliver. This is when Jaques, probably Jakes, arrives just in time to tell the story. It's so improbable. Even the villainous brother, Oliver, is changed after his brother defends

him, when he's sleeping, from a lioness. All of this nonsense keeps happening. It's almost like Shakespeare is daring you to disbelieve it.

- 5.150** Then he caps it all, because what happens at the end? The god of marriage descends, Hymen descends, and we have this *deus ex machina*. You've had all these various trajectories of desire, and Hymen comes down and sorts it all out, marries everyone off in the correct way. Now, some critics say this was meant to be one of the Duke's pageboys dressed up for the occasion, because it's too neat otherwise. But I think it's probably not. I think this is probably a supernatural element. I think Shakespeare is introducing a god.
- 5.151** This is his final test of how much improbability you can stomach. So suddenly we find ourselves in this elaborate ritualistic masque. We've been forced to suspend our disbelief to such an extent that the manifestation of a supernatural deity isn't going to bother us at this point, because we've already been tested so much. The play, in other words, is so insistent that everything should turn out all right, that it has the quality of a fairy tale.
- 5.152** It doesn't leave that lingering bitter taste that you get in *The Merchant of Venice*, with the forced conversion of Shylock, or the end of *Twelfth Night*, with Malvolio swearing revenge on everyone. In *As You Like It*, Shakespeare is insistently happy. It's what the title suggests. This is as we like it. Even a cynic, the most cynical mind, going along to see a production, is going to bathe in this exuberance. You can't help it. I mean, once a lioness has turned up, what choice have you got, but just to go along with it?
- 5.153** Even Wittgenstein, who was highly critical of Shakespeare, he recognized this quality that draws us in, that makes itself coherent, even at its most incoherent. So Wittgenstein compares the sensation of a Shakespeare play to a dream. He says, "A dream is all wrong, absurd, composite, and yet at the same time is completely right. Put together in this strange way, it makes an impression. Why? I don't know. And if Shakespeare is great, as he is said to be, then it must be possible to say of him, it's all wrong. Things aren't like that. And yet, at the same time, it's quite right according to a law of its own."
- 5.154** This is verisimilitude. I said before that Shakespeare creates in each play its own little world, and we are drawn in, and while we are reading it or watching it, we buy into it. And each little world is different. We know that the forest of Arden isn't real. Shakespeare will not let us forget that it isn't real. But for a few hours, we can indulge in the fantasy of its existence. And for that short time, it feels real.
- 5.155** And we likewise know that love is irrational, but we cannot afford not to lose our heads. What other writer but Shakespeare could deconstruct a whole tradition, while reveling in the potential of that tradition? The golden age never was, but in *As You Like It*, we can experience it nonetheless.

Lecture 6: Two Gentlemen & Midsummer Night's

At a glance — Two Gentlemen of Verona and A Midsummer Night's Dream.

- 6.1** If you visit the city of Tallinn in Estonia and go to the main town square, you'll see the oldest surviving town hall in northern Europe. It's a Gothic building which was completed in 1404. If you go in there and you go to the council chamber, there's a wooden bench, also from the early 15th century. On the side, there's a carving of a woman riding a man on all fours with a whip in her hand.
- 6.2** Now, I noticed this quite by accident. I was snooping around the great chamber, the council chamber, and I thought this was a bit incongruous for such an austere and prestigious location. It turns out that the man in that engraving is actually Aristotle, the tutor of Alexander the Great, the philosopher who laid the foundation for Western intellectual tradition. He's quite an important figure.
- 6.3** So why would such a revered figure demean himself in this way? Why would he allow a woman to ride him like he was a horse? What the hell is going on? And I looked into it. I didn't know what was happening here, but apparently, it's a story that dates from the 13th century, and the woman is Phyllis, who is Alexander's lover or wife. Like Antony, when he falls in love with Cleopatra, Alexander is neglecting his official duties because he's infatuated.
- 6.4** And what happens is, Aristotle warns Alexander that the influence of women can have this effect, can have this enervating effect. So, Alexander makes a point of spending less time with Phyllis. And what happens then is that she knows that Aristotle is to blame for this sudden lack of attention she's getting from Alexander. So she decides to seek revenge by seducing Aristotle. The story is a little odd, but apparently, she let her hair down and danced provocatively outside Aristotle's window.
- 6.5** He was overcome with desire, being a fan of dancing, apparently, and he wants to have sex with her. And she agrees, so long as he proves his love by allowing her to ride him like a horse. So that's what happens. So she saddles him up, and she rides him around the garden. And in true farce-like style, Alexander then comes outside at the wrong moment, presumably to find out what all the noise is about. And he sees his tutor, the great Aristotle, degrading himself in this astonishing way.
- 6.6** Aristotle then manages to turn this humiliation to his advantage as an opportunity for teaching. And he says that the moral of the story is that, if such an esteemed and important man as Aristotle can fall prey to the charms of women, how much easier would it be for younger and more callow men? It's an odd story, isn't it? But perhaps the reason why the image is on the bench, I suppose, is to remind us—because this great council chamber was for the most important learned men in society.

- 6.7 So I think this reminds us that even the most powerful people are human beings, are susceptible to their basic desires. And there's also something to be said here about the power of women in courtship and seduction. We saw before, when we talked about *As You Like It*, how Phoebe enjoys the power over Silvius because he is smitten with her. And there's little doubt in my mind that, had Phoebe said to Silvius, "Go down on all fours and let me ride you like a horse," he would have acquiesced.
- 6.8 Because, of course, as we know, in discourses of patriarchy, women are often cast as the victims. But of course, that's because of the relative physical vulnerability of women. And of course, during Shakespeare's time, they had a dependence on men. But Shakespeare is also interested in how men make themselves into horses, make themselves into fools for women.
- 6.9 I mean, this is what Romeo says in Act 3, Scene 1, of *Romeo and Juliet*. He says, "O sweet Juliet, thy beauty hath made me effeminate, and in my temper softened valour's steel!" So I know I keep going on in these lectures about men making fools of themselves, but it's so key to Shakespeare's comedy. It's a staple of his work. It makes us fools, but it simultaneously elevates us. And in this sense, the figure of Rosalind, who understands both of these principles, makes her the quintessential figure of Shakespearean comedy.
- 6.10 But there's another aspect to this, which we find in Mercutio in *Romeo and Juliet*, when Mercutio teases Romeo. We see it also in the soldiers who complain of Antony's neglect for his army. That is how male relations with each other are damaged by their love for women. A bit of a Yoko Ono situation, I suppose. In modern parlance, we might call this "bros before hoes." That's what people say, isn't it? Obviously, I don't say it, but people say it.
- 6.11 Now, in the English Renaissance, we see this tradition of writing about friendship. They called it "amicitia," and this harks back to the classics and the notion of male friendship as being the highest form of love. Cicero wrote a famous tract on friendship called *De Amicitia*. Aristotle uses the metaphor of the friend as another self. Horace does it. In his *Odes*, Horace pleads directly to the ship that will be transporting Virgil to Greece, in the hope it might preserve the man who he affectionately terms "the other half of his soul."
- 6.12 There's a clear overlap, isn't there, between the language of love and the language of the highest male friendship. We still use that phrase, "my other half." And this was completely axiomatic. By the time you get to the 17th century, Sir Thomas Browne was writing about friendship as a mystical union of one soul in two bodies.
- 6.13 Now, this idea, this male-centered idealization of friendship, I think this perhaps accounts for the more baffling elements of Shakespeare's early play, *The Two Gentlemen of Verona*, which I'm going to talk about now, because it's one of those plays that you don't see very often. I imagine a lot of you don't know about this play.

Well, you would have heard of it, but you probably haven't seen it. It's rarely staged, and that's not that surprising because, firstly, its weaknesses are very obvious and difficult to explain away.

- 6.14** Now, I don't normally give synopses of the plots in these lectures, but I will do so for this because I don't think everyone knows about this play. I'll outline it now. The title of the play, *The Two Gentlemen of Verona*, refers to Valentine and Proteus, who begin in Verona. Most of the play actually takes place in Milan. They're best friends. Proteus is in love with Julia, and Valentine mocks him for this and says that he isn't content to stay at home and waste his time like that. He's not going to be falling in love with women.
- 6.15** He says, "I rather would entreat thy company to see the wonders of the world abroad than, living dully sluggardized at home, wear out thy youth with shapeless idleness"—idleness is often associated with love at this time. Remember, the potion in *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is called love-in-idleness. And so he leaves for Milan with his servant Speed, who's a clownish figure.
- 6.16** Proteus' father, Antonio, doesn't much approve of all this sluggardizing. And so he sends Proteus away to Milan as well, to be more productive and to seek his fortune. Proteus isn't happy about it, but he bids Julia farewell. They exchange rings. They swear they'll always be faithful to one another. We know what's going to happen. Proteus is accompanied by his servant, Launce, sometimes modernized as Lance, but let's go with Launce, who also has a dog called Crab.
- 6.17** Now, by this point, Valentine, in Milan, has fallen in love with Silvia. Silvia is, even if you don't know the play, you will know the famous song, "Who is Silvia? What is she?" That's where this comes from. Silvia's father, the Duke, isn't happy about Valentine's petition, wants Silvia to marry Thurio instead. And so, Valentine and Silvia, what do they do? They decide to elope because the father won't let them get married. They elope. And the problems begin when Proteus also reaches Milan and, directly, of course, inevitably falls in love with Silvia as well.
- 6.18** I mean, he's called Proteus, isn't he? He's somewhat changeable. He's just said you shouldn't be wasting your time with women. Straightaway, he's fallen in love with Silvia. Now, he betrays Valentine by revealing the elopement plan to the Duke, and Valentine is banished to the forest where he joins a gang of outlaws, proper Robin Hood-style outlaws. In fact, they even mention Robin Hood. One of the outlaws says, "By the bare scalp of Robin Hood's fat friar, this fellow were a king for our wild faction."
- 6.19** In other words, they're so impressed by Valentine, they're going to offer him the role of the leader of the gang. It's either that or they're going to kill him, so there's not much of a choice, really. Meanwhile, Julia, who is gutted that her lover has left her, decides she cannot be without Proteus, and so she disguises herself as a boy called Sebastian, and also leaves for Milan. Proteus, believing her to be a boy, enlists her as his page.

Launce, being too irresponsible and unreliable, he'd rather have this boy page instead. Launce is always bothering about his dog, anyway, Crab.

- 6.20** Then he dispatches this new boy page, not realizing who she is, on an errand of love to Silvia, and tells her to give her a ring, and you can guess what it is. It's the ring that Julia actually gave to him. Silvia refuses the ring because she's still in love with Valentine. Instead, she flees to the forest in search of him, accompanied by the knight, Sir Eglamour, as her protector; and there, they are attacked by the outlaws.
- 6.21** Sir Eglamour runs away. He isn't really a protector. Silvia is captured, and we then move to Valentine alone in the forest. He hears noises, he hides, and Proteus and Julia, still disguised as Sebastian, enter with Silvia, who Proteus has rescued, or rather taken her as his own prize, which is his true objective. And then—we're at the end now—then comes the scene where critics normally describe this as problematic. Let's get that word back again, problematic. Let's explain why.
- 6.22** Proteus attempts to woo Silvia, and when she resists, he attempts to rape her. Remember, this is all in front of the disguised Julia, who, as you can imagine, is absolutely horrified by this. Valentine then reveals himself that he was there all along, berates Proteus for attempting to rape his beloved. Proteus apologizes. And what does Valentine do? Valentine not only accepts the apology, he offers Silvia to him as a sign of friendship. And she gets no say in the matter. In fact, she doesn't speak for the rest of the play.
- 6.23** All of this happens in under 30 lines. This crazy attempted rape, apology, and offer of the victim to him as a token of friendship. It's mad, really. Then Julia faints, comes around, reveals who she is. Proteus feels terrible about the whole thing and says, "Well, I might as well stick with Julia, because what's really the difference between one woman and another?" He says, "What is it in Silvia's face, but I may spy more fresh in Julia's with a constant eye?" If I really work hard at it, aren't women just all the same, basically?
- 6.24** Then the outlaws arrive with the captured Duke and Thurio. Thurio says he's no longer got a claim on Silvia, and so the Duke agrees that she can marry Valentine. And so we end the play with the promise of a double wedding, and we all live happily ever after. Now, needless to say, this is not a feminist play. There are a number of ways that we can make sense of it, however. I think, firstly, it's worth saying, this is an early play, right? So this isn't Shakespeare at his best. This is Shakespeare trying things out. He's learning his craft.
- 6.25** And the writing has a lot of hallmarks of those early plays. For instance, the verse passages are very ungainly. I think Valentine's an exception. Valentine gets some of the more complex lines, but they're all mostly end-stopped in that way that Shakespeare wrote in his early plays. The lines tend not to run over to the next line. That happens in

A Midsummer Night's Dream as well, but there it sort of adds to the folklorish fairytale quality. In the Two Gentlemen of Verona, it just feels mannered, overly mannered.

- 6.26** But I don't think youthful inexperience can quite explain this baffling scene. I mean, Shakespeare had already written The Comedy of Errors, and I could say he got that right. The Taming of the Shrew, he mostly got that right, I think. They both work well in performance, and Two Gentlemen of Verona doesn't really, or at least I've never seen a performance that works. Now, I've argued that Shakespeare is a natural comedian, but I think, in The Two Gentlemen of Verona, the comedy doesn't land.
- 6.27** I am persuaded, however, that in this play, Shakespeare was grappling with ideas and themes and techniques that he eventually did master. I think it's part of the artistic process that we fail as we go along the way. It's absolutely clear that various aspects of this play do recur in later works, and when they do, they are executed with aplomb.
- 6.28** Now, you'll probably have spotted already the thematic similarities, the plot similarities. I gave you that brief synopsis. Well, the moment where Silvia's father insists she marry Thurio rather than Valentine, and they decide, "Well, we're going to have to run away to the woods," what does that remind you of? I mean, that's exactly what happens in A Midsummer Night's Dream, in which Hermia is in love with Lysander, but her father wants her to marry Demetrius, and so they run away. It's the same thing.
- 6.29** And yet, A Midsummer Night's Dream is an authentic masterpiece, and The Two Gentlemen of Verona is not. However, what I will say in the defense of this play is, firstly, the character of Launce is an excellent clown, Launce and his dog Crab. I think it's a prototype of Launcelot Gobbo in The Merchant of Venice. We've got the cross-dressing of Julia as Sebastian, which anticipates the cross-dressing of Jessica, when Jessica escapes from Shylock's, from her father's house, from Shylock's house, in The Merchant of Venice, or Rosalind's disguise of Ganymede in As You Like It.
- 6.30** The endless deception approaches, anticipates Bertram in All's Well That Ends Well. So, we've got all these little seeds that he didn't quite get right the first time, but he gets right later on, so we can forgive him. Shakespeare, of course, is going to go back to Verona, famously in Romeo and Juliet, and he's going to do the same; parental obstacles are going to be presented there. Of course, there's the plot line of a woman in love, disguised as a boy, serving the man she loves, to woo another woman. Well, that's Twelfth Night, isn't it?
- 6.31** It does feel like this was the training ground for Shakespeare's genius, a kind of forum for him to work out his ideas until he had the skill to perfect those ideas. Perhaps, without The Two Gentlemen of Verona, we wouldn't have had the later masterpieces, perhaps. And if that's the case, then the value of The Two Gentlemen of Verona is inestimable, just for that alone. But let's come back to Launce and the Crab, this dog

Crab. I actually think this is a fully realized comic creation. I think this works brilliantly well.

6.32 So in Act 4, Scene 4, for instance, we hear Launce complaining about Crab, who was sent as a gift from Proteus to Silvia. And upon entering the dining room, he jumps up on the table, he steals a chicken's leg. That's what dogs do. And we have this prose soliloquy in which Launce laments that Crab is not a proper dog who behaves in a dignified manner. And it's also weirdly touching because his affection for the dog means that he is happy to take the blame for the dog, which I find rather sweet.

6.33 He says, "If I had not more wit than he, to take a fault upon me that he did, I think verily he had been hanged for it. Sure as I live, he had suffered for it. You shall judge. He thrusts me himself into the company of three or four gentlemanlike dogs under the Duke's table. He had not been there, bless the mark, a pissing while, but all the chamber smelt him. 'Out with the dog!' says one. 'What cur is that?' says another. 'Whip him out!' says a third. 'Hang him up,' says the Duke.

6.34 I, having been acquainted with the smell before, knew it was Crab, and goes me to the fellow that whips the dogs. 'Friend,' quoth I, 'you mean to whip the dog?' 'Ay, marry, do I,' quoth he. 'You do him the more wrong,' quoth I. 'Twas I that did the thing you wot of.' He makes me no more ado, but whips me out of the chamber. How many masters would do this for his servant?"

6.35 So the reversal is complete. Launce is servant to the dog, to Crab, not the other way round. The dog has urinated under the Duke's table, and Launce is going to say that he did it, because he doesn't want them to whip the dog. It's kind of sweet. Sort of silly, but sweet. And if it's delivered well, it does really work, not just because of the comedic conceit, but also because there is a live dog on stage.

6.36 Now, I don't know if you've ever seen an animal on stage, but dogs cannot act. What you have is this—I mean, that sounds like an obvious thing to say, but the point is, you have this intervention of the real world in the theatrical world. It's a curious effect because, if you see a dog live on stage, you suddenly become aware and conscious of how the actors are acting, and the dog is just being the dog. Look, I may not be making sense, but if you see it, you'll know what I mean.

6.37 Now, a lot of critics do say that Launce and Crab are the saving graces of the play. But perhaps, perhaps, there is more to it than we suppose. Perhaps there's something we're missing. Harold Bloom, who I've mentioned before, wrote a book called *Shakespeare: The Invention of the Human*, and he urges us, as I've said, to approach Shakespeare with humility. He says this writer, this unparalleled genius, it could be that he's attempting something that we don't get, that we don't grasp, that maybe has died over time.

6.38 He says, this is what Bloom writes. "One ought never to underestimate Shakespeare, and I uneasily sense that we have yet to understand the *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, a

very experimental comedy." So what exactly is the nature of this experiment? Well, as I've said, I think it's an interrogation of this conflict between love and friendship. That startling scene of a man attempting to rape his friend's lover, and then the friend offering the rape victim to him as a token of friendship—it is undoubtedly shocking.

- 6.39** But maybe Shakespeare is trying to do something here, which I don't quite get. I know that this is about the tradition of friendship, of *amicitia*. That seems to be at the heart of this. What Shakespeare is saying is unclear, though. Maybe he's not saying anything at all. Maybe he's just experimenting. And as I said, it should be the right of an artist to experiment and fail, or maybe succeed and not be understood, which might be what's going on here.
- 6.40** This tradition of male friendship, it's everywhere at the time, where male friendship is prioritized over marriage. Even in the Bible, we learned that the love of David and Jonathan was passing the love of women. The story of Titus and Gisippus, which was a source for *The Two Gentlemen of Verona*, itself drawn from Boccaccio, from the *Decameron*, and later adapted into English by Sir Thomas Elyot in the *Book of the Governor*, that was held up as a paragon of male friendship. That's the story on which this is based. And Proteus' betrayal and Valentine's gift of Silvia to Proteus is closely mirrored in that story.
- 6.41** Now, for Elyot, Thomas Elyot, who was the translator, this story served a didactic purpose. It was about conveying the ideal of friendship. But Shakespeare isn't didactic, and I think, therefore, there's something else going on here. But what we can say is that, in both the source text and Shakespeare's play, friendship appears to triumph over love. And that's why so many critics today are so uncomfortable with it, because they're not immersed in the historical discourse that it addresses.
- 6.42** The critic, John Dover Wilson, argued that it could have been a textual corruption. Like he was saying, this scene is way too short. It's not developed, and that's why this happens. But he also says that it might be that modern critics have an inability or a refusal to view the scene through Elizabethan eyes. And I think there might be something in there.
- 6.43** What isn't clear is how Shakespeare wanted us to feel about this triumph of friendship over love. As so often in the plays, we find ourselves torn. Perhaps the discomfort that many critics feel today is part of the point. What if Shakespeare is trying to make us uncomfortable? So, rather than dismiss it as problematic, maybe he wants us to feel that there's something very wrong here. Maybe that's the reaction he's trying to elicit.
- 6.44** Now, I'll go back to this word problematic because I hate it so much. I think a good way to remedy this is, if you read—and I urge you to do it—if you haven't read Oscar Wilde's novel, his only novel, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, read the preface. When it was first published, he got a lot of flack. People said it was immoral, disgusting. It was even quoted in his trial to prove his decadence and immorality.

- 6.45 The, when it was published again, he wrote a preface explaining the role of the artist. I think every critic should read this preface. He says that—in it he says that vice and virtue are simply materials for artists. He reminds us that the depiction of immorality is not necessarily an endorsement of immorality. And even if it were, why should it matter? This is what Wilde says. "There is no such thing as a moral or an immoral book. Books are well written or badly written. That is all." That's really worth reading, the whole thing.
- 6.46 So keep this in mind when people say Shakespeare is problematic. When I hear that, I say, "So what?" If I want a sermon, I go to a church. This is drama. Now, I've said that the key plot of *The Two Gentlemen of Verona* is a first attempt of a similar but considerably better executed plot in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. And there too, Shakespeare exploits the follies of love and misdirected desire to glorious effect.
- 6.47 So let's look at *Midsummer Night's Dream* explicitly now, because we've talked about the effects of love a great deal in Shakespeare, how love in comedy is quintessential to the resolution of the plot. Remember, the hallmark of the comedies is the restoration of order after chaos. There's nothing more chaotic and irrational than love. And so, of course, the comedies are grounded in this principle.
- 6.48 The theme, therefore, is intimately connected with the structure. That's why the marriage is at the end. And this is why, as we've seen—well, actually, *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is considered a marriage play. A lot of people assume that it was written for a marriage, not just that the subject was marriage, but it was performed at a wedding. This would actually make a hell of a lot of sense.
- 6.49 But this brings us on to the broader point about structure, and it refers back to what Aaron Sorkin said about intention and obstacle, that writers need to know what their characters want, and they need to know what is preventing them from getting what they want.
- 6.50 You actually get this a lot in musical theater as well. There's a very strong convention in musical theater, if you watch any musical, you'll notice that the second or third song is always the protagonist singing about what they want. Just look at your musicals and remember that. They call it the "I want" song. It always happens, because it's the structure of a musical: someone wants something, they spend the musical getting something. Same with most drama. Intention and obstacle.
- 6.51 Now, in Shakespeare's comedies, the intention is the realization of love, and the obstacles are varied. In the case of *Love's Labour's Lost*, the obstacle is established straightaway. It's the pact that the men sign, saying they're going to be celibate for the period of their studies. In *Romeo and Juliet*, the obstacle is, of course, clear because the two lovers are from rival families. In *The Merchant of Venice*, the obstacle is a father's will, the dead father who's left this will, saying that any suitor for his daughter must first solve a riddle.

- 6.52** So there's various ways in which Shakespeare can craft an obstacle for the intention of the realization of love. In *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, he takes a different approach, doesn't he? Because the obstacle there is supernatural. We have a whole other race living concurrently with the human race. Remember, I talked about the little worlds of Shakespeare's plays. In this little world, we have not just humans, but a race of sprites and fairies, spirits, woodland creatures.
- 6.53** When Titania and Oberon, the King and Queen of the Fairies, are introduced early in the play, we learn that the quarrel between them, they're having this quarrel over an Indian boy, a changeling boy, that Oberon wants for himself. Titania refuses to relinquish the boy. And this quarrel, apparently, has already caused the weather to go bad. So straightaway, what Shakespeare is saying is that the fate of humankind is dependent on what happens in this supernatural world. They've caused a storm by arguing.
- 6.54** Human existence, therefore, is dictated by the supernatural, not in a Christian sense of predestination, a Calvinist sense, but in a pagan sense of fairy folklore. Shakespeare draws on English folkloric tradition to create his enchantment and his magic. We encounter woodland sprites, fairies of various sizes. This is an interesting development in Shakespeare's play.
- 6.55** So Titania and Oberon appear human-sized. Other fairies—you've got Mustardseed, Moth, and Cobweb, often played by children. They're clearly meant to be diminutive, tiny little things. The insinuation is that they are very small. Shakespeare implies they're tiny. He mentions that "in fear, they can creep into acorn cups." And this is interesting. This popularized the idea of fairies being small, little things that float about, like Tinkerbell in *Peter Pan*. That wasn't a thing before *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, not really. Fairies were an equivalent race to humans, more like elves in *The Lord of the Rings*.
- 6.56** We see this idea in *Romeo and Juliet* as well. Do you remember when Mercutio has his Queen Mab speech? He gives a speech about the midwife of dreams, Queen Mab. He says, "O, then, I see Queen Mab has been with you. She is the fairies' midwife, and she comes in shape no bigger than an agate-stone on the forefinger of an alderman, drawn with a team of little atomae over men's noses as they lie asleep."
- 6.57** Now, up until this point, as I say, fairy folk were considered humankind, human-sized. Look at *The Faerie Queene*, Edmund Spenser's epic. Shakespeare does something else in this play, something else that's a bit different. He enlists Robin Goodfellow. Robin Goodfellow is a figure from folklore. Shakespeare did not invent Robin Goodfellow. He was a known figure. He's the Puck, and traditionally, Robin Goodfellow is more diabolical than benevolent.
- 6.58** This distinction is important because Titania and Oberon are ultimately benevolent entities, aren't they? They wish to bless the marriages of the couples, "to give their bed

joy and prosperity," as they say. That's what Titania says in Act 2. Their fairies, remember, at the end, will sing the three married couples to bed, at the end of Act 5. Their quarrel over the Indian boy inadvertently creates chaos, but they are not malevolent. They're not trying to cause chaos in the human world.

6.59 Robin Goodfellow does create disorder through the misapplication of the love flower, but that eventually gets set right. Oberon wants it to be set right. He doesn't want to be cruel. Now, the influence of this folklore is everywhere. One of the places, when I've got a deadline, a writing deadline, I always go to the island of Sark in the Channel Islands. I'd really recommend it. It's the highest of the Channel Islands. There's only 400 people living there.

6.60 Cars are illegal. Streetlights are illegal. You can see beautifully the stars at night because there's no light pollution. You don't hear cars driving around because there are no cars. It's an incredible place. There's one place, there's a precipice called Tintagel, where I go to sit. There's a rock that is naturally shaped like a seat, and I sit there with my laptop, and I write, and no soul ever bothers me.

6.61 But the reason I'm mentioning this is because, on Sark, there is a tradition of these creatures called the Pouquelayes, headless creatures, detachable heads. They could take their heads on and off. You actually see on Sark, some of the old cottages have little ledges on the chimneys because there was a tradition that witches would rest on the ledges rather than go down the chimney and bother you. So this is a place steeped in folklore.

6.62 You can sense the fairies on Sark, and the Pouquelayes, I've heard about them a number of times. I think the last sighting was by a fisherman in the early 1900s. I haven't seen them. But that word Pouquelayes, clearly, etymologically, comes from Puck. And lots of different languages and different traditions have variations on that word Puck to mean mischievous, diabolical goblin. Robin Goodfellow is a puck. We often call him Puck, don't we? He's known as Puck. He's actually the Puck. He's Robin Goodfellow, the Puck, because a puck is a race, not a name.

6.63 There's actually an early illustration of Robin Goodfellow, the earliest one. This is from 1628, and it's on the title page of a small book called Robin Goodfellow: His Mad Pranks and Merry Jests. If you look at that, you'll see what I mean about his essential diabolism, because he has a caprine quality. He's more like a faun. He's got horns, pointed ears, goat's legs. He's got an erect phallus to emphasize his sexual licentiousness, his lusty and unruly nature, which was a common feature of fauns in classical antiquity.

6.64 There's a very famous statue, which was unearthed at Pompeii, of a faun copulating with a goat, with its erect phallus. It's very odd, I know. But you get this idea of the faun, the mischievous thing, being demonic, but also sexually aggressive. It's interesting to see Robin Goodfellow in that way because we think of him as the Puck from

Shakespeare. But what I'm saying is that Shakespeare has changed what Robin Goodfellow meant. Again, it's that thing of, he has to innovate, he has to change.

- 6.65** Robin Goodfellow is not just a puck; he's with the fairies, he's on their team. When we first encounter him, a fairy recognizes him. He's a bit of a celebrity in the woods. He asks if he is that puck known as Robin Goodfellow, and he replies, "I am a merry wanderer of the night. I jest to Oberon and make him smile when I a fat and bean-fed horse beguile, neighing in likeness of a filly foal." So he's a merry-maker. He's a shapeshifter.
- 6.66** "And sometime, lurk I in a gossip's bowl, in very likeness of a roasted crab. And when she drinks, against her lips I bob, and on her withered dewlap pour the ale. The wisest aunt, telling the saddest tale, sometime for three-foot-stool mistaketh me." You see, he can change his size as well as his shape. He can be whatever he wants, a three-foot stool. "Then slip I from her bum, down topples she, and 'tailor' cries, and falls into a cough. And then the whole quire hold their hips and laugh, and waxen in their mirth and neeze and swear a merrier hour was never wasted there."
- 6.67** So his role is mischief, not malice. And this is a significant deviation from traditional representations at the time. And of course, his service to Oberon draws him firmly into the fairy kingdom. Remember the moment I quoted in a previous lecture from Comedy of Errors, Act 2, Scene 2? Dromio of Syracuse describes what these fairies are all about, and it's far more traditional.
- 6.68** "This is the fairy land." He's talking about Ephesus. "This is the fairy land. O spite of spites! We talk with goblins, owls, and sprites. If we obey them not, this will ensue. They'll suck our breath or pinch us black and blue." Mischief, then. Remember what the children dressed as fairies do to Falstaff in the woods at the end of Merry Wives of Windsor, pinching him black and blue? See, for malice, you need to go to the witchcraft of Macbeth, of course. The witches in Macbeth have wrenched a thumb from the dead body of a shipwrecked sailor.
- 6.69** But in A Midsummer Night's Dream, Robin Goodfellow—no, he's one with the fairies; he's not ripping people's thumbs off. He's dashing around the globe at the speed of light. He's changing his shape. He's turning into a stool, so the old woman falls over. He's doing whatever he wants. He's a kind of prototype for Ariel in The Tempest, with Prospero fulfilling Oberon's role, although Ariel takes himself far more seriously than Robin ever does.
- 6.70** Now, let's discuss structure. I think this is absolutely key. The fusion of structure and theme is in the resolution of conflict in Shakespearean comedy. I think, in this case, it reveals a particular—there's a sophisticated architecture here, because you have the core plot revolving around four lovers. You've got Lysander and Hermia are the standard lovers. They want to get married. The conflict arises because their father, her father, rather, does not wish her to marry Lysander. He wants her to marry Demetrius.

- 6.71** The Athenian law at the time says she has to comply with her father's wishes. If she doesn't, she's going to be put to death, or she has to choose a life of celibacy. So they elope. And the further conflict emerges because, of course, Demetrius loves Hermia, but not Helena, and Helena desperately loves him. So we have this love triangle, unrequited love. So the conflicts are set up. The conflicts are clear.
- 6.72** So the intervention of the fairy world creates further troubles. That's what it does, in an attempt to resolve the—remember what I said about the fairy world, Oberon being benevolent? He wants to resolve this problem of Helena and Lysander being in love with each other— sorry, Hermia and Lysander being in love with each other, and Helena loving Lysander. This is never going to work; it has to be resolved.
- 6.73** Oberon wants to see Demetrius fall in love with Helena. But because he describes how Demetrius is going to be dressed like an Athenian, and Puck gets it wrong, he mistakes the one man for the other, and then the chaos amplifies. He puts the love juice from the flower into the wrong eye. And additionally, you've got the resolution of the quarrel between Oberon and Titania, which uses the same mechanism of the love potion, the love flower, which is just a bit of petty revenge, really, because of this Indian boy conflict that they had.
- 6.74** What she's going to do when Puck puts the love juice in her eye, she's going to fall in love with the next creature she sees. Puck's transformative abilities then means that he can turn Bottom, the weaver, into a man with a donkey's head. That is who she's going to fall in love with. Right. Now, this all feels like fun and games. But again, as often with Shakespeare, the secondary plot echoes the first plot. OK? This happens all the time.
- 6.75** We have the same situation as we did with King Lear, where you've got the second plot mirroring the first, but this time we're playing it for laughs. So this notion of misdirected desire is played out twice, and it goes as far as it can, I think, in Titania's desire for a man with the ass's head, because that becomes a spectacle of bestiality. It's about as far as it can go.
- 6.76** Now, the figure of Bottom and the Mechanicals is really structurally significant as well. They're called mechanicals because they have menial jobs. Mechanicals were tradesmen. They're working-class folk. They speak in prose, of course. The lovers are contrasted by speaking in verse. So you can hear it. It's almost, again, it's like a different dialect. The lovers, generally speaking, rhyme in couplets until, that is, they are attempting to mimic the poetry of love in their performance of the tragedy of Pyramus and Thisbe.
- 6.77** Peter Quince is the carpenter because quince sounds like coin or quoine, which was a wedge-shaped block used in building. All of their names are jokes. Nick Bottom is a weaver because the bottom was the spool that you thread the thread around in weaving. Then you've got the Flute. Flute is a bellows-mender. I think you can work that one out for yourself. It's got a nozzle resembling a flute. You've then got Robin

Starveling, who's the tailor, because there was a tradition at the time that tailors were weak and gaunt, and they starved themselves.

6.78 Snug is a joiner. That makes sense because the pieces of wood join together snugly. Snout is a tinker, so he's one who mends pots and kettles. A snout is the equivalent of a spout, basically. Anyway, you've got these menials, these are the Mechanicals, and they're going to put on a play for the wedding, for Theseus' wedding. It's going to be the play of Pyramus and Thisbe, the tragedy, to celebrate the marriage of Theseus and Hippolyta.

6.79 But what happens? Shakespeare implicates them in the main plot. So he's got this secondary subplot, and he implicates the subplot into the main plot because he has them rehearse in the woods. Puck, or Robin Goodfellow, sees them and senses an opportunity. Bottom the weaver, therefore, becomes implicated in a love plot that mirrors the misdirection between Lysander and Hermia.

6.80 We fall in love with Bottom before Titania does. He's such a lovable character. He's so likable. He is vain, but it's that kind of harmless vanity of the endearing kind. He wants to play all the roles. When they're rehearsing for Pyramus and Thisbe, he wants to play Pyramus because it's the hero. He also wants to play Thisbe. Oh, and he wants to play the lion, and he demonstrates the roar. So it's quite endearing. Quince is worried. He says, "You're going to frighten the ladies if you roar." So he says he'll roar "as gently as any sucking dove."

6.81 So how can we not warm to this? The character of Bottom is a kind of anchor to the play. Even when he's transformed, even when he becomes the donkey or has the head of a donkey, he's still identifiably Bottom and speaks like Bottom. He speaks to the fairies with the same good-natured, down-to-earth manner that he does to everyone else. "I shall desire you have more acquaintance, good master Cobweb," he says. He's the everyman. He's our representative in the madness of this dream.

6.82 The reality of these various entanglements between the lovers proves no more or less absurd than the drama of Pyramus and Thisbe. So the lovers now arranged not in a love triangle, but a love square or a love parallelogram, if you like, they've been positioned, they sit and laugh when they see the play. It's all been resolved, and they sit, and they watch Pyramus and Thisbe, and they laugh at how bad the acting is.

6.83 The theatrics of the misdirected love in the Mechanicals' play, the final performance, becomes a commentary on the momentary madness that we witnessed from the lovers earlier in the play. So let's return to this. Let's return to the deranging effects of love. Now, in this play, as I said, they have a supernatural origin. And in that sense, *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is closer to a pagan worldview than a Christian worldview.

6.84 In the polytheistic context of ancient Greece and Rome, we know that the gods can be like Puck. They can be Puck-like figures. They intervene in human affairs. They often seek to settle petty disputes among the mortals, or they fancy the mortals and sleep

with them. They're pretty petty, aren't they? You only need to read Ovid's *Metamorphoses* to understand that, which is a text that Shakespeare knew very, very well. It would have been one of his grammar school texts.

- 6.85** The caprice of the ancient gods sort of makes sense of the world. One of the great debates within Christianity is: How do we reconcile an unjust world with all these natural disasters and horrible things happening with a benevolent God? You don't have that problem in the ancient world because the gods weren't benevolent. They were horrible and mischievous and selfish and capricious and all the rest of it.
- 6.86** Now, the flower in *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is called love-in-idleness. That's a phrase which immediately conjures the notion of irrationality, irrepressible desire. An Elizabethan audience would have got this straightaway. They would have grasped the connotation. The phrase love-in-idleness has this overtone. And in fact, this is made explicit in *The Taming of the Shrew*, because look at what Tranio says of Lucentio. This is in Act 1, Scene 1.
- 6.87** Tranio says, "I pray, sir, tell me, is it possible that love should of a sudden take hold?" Is it possible that love at first sight is a thing? Lucentio says, "O Tranio, till I found it to be true, I never thought it possible or likely. But see, while idly I stood, looking on, I found the effect of love in idleness. And now in plainness do confess to thee, that art to me as secret and as dear as Anna to the Queen of Carthage was. Tranio, I burn, I pine, I perish, Tranio." So idleness seems to be a precondition of this obsessive love.
- 6.88** And what does Claudio say? In *Much Ado About Nothing*, about his love for Hero, he says, "When you went onward on this ended action, I looked upon her with a soldier's eye, that liked, but had a rougher task in hand than to drive liking to the name of love." He was too busy being a soldier to think of love. He couldn't love her. His attentions were focused on the war, but it's in leisure, in idleness, that love can flourish.
- 6.89** Is this not the reason for the downfall of Antony? His love for Cleopatra is inappropriate because he's at war. His warlike qualities diminish because of Cleopatra. He can't lead an army anymore. So I'm saying that, by making love a product of supernatural intervention in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, I suppose what it does is, it explains the sheer lunacy of love, doesn't it?
- 6.90** I use that word lunacy deliberately, not just because of its connection to the moon and the belief that the movement of the moon created hysteria and madness—and the moon is involved in the genesis of this magical flower. This is told us directly. Oberon says, Oberon says in Act 2, "Flying between the cold moon and the Earth, Cupid all armed, a certain aim he took at a fair vestal, throned by the West." The fair vestal, by the way, is always Queen Elizabeth I, always.
- 6.91** Whenever you hear about Cynthia or the moon or Diana or the celestial goddess, at this time, it's always Queen Elizabeth I or at the very least, it's a very likely reference. So Cupid, Oberon is describing Cupid, "loosed his love shaft smartly from his bow, as it

should pierce a hundred thousand hearts. But I might see young Cupid's fiery shaft quenched in the chaste beams of the watery moon, and the imperial votaress passed on, in maiden meditation, fancy-free."

6.92 What did Elizabeth do? She rejected all suitors. Cupid's arrow had no power over her. She remained the Virgin Queen. I think this is quite bold of Shakespeare to allude to this. Well, she retained her power by not getting married. It's as simple as that. So much so that she was able to "quench Cupid's arrow," to take away the power of Cupid. This is what happened then.

6.93 "Yet marked I where the bolt of Cupid fell." I saw where it fell. So Cupid has fired his bolt, but the determined chastity of the Queen has deflected it, and it's fallen onto a flower. He says, "It fell upon a little western flower, before milk-white, now purple with love's wound, and maidens call it love-in-idleness. Fetch me that flower, the herb I showed thee once; the juice of it, on sleeping eyelids laid, will make or man or woman madly dote upon the next live creature that it sees."

6.94 And there's the conceit. So, the juice from this flower, once it's been applied to the eyes, whatever you see next, you're going to fall in love with. And that's the kind of etiology of the potion. It's a condensed form of the power of Cupid's arrow in a flower. And Cupid, of course, as I've said, is blind because love hits where it hits. It's arbitrary. We don't choose. We are chosen. And this is Helena in Act 1, Scene 1. She says, "Love looks not with the eyes, but with the mind; and therefore is winged Cupid painted blind."

6.95 There's a poem from 1594 by Richard Barnfield, that pastoral poet that I mentioned, and it's called The Affectionate Shepherd. And in this poem, he has Cupid and Death get drunk together, fall asleep, and accidentally swap their arrows. So basically, when Death goes out to kill an old man, to take the soul of the old man, he shoots him with Cupid's arrow instead. And so you get the comedy of an old man falling in love with this beautiful young shepherdess.

6.96 And of course, that's the point. When it comes to love, we simply have no choice at all. And A Midsummer Night's Dream dramatizes that sense of irrationality and confusion by attributing it to the supernatural, and in particular, the follies and mistakes of the fairies and the sprites. The question of the nature of love is one that we keep returning to, and for good reason.

6.97 Theseus explains love's irrational nature in Act 5 in a passage that I quoted in a previous lecture. He described, "The lunatic, the lover, and the poet are of imagination all compact." They are all connected. This is a common theme: when we are struck by love, struck by Cupid's arrow, we are, I suppose, bonkers. We lose our minds, we lose our rationality. So, when Lysander is under the influence of Cupid via the love-in-idleness flower, he doesn't just love.

- 6.98** It's not that he falls out of love with Hermia and falls into love with Helena; it's that he now hates Hermia. He's gone from one extreme to the other. And in the midst of this utter confusion, we have this rather touching moment. Hermia says, "Hate me? Wherefore? O me! What news, my love! Am I not Hermia? Are you not Lysander? I am as fair now as I was erewhile. Since night you loved me, yet since night you left me. Why, then you left me—O, the gods forbid!—in earnest, shall I say?"
- 6.99** And Lysander says, "Ay, by my life, and never did desire to see thee more. Therefore be out of hope, of question, of doubt; be certain, nothing truer. 'Tis no jest that I do hate thee and love Helena." And the confusion is rife, isn't it? Lysander's love for Hermia has turned to hate. Demetrius's hate for Helena has turned to love. Helena, in turn, assumes this is some elaborate joke, so she scorns Demetrius, Lysander, and Hermia.
- 6.100** Hermia is furious with Helena for stealing the affections of Lysander, and so says that, although she is short, she's not so short that she can't scratch out her eyes. She says, "I'm not yet so low but that my nails can reach unto thine eyes." So you can imagine all these people grappling with each other. And on stage, it's very, very funny. It's also very cruel, but it is farcical. So we're back in the territory of the Comedy of Errors. But instead of mistaken identities, we have the intoxicating effects of love via the supernatural.
- 6.101** And so, when Oberon commands Puck to resolve the matter, to use the juice from the other flower, from Diane's bud as an antidote, well, they leave Demetrius alone, don't they? Demetrius retains the effects of the love-in-idleness potion and persists in his love for Helena. Why? Because this resolves the matter. It's because, at the start, we had this problem in the plot, didn't we, of Demetrius not loving the right woman. Well, now it's resolved. And for the purposes of the plot, I guess, it doesn't really matter which woman he loves.
- 6.102** Puck says it, doesn't he? "Jack shall have Jill, nought shall go ill." It doesn't matter who marries whom as long as everyone gets married and it's all fine, that the love parallelogram is resolved into a square, and everyone's content. And that's where we get to at the end. And then they watch the Mechanicals' play; and as I've said, they scoff at it, they laugh at it, they think it's ridiculous, and they don't realize that what they're watching is their own experiences theatricalized, because what they did, and what we just saw them do, was no less farcical than what the Mechanicals are doing as Pyramus and Thisbe.
- 6.103** Isn't the story the same? I mean, wasn't Pyramus and Thisbe the story of lovers who are forbidden to marry by their parents, and so they run away to the forest by night and are thwarted in their love? It's exactly the same. The two couples don't see it because now they're in their happy state. Their scenario resolved itself before it could become tragic, before they had the fate of Pyramus and Thisbe with the lion. So now they're at liberty.

- 6.104** They can sit, they can watch, they can provide sardonic commentary on the performance of Bottom and Snug and Snout and Flute and Starveling and Peter Quince, who are very bad actors, of course, and it's a lot of fun to watch them put on a serious play. It's one of those scenes that still is very funny, I imagine as funny as it was in the Elizabethan era.
- 6.105** So, what do we make of this play? Well, the play is called *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. So are we to take the entire play as if it were a dream? I suppose it would make sense of it. And Puck certainly seems to think so. It's at the very end of the play; we have this very interesting moment, don't we, where Puck or Robin Goodfellow steps forward and tells us to treat it as such: like a dream, if we weren't pleased.
- 6.106** Now, this is an interesting conceit. You may know that, at the end of every Shakespeare production, they would have had a jig. Even the tragedies, they'd have a jig, they'd have a dance. And in *As You Like It*, after the jig, the boy who played Rosalind steps forward and speaks as the boy actor. It's a very interesting moment, this breaking of the fourth wall.
- 6.107** So after the jig, if you can imagine, the boy steps forward and says to the audience—this is *As You Like It*, by the way, I'm going back to *As You Like It*, just to make this point—Rosalind, the boy playing Rosalind, steps forward and says, "I charge you, O women, for the love you bear to men, to like as much of this play as please you; and I charge you, O men, for the love you bear to women— as I perceive by your simpering, none of you hates them—that between you and the women the play may please."
- 6.108** "If I were a woman"—that's an incredible statement. He's just been playing a woman the whole time. Now it's all broken. We're back to the actor. "If I were a woman, I would kiss as many of you as had beards that pleased me, complexions that liked me, and breaths that I defied not." I would kiss all the men in this room—it's an incredible thing to say. "And I am sure, as many as have good beards or good faces or sweet breaths, will, for my kind offer, when I make curtsy, bid me farewell."
- 6.109** So it's a really lovely moment. Even now, when the boy behind Rosalind is speaking for himself, he's still teasing gender roles. If he were a woman, he would kiss the men. But we've just observed him playing a woman who does precisely that. They had on-stage kisses all the time. This is one of the reasons the Puritans hated it, because you saw men kissing each other. They had to have done it. You can't imagine *Romeo and Juliet* without the kisses. It wouldn't make sense.
- 6.110** And this, therefore, is a teasing epilogue that reminds us of the essential theatricality of the piece, and that, in order to enjoy these plays, we have to invest ourselves in the temporary reality that we see. Compare that to the prologue of *Troilus and Cressida*, in which the speaker dressed in armor steps forward and shows complete indifference to the audience. He steps forward, and he says, "Like or find fault; do as your pleasures are."

- 6.111** It's so bold, it's so perfect. It sets the tone for Troilus and Cressida, which is such a satirical and poisonous reimagining of the Trojan War. "Like or find fault; do as your pleasures are." I don't care if you don't like the play. Imagine saying that at the start of the play. You couldn't have a line like that in any other play but Troilus and Cressida. Perfect. Anyway.
- 6.112** But let's hear what Puck has to say to the audience. I love these moments where there's a fourth wall being broken. It's really interesting. And this is what Puck says. At the end of the play, this is the epilogue.
- 6.113** "If we shadows have offended, think but this, and all is mended, that you have but slumbered here while these visions did appear. And this weak and idle theme, no more yielding but a dream. Gentles, do not reprehend. If you pardon, we will mend. And as I am an honest Puck, if we have unearned luck, now to 'scape the serpent's tongue, we will make amends ere long; else the puck a liar call. So, good night unto you all. Give me your hands, if we be friends, and Robin shall restore amends."
- 6.114** It's perfectly pitched. The fourth wall is broken. The puck reaches out from fairyland to the world of humans and offers peace, and we applaud. Because what's the point of this fantasy, if we don't allow ourselves to be complicit?

Lecture 7: The Merchant of Venice

At a glance — The Merchant of Venice.

- 7.1 We'll begin at the beginning. A Jewish merchant is sitting in his countinghouse, surrounded by piles of gold. In a soliloquy, he boasts about all of his wealth. He wallows in his luxury. He expresses how he is eagerly awaiting the return of his cargo. Later in the play, he will lie, he will betray, he will murder Christians, including two friars. He will poison an entire convent full of nuns.
- 7.2 Now, if it's an anti-Semitic stereotype that you're looking for, this is definitely it. But this is not Shylock, Shakespeare's Jewish villain in *The Merchant of Venice*. This is Barabas, from Christopher Marlowe's play, *The Jew of Malta*. This was a play that was written a few years before Shakespeare's *Merchant of Venice*. And Marlowe, of course, was a direct contemporary of Shakespeare.
- 7.3 He was born just a month before Shakespeare was born. He was very, very popular on the London stage by the time that Shakespeare arrived in London—or he was getting very popular at that point. So he was a step ahead. He achieved success far quicker. He was at the university. He had contacts. He had a more privileged background, and of course, Shakespeare was a new arrival on the scene.
- 7.4 And it's often the case, as I mentioned before, that Shakespeare is often writing in response to Marlowe. He obviously respected him very, very deeply. His first tragedy, *Titus Andronicus*, is very Marlovian. It has a lot of the qualities that Marlowe had. Marlowe loved the spectacle of violence and the spectacle of tragedy. He had his plays.
- 7.5 He had two plays, *Tamburlaine Part One* and *Tamburlaine Part Two*, about this marauding conqueror, who would capture kings and force them to ride as though they were horses and all sorts of very gruesome. He kills his own son at one point. It's very, very extreme. One of the kings who is locked in a cage dashes his own brains out against the bars of the cage. Marlowe loved the spectacle of blood and gore and villainy, and he really reveled in it.
- 7.6 Now, Shakespeare, of course, didn't do characters that were that two-dimensional. But early in his career, he's certainly borrowing from that. If you look at *Titus Andronicus*, the villain in that, really, well, one of the villains is Aaron the Moor, who is very like a Marlovian character. He's a sadist. His only goal in life is to commit as many atrocities as possible.
- 7.7 He's very self-amused, and a lot of Marlowe's villains find their villainy funny and enjoyable, a bit like Richard III does; so there's an element of Marlowe in Richard III as well. Now, I've already mentioned, when we were talking about *As You Like It*, you'll remember that I mentioned that a line from Marlowe is explicitly quoted by

Shakespeare in that, "Whoever loved that loved not at first sight?" He calls him the dead shepherd.

7.8 But I just want to alert you to another moment in *As You Like It*, which could well be an allusion to Marlowe. This is Act 3, Scene 3. Touchstone says, "When a man's verses cannot be understood, nor a man's good wit seconded with the forward child, understanding, it strikes a man more dead than a great reckoning in a little room." And Marlowe had indeed been struck dead in a little room in Deptford in May 1593 over the reckoning.

7.9 The reckoning was the bill, or that was the story that was going about at the time anyway. It was some sort of quarrel. Probably was. Marlowe was a spy for Walsingham. He was a spy for the government, and the man who killed him was also connected to Walsingham's spy network. It might very well have been a hit job, but we absolutely do not know. Nevertheless, Marlowe dead, 1593, and left the space clear for Shakespeare to ascend.

7.10 Actually, I think, if Marlowe hadn't died, who knows what Marlowe would have achieved later in life? Maybe he would have been the bard. Who knows? I actually doubt that, but you never know. But it is no great stretch to suppose that *The Merchant of Venice* was written as a direct response to Marlowe's *The Jew of Malta*, because *The Jew of Malta* was hugely popular.

7.11 It's very likely that—Marlowe was associated with the Admiral's Men, the theater company, the Admiral's Men, Shakespeare with the Lord Chamberlain's Men. It might well have been that the Lord Chamberlain's Men saw this and thought, "Oh, this is a huge success. Let's fill that void. Let's write something that caters to the same tastes." But of course, Shakespeare, being Shakespeare, didn't write something quite so pantomimic, quite so simplistic. He went many, many steps further with his play.

7.12 Of course, he did have an avaricious Jewish figure as a main part in the play, but he does a lot, lot more with it. Now, I'm going to be a bit careful here because it is, of course, entirely understandable to interpret *The Merchant of Venice* as an anti-Semitic play, Shakespeare's play as being anti-Semitic. It has certainly been interpreted that way in the past. It's been used that way. The Nazis staged *The Merchant of Venice* as part of their propaganda, their anti-Jewish propaganda.

7.13 But I think, when we talk about this, it's very important, as with all of Shakespeare's plays, to contextualize this historically. The play was conceived in a completely different age, in completely different circumstances. The world had not been changed by the Holocaust, of course; that's a major aspect. But in addition to that, Jewish people were unknown in London. Shakespeare would not have known Jewish people. The audience members would not have known Jewish people.

7.14 So, to give you this background, Jews in England were deported in 1290. I think it's the only European country to do this. And they were readmitted after Shakespeare's death,

1656. In the interim years, the only Jewish people that were allowed to be in the country were those who had converted to Christianity. There was a home in London called the Domus Conversorum, where converted Jews—Jews who had become Christian— were allowed to live. That was established by Henry III.

- 7.15** And I should say that, when *The Jew of Malta*, Marlowe's play, and then *The Merchant of Venice* were composed, there was a resurgence of anti-Semitic feeling in London because there had been an assassination attempt against Elizabeth I. And the man who was found to be guilty of that and blamed—well, we can't be 100% certain that he did it, but he might have done—was her physician, Roderigo Lopez.
- 7.16** Lopez was a Portuguese man of Jewish heritage. He wasn't a practicing Jew. He was converted to Christianity, but he nonetheless was executed for treason. Very brutally, of course. The executions at this time were public and brutal. People were hung, drawn, and quartered, had their entrails pulled out. It was a horrific display. But it's an important historical moment to note, 1594. It's only a few years later that *The Merchant of Venice* comes out. It's not difficult to connect the dots.
- 7.17** In fact, there's a possible reference to Lopez, or at least an allusion to Lopez, in *The Merchant of Venice*. This happens in Act 4, Scene 1, when Gratiano is berating Shylock in the famous court scene, and Shylock is whetting his knife. He wants his pound of flesh. He's going to cut his pound of flesh out of Antonio. And Gratiano mentions the theory of Pythagoras, the theory I'm quoting here, "that souls of animals infuse themselves into the trunks of men."
- 7.18** And he says to Shylock, "Thy currish"—doglike—"thy currish spirit governed a wolf, who hanged for human slaughter. Even from the gallows did his fell soul fleet; and whilst thou layest in thy unhallowed dam, infused itself in thee. For thy desires"—he's saying to Shylock—"are wolfish, bloody, starved, and ravenous."
- 7.19** Which makes sense well enough, apart from what is this wolf that was hanged for human slaughter? That's never happened. No one's ever hanged a wolf for trying to kill someone. But of course, they're talking about Lopez, which comes from the Latin *lupus*, which means wolf. This is a likely reference, not 100%, but very likely.
- 7.20** Now, let's contextualize anti-Semitism at the time. There were unpleasant myths about Jews have been abounding throughout history. This is the ancient prejudice, isn't it? This is the one that recurs. It was believed that the poisoning of wells by Jewish people had initiated the Black Death epidemic in 1348. This is why Marlowe's Barabas boasts, "Sometimes I go about and poison wells." Marlowe is tapping directly into the anti-Semitic trope.
- 7.21** The 17th-century preacher Thomas Calvert believed that Jewish men menstruated and that they needed to murder Christian babies to replenish the blood that they had lost through menstruation. There was a pamphlet in 1656 by William Prynne, who was this

firebrand Puritan, a polemicist, and he was writing about the prospect of readmission. There were debates about: Do we readmit Jews to the country?

- 7.22** And he wrote this. He wrote, "The Jews, almost every year, crucify one child to the injury and contumely of Christ." That's what was believed. So when the Nazis stage a play about a villainous Jew, they are amplifying an already widespread and toxic prejudice amongst the population. When Shakespeare casts a Jewish man as his villain, that is in the context of an audience who don't know any Jews, who are not inclined to go out in mobs and attack Jews, as the Germans are in Nazi Germany did, Kristallnacht, et cetera.
- 7.23** It's more like a bogeyman figure in Elizabethan England. It's untethered to reality. He does definitely draw on anti-Semitic tropes; of that, there's no doubt at all. But like I said, we need to be able to put this play into its historical context. Once again, I would urge you to resist the temptation to assume that we knew anything about Shakespeare's mindset or beliefs, because we simply don't.
- 7.24** One other point I really need to emphasize is that Shylock is an altogether more fascinating and fully rounded human character than Barabas. Barabas is a two-dimensional, cackling villain. Shylock is a human being. In Shylock's mouth, Shakespeare put some of his most moving poetry, because Shakespeare is always, as I've said, able to see the world from multiple angles, see it through many, many eyes.
- 7.25** And this is why I think it's such an ambiguous play. I think this is why there's so many debates about: Is it anti-Semitic? Is it not? Even Jewish critics are divided on this. Harold Bloom, who was a Jewish critic, thought it definitely was anti-Semitic, but he still thought the play was a masterpiece. Paul Cantor, who's another Jewish critic, says it isn't an anti-Semitic play, and he points out, actually, that Jewish people have embraced this play over the centuries as being a positive representation.
- 7.26** He says that many Jewish actors and directors have performed it. It was translated into Yiddish in the 1890s. Cantor says this—I'm going to quote Cantor directly. He says, "For several centuries, Shylock remained the most sympathetic portrait of a Jewish character by a non-Jewish writer. You really have to get to a play like Lessing's Nathan the Wise in the 18th century to get anything comparable."
- 7.27** This is also why the play can be performed as entirely philo-Semitic. The most recent production which I saw is in London. It was in London. It was a production in the West End, starring Tracy-Ann Oberman, and she was playing a female Shylock. She was utterly brilliant, completely captivating. But what they had done in that production is relocate the play to 1930s London, around the time of the Battle of Cable Street, when Oswald Mosley's Union of Fascists were marching through the East End of London, and local people came out to resist them, because this was a largely Jewish area.
- 7.28** Her production—well, she didn't direct it, but she's the star—relocated it to this time in British history. And the Christian characters, Antonio, Bassanio, and the others, are

Blackshirts. They are dressed—they have black shirts. They are the fascists. The Christian characters are the fascists, and our sympathies lie completely with those in the Jewish ghetto, and Shylock in particular.

- 7.29** And I think it really says something about Shakespeare's play, that it could be staged in this way, that you can play it as though Shylock is the— I don't want to say hero, but the one that we warm towards the most. That was done without losing any fidelity to the text. I mean, as always, there are a few trims here and there, but it's there in the text if you want it to be that. You can play it both ways.
- 7.30** What extraordinary complexity the play must have, if Shylock, the villain of the piece, can be reframed as the hero without radically altering the dialogue. That, to me, tells you everything about the moral ambiguity that Shakespeare is interested in. Like I say, Shakespeare, even if you have a cursory familiarity with Shakespeare, you know that he's not going to be interested in these caricatures, these villainous stereotypes. He knows that human beings don't fall into stereotypes.
- 7.31** Ben Jonson, his great rival, liked creating comic villains. Shakespeare doesn't create comic villains, villains that you laugh at. I think the closest he comes to it is Aaron in Titus Andronicus and Richard III. But even Richard III—those things are complicated. Aaron in Titus Andronicus even begins to feel some kind of fatherly affection for his newborn baby, which undercuts the bluntness of the villainy that is being represented.
- 7.32** Likewise, in Richard III, once he's having his dream about his victims, and he's reflecting on himself, he starts out as a self-amused villain. It becomes more complex towards the end. So, even in those early attempts at portraying villainy, he's interested in complexity. And by the time you get to Iago, I mean, Iago is the most three-dimensional, mysterious—a character we still don't really understand or grasp because he's so endlessly fascinating.
- 7.33** That is the ultimate portrayal of villainy in literature, I believe. I've never read anything like it. But there's also Edmund in King Lear, or Macbeth and Lady Macbeth, of course. These are complex human villains. Something that Shakespeare is interested in is this idea that evil isn't something that you are; it is something that you do. The idea that—I mean, Macbeth is a hero, is a wonderful man, a good man. Lady Macbeth and Macbeth have a strong, happy marriage.
- 7.34** Part of the disturbing element of that play is that you watch him do this. You watch him do the thing he knows is wrong, but doing it anyway, propelled by something. Ambition, yes, but also fortune, fate. The witches say he's going to do it. It makes you think, doesn't it? Could I have done the same? It's a very interesting thing to watch. Now, that's not Richard III. We don't stand there like Richard III and cackle and articulate our evil schemes and laugh about it. That's what a pantomime villain does. But Macbeth, not so much.

- 7.35 Now, *The Merchant of Venice*, the main theme, I would say, of *The Merchant of Venice* is the differences between appearance and reality. Of course, often in Shakespeare's plays, when song is used, it's normally commenting thematically on something broad about the play. Of course, the main aspect of *The Merchant of Venice* is the main plot, which is about Portia's three caskets in Belmont. And of course, as we know, Bassanio is in love with Portia. He borrows money from Antonio so that he can pursue his suit with Portia in Belmont.
- 7.36 Unfortunately, Antonio has to borrow from Shylock, and that's where the subplot comes in. Shylock says, "I'll lend you the money, but if you fail to pay me back, I get to cut a pound of flesh from your body," which is a very cruel and vicious bond. But that is how the two plots intersect. And of course, Portia is a bit of a slave to her dead father. Her dead father has written this will and said that Portia can only marry if the suitor picks the right casket, one of the three caskets.
- 7.37 We're going to get onto that later in the lecture, because that notion of appearance versus reality is completely tied up in that main plot about the caskets, but also in addition to Shylock. Shylock is actually a relatively minor character. If you think about it, he only has around 80 lines in the whole play. And yet, isn't that interesting that you come away thinking about him? He's not in the final act at all.
- 7.38 In fact, I think structurally, Shakespeare needs that final act. We need that final act because we need to forget about him. We need to forget about the treatment of him. That forced conversion at the end of Act 4 is very uncomfortable to watch. We also have to forget about Shylock's cruelty. Shylock whetting the knife, his spite, his demand for a pound of flesh. The final act, in a way, reminds us that this is a comedy, and pulls us back to it.
- 7.39 But it is an experimental comedy. As with most of Shakespeare's comedies, he's experimenting with the form, with the genre, and he needs that final act here to steer us away from the tragic. And yet, it is Shylock's fate, as I say, that forced conversion to Christianity lingers with us. I think to read the play as some kind of morality tale against the evil of Jews, I think that is a serious misreading. And yet, I also think it's an understandable misreading, because there are inevitably heightened sensitivities about this topic.
- 7.40 Let's think about appearance and reality. That's the thing I want to fuse into your mind, appearance and reality. When you read back the play, keep that in mind. "All that glisters is not gold." That's on the scroll inside the golden casket, which is wrongly chosen by the Prince of Morocco. Maybe Shylock is doomed because he cannot conceal his true nature. Maybe that's the point. He is a Jewish man who is avaricious, who is cruel, who is vengeful, who is so detestable, in fact, that his daughter, Jessica, is going to flee the house.

- 7.41 So on the surface, that's all straightforward. But hang on a minute. Aren't the qualities that the state seeks to punish in Shylock exactly the qualities that the state embodies itself? Remember that lending at interest, usury, is anti-Christian. In medieval England, under Catholic doctrine, all lending at interest was forbidden. Usury is a sin. Shylock is a usurer.
- 7.42 Now, let's talk a bit about usury. It's a very important way that Shakespeare digs into the hypocrisy of the Christian world of the play. There's a lovely little town in Italy called San Gimignano. It's in Tuscany. You will recognize it immediately. As you approach, you see these very tall towers, this medieval—it's become a bit of a tourist trap. But I've been there a couple of times when it's empty because I've gone in winter or whenever. It's really worth seeing.
- 7.43 If you go into the church in San Gimignano, there are these astonishing frescoes of hell, in the church, by Taddeo di Bartolo, and these were painted in the late 14th century. It's very elaborate, as with all of these frescoes of hell, very elaborate, very fantastical. But what this does is it depicts the sinners in hell being punished according to their crimes.
- 7.44 For instance, the gluttons are depicted around a dinner table with food, and they have these hairy, muscular demons pressing their heads into the food for all eternity. During their lifetime, they were gluttons, and so in hell, they're going to have to keep eating. There's actually a Homer Simpson joke, in *The Simpsons*, where that actually happens. Homer is in hell, and a demon says, "Oh, you like donuts, do you? You're a glutton. Have all the donuts in the world." And there's some machine that's feeding him donuts endlessly.
- 7.45 But unfortunately for the demons in hell, he loves it, and he can't get enough. That's the joke. But that joke in *The Simpsons* is actually something that is based on this medieval talionic principle. It goes back longer than the medieval period. The talionic principle is biblical—*lex talionis*, the law of equivalent retribution, eye for an eye, tooth for a tooth. That's the idea, this talionic punishment.
- 7.46 You find it a lot in these medieval pictures of hell. Slanderers, people who've spoken lies, they're hanged by their tongues, that kind of thing. If you go to the Duomo in Florence, the famous cathedral in Florence—you can walk up to the interior of the dome and you can see Vasari's fresco of hell. There's all sorts of talionic things going on there. There are lots of winged demons, lots of hairy demons.
- 7.47 There's sexual misconduct. There's a Sodomite who is being penetrated anally with a flaming stick by a demon, which is obviously meant to mimic the sex act, which is something that happens in Christopher Marlowe's *Edward II*. Edward II is a gay king. At the end of the play, he is killed with a red-hot poker in his fundament. It's a bit brutal, but of course, it's meant to mimic his sexual relationship with Piers Gaveston. It's talionic.

- 7.48 Dante's Inferno is full of it. If you read Dante's Inferno in hell, which I really recommend you do, he has, for instance, the fortune tellers. In hell, in Dante, the fortune tellers are walking around with their heads twisted entirely backwards, because they've claimed that they can see the future. They can see what's ahead. In hell, all they can see is what's behind. That's a talionic, poetic-justice thing.
- 7.49 Dante's Inferno is fascinating. I really love the fact that he puts his enemies in there. Anyone who annoyed him in his life, if he's got a grudge, he puts them in hell, getting flayed or whatever. It's quite petty, really. But it's a very interesting poem. Let's go into the question of usury, specifically. In San Gimignano, on this fresco in the church by Taddeo di Bartolo, this 14th-century fresco, the usurers—and he actually writes, next to the sinners, he writes the names of the sin—gluttony, slander, lust, whatever.
- 7.50 Next to usury—in Latin, obviously—in usury, he has a man lying on the floor naked, while a demon squats over his mouth and defecates coins into his mouth for all eternity. That's what happens to the usurer. It's quite a creative form of talionic punishment. But that image, I think, gives you a sense of how Christians of the time felt about usury. This was a great evil, a huge evil.
- 7.51 But let's contextualize this in terms of The Merchant of Venice. Moneylending was essential. It was an essential aspect of commerce. And Christians, the British government, or rather the English government, needed to borrow money, and this particularly matters for Venice. In the late 16th century, Venice was one of the great mercantile capitals of the world. It was a maritime republic whose wealth flowed from its vast trading networks, stretching across the Levant, northern Europe. It connected east and west.
- 7.52 This is why there are continual references in the play to these argosies at sea, these boats coming and going into the harbors, carrying silks and spices and precious metals and that kind of thing. The merchants were the intermediaries between east and west. They had turned the city into this cosmopolitan hub, where commerce and diplomacy and finance all converged under the authority of the Venetian Senate.
- 7.53 That's the important context for this play. And of course, businessmen in that context required money to be lent. Moneylending was part of their existence. They needed loans from time to time. But under Catholic canon law, Christians were completely forbidden to charge interest on loans because, as I said, that was usury. If you did that, you would end up in hell, with a demon squatting on your face, depositing coins into your mouth for all eternity. It's not nice.
- 7.54 Usury was actually considered on the same level as sodomy. Sodomy was considered a major sin by medieval Christians. In Dante, the usurers and the sodomites occupy the same sub-circle of hell. There's actually a book by Thomas Pie from 1604 called Usuries Spright Conjured. I actually read an original copy of this many years ago in the York

Minster Library. I called up this copy, and I read it, and I copied out the relevant passages, which is good, because now I can read a quote to you today.

7.55 Pie said, "To make money breed is against nature, for money hath no such gendering or procreating nature, being naturally barren." So the logic here is that the usurer finds a method to make money reproduce, whereas the Sodomite removes the reproductive possibility from the act of sexual intercourse. And therefore, Pie says explicitly, usury is called a kind of sodomy. So the two things are the same.

7.56 That's the extent of the horror of usury by devout Christians in Renaissance Europe. Money should not breed. However, Jewish law did not prohibit charging interest to non-Jews. So you can see what's happened here. Jews are forbidden to lend at interest to other Jews, but they're allowed to lend to Gentiles. And this is why, in the Venice of Shakespeare's play, we have Shylock living with his daughter, Jessica, and Gobbo, in the Jewish ghetto. Gobbo, who is the clown of the play, he's the servant of Shylock, who leaves him.

7.57 And this is the Ghetto Nuovo, which was established in 1516. This is the first legally segregated Jewish quarter in Europe. It's a real place. And if you watch the 2004 film with Al Pacino that I've mentioned before, the film of *The Merchant of Venice*, it really helps you to visualize the geography of the play. It's filmed in Venice, and you can really see that distinction between the Ghetto Nuovo and the rest of the city. The ghetto is locked up at night.

7.58 So let's summarize this. So in Christian societies, such as Venice, where Jews lived as minorities, Jewish moneylenders could legally charge interest. Because of that, they were, of course, hated. We always hate the people that we owe money to. There's a genuine sense of hatred, but they were also depended upon. You have this ambivalent perspective of their role in society, because the city needed them and loathed them at the same time.

7.59 Antonio does sometimes lend without interest, and he does that because, of course, to lend at interest is a sin. So Antonio sometimes will lend it without interest. Shylock hates him for that. But Shylock actually says that the reason why he so despises him is, and this is the quotation, he says, "He lends out money gratis and brings down the rate of usance here with us in Venice." So he sees it as a direct competitive threat that the Christian won't lend at interest.

7.60 But broadly speaking, the economy is bolstered by the tolerance of usury by Jewish merchants, and the events of the play do bear that out. This brings us back to the notion of appearance versus reality, and why I don't think that the interpretation of *The Merchant of Venice* as simply demonizing Jewish people—I don't think that that is particularly borne out by the text.

7.61 We have to remember that *The Merchant of Venice* is a comedy. We often forget this because it's one of the comedies that feels to us, to our modern sensibilities, more like

a drama. But it is a comedy. The key plot is a comedy plot. The key plot is the love plot of Portia and the caskets, the marriage to Bassanio, and then her test of Bassanio's devotion through the game with the ring.

- 7.62** Portia and Nerissa test their husbands with the rings. This is a very typical comedy conceit. It's also satire, though. It's a comedy, but it's also satirical. Remember, before I talked about the distinction between comedy and satire? This is both. The satire here is of the hypocrisy of the Christian state. Think about the opening scene of the play. Antonio is there with his two friends. They don't understand: Why is he so melancholy? Why is he so sad?
- 7.63** His friends, of course, are also of the mercantile class. They're called Salarino and Solanio. Salarino and Solanio. Salarino, Solanio? They sound the same, don't they? You could mix them up. They're interchangeable, but so too are the characters. Now, I did say, didn't I, that even in his minor characters, Shakespeare likes to invest them with individual personalities and traits. He doesn't seem to do it here.
- 7.64** Not only are their names easily confused, the characters could be exchanged, and you wouldn't notice. You could probably conflate the two into one. It's one of those things with Shakespeare: if I cover up the name on the side of the play, I can normally tell who's speaking, because he's so adept at investing each one with individual characteristics. Not with these two, but I think it's deliberate. They have the same speech patterns. They finish each other's sentences at one point. They may as well be the same thing.
- 7.65** I think that is a satirical point. I think he's saying that the mercantile class in Venice are basically all the same. Single-minded. Money, money, money—that's all they are. I think this is the point here. They do suggest straightaway, Antonio is melancholic. Why? They say it's because you're worried about your ships at sea, you're worried about your argosies, you're worried about your money, your valuable cargo, foundering at sea and not coming back. He says it's not that. They say why then, he's in love. Perhaps he's in love.
- 7.66** Now, that's another interesting possibility. I've said before, I think, in the case of Twelfth Night, I don't think there's much doubt that the Antonio character is in love with the Sebastian character. I think that is made quite clear. Similarly, we have an Antonio here who seems extremely devoted to Bassanio. It isn't quite to the same overt level, but I think there is a possibility that his devotion to him goes beyond the platonic, possibly. It depends how you read it, but the devotion is intense.
- 7.67** Solanio says in the opening scene, "Why, then, you are in love." Later, we have Antonio described as Bassanio's lover, although that was a term that was used for friend as well. But their conversation consists of these passionate phrases, "My Antonio, sweet Bassanio." If nothing else, they are very, very close. I don't think this is a homosexual

relationship, don't get me wrong. I think, though, the devotion of Antonio is something that could be sexualized if he were so inclined.

7.68 It's that point we made before, but we were talking about *The Two Gentlemen of Verona*. The idealization of male friendship at this time reaches such a point that it starts to borrow from the language of love and romance, and the two become conflated. Now, this is from Act 2, Scene 8. So Salarino says, "And even there, Antonio's eye being big with tears, turning his face"—he's describing Antonio and Bassanio parting—"even there, his eye being big with tears, turning his face, he put his hand behind him, and with affection wondrous sensible, he wrung Bassanio's hand, and so they parted."

7.69 Solanio says, "I think he only loves the world for him." Like I say, it's reminiscent of the other Antonio in *Twelfth Night*. Maybe that name, Antonio, meant something to Shakespeare. Actually, Sebastian and Bassanio come from the same root, so there's something in that. Anyway, so we have the melancholy Antonio. We have his two gentleman friends, Salarino and Solanio, who may as well be the same person.

7.70 This is our first encounter with the Venice of the play. It's possible that Shakespeare is presenting these characters, as I say, to talk about the Venetian mercantile class, to make a point. Because I think to be that avaricious, to be that obsessed with wealth and the acquisition of money, to an extent, you have to surrender your individuality or at least that may be the point that's being made here, because you're devoting your lives to this, to money, to the god of Mammon.

7.71 Here is Salarino talking about how worried he would be if he had so much money at stake at sea. Remember, Antonio has many ships at sea, and this is what his friend says. He says, "Should I go to church and see the holy edifice of stone, and not bethink me straight of dangerous rocks?" So even when he's in church, if he's looking at the stones, he's not going to be thinking about God or Jesus or the gospel. He's going to be thinking of the rocks that might be at sea that might crash his boat.

7.72 "Should I go to church and see the holy edifice of stone, and not bethink me straight of dangerous rocks, which touching but my gentle vessel's side, would scatter all her spices on the stream, enrobe the roaring waters with my silks." Even at the moment when he's meant to be devoted to God, this Christian, apparently, is going to be worrying about his wrecked cargo and about his money. The thought of it makes him shudder. He can see the spices scattered on the stream. He can see the robes floating on the tides. He visualizes it.

7.73 That humor has dated, but that is a humorous moment. It makes him out to be a complete hypocrite— this nobleman, this respected gentleman, admitting, quite candidly, that God takes second place to his silks and his spices. His business is what matters. Remember, this is the first scene. Shakespeare is establishing something very,

very early on. The appearance of respectability, shattered by the reality—appearance and reality, keeps coming back.

- 7.74** It isn't just Jews that are avaricious, in other words, or obsessed with wealth. Everything they accuse Shylock of, they are guilty of, too. I'm not saying that Shylock isn't avaricious; of course, he is. When Jessica leaves with his money, with Lorenzo, he's as worried about the loss of his ducats as about the loss of his daughter. Do you remember that bit? "My ducats, my daughter, my ducats, my daughter." He doesn't know which matters more to him.
- 7.75** And yet, he does and has devised this cruel pound of flesh retribution for the failed payment of debt, this money that Antonio—and remember, if we're going back to the devotion between Antonio and Bassanio, he's risking his life so that his friend can go and get married, to get that money. That's the intensity of that friendship. But like I say, I think the Christians are as thirsty for wealth as the Jewish characters. They can be similarly cruel.
- 7.76** Now, I can keep making this point, but the best way to really make the point is to hear it from Shylock himself. It is the most famous speech in the play. I think it gets the point much quicker than I could. This is Act 3, Scene 1. Salarino has asked Shylock, "Why would you insist on a pound of flesh?" If he breaks his bond, why would you insist on taking it? What good is it? What good is meat, is that for?
- 7.77** And Shylock says, "To bait fish withal. If it will feed nothing else, it will feed my revenge. He hath disgraced"—now, he's talking about Antonio here, remember? "He hath disgraced me, and hindered me half a million; laughed at my losses, mocked at my gains, scorned my nation, thwarted my bargains, cooled my friends, heated mine enemies. And what's his reason? I am a Jew.
- 7.78** Hath not a Jew eyes? Hath not a Jew hands, organs, dimensions, senses, affections, passions? Fed with the same food, hurt with the same weapons, subject to the same diseases, healed by the same means, warmed and cooled by the same winter and summer, as a Christian is? If you prick us, do we not bleed? If you tickle us, do we not laugh? If you poison us, do we not die? And if you wrong us, shall we not revenge?
- 7.79** If we are like you in the rest, we will resemble you in that. If a Jew wrong a Christian, what is his humility? Revenge. If a Christian wrong a Jew, what should his sufferance be by Christian example? Why, revenge. The villainy you teach me, I will execute; and it shall go hard, but I will better the instruction."
- 7.80** This speech is extraordinary, and it pulls us in all directions. Shylock's catalogue of grievances is completely legitimate. We can't argue against this. He has been the subject of abuse and humiliation at the hands of Antonio. Antonio doesn't deny it. He confirms it. Then we have Shylock's appeal to his fundamental humanity. You have to think: How might an audience, an Elizabethan audience, have taken this?

- 7.81** They would have been expecting another Barabas. They've just seen The Jew of Malta a couple of years ago. Huge success. They want another villain. And what happens? Suddenly, the Jew is standing there, talking about his essential humanity. "If you prick us, do we not bleed? Are we not the same as you?" That's not what they were expecting. This is just another example, I think, of Shakespeare never letting you settle, always countering your expectations.
- 7.82** The villain reminds you that he's as human as you are and is able to appeal to your innate empathy. Barabas can never do that. Barabas couldn't have said this speech. It wouldn't make sense. But then the speech turns again, because he's not going to let you settle on that, either. So, for all this rather moving appeal to humanity, well, actually, it's just a justification for vindictiveness.
- 7.83** He says, "And if you wrong us, shall we not revenge?" But revenge is not inevitable. Yes, if you tickle us, we laugh. If you prick us, we bleed. If you poison us, we die. These are things we cannot choose. We do choose to take revenge. It's a false comparison. He is making a conscious choice. And so you think, OK, I've been pulled one way. I'm feeling and understanding the grievance of this Jewish man. I'm understanding that he, too, is a human being. I empathize.
- 7.84** But hang on a minute. He wants to make a choice to be vindictive, and he's using and exploiting this appeal to his humanity to lure me into believing that even his revenge is not a choice. So I'm being manipulated. So, as you watch this, you then turn against him. But Shakespeare doesn't leave it there, because then we hear Shakespeare explain the vindictiveness. He explains that it is a mirror image of the Christian vindictiveness. It's the conduct of Christians in Venice that have taught him to seek vengeance.
- 7.85** He's following the Christian example. "The villainy you teach me, I will execute." So you can see why this role can be played in all sorts of ways, how the moral ambiguity is unavoidable. You can't easily clean Shylock up into one form of character or another. He's too complex. He's as complex, as contradictory, as any other character. He is, in other words, human. And even in his vindictive outbursts, he is humanized.
- 7.86** As we've seen, the hypocrisy of the Christian society of Venice is undeniable. Usury is an abominable sin, they say, but they're happy to borrow money from Shylock, aren't they? Actually, in Elizabethan England, in 1571, under Elizabeth I, Parliament passed an act against usury, and it effectively said, "Yes, usury is a sin, so we're only going to do it up to 10%." That was a law passed in England.
- 7.87** How does that work, theologically? Can you cheat and murder and lie and steal if you only do it 10% of the time? That's not how the Bible works. The laws of God are non-negotiable. But of course, Elizabeth's state had to legalize it to a degree because they needed it. So they're going to bend the rules of God just a little bit. Hypocrisy, there's no getting around that; that is hypocrisy. And that is what Shakespeare is addressing here.

- 7.88** So let's go back to Act 1, Scene 3. This is when Antonio and Bassanio visit Shylock to secure the loan, and Shylock explicitly mentions that Antonio has berated him, has called him a usurer, and now he's coming to get his services. Unbelievable. The gall of it, the audacity. What does he say? "Signor Antonio, many a time and oft in the Rialto you have rated me about my monies and my usances. Still, I have borne it with a patient shrug, for sufferance is the badge of all our tribe.
- 7.89** You call me misbeliever, cutthroat dog, and spit upon my Jewish gaberdine, and all for use of that which is mine own. Well then, it now appears you need my help. Go to, then; you come to me and you say, 'Shylock, we would have monies.' You say so. You, that did void your rheum upon my beard and foot me as you spurn a stranger cur over your threshold. Monies is your suit.
- 7.90** What should I say to you? Should I not say, 'Hath a dog money? Is it possible a cur can lend 3,000 ducats?' Or shall I bend low and in a bondsman's key, with bated breath and whispering humbleness, say this: 'Fair sir, you spat on me Wednesday last; you spurned me on such a day; another time you called me dog. And for these courtesies, I'll lend you thus such monies?'"
- 7.91** He makes a good point. Later in Act 3, Scene 3, he's going to remind him, "Thou callst me dog before thou hadst a cause; but since I am a dog, beware my fangs." So again, it's speeches like this that shake up the genre of comedy. The caricaturish villain that we might hope to find in a story of this kind becomes the heart of the emotion of the story of this kind. The audience can't help but feel for him and actually support him in this.
- 7.92** This was really played up in that production I mentioned with Tracy-Ann Oberman in London. The mistreatment, the constant vicious mistreatment of the Jewish people in the ghetto, why shouldn't he get revenge? Why shouldn't he push back? This is Shakespeare, I think, at his most innovative, his most disruptive, perhaps even his most disconcerting.
- 7.93** Now, compare Shylock's appeal to humanity, blended as it is with venom and with threats, with Antonio's response. So this is still in Act 1, Scene 3. Shylock has said that Antonio has called him a dog. And remember, Antonio wants his money. There's no contrition, though. There's no attempt to placate him or the situation. He doesn't say, "I'm sorry I called you a dog, but please may I borrow some money now?" He doesn't say that.
- 7.94** He says, "I am as like to call thee so again, to spit on thee again, to spurn thee too. If thou wilt lend this money, lend it not as to thy friends; for when did friendship take a breed for barren metal of his friend? But lend it rather to thine enemy, who, if he break, thou mayest with better face exact the penalty." So he's saying, "I don't like you. I'm going to carry on spitting on you. But that's better for you because I'm your enemy now. So if I fail to pay you back, you can exact your revenge." That's the point.

- 7.95** And even there, when he's trying to borrow money, he's having a dig at him for being a usurer. There's that phrase, "a breed for barren metal." Remember what I said about making money breed, making money reproduce? That's the sin that Antonio hates him for, because Antonio is a fervent Christian. That's why he lends money without interest. He hates this.
- 7.96** But that said, Antonio and Shylock, in a sense, mirror each other. They are both fervently religious. They both believe they're in the right. The title of the play, *The Merchant of Venice*, a lot of people think that means Shylock. It's not. *The Merchant of Venice* is Antonio, and yet, it could have just as easily been called *The Jew of Venice*. In fact, it was. When it was entered into the Stationers' Register in 1598, it was entered as *The Merchant of Venice*, or otherwise called *The Jew of Venice*.
- 7.97** People knew that this was about both of these characters and that they are, in a sense, mirror images of each other. Now, I hope, as I've shown, this isn't really a straightforward story of goodies and baddies, even though it does have a fairytale quality, given the preposterous story of the caskets, the winning of the girl by solving a puzzle, and then the later puzzle of the rings, the trick. But whether our sympathies lie more with Antonio or with Shylock will depend on the interpretation of the director and the audience.
- 7.98** The great critic, William Hazlitt, one of my favorite essayists, very underread, in 1816, he wrote that, in the comparison between the Christians and the Jews, Shylock often comes off better. Now, here he is reviewing a production in the early 1800s with Edmund Kean playing Shylock. This is what William Hazlitt writes. "His Jew is more than half a Christian. Certainly, our sympathies are more oftener with him than with his enemies. He"—Shylock, "he is honest in his vices; they are hypocrites in their virtues."
- 7.99** Isn't that perfectly put? And that's the play's satirical heart. And so, although early productions did play Shylock for laughs, I can't help thinking that does a disservice to the moral complexity of the role. Venice, in the play, is established as a city of carnival, of opulence, of festivity. Those in the Jewish ghetto, one supposes, have the austerity that the Christians seem to lack.
- 7.100** And I say all this not to undermine the anti-Jewish tropes in the play, which definitely exist. Gobbo, the servant, says, "The Jew is the very devil incarnation." We don't forget, we can never forget, that Shylock is forced to convert to Christianity. At the end of Act 4 is a scene that is very hard to watch. In fact, when the play was rewritten by George Granville as *The Jew of Venice*, that was in 1701, he took that aspect of the story out. He was trying to lighten the play, get back to its comic roots.
- 7.101** And Jessica does want to be saved from her own Jewishness by marrying a Christian. She says, "Our house is hell." Note Gobbo's response to that. He says in Act 3, Scene 5—well, Jessica says, "I shall be saved by my husband. He hath made me a Christian." Gobbo says, "Truly, the more to blame he. We were Christians enow before; e'en as

many as could well live, one by another. This making of Christians will raise the price of hogs. If we grow all to be pork-eaters, we shall not shortly have a rasher on the coals for money."

- 7.102** So the clown is echoing this mercantile, this obsessive money, this sentiment in Christian Venice. Obviously, it's an absurdist idea. If too many people convert to Christianity, yes, you save more souls, but you have to pay more for your bacon. He turns this question of salvation into a supply and demand joke, an economic joke. This says a lot about the culture of Venice at the time. The butt of the joke is Venice, as much as it is Jessica.
- 7.103** But we mustn't forget that the other key role in this play is, of course, Portia. Portia is absolutely key. Her role is very much tied in with the improbabilities of the plot. So her father's will, the casket, her disguise as a lawyer in the trial scene, along with Nerissa disguised as her clerk. Even though their two husbands are there, no one sees through the disguise. You rarely see through disguises in Shakespeare.
- 7.104** But I should say something here about realism. I've mentioned this before, but I just want to hammer this home: Shakespeare does not concern himself with plots. Plots weren't his thing. Plots for him were like a skeleton to hang the flesh on: his poetry, his characterization, his need to drive towards greater human truths. The plots were incidental to him. I've said that one of his great gifts is verisimilitude, the idea of making a little world that makes sense within each play. It makes sense while you're traveling within it.
- 7.105** If you stop to think about the plot points of any given Shakespeare play afterwards, you'll say, "Oh, that doesn't make sense." When Tolstoy wrote a famous essay attacking Shakespeare because his plays didn't make sense logically, Tolstoy was thinking like a realistic Russian novelist, not like a poet. He had a tin ear for poetry. So he doesn't get this. He doesn't get that, in *King Lear*, why would a brother write to his other brother about his evil schemes, even though the brothers live in the same house? Yeah, fair enough.
- 7.106** Of course, it doesn't make sense. None of it makes sense. You can't read these plays for realism. It's incoherent. Shakespeare's plays don't sustain that reading. In *The Winter's Tale*, Bohemia has a sea coast. Why? Bohemia doesn't have a sea coast. It's landlocked. Or *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, with a landlocked Milan, also has a port. Or in *Titus Andronicus*, where they go out hunting panthers—there's no panthers in Rome. It doesn't make any sense, right?
- 7.107** Or the *Comedy of Errors*, we've already talked about this. Two sets of twins who've never met each other happen to be wearing the same clothes on the same day. Of course, it can't happen. Viola and Sebastian in *Twelfth Night*, identical twins of different biological sex can't happen. Not possible. It doesn't matter. None of this matters, because Shakespeare compels us not to think in terms of realism, but to immerse

ourselves in scenarios that are essentially poetic approximations, which get to a truth about human experience.

- 7.108** People in real life don't speak in blank verse. They don't speak in iambic pentameter. There's a line from *The Winter's Tale*, which I think helps us here. This is what Paulina says before the reanimation of Hermione's statue, that famous moment at the end. She says, "It is required you do awake your faith." I think that's a very good way to think of the theatrical experience. There's no point sitting there, saying, "That wouldn't happen, that wouldn't happen." Otherwise, you're missing a whole lot.
- 7.109** In fact, Shakespeare always seems to escalate the improbabilities. We talked about this with *As You Like It*, how he made it more improbable than the source text, daring you to say that wouldn't happen. He knows it wouldn't happen. One of the major sources for *The Merchant of Venice* is an Italian play, *Il Pecorone*. In that play, the merchant loses just one ship. In Shakespeare's case, with Antonio, we have to believe that he's lost six ships all at once. Then, at the end, three of them just come back. It's fine. We have to believe all of that. All of that is an invention. It's more improbable than the source text, than the Italian source text.
- 7.110** With that in mind, let's have a look at the caskets. Let's consider the caskets. When we first meet Portia, she is declaring to her waiting woman, Nerissa, that she is "weary of this great world," which echoes the first time we saw Antonio, the melancholy of Antonio. But whereas Antonio's sadness is something of a mystery, Portia has good reason. She is a slave. She has been confined by her dead father's wishes.
- 7.111** He has written in his will that she cannot marry a suitor until that suitor picks the correct casket, either the gold one, the lead one, or the silver one. Inside the winning casket will have a portrait of Portia, the prize. This is what her father, her dead father, has condemned her to. It's hugely improbable. It's hugely ridiculous. And the stakes are high because the men who approach her take a vow that, if they choose the wrong casket, they will never marry again. I don't know how quite you would enforce that. It doesn't matter.
- 7.112** But it's an interesting comment on the patriarchal conditions of the time, because, of course, at this time, women had to seek consent from their fathers to marry, or rather, their suitors did. This takes that principle to the absolute extreme, because even when the father is dead, he holds on to that power over the daughter. He still controls her fate. This is how Portia puts it in Act 1, Scene 2.
- 7.113** "I may neither choose who I would nor refuse who I dislike. So is the will of a living daughter curbed by the will of a dead father. Is it not hard, Nerissa, that I cannot choose one nor refuse none?" Now, Portia and Nerissa do have some fun, mocking the suitors. They look on, and they mock them when they approach. There is one, though, that she likes. There's one she actually loves, and that's Bassanio. Nerissa, for her part,

is in love with Gratiano, and they're going to engineer the situation to get what they want.

- 7.114** Now, remember, the Prince of—the first one is the Prince of Morocco. The Prince of Morocco, as a suitor for Portia, chooses the gold casket. Why? Because he's pompous. He's self-important. The gold reflects him. The inscription on the casket says, "Who chooseth me shall gain what many men desire." And many men desire Portia, don't they? Isn't that why he's there?
- 7.115** Basically, with the Prince of Morocco, it isn't some passionate need. He isn't in love with her, like Bassanio is. He is in love with what Portia represents—status, victory, triumph over other men. That's what this is really about. And inside the casket— he confidently picks the gold casket—and inside, of course, there is not a portrait of Portia, but a death's head.
- 7.116** And the message on the scroll says, "All that glisters is not gold. Often have you heard that told. Many a man his life hath sold, but my outside to behold. Gilded tombs do worms enfold. Had you been as wise as bold, young in limbs in judgment old, your answer had not been enrolled. Fare you well; your suit is cold."
- 7.117** The choice of each casket reflects the folly of each suitor. They judge its meaning by its outward appearance, appearance versus reality. They get it wrong because they conflate the two. Now, the Prince of Morocco is going to die someday, and the death's head signifies his fate. He will also be buried in a golden casket, won't he? But like all men, he's going to be reduced to worms. Can't escape it. It doesn't matter how much money you've got, you can't take it with you.
- 7.118** And in any case, he doesn't get the girl, and neither does the Prince of Aragon. And whereas Morocco's motivation was status, Aragon's is money, very clearly money. Portia has a considerable dowry. She's rich. She's very rich. And this is what the inscription on the silver—he chooses the silver casket because the inscription says, "Who chooseth me shall get as much as he deserves." And Aragon is arrogant, and he believes he deserves the prize. He is insufferably arrogant.
- 7.119** He doesn't select the gold casket because it says, "Who chooseth me shall gain what many men desire." He has this very snobbish response, doesn't he? He says, "I will not choose what many men desire, because I will not jump with common spirits and rank me with the barbarous multitudes." I'm better than other men, so I'm not going to choose—you can see what Shakespeare is doing. He sets up the personality of the suitor, and then punishes them for their sin and folly. Total snob.
- 7.120** He's a bit like Coriolanus, who won't talk to the plebeians. Talks about their bad breath and their bad judgment. Total snob. "Who chooses me shall get as much as he deserves." And he knows that's the right choice. What does he say? "I will assume desert." I get what I deserve. And he does get what he deserves. He gets a portrait of a

blinking idiot. And then, of course, you get to Bassanio. Now, Bassanio, who, as we know, chooses the leaden casket.

- 7.121** And there's been a lot of debate about whether he is guided to choose the leaden casket by Portia in some way. Remember that, when it says on the leaden casket, "Who chooseth me must give and hazard all he hath," and isn't that true of love? You have to take a risk. And the selection is made because Bassanio, unlike the other two suitors, understands what love is, and that it does involve giving and hazarding all that you have. He isn't there for the status, he isn't there for the money.
- 7.122** This is an interesting—we've had the three, we've had Morocco and Aragon and now Bassanio. It's only now that we get a song played, probably sung by one of the pageboys. Portia, though, will have directed this. We hear this song as he's deciding. I've said before, haven't I, songs in Shakespeare have this choric quality? This song, I think, summarizes the theme of *The Merchant of Venice*. That's what it's all about.
- 7.123** It's a song about understanding the difference between infatuation and love, appearance and reality, what they call fancy. Infatuation was known as fancy. In England, we still say it, "You fancy her, don't you?" I don't know if they—do you say it in America? Maybe not. No, it's not a very American thing. But in England, it's still commonly used. But of course, fancy, if you fancy someone, you're infatuated with someone, you're not in love with them. You are in love with the appearance, what's on the surface.
- 7.124** So, of course, this song is about this theme encapsulated. This is the song. These are the lyrics. "Tell me where is fancy bred, or in the heart, or in the head? How begot, how nourished? Reply, reply. It is engendered in the eye, with gazing fed; and fancy dies in the cradle where it lies. Let us all ring fancy's knell. I'll begin i— ding, dong, bell." Ding, dong, bell. That's the death knell of fancy. OK?
- 7.125** Now, you could argue that this is guiding Bassanio to the right choice. Think about the rhymes there. "Tell me where is fancy bred, or in the heart, or in the head? How begot, how nourished?" Rhymes with lead. Possibly, and of course, the song envisages the death of fancy. And a leaden casket would make sense, because that's the death of—that's used for coffins, wasn't it? Lead was used for coffins.
- 7.126** Either way, I don't think it is as mechanical as Portia writing a song to guide him to the right choice. I think it is Shakespeare poetically commenting on the action through the use of song. But either way, the point is that Bassanio must choose. He can't choose the casket that is superficially attractive, but the one that has the true substance, the leaden one.
- 7.127** Fancy, which was originally, by the way, a contraction of fantasy, as in illusion, that feeling is engendered in the eye, as the song says, not the heart. That form of love isn't real. I mean, how many of us do that? How often do we mistake fancy for love?

Probably most of us, at some point or another. When Bassanio picks the correct casket, we can be reassured that his love is deeper than mere fancy.

- 7.128** Now, throughout these lectures, I've talked about this notion of love and infatuation and how they can be confused. I think this song could appear in many of Shakespeare's comedies and still make sense. Sometimes what begins as fancy turns to love, as in the case of Romeo and Juliet. Sometimes the fancy is exposed as hollow, shallow, misleading, but it is never the same as love.
- 7.129** Now, even here, in Belmont, at the apparent fulfillment of the fairy tale, the mercantile reality of Venice is still there. It's still something that Shakespeare wants to remind you of. He won't let us forget it, that this is a world that prioritizes commerce over God and certainly, commerce over love. Now, Bassanio has chosen well, but he needs Portia to ratify it, as though it were any other business agreement. This is his mercantile instinct. He says, "So, thrice fair lady, stand I, even so, as doubtful whether what I see be true until confirmed, signed, ratified by you."
- 7.130** And her response: "You see me, Lord Bassanio, where I stand, such as I am. Though for myself alone, I would not be ambitious in my wish, to wish myself much better; yet, for you, I would be trebled twenty times myself, a thousand times more fair, ten thousand times more rich; that only to stand high in your account, I might in virtue, beauties, livings, friends, exceed account. But the full sum of me is sum of something, which, to term in gross, is an unlesened girl, unschooled, unpractised."
- 7.131** The language is that of commerce. You can hear it, right? Treble, twenty times, ten thousand times more rich. To stand high in your account, the full sum of me, to term in gross. So even in Belmont, the porous and watery world of Venice trickles in. It's all about the money. And Bassanio makes no bones about it, by the way. I'm not denying the love that they share, but he does need the money. He does.
- 7.132** This is a transaction, and that transaction must then be tested by Portia and Nerissa with the trick with the rings. That's the point. The love, of course, survives the test, even though Bassanio fails it by giving Portia the ring. She is disguised as the lawyer, the lawyer who obviously tricks Shylock into losing, and so he gives her the ring. She asks for the ring, and he gives it to her, not knowing he's giving it to the person who gave it to him to begin with.
- 7.133** The point is that we're left with this sense that we might never really know anyone, that appearance and reality are too often conflated. Let's remind ourselves what Bassanio says after hearing the song about the death of fancy. He says, "So may the outward shows be least themselves. The world is still deceived with ornament. In law, what plea so tainted and corrupt, but being seasoned with a gracious voice, obscures the show of evil?" Isn't that true? Any honey-tongued lawyer can win a case for the most evil man.

- 7.134** "In religion, what damned error but some sober brow will bless it and approve it with a text, hiding the grossness with fair ornament?" How many times in history has the Bible been quoted to achieve evil? "There is no voice so simple but assumes some mark of virtue on his outward parts." We're about to hear it, aren't we? We're about to hear the law "seasoned with a gracious voice," from Portia herself.
- 7.135** In the trial scene, we're about to hear her famous speech on how the quality of mercy is not strained. One of the best, most touching speeches in Shakespeare, which I will leave for you to read yourself, because I don't want to spoil it for you. But while Shylock's revenge is thwarted, do we really have justice? They force him to convert to Christianity. That feels as vindictive as anything that Shylock ever attempted.
- 7.136** And of course, any conversion that is forced is no conversion at all. It's a form of torture. It's a form of authoritarianism. "In religion," says Bassanio, "what damned error but some sober brow will bless it and approve it with a text?" Well, we're seeing it, aren't we?
- 7.137** And we've already established that the superiority of those who profess their Christianity is often undercut by their conduct. The world is indeed deceived with ornament, and nowhere more so than Venice, with its silks and its spices and all the fine clothes and the trappings of wealth that allow the worst of men to appear respectable.

Lecture 8: Twelfth Night

At a glance — Twelfth Night, closing with Walter Pater.

- 8.1 In 1873, the critic Walter Pater wrote a book called *Studies in the History of the Renaissance*. This is a key text in the Aesthetic movement. I would recommend that everyone read it. It's an important book. It's the book, incidentally, that revived interest in Botticelli, who by that point had become quite a specialist figure in art.
- 8.2 It also had a very famous and very controversial conclusion that was excised in subsequent editions because Pater, in that conclusion, expresses the aesthetic view that prioritizes the importance of sensation, the seeking out of intense experiences. That didn't go down too well. This was interpreted by many people at the time, the predominantly Christian ethos of the time, as being hedonistic, as being self-indulgent. Of course, similar accusations were leveled at Oscar Wilde, who was another famous exponent of aesthetic values.
- 8.3 Now, one of Pater's key arguments is encapsulated in this phrase. He says, "All art constantly aspires towards the condition of music." Now, what he means by this is that, in music, there is a fusion of matter and form. The best writing aspires to that. The words are the form; the ideas that they convey are the matter. Now, in music, you can achieve that fusion; it's naturally there. And other art forms are aspiring towards it.
- 8.4 But Shakespeare, I think above all, comes closest to that fusion, where the one echoes the other. There are innumerable examples of this kind in Shakespeare. I would really like you to keep in mind, when you think about his use of language, how he is achieving this fusion of matter and form. A great example is the opening of *Twelfth Night*. So let's begin there. The opening of *Twelfth Night* is one of the most famous openings in Shakespeare.
- 8.5 We begin not with words, but with music. As we sit there in the audience, we hear music. In Shakespeare's time at the Globe Theater, this would have been played from the Musician's Gallery, the balcony above the stage. We begin with music, and then Orsino, the Duke of Illyria, comments upon the music. These are his musicians, playing at his behest. He is in love, but he's also melancholic.
- 8.6 He's in love with the Countess Olivia, and he says, "If music be the food of love, play on. Give me excess of it, that, surfeiting, the appetite may sicken and so die. That strain again, it had a dying fall. O, it came o'er my ear like the sweet sound that breathes upon a bank of violets, stealing and giving odor. Enough, no more. It is not so sweet now as it was before."
- 8.7 Now, in Mark Van Doren's book on Shakespeare, he points out that Orsino's opening speech is not merely accompanied by music. It discusses music, and it is music in itself. And that's Pater's idea in action, words in action, the fusion of matter and form right

there. So let's examine the speech a little closer. It's worth doing this in a bit of detail, I think, to make the point.

- 8.8** "If music be the food of love, play on." A very famous line. That is a standard line of iambic pentameter. You can hear it. "If music be the food of love, play on." Five metrical feet, each foot comprising of two syllables, the first one unstressed, the second stressed. "If music be the food of love, play on." Now, because of time constraints, I can't go into prosody and meter and verse form in this lecture, but if I ever do a series of lectures on the poems, I will spend some time on this.
- 8.9** But very briefly, it is worth being aware that verse form in English poetry is based on stressed syllables. So unlike classical Greek poetry, where it's the length of syllables, it is here in the stress of syllables, which is natural to English because, of course, stresses change the meaning of words. My name is Andrew, not Andrew. You hear it all the time, but we don't really think about it.
- 8.10** If my name were a metrical foot in poetry, it would be a trochee, Andrew, not an iamb, Andrew. It seems obvious. When I was a schoolteacher, this was the first thing I used to teach my pupils before we went into any play of Shakespeare's. We would talk about different verse forms. I'd try to teach them how to scan a poem, to identify whether it was iambic pentameter or trochaic tetrameter or whatever it might be. I would try to enable them to write their own verse with these rhythms in mind.
- 8.11** The terminology makes it sound far more complex than it is. And after about a week, even these kids, 11-year-old kids, were able to write their own lines of iambic pentameter. They were able to come up with lines and speak in iambic pentameter on cue. It doesn't take long. And it doesn't have to be elevated poetry. "If music be the food of love, play on." Or, "Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?"
- 8.12** It can be as simple as, "The macaroni fell upon the floor," or "My homework was ingested by the dog." They would just know the rhythm. We can all do this if we learn it. We don't have time here. But if you are unfamiliar with meter and verse form and how it impacts Shakespeare's language, I would read a book about it.
- 8.13** There's a really good book by Stephen Fry, very simple, very accessible. It's called *The Ode Less Travelled*. He goes through all the various verse forms with all the various terms and sets little exercises. It's a book that just—it's very simple. But if you know this stuff, it will really impact your appreciation of Shakespeare. For one thing, you'll be able to immediately note that shift from prose to verse. You will hear when he is modifying the verse and to what effect.
- 8.14** Why do the witches in *Macbeth* not speak in iambic pentameter? Why do they speak in trochaic tetrameter? You probably haven't even thought about it, but actually, it changes them. It makes them otherworldly, mysterious, evil. It gives them a different tone. It's very, very effective. And once you know this stuff, you begin to naturally sense

these other resonances, these other meanings, because a lot of the time, the meaning is also in the rhythm of the language, not just the language itself.

- 8.15** Language aspiring to the condition of music, the fusion of matter and form. Pater was right. It isn't just the words that the characters speak or what they say. It's the shift in rhythm, the silences, the caesura, which means the cut, the break in a line, that suddenly disrupts an otherwise immaculate iambic line. That tells you something about what the character is thinking.
- 8.16** So let's get back to the speech. "If music be the food of love, play on." Perfect iambic pentameter, perfect rhythm, echoing the consistency of the music. But then it's disrupted. "Give me excess of it, that, surfeiting, the appetite may sicken and so die." So you can hear the passion in the voice, the determination to be overfed with music, to rid himself of the feeling. And the key stress there is excess.
- 8.17** Think of it this way. The first three lines of Orsino's speech, the first and the third, are pure iambic pentameter, strictly rendered. "If music be the food of love, play on," and "the appetite may sicken and so die." But that second line disrupts it, changes the meter. Instead, the accentuation is on excess. So let's hear it again. "If music be the food of love, play on. Give me excess of it, that, surfeiting, the appetite may sicken and so die." Can you hear it?
- 8.18** In a way, you could conduct it. It directs our actor to a certain sentiment within the words. Just as the caesura in the next line, this natural break in the rhythm, tells us that he is now listening again to the music, taking it in, indulging in the experience. He says, "That strain again, it had a dying fall." The line is iambic, but you can't deliver it in a rushed way. You can't plow through. You couldn't say, "That strain again, it had a dying fall," in that iambic way. You say, "That strain again, it had a dying fall."
- 8.19** It's natural. They're two complete clauses. The second clause is commenting on the first. We naturally pause when we read it. The rhythm is broken. We're invited in that break to share in Orsino's experience of the music. Now, you can read that line in two ways. "That strain again." He could be instructing the musicians. He could be saying, "That strain again. Play it again, Sam." Or he is saying, "Ah, that strain again." But either way, the caesura stands. It's always going to be cut there.
- 8.20** And in the next lines, the rhythm of Orsino's language is reenacting what he describes. He's describing the music and the effect of the music. And he said, "O, it came o'er my ear like the sweet sound that breathes upon a bank of violets, stealing and giving odor." He's talking about the way that music flows through us, like a natural breeze that flows across flowers, picks up the scent, and perfumes the air. That's the effect of music. We don't receive it passively. It seems to color the world around us.
- 8.21** But the rhythm of the poetry regenerates the movement of the breeze. See what I'm saying? Fusion of matter and form. And then it's abruptly halted because Orsino now wishes to rid himself of the sensation, to break out. We can hear the break. Listen very

carefully. "O, it came o'er my ear like the sweet sound that breathes upon a bank of violets, stealing and giving odor. Enough, no more. It is not so sweet now as it was before."

- 8.22** You can feel it, can't you? It's there. He is at first indulging in the sensation of the breeze passing across the flowers. He feels it. Then he breaks off deliberately, abruptly. He immerses himself in the music; he tears himself away. The love he feels for Olivia is not a joy for him, but a torment. And he expresses this not just in the words, but in the music of the words.
- 8.23** And you might think I'm dwelling too much on this detail, but it does matter. You could do this with any passage in Shakespeare. He doesn't waste syllables. Everything is thought about. I return to Walter Pater. All art, all art, constantly aspires towards the condition of music. There is a musicality to Shakespeare's verse. He is, first and foremost, a poet.
- 8.24** I've talked about the Folio and the quarto editions. Now, when the Folio was put together, there were three or four compositors, men sitting in a room, writing, putting it all together. Sometimes you can tell where the compositor has made a mistake, because the verse form isn't right, because it jars where it shouldn't. We don't have Shakespeare's original documents. We don't have his foul papers.
- 8.25** I've mentioned it before, I think we have one page, which is probably in his handwriting, which is a page from a play called Sir Thomas More. That was a play that was written by Anthony Munday and Henry Chettle, probably. Then it was revived significantly by Shakespeare. It was a big collaborative effort. Thomas Heywood was involved; Thomas Dekker was involved. But we don't know for sure. People have analyzed the handwriting compared to legal documents that Shakespeare has signed, and they're pretty sure that it is his. Anyway, look, that's a whole other lecture, isn't it?
- 8.26** Now, let's move on from this opening speech of Twelfth Night. There's a lot to cover here, because I think this play, for me, Twelfth Night, is the supreme example of Shakespeare's art as a comic writer. I think it's up there with As You Like It. I wanted to close this series of lectures on this play for a good reason. Now, obviously, the play is in Illyria. We don't know where exactly that is, in terms of today's geography, but the coast of Croatia is probably a good estimation.
- 8.27** Illyria was a real Roman province on the Adriatic. The word did appear on Elizabethan maps, but it was distant, romantic—I've mentioned this before with the setting of Comedy of Errors, with Ephesus. It's a place where Shakespeare could impose onto it whatever he wanted. He could make it whatever he wants it to be. Illyria is this poetic, distant, exotic location, a semi-imaginary Mediterranean court.
- 8.28** And yet, the domestic arrangement of Olivia's household feels very English, doesn't it? Again, this happens all the time. Whenever Shakespeare writes about these foreign settings, he seems to be reimagining his homeland, really. We've already discussed the

most obvious example of the forest of Arden in *As You Like It*, which feels far more English than French. But this is the same in *Twelfth Night*.

- 8.29** Olivia is a countess. She has Malvolio as her steward. We shouldn't, by the way, make the mistake of thinking that Malvolio is a working-class servant. He's not. He's a steward in an aristocratic household. The steward's role was often occupied by a gentleman, maybe even the second son of an aristocratic family, the one who wasn't going to get all the money. Minor aristocracy, perhaps. He's a social climber.
- 8.30** The other people in the household, you've got the servants. You've got Maria, who's the waiting woman. You've got Sir Toby Belch, who is the kinsman to Olivia, the drunk uncle or cousin who's always hanging out. That's him. You've got his friend, Andrew Aguecheek, who's a sort of hanger-on, this tall, slender annoyance, but the kind of friend that Sir Toby keeps around because he wants to mock him. He enjoys mocking him. He enjoys setting him up for sport, as he does in the play. Sets himself up into a duel for his own amusement.
- 8.31** He's actually a drinking companion, probably, more than anything. Sir Toby Belch is a drunk, and they get drunk. Sir Toby is very much a kind of minor Falstaff. He's not to those levels. He's more like a Lord of Misrule. He's the eccentric relative who was tolerated at the time by aristocratic families. You always have one; all families have them. You know, when you have Christmas dinners, and the drunk uncle comes around. We all have it.
- 8.32** There's also a guy called Fabian in the household who is a kind of servant. It's not really clear what he is. Feste is the key one. Feste is the clown, so the household clown, the aristocratic clown. It's a fairly typical aristocratic household, complete with the eccentrics. Here, Shakespeare does something quite brilliant, because the tensions within Olivia's household seem to mirror the political tensions of the time that Shakespeare was writing in.
- 8.33** Malvolio is described by Maria as a kind of Puritan, a kind of Puritan. He's not exactly a Puritan. He's not a religious zealot. He embodies the ideas of the Puritans at the time. Now, remember that, with the exception of the plague, the Puritans were the greatest threat to Shakespeare's livelihood. They wanted the theaters to shut down. They thought they were dens of vices. They thought they were evil, diabolical places. They hated it.
- 8.34** Philip Stubbes, who was a pamphleteer, was part of the puritanical cultural movement at the time. He wrote a text called *The Anatomie of Abuses*. This was in 1583. And this is a dialogue between these two figures, Philiponus and Spudeus. And Philiponus is Stubbes' mouthpiece, and Spudeus is asking lots of the right questions, a bit like a podcast scenario. And he says, "Stage plays, whether their subject matter is divine or profane"—and this is a direct quote—"are quite contrary to the word of grace and sucked out of the devil's teats to nourish us in idolatry, heathenry, and sin." Crikey.

- 8.35** William Prynne, that's another Puritan. He was a highly intelligent, scholarly man. He condemned the theater as "the chief delight of the devil." That's in his book, *Histriomastix*, which is from 1633. Prynne describes the theater as "a realm of adulterers, adulteresses, whoremasters, whores, bawds, panders, ruffians, roarers, drunkards, prodigals, cheaters, idle, infamous, base, profane, and godless persons." You can hear the Ian Paisley-style rage.
- 8.36** He's not entirely wrong there, by the way. The theaters were rough places. You go down to the South Bank at this time, you would see fights, you would see drunks, you would see rent boys and prostitutes and all sorts of things, bear-baiting, all the rest of it. As I mentioned, you had the Bear Garden. The Bear Garden was just a few minutes' walk away from the Globe Theater, where you could see bears tied to posts, whipped, eaten by dogs—utterly barbaric.
- 8.37** The bears actually became very, very famous. There was Harry Hunks, the bear. Sackerson was a famous bear at the Bear Garden. Shakespeare mentions Sackerson in *The Merry Wives of Windsor*. He has Slender saying, "I have seen Sackerson loose twenty times and have taken him by the chain; but I warrant you, the women have so cried and shrieked at it, that it passed." So these are brutal places. These are horrific places.
- 8.38** I find it so fascinating that, within this small area, you had this theater producing the greatest art that we have seen in the English tongue. And just down the road, you've got the lowest form of art: bear-baiting, animal cruelty, drunkenness, etc. This conflation of high and low is endlessly fascinating to me. And even within the Globe itself— fights, drunks, whatever, prostitution, the lot. Maybe that's what it needs. Maybe, to cultivate the highest genius, you need that disorder. Maybe. Maybe genius and horror is pretty close together. Just a thought.
- 8.39** Anyway, the conflict in Olivia's household between Sir Toby Belch, Sir Toby Belch, who represents the tradition of aristocratic revelry in the court, on the one hand, and then you've got Malvolio, who represents the Puritan discipline. And the title of the play, *Twelfth Night*, could refer to when it was first performed. I actually rather fancy that the title was the subtitle. The subtitle of the play is *What You Will*. It sounds much more Shakespearean to me.
- 8.40** Think about some of his other titles—*As You Like It*, *Much Ado About Nothing*, *What You Will*. These things all seem of a kind. *Twelfth Night*, it was probably perhaps renamed *Twelfth Night* because the first performance coincided on *Twelfth Night*, because *Twelfth Night* isn't mentioned in the play, so that would make sense of it. *Twelfth Night* is that festive season, isn't it? It's the thing that Malvolio despises.
- 8.41** The reason I find this so interesting is because, obviously, this is pre-civil war. Obviously, this tension between the old-school aristocrats and the Puritans was festering during Shakespeare's time, and he dramatizes and theatricalizes that through

the conflict between Malvolio and the other servants. But that discord, it's almost like a microcosm of the discord that would eventually develop into the clash between the Cavaliers and the Puritans that culminated in the 1640s. And the Puritans, of course, as we know, won out. And what did they do? As soon as there's a Puritan-led Parliament, 1642, they shut the theaters down. That's what they do. They won. Malvolio won.

8.42 Let's go back to this scene. This is Act 2, Scene 3. Toby and Andrew and Feste and Maria are enjoying a night of carousing and drunkenness, and they are interrupted by Malvolio. He's very upset about this, don't you know? And he walks in and says, "My masters, are you mad? Or what are you? Have you no wit, manners, or honesty, but to gabble like tinkers at this time of night? Do ye make an alehouse of my lady's house, that ye squeak out your coziers' catches"—catches of tunes, songs—"without any mitigation or remorse of voice? Is there no respect of place, persons, nor time in you?"

8.43 Sir Toby says, "We did keep time, sir, in our catches. Sneck up!" We did keep time. We were keeping time in our songs. Again, doing that Shakespearean thing, taking a word, changing the meaning, throwing it back. Does it all the time. Sneck up is the equivalent of get lost. He's saying, "Go hang yourself on the catch on the door." He insultingly puns on Malvolio, like I said, this time and place. This is only going to antagonize Malvolio further, isn't it, this kind of thing?

8.44 Now, Malvolio says, "Sir Toby, I must be round with you. My lady bade me tell you that, though she harbors you as her kinsman, she's nothing allied to your disorders. If you can separate yourself and your misdemeanors, you are welcome to the house; if not, and it would please you to take leave of her. She is very willing to bid you farewell." He's being quite polite about it, but he's annoying, isn't he? He's an annoying prig.

8.45 Sir Toby sings, "Farewell, dear heart, since I must needs be gone." Maria is saying, she says, "Nay, good Sir Toby, calm down." Hey, we've all had a drink. She's trying to settle it down. She's more conciliatory to Malvolio's complaint. I think, for good reason, she's the waiting woman, the gentlewoman's waiting woman. She obviously wants the house to be in order, and she obviously supports the rules set down by Olivia.

8.46 Now, Sir Toby challenges Malvolio. He's basically saying, "Are you getting above yourself? What are you? Who are you?" Sir Toby is a knight. "Who's this guy to tell me what to do?" He says, "Art thou any more than a steward? Dost thou think, because thou art virtuous, there shall be no more cakes and ale?" Very famous line. Feste says, "Yes, by St Anne, and ginger shall be hot in the mouth too." We will have all sensations, as Pater said. We will chew on ginger. We will have everything.

8.47 There shall be no more cakes and ale. That's what the Puritans wanted. They didn't want any more cakes and ale. We're going to return to Malvolio later because I do think he's the key figure in this play. But it really is astonishing how the smaller characters end up being the points that dominate, like with Shylock, like with Falstaff in the Henry IV plays.

- 8.48** Anyway, Twelfth Night is a play ultimately about desire. And Malvolio has a desire of his own, for all his puritanical ways. In particular, he desires social climbing. He's gulled into believing that his mistress, Olivia, might have fallen in love with him. But his desire is, of course, purely opportunistic. It's potentially erotic; you can read it that way, but it's definitely opportunistic. He sees it as an opportunity to make something better of himself.
- 8.49** Before we return to that, let's consider the other examples. The play sees the shipwrecked Viola disguised as the boy Cesario, who wants to gain a post at Orsino's court and does so. At Orsino's court, Cesario, who is Viola, is dispatched to woo Olivia on Orsino's behalf, at which point, Olivia, believing Viola to be a boy, falls instantly in love with her.
- 8.50** We saw this before in As You Like It, remember, with Phoebe falling in love with Ganymede, who's actually Rosalind? It's a similar kind of joke. Remember that Viola is played by a boy. It's layers of complication. Antonio, meanwhile, seems to be infatuated with Sebastian, who has also been shipwrecked. Again, the twins have been separated by a shipwreck.
- 8.51** We remember later in the play when he requests the return of his purse from Viola, thinking Viola is Sebastian; she says, "I haven't got a purse." It's interesting to see his reaction. If you want to make a case that Antonio is in love with Sebastian, which I think is a strong case, he reacts to that not like a betrayed friend, but like a scorned lover, very clearly. "But oh, how vile an idol proves this god!"
- 8.52** He had idolized Sebastian, elevated him, and he launches into this passionate speech about betrayal and how Sebastian's beauty has deceived him. He says, "Thou hast, Sebastian, done a good feature shame. In nature, there's no blemish but the mind. None can be called deformed but the unkind. Virtue is beauty, but the beauteous evil are empty trunks, o'erflourished by the devil."
- 8.53** We can argue about whether this love is platonic or romantic. It seems pretty intense to me. Then, of course, we also have Viola's love for Orsino, and in some way, Andrew Aguecheek and Malvolio both desire Olivia. Like in A Midsummer Night's Dream, a similar thing; we end up with these entanglements of various trajectories of desire going on, which are then resolved. That's the chaos. The chaos is through desire, and that is resolved at the end through marriage.
- 8.54** But whereas in A Midsummer Night's Dream, the desire becomes misdirected through potion or love potion from a flower, the juice of a flower, here it is misdirected through mistaken identity, cross-dressing. This is even reflected, I think, in the way that the names seem to be virtual anagrams, Viola, Olivia, Malvolio. Everything seems to blend into the other.
- 8.55** So, why is it that desire can be so misdirected? Well, remember, Proteus' line from The Two Gentlemen of Verona. I flagged it up before. "What is in Silvia's face, but I may spy

more fresh in Julia's with a constant eye?" That problematic line. We've already seen how the love plot of *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is resolved by Demetrius retaining his love for Helena that he didn't originally feel, but the effect of the potion hasn't worn off.

8.56 And in *Twelfth Night*, Sebastian is instantly content to marry Olivia, who hadn't fallen in love with him at all, but had fallen in love with his likeness. So isn't that interesting? Once Viola's disguise is revealed, Orsino is happy to transfer his affections instantly from Olivia to her, almost like it doesn't matter who it is. And does Orsino really love Olivia?

8.57 We open with this famous speech, "If music be the food of love, play on." But is this obsession really because he knows or understands the object of his desire? Has he fallen in love with the idea of falling in love? I wonder. There's a lot of that in Shakespeare. It certainly happens to Romeo with Rosaline, if you look at the way he moons about like a teenager. And this rings true, doesn't it? Have you ever heard a teenager complain about a boyfriend or girlfriend? It's more about persona. It's more about identity. It's creating something that isn't really there.

8.58 I think that's a very interesting way to think about that distinction between infatuation and love, fancy and love, that is really emphasized in *The Merchant of Venice* and in the song of the casket, falling in love with the idea of being in love. Remember, of course, Romeo is quite happy to instantly transfer that kind of rhetoric to Juliet. Again, it doesn't matter who it is. The difference with Juliet is, actually, when he starts on that journey, it becomes authentic love. It switches.

8.59 That's what the play is doing. I think this is one of Shakespeare's great insights about love. I don't think anyone has written more powerfully about the authenticity and transformative nature of love, but also the acknowledgement that love and infatuation are not the same thing, and how we, as human beings, have an innate tendency to confuse the one for the other, and how dangerous that is, and how funny that is.

8.60 I'd like to suggest another way that we can make sense of this idea, this concept. To make a point, I want to draw on a French writer Stendhal, which is the pen name of Marie-Henri Beyle. Stendhal wrote in 1822 a book called *De l'Amour*, on love. He coined this phrase, crystallization, Stendhal's phrase, crystallization. Let me explain what he means by that.

8.61 Stendhal says that, if you throw a twig into the salt mines of Salzburg, a curious thing happens, because if you leave it there, what was at first just a twig becomes crystallized, covered with layers of sparkling salt, salt crystals, so that it resembles something valuable, but it's just a twig. And he argues that when we fall in love—or often when we fall in love—we take an ordinary person and we project onto them virtues and beauties and perfections that are not really there. They've come from us.

- 8.62** So we are essentially creating someone to fall in love with, and the real person actually is irrelevant. Now, Stendhal probably derived this idea from Montaigne. Montaigne says, the French essayist, he writes, "Like the passion of love that lends beauties and graces to the person it does embrace, and that makes those who are caught with it, with a depraved and corrupt judgment, consider the thing they love other and more perfect than it is."
- 8.63** Have you ever noticed how angry people get in relationships when one of the party disappoints the other, when they realize, "That wasn't the person I thought it was." Why? Because they've projected onto that person something that they weren't. This is such a common experience. I think most of us, if we're being honest, have experienced something like this. In our passion, we see what we want to see.
- 8.64** If you haven't experienced it personally, you must have had friends who've done this. You must have thought to yourself, "What the hell does she see in him? Why can't she see how horrible he is?" This is something that I've seen a lot among my friends, and you can't tell them, because the love object has been crystallized. They can only see the salt crystals, not the twig. It's hopeless to tell them.
- 8.65** It's an inevitable aspect of human existence. You see your friend paired off with genuinely horrible people. They've fallen in love with a phantom. Now, this is not a therapy session, so I don't want to go into this too much. Let's bring it back to Shakespeare. Consider how often it happens in Shakespeare. We mentioned Orsino, Romeo, and Helena.
- 8.66** There's Claudio, as well, in *Much Ado About Nothing*. Why does Claudio react so badly to this infidelity? It's because he's elevated Hero into this paragon of purity and beauty. He's been tricked, and so he reacts violently when he thinks she's something she isn't. The crystallization shatters. There's Troilus, who calls Cressida a pearl. And that explains, doesn't it, his reaction when he thinks she's betrayed him.
- 8.67** Helen of Troy has catalyzed the whole war. Helen of Troy, the face that launched a thousand ships, not in Shakespeare; in Shakespeare, she's an airhead. She's some sort of nothing. She's nothing. He represents her like that to show that those who have fallen in love and been bewitched by Helen of Troy have been projecting something that isn't there: a stark distinction between the idealization of the loved one in the eye of the lover and the reality.
- 8.68** That's set up brilliantly, of course, in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, when we see Titania fawning over Bottom, with the head of the donkey. The point is that this idea of crystallization is anticipated in Shakespeare. The lovers often don't see the beloved; they project their ideals onto them. But at the same time, Shakespeare is no cynic, because he knows that love is real and transcendent, and he knows how to portray that, too.

- 8.69** I'm not saying that all relationships are like this. Real love does exist. People aren't always crystallizing their loved ones. They're knowing them for who they are. Often, they love them knowing they're the twig, because they know what they are and they love them, their flaws included. This is something he addresses in the Sonnets. Love is not love unless you accept the flaws as well.
- 8.70** But Shakespeare is not afraid of those complications. He's fascinated by those complications, and he talks about it and addresses it and represents it. I'm not convinced that Orsino is in love with Olivia. I think he has crystallized her. I think he's in love with a vision, or possibly with himself, certainly with music and melancholy and the performance of the lovestruck. I think he's enjoying all of that.
- 8.71** And it may be that he's fallen in love with Viola. It may be that he's fallen in love with Viola when she's disguised as a boy, and he thinks she's a boy. Certainly, their language implies this. When Viola enters his service, they barely know each other. But he says, "I have unclasped to thee the book, even of my secret soul." I've shared with you everything. Why? Why would you do that with a boy, a pageboy? Unless there's something about Viola as a boy that attracts him.
- 8.72** Remember at the end of the play? Let's go back. When he dispatches Cesario to woo Olivia on his behalf, he actually does that because he thinks Cesario is beautiful. And what he says, "Diana's lip is not more smooth and rubious; thy small pipe is as the maiden's organ, shrill and sound, and all is semblative a woman's part."
- 8.73** Even at the end, when the disguise is revealed, he keeps calling her Cesario, doesn't he? As though, yes, OK, I know now this is a woman, not a boy, but I'm going to keep calling her a boy, because I'm enjoying the fantasy of her as a boy. It's very complicated. All these very interesting trajectories of desire and how they get resolved or, indeed, not resolved.
- 8.74** What we have in Twelfth Night, in fact, with this cat's cradle of desire, is a sense that love is arbitrary. Freud believed that love is either narcissistic in origin, that we fall in love for those who reflect ourselves, or that it's a kind of prop, that we fall for someone who provides something that we lack, a support mechanism. Shakespeare sees this multiplicity, the multidimensional possibilities of love, and he's able to capture the transcendent, too.
- 8.75** That is something I think that it takes a poet to achieve. It takes a poet to understand love. It takes a poet to express it. He does this mostly in the Sonnets, in Romeo and Juliet, in Twelfth Night. The comedies, more generally, we see love in the comedies as a chaotic force. It's something that can spiral out of control. It can throw us in unexpected dimensions. It can sabotage us endlessly.
- 8.76** And for all the joy that it brings, for all that it can be the ultimate experience of being human, it's also bloody funny. He knows this, he gets it. Within all this chaos, it feels as though, really, it's just the fool that is anchored, isn't it, in this play? In Twelfth Night,

it's Feste. Feste is the anchor, and he's one of the most brilliant of Shakespeare's fools. He's a fantastic creation.

- 8.77** Now, when we first see him, we immediately like him, don't we? Olivia is mourning for her brother. She's there; you can imagine her dressed in black, and he approaches her. "Good Madonna, why mournst thou?" Olivia says, "Good fool, for my brother's death." Feste says, "I think his soul is in hell, Madonna." Olivia says, "I know his soul is in heaven, fool." And Feste says, "The more fool, Madonna, to mourn for your brother's soul being in heaven. Take away the fool, gentlemen."
- 8.78** And he's right, isn't he? Why? How can you rebut that wisdom? How can you? If you're mourning for your brother's death and you're saying he's in heaven, why would you mourn that he's in paradise? Makes no sense. Now, Feste is this true individual. He's not quite like the other fools in Shakespeare. He has a more resigned quality. We get the sense that he's not a happy fool. He just understands that this is his role, and he understands that, basically, contentment is about the best that we can ever achieve, not happiness.
- 8.79** I do think a lot of the problems of today, people think they must be happy all the time. Actually, being alive is about, mostly, getting away with being content, isn't it? Anyway, that's a whole other thing. But consider the song that Feste ends the play with. The song, it echoes Jaques' seven ages of man speech, except that it's nowhere near as cynical. Feste sings about the inevitability of troubles in life, which is pretty much what I'm saying. Life is that much happier if you just accept that it's mostly hard work, I think.
- 8.80** And Feste sings about this. He says, "When that I was and a tiny little boy, with hey, ho, the wind and the rain, a foolish thing was but a toy, for the rain, it raineth every day. But when I came to man's estate, with hey ho, the wind and the rain, 'gainst knaves and thieves men shut their gate, for the rain, it raineth every day. But when I came, alas, to wive, with hey, ho, the wind and the rain, by swaggering could I never thrive, for the rain, it raineth every day," and so on, and so on.
- 8.81** Shakespeare was obviously very fond of this song. It actually comes back in King Lear. The fool sings a stanza, a new stanza, although the impact there is far more dark, far more foreboding. But Feste's song seems to be a—I mean, ostensibly, it seems a bit of a flippant way to end Twelfth Night, but he's right. There is no happy-ever-after. There is no love without storms. And while a comedy ends in marriage and, theatrically, it freezes us at this moment of bliss, Shakespeare wants to remind us that that's not the end of the matter.
- 8.82** We have a similar effect with Balthasar in Much Ado About Nothing, the song that Balthasar sings. Remember what I'm saying? Songs comment on the theme more often than not in Shakespeare. This is the song from Much Ado About Nothing. "Sigh no more, ladies, sigh no more. Men were deceivers ever. One foot in sea and one on

shore, to one thing constant never. Then sigh not so, but let them go, and be you blithe and bonny, converting all your sounds of woe into hey, nonny, nonny."

- 8.83** Men are always going to cheat, so women just have to accept it, shrug their shoulders, get on with the business of living. "Hey, nonny, nonny" has much the same sense of, "Hey, ho, the wind and the rain." This is hardly the stuff of typical love tales, is it? It's brutal realism.
- 8.84** Now, I want to return to Malvolio, who, as I've said, is the key figure of this play. What is the nature of his love for Olivia? Well, let's go to the box tree scene. This is this famous scene, never fails in performance. It's always funny. Act 2, Scene 5. Maria has forged the letter, pretended it resembles Olivia's handwriting. She drops it on the floor. This is the letter that's going to say that she's in love with Malvolio. Olivia's in love with Malvolio, but of course, she isn't. Maria has faked it.
- 8.85** Toby, Andrew, and Fabian hide in the box tree, and they eavesdrop, because to them, this is all a game. Maria says, "Here comes the trout that must be caught with tickling." Here comes Malvolio, and they all scatter. And Malvolio approaches, and he is as pompous as ever. He thinks he's alone, and when he thinks he's alone, he's revealing his ambitions. He says, "To be Count Malvolio," and then he launches into this elaborate fantasy about marrying Olivia.
- 8.86** Throughout this, I'm going to read the speech, but throughout it, Toby and Fabian are interjecting, so I'll just take out their interjections because I want to focus on what Malvolio says. He says, "Having been three months married to her, sitting in my state, calling my officers about me, in my branched velvet gown, having come from a daybed where I left Olivia sleeping." So you can see he's fantasizing about—there's an erotic tinge here. He's imagining that he's left Olivia sexually exhausted. He's wandering around in his velvet gown, lording it over everyone.
- 8.87** But of course, we know he's not interested in Olivia. He's interested in status. He says, "And then to have the humour of state." Now, this is always going to be funny, isn't it? Some pompous guy, playing out a fantasy when he thinks he's alone, and other people are listening in, and of course, we in the audience are listening in; that's always going to be a bit funny. Often, in farce, there's a moment where someone is caught practicing in front of a mirror, what they'll do, or something like that. This is very common.
- 8.88** Malvolio says, "And then to have the humour of state; and after a demure travail of regard, telling them I know my place as I would they should do theirs, to ask for my kinsman, Toby." He should know his place. He doesn't, does he? He's imagining that he's a lord. "Seven of my people, with an obedient start, make out for Toby, make out for him. I frown the while; and perchance wind up my watch, or play with my—some rich jewel." Actually, it says he's touching his chain.
- 8.89** So you can imagine him say, "I'm just going to sit there and play with my—" and he plays with his chain, but now he imagines it's not going to be a chain. When he's a lord,

it'll be a rich jewel, some rich jewel. He's insufferable, isn't he? "Toby approaches, curtsies there to me. I extend my hand to him thus, quenching my familiar smile with an austere regard of control, saying, 'Cousin Toby, my fortunes having cast me on your niece give me the prerogative of speech. You must amend your drunkenness.'"

- 8.90** So he's imagining, in his fantasy, lecturing Toby about how he should be better behaved. And Toby has to be obsequious and has to listen to him because now Malvolio is Count Malvolio. So he's a prig, and he's a bore, and he's insufferably vain. And Toby, of course, hears all this fantasy, and he's growing ever more agitated. He's getting angry about it, because Malvolio really wants power, doesn't he?
- 8.91** He wants power over Toby, and everyone; has seven men dispatched to get Toby at his will. He's able to hector Toby about his drunkenness. He's able to sit in his chair of state — there's a raised chair under a canopy which was used by high-born figures when they were giving audience. It's the most pompous thing imaginable. It may as well be a throne, as far as Malvolio is concerned.
- 8.92** I think it's clear that we're not meant to like him. Shakespeare has called him Malvolio. That means ill will, as opposed to Feste, which means festivity. It's very clear what Shakespeare is doing here. Malvolio has no goodwill for anyone except for himself. But because Shakespeare is Shakespeare, even when he's tackling the Puritans, who he must have despised, because they were trying to shut down his livelihood, even when he's talking about Puritans, he cannot bring himself to resort to caricature. He can't do it.
- 8.93** You could have easily had Malvolio as a completely caricatured Puritan who gets what he deserves, and it's as simple as that. But Shakespeare won't do it. Actually, Harold Bloom thought that Malvolio was a direct satire of Ben Jonson. It might be the case. It's very interesting, those two with their constant back-and-forth; it might be the case that he was doing that. He certainly does embody those priggish and precisionist tendencies that Puritans have, even though, as I say, he's not a Puritan in the strictest sense.
- 8.94** And look at what happens when—it is pretty ruthless, actually, the mockery of Malvolio. When Malvolio picks up the letter, and he notices the handwriting, and he realizes this is Olivia's handwriting, what does he say? He says, "By my life, this is my lady's hand. These be her very Cs, her Us, and her Ts." Well, I shouldn't have to spell this out. There's no natural or plausible reason why Malvolio would single out those letters. Remember the "and" at the time was abbreviated to N, and has an N sound in it.
- 8.95** So when Malvolio reads out these letters, he's spelling out a word, her Cs, her Us, and her Ts. You know what he's saying. That word is still taboo today. You see a shock. That word is still a taboo word today. And what does Shakespeare do? He puts the most offensive word in the English language into Malvolio's mouth, into the Puritan's mouth. He's mocking him, and it works. He's done this before.

- 8.96** If you remember in Hamlet, when Hamlet is talking to Ophelia before they watch the play, before they watch the Mousetrap, he's lying in her lap, and he says, "Do you think I meant country matters?" He does this. This here is a joke at Malvolio's expense. In a way, it disrupts the verisimilitude of the play because, like I say, he wouldn't naturally pick on those letters. It's Shakespeare's joke at him. He wants us to laugh at him quite pointedly.
- 8.97** You can hear the audience laughter because he spells out the word, and then Andrew Aguecheek says, "Her Cs, her Us, and her Ts, why that?" You can imagine another laugh, because he's almost responding to the audience. Why are you laughing at that? I don't get it. It's a double joke. It's a sly way of breaking the fourth wall, acknowledging the joke that Shakespeare has dared to make. It's a really good comedic conceit.
- 8.98** Malvolio is convinced that Olivia loves him, and he follows the instructions in the letter. Remember the letter says, "Come to me, wearing yellow stockings and cross-gartered, and smiling." Maria explains why she's chosen this. She says, "If you will then see the fruits of the sport, mark his first approach before my lady. He will come to her in yellow stockings, and 'tis a color she abhors, and cross-gartered, a fashion she detests. And he will smile upon her, which will now be so unsuitable to her disposition, being addicted to a melancholy as she is, that it cannot but turn him into a notable contempt."
- 8.99** In other words, this is the very worst thing that a suitor could do. Dress in the fashion she hates, smile when she's in no mood for smiling, and they're going to get him to do it—the prig, the Puritan. They're going to get him to prance around smiling in yellow garters and cross-gartered stockings. And he's not a man who smiles. We know this. In the film version, the Trevor Nunn film version that I've mentioned from 1996, Nigel Hawthorne plays Malvolio.
- 8.100** You see the moment when he read the letter and he tries practicing a smile. He hasn't smiled once so far in the film, and it takes him ages to get it. It's a very funny moment. Let's see how this plays out. This is Act 3, Scene 4. So Malvolio comes in, in yellow stockings and cross-garters; Maria is there. Olivia says, "How now, Malvolio?" Malvolio, "Sweet lady, ho, ho." And she says, "Smilest thou? I sent for thee upon a sad occasion."
- 8.101** And Malvolio says, "Sad, lady? I could be sad. This does make some obstruction in the blood, this cross-gartering. But what of that?" So, the crossing of the garter has actually stopped his blood. So he could frown if he wants to, but he won't, because she wants him to smile. He says, "If it please the eye of one, it is with me as the very true sonnet is. Please one, and please all." So in other words, if it pleases her, he will suffer anything.
- 8.102** And she says, "Why, how dost thou, man? What is the matter with thee?" Malvolio says, "Not black in my mind, though yellow in my legs. It did come to his hands, and commands shall be executed. I think we do know the sweet Roman hand." So he's

received her command. He's recognized her handwriting. He will proudly execute her instructions.

- 8.103** But she tells him that he probably needs to lie down. She says, "Wilt thou go to bed, Malvolio?" And of course, he misinterprets that. "To bed! Ay, sweet heart, and I'll come to thee." And Olivia says, "God comfort thee! Why dost thou smile so and kiss thy hands so oft?" Now, obviously, I can't just read out this scene. This is a scene for actors, and this doesn't do justice to it. You have to see it in performance. It is a gift for actors.
- 8.104** And we're laughing along because Malvolio is such a prig, and we do sense that he's getting his comeuppance. But at the next stage of the prank takes a darker turn, you'll recall. So the pranksters, Maria and Feste and Toby Belch, etc, they have him locked in a dark house for being mad. Now, in Trevor Nunn's film, he changes this a bit. He has Maria, who's played by Imelda Staunton, express concerns. She suddenly realizes, "Oh, this has gone too far now. This was funny before. Now it's cruel." But this is a directorial intervention. This is not what Shakespeare wrote.
- 8.105** This was actually all her idea. And not only is it all her idea, but she actually expresses a flippant disregard for Malvolio's feelings and whether or not he might actually be driven mad. Because Fabian says, "If this were played upon a stage now, I could condemn it as an improbable fiction." I can't believe he's behaving like this. Sir Toby says, "His very genius hath taken the infection of the device, man." And Maria says, "Nay, pursue him now, lest the device take air and taint."
- 8.106** In other words, she doesn't want to reflect on it. She wants to keep going. She doesn't want him to think about it because he might realize he's being gulled. She wants to keep on. And Fabian says, "Why, we shall make him mad indeed." And Maria says, rather cruelly, "The house will be the quieter." And then Sir Toby says, OK, "Come, we'll have him in a dark room and bound. My niece is already in the belief that he's mad. We may carry it thus for our pleasure." This is actually very dark stuff.
- 8.107** Now, in Trevor Nunn's film, he reassigns Fabian's line, "Why, we shall make him mad indeed," to Maria, and she delivers it in a very concerned tone. And her chilling line, "The house will be the quieter," is cut. Now, I mention this because I think that film is brilliant, and I think it's really worth watching, and I highly recommend it, but what I would say is that the interpretation is not what Shakespeare wrote. Maria is not—she is very much a part of this.
- 8.108** Now, I mean, what Nunn is doing is, he wants to mitigate the cruelty of the prank by making the architect of the prank have second thoughts, which is an interesting thing to do, but it's not what's in the play. It does make sense to us, I think, because to a modern audience, this just feels vicious. We don't have the context of an Elizabethan audience who are—remember, these people, these men and women, were continually hectorated by the Puritans for even going to the theater.

- 8.109** Shakespeare knows that everyone watching this play will hate the Puritans. So, of course, that puts a different spin on it. This is the person that it's OK to hate. And of course, we are living through a time where we have—there are so many Malvolios today, who don't want us to have our cakes and ale. There are so many who say that plays and films and books are problematic, and they need to be censored or banned if they're offensive. Those are all Malvolios.
- 8.110** I do think those people should be mocked, but I don't think they should be tortured. I can't help but feel sorry for Malvolio. I can't help it. He is ambitious. He does want to be Count Malvolio. Is that really that bad, though? It makes Shakespeare a bit of a hypocrite, if you think about it. Shakespeare wanted to be a gentleman as well. He spent his whole life trying to get a coat of arms, which he did. His father tried and failed. Shakespeare got the coat of arms.
- 8.111** This was actually one of the sources—Ben Jonson actually mocked him for this, quite explicitly. So there's a play that Ben Jonson wrote called *Every Man Out of His Humour*, and there's a character called Sogliardo. And this character sounds quite familiar. This is a man who's come from the country to the city and managed to get a coat of arms. Sounds a bit like Shakespeare, doesn't it?
- 8.112** And Shakespeare just got his coat of arms, and he had used the motto "Non sanz droict," the French, meaning "Not without right." That's the motto on Shakespeare's coat of arms. In Ben Jonson's play, someone suggests that Sogliardo, who's the Shakespeare stand-in, should use the motto "not without mustard." So a pompous motto just becomes a request for a condiment, so Ben Jonson is mocking him. It's pretty brutal, actually.
- 8.113** But there's no reason to suppose that Shakespeare didn't have a sense of humor, wasn't able to laugh at himself. There's lots of anecdotes of Shakespeare and Jonson's friendship. I think it's clearly a respectful rivalry. I think that's what it was. In the Folio, after Shakespeare's died, Jonson's praise of Shakespeare is about as fulsome as it gets. I don't mean fulsome in a negative sense, as in fake; I mean, really grand.
- 8.114** He says this is "the swan of Avon. He's a man, not just for now, but for all time. He's ageless." That's what Jonson says. Jonson knew, I think, that Shakespeare was his superior, but he would never have admitted that. Anyway, so it may be right. Maybe Bloom is right that Malvolio is a version of Jonson, maybe. Maybe there's some in-jokes here we don't get. Maybe there's something to do with the yellow stockings. It might be connected to Jonson. I don't know.
- 8.115** The point I'm making is that it does seem inconceivable to me that social ambition in of itself, something that Shakespeare was guilty of, that that should be punished in this cruel way by convincing someone that he's mad and locking him up. I mean, that seems far too excessive. If he wants to be a count, if he wants to try and marry Olivia, so what? It's not that bad. The practical joke is fine.

- 8.116** I mean, I always find practical jokes a bit cruel, actually. I don't really like them. But when he's dressed up in yellow stockings and cross-garters, that's fine, that's funny. Shouldn't it have just ended there? Because by the time he's in the dark house, when Feste visits him disguised as the curate, Sir Topas, at that point, I think most of us will think this has gone way too far.
- 8.117** You have Malvolio in the dark and he says, "Sir Topas, never was a man thus wronged. Good Sir Topas, do not think I am mad. They've laid me here in hideous darkness." Feste, playing the curate, says, "Fie, thou dishonest Satan! I call thee by the most modest terms, for I am one of those gentle ones that will use the devil himself with courtesy. Sayest thou that house is dark?" And Malvolio, who's in the dark, behind the bar, says, "As hell, Sir Topas."
- 8.118** And Feste says, "Why, it hath bay windows, transparent as barricadoes. And the clearstores toward the south north are as lustrous as ebony. And yet, complainest thou of obstruction?" This is what we call gaslighting. It's designed to drive him mad. Feste is denying that he's in the dark. He's denying it. He's saying, "No, it's really bright in here."
- 8.119** Remember, Petruchio did the same to Katharina. Malvolio says, "I am not mad, Sir Topas. I say to you, this house is dark." And Feste carries on. "Madman, thou errest. I say, there is no darkness but ignorance, in which thou art more puzzled than the Egyptians in their fog." Malvolio says, "I say, this house is as dark as ignorance, though ignorance were as dark as hell; and I say, there was never man thus abused. I am no more mad than you are."
- 8.120** Now, it could be, like I say, that I'm reading this through 21st-century eyes. I feel more sympathy for Malvolio than an Elizabethan audience might. For one thing, they all hated the Puritans, but also, madness was funny to the Elizabethans. They used to go to Bedlam, to madhouses, and laugh at the inmates. This is something—we find that unconscionable. We couldn't comprehend that kind of thing. That was the norm for them.
- 8.121** Just as they had public executions, where they would take the kids along to watch someone's entrails being dragged out of their body while they were still alive. We can't comprehend that. We have to try as we can to see this from an Elizabethan perspective. Bear-baiting, as well; I don't understand why you would find that entertaining. It's inconceivable to me.
- 8.122** But I suppose, we think of L. P. Hartley's great novel, *The Go-Between*. Do you remember the opening line of that novel? Very famous. "The past is a foreign country. They do things differently there." Sums it up, doesn't it? But also, I think the ambiguity is the point. We're meant to think that the gulling of Malvolio is deserved, and yet we later feel guilty for laughing along with it. It's one of those things, like I say, Shakespeare never lets you settle. It's never simple.

- 8.123** Just as in *Julius Caesar*, when you're swept up with Mark Antony's speech, and you're all for the plebeians, and then they kill the poet, Cinna. You think: Why did they do that? He never lets you side; he doesn't side with anyone, and he won't let you side with anyone. Shakespeare doesn't write morality plays. He knows that, whatever side you're on, there are moral ambiguities. He revels in the complexity of life, in other words.
- 8.124** So that, for all that we loathe Malvolio's priggishness, it's difficult not to be moved by his final address to Olivia. So Malvolio says, "Madam," this is when he's been released. We've had the revelation of the twins, the marrying-off, everything is fine, everything is happy. This should be the end of the play. But no, Malvolio comes in. "Madam, you have done me wrong, notorious wrong." Remember, he still thinks that she did write that letter.
- 8.125** Olivia has no idea what's going on. Olivia says, "Have I, Malvolio? No." This is really key. Olivia is innocent. She actually values Malvolio. When she hears that he's gone mad, she's really worried. She values him, she respects him, she likes him, and the household could not operate without him. He's good at his job. And this is what Malvolio says to Olivia.
- 8.126** "Tell me, in the modesty of honor, why you have given me such clear lights of favor," as in, why did you write this letter? "Bade me come smiling and cross-gartered to you, to put on yellow stockings and to frown upon Sir Toby and the lighter people, and acting this in an obedient hope. Why have you suffered me to be imprisoned, kept in a dark house, visited by the priest, and made the most notorious geck and gull that e'er invention played on? Tell me why."
- 8.127** We're not laughing now. Yes, Malvolio is a snob, but he's still a human being. He did not deserve this. And consider when this happens in the structure. We've said, we've just had the revelation that Cesario is actually Viola; that Olivia has married Sebastian, not Cesario; that Orsino will marry Viola and thereby fulfill her love. We have the promise of two marriages. Chaos becomes order. The comedy feels resolved.
- 8.128** This is the happy ending, right? This is the happy ending that a lesser writer would present to us and leave. But that's not what Shakespeare does. Malvolio spoils it for us, for the audience. He spoils our happiness, and not because of anything he's done, but because we're confronted with the fact that he's become the victim of a cruel joke that we have laughed at.
- 8.129** So we can't leave the theater feeling entirely content. We went along to enjoy a comedy, and what did we get? We started laughing at the victim of a cruel prank, and now we're being berated for it. That's not really the experience we signed up for. Shakespeare isn't interested in what we wanted. He'll give us what he wants to give us. Instead of leaving the theater laughing and saying, "That was a great comedy," we're leaving with a nagging uncertainty, a sense of discomfort.

8.130 That, I think, is what makes this play so spectacular. He's doing something really bold. It's really unexpected. He doesn't treat the genre of comedy as a tick-box exercise and simply fulfill all of the necessary criteria. He complicates it. And then, of course, we have Malvolio's chilling final line. "I'll be revenged on the whole pack of you." So, for all the hilarity of the revelations of the twins, the misunderstandings now resolved, the joy of love fulfilled, this is the line that echoes when the curtain falls.